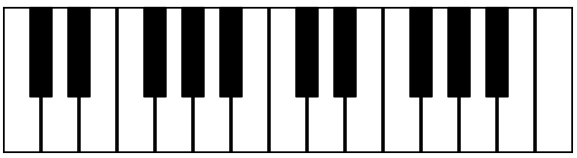
Read at Sight

A graded sight-reading course for piano

Volume 5 - Repertoire Reading



Middle C

Real piano music: two voices in one hand, chorales, chromatic notes, triplets, every key, the pedal and ornaments, with pieces by Bach, Beethoven, Schumann and Chopin.

Exercises generated to graded rules; pieces are original or public domain.

How to use this book

What is new in Volume 5

This is the last volume. The hand positions of Volumes 1-4 give way to reading as pianists do: by key, by chord shape and by pattern. Finger numbers now appear only where a passage needs a particular fingering. You will read two voices in one hand, four-part chorales, chromatic notes, triplets and four new time signatures, every major and minor key, the sustain pedal, clef changes and ornaments. Most of the pieces are real music: Bach chorales and inventions, Beethoven, Schubert, Schumann, Chopin and Satie. Start this book when you can read Volume 4 music: chords in both hands, ledger lines, syncopation, sixteenths and keys with three sharps or flats.

The five rules

1. Never stop: keep the beat going, even after a wrong note. 2. Count out loud and use a metronome at the speed shown. 3. Keep your eyes on the music, not your hands. 4. Read the shape: up, down, or the same, and by how much. 5. Play each exercise once, tick its box, and move on. Come back only after a few weeks.

Before every exercise: 10 seconds

Name the key (the key signature and the last bass note) and the time signature. Look at the left hand's pattern: held chords, a waltz, a broken chord, a second voice? Find the highest and lowest notes, any accidentals, and any bar that repeats an earlier one. Then count one bar in and play.

How each unit is laid out

A unit opens with what is new, short examples, and reading tips. Parts A to C (sometimes D) are generated exercises that practise the new idea. The pieces come next: in this volume they are the heart of each unit, and most are real music by the great composers. A checkpoint ends the unit.

A daily routine (15-20 minutes)

Warm up with the scale and the I, IV and V chords of the day's key (2 minutes). Read 4-6 new exercises, one pass each (8 minutes). Then read one piece, or a page of one, and practise a passage from it (8 minutes).

Contents

Each unit adds exactly one new idea to everything before it.

Unit 1 Two Voices in One Hand 4
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Chromatic passing and neighbour notes, V7 of V, the melodic minor

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Eighth-note triplets; 3/8, 9/8, 12/8 and 2/2 (alla breve)

Unit 5 Four Sharps and Four Flats 65
E major and A-flat major; C-sharp minor (B-sharp) and F minor (E-natural)

Unit 6 Every Key 79
Five, six and seven sharps or flats; enharmonic keys (F-sharp = G-flat)

Unit 7 Pedal, Clefs and the Whole Keyboard 94
The sustain pedal; the left hand in the treble clef and the right hand in the bass clef

Unit 8 Counterpoint, Ornaments and Review 111
Sequences and imitation; trills, mordents, turns and grace notes; review

Unit 1

Two Voices in One Hand

New: A tune and a held voice in the same hand: stems up and stems down

Real piano music often asks one hand to play two things at once: a tune on top and a second, quieter voice underneath, or a bass note held while the hand moves above it. To show this, the music is written in two voices on the same staff. The upper voice has its stems up, the lower voice its stems down.
From this volume on there are no hand-position pictures. Read by key and by chord: before you play, name the key and look at the shapes the hands make.

What is new

Stems up, stems down

When a staff holds two voices, the upper voice's stems point up and the lower voice's stems point down, even where the notes are close together. Each voice has its own complete rhythm, so both must add up to a full bar.

A held note under a moving tune

A half or whole note with its stem down keeps sounding while the upper voice moves on. Hold it down with one finger (often the thumb in the right hand, or the little finger in the left) and play the tune with the others.

Shared notes
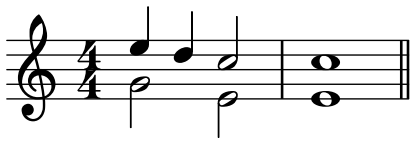
Where both voices sing the same note, it is printed once with two stems. Play it once.

Two voices in the left hand

The bass (stems down) holds while a tenor line (stems up) moves above it. The little finger holds the bass; the thumb and middle fingers play the tenor.
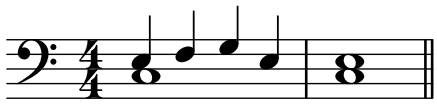
Two voices on one staff

Upper voice (stems up): E D C, then C. Lower voice (stems down): G held for two beats, then E. Count the voices separately: each adds up to a full bar.



A bass and a tenor in the left hand

The left hand holds C (stems down) while the tenor walks E F G E above it.



Reading tips

1. Before you play, find each voice's longest notes: those are the ones to hold.

2. Play the upper voice alone once in your head, then imagine the held notes underneath it.

3. Let the tune sing and keep the held voice quiet.

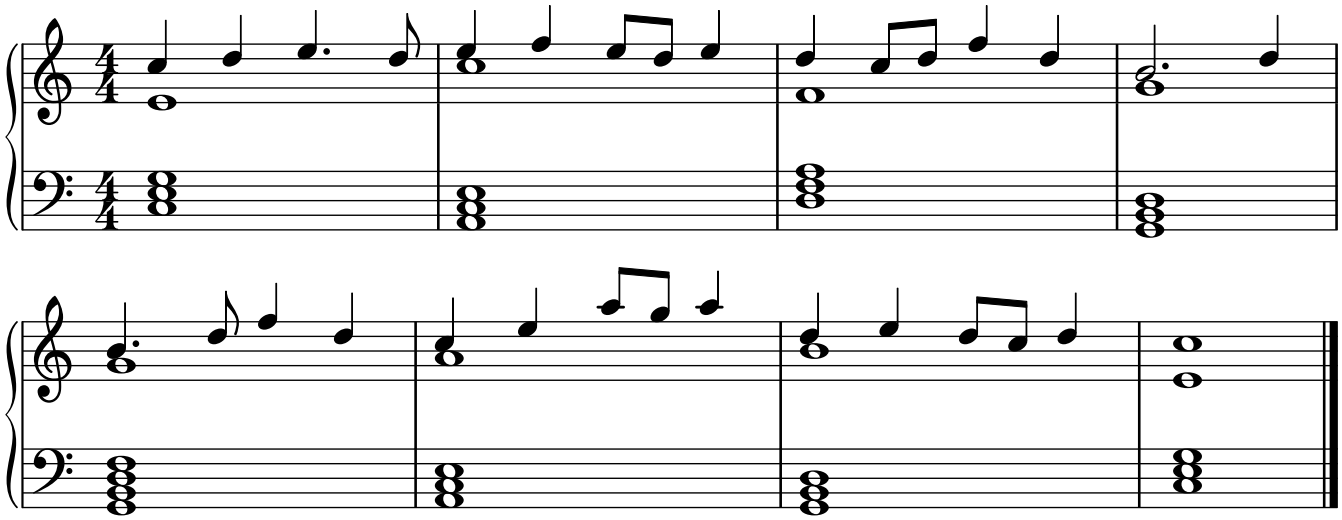
4. If a held note is hard to keep down, it is better to let it go a little early than to stop the beat.

Part A: A held voice under the tune

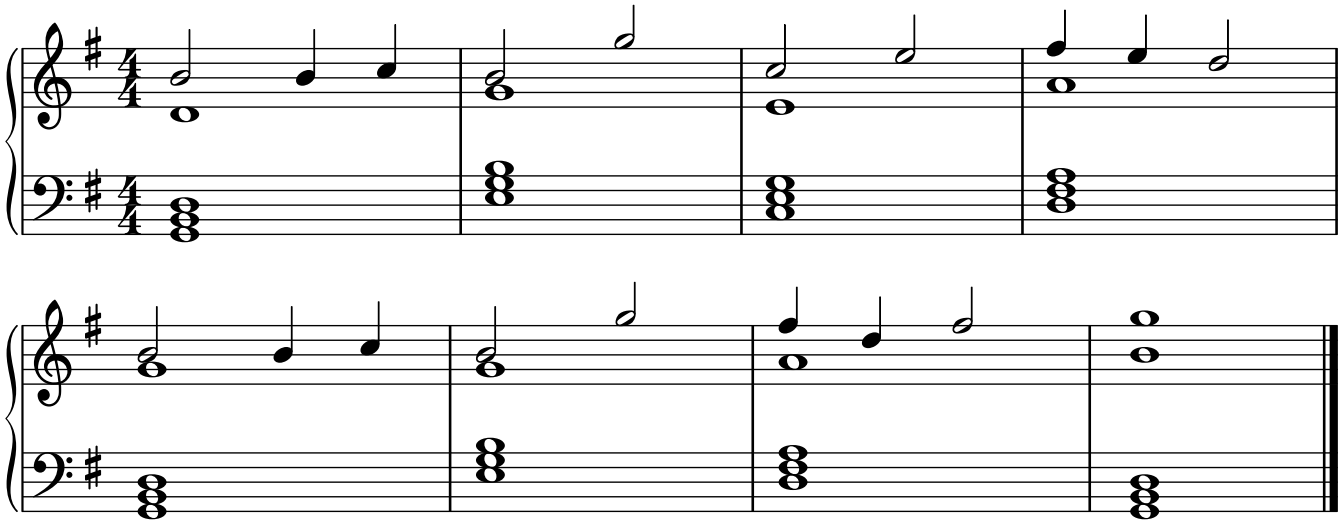
♩ = 66

C major and G major. The right hand holds the stems-down note for the whole bar while the tune moves above it. The left hand plays held chords.

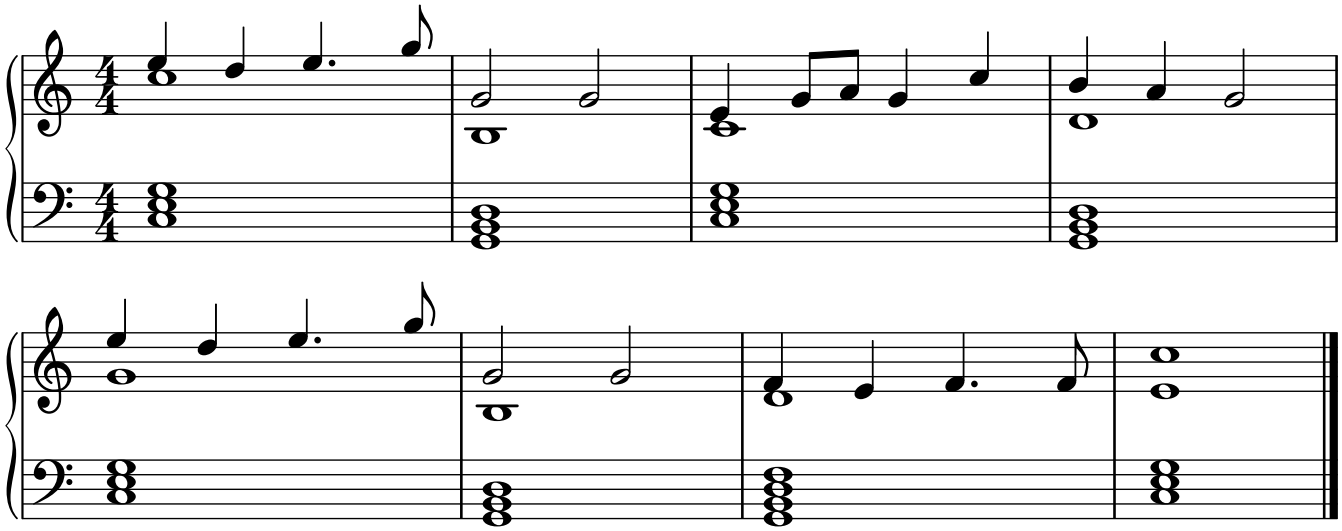
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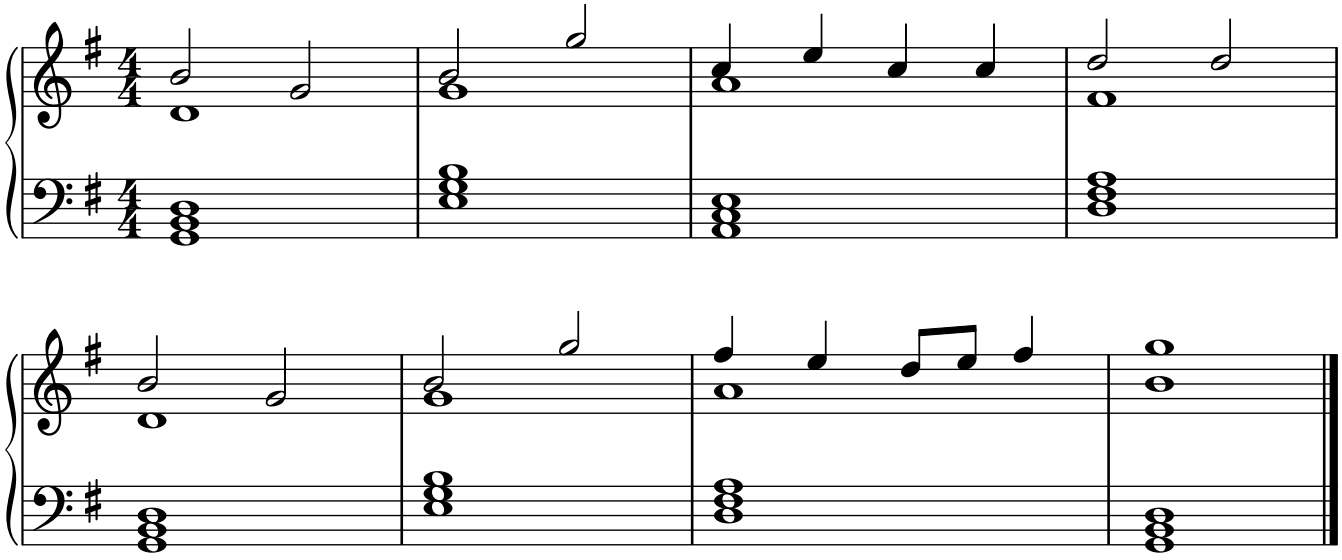
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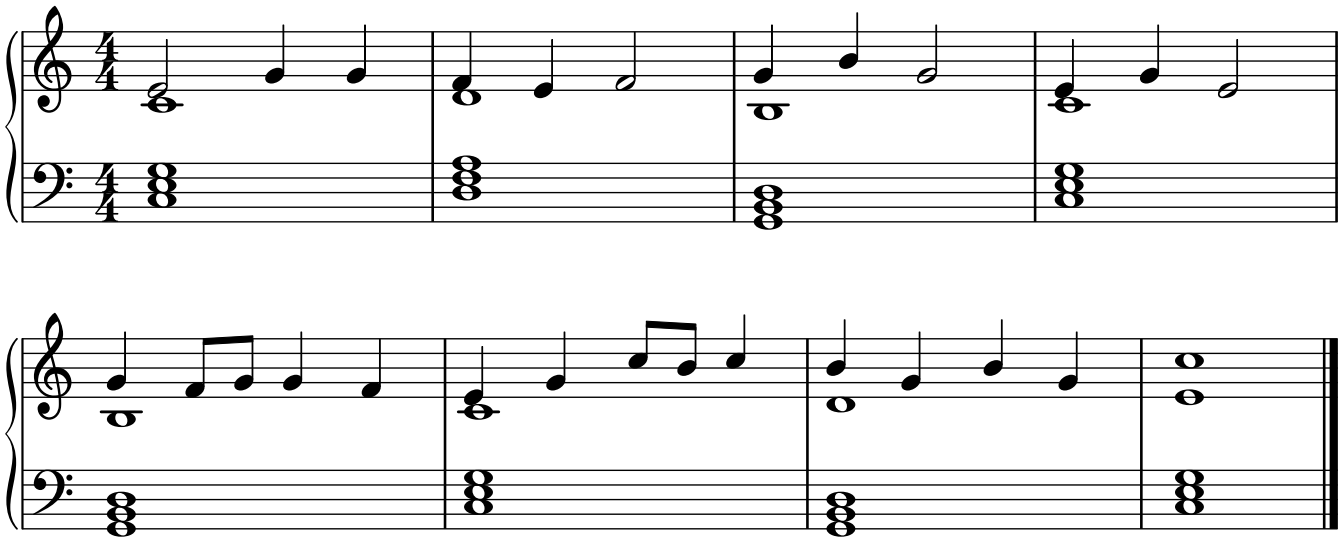
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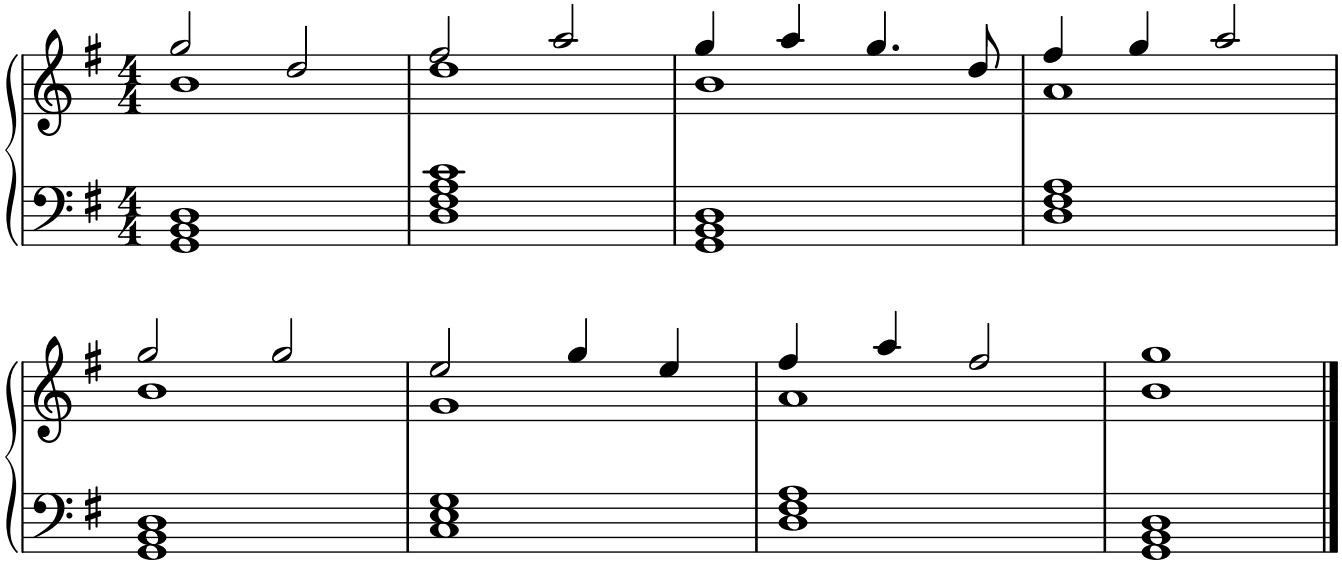
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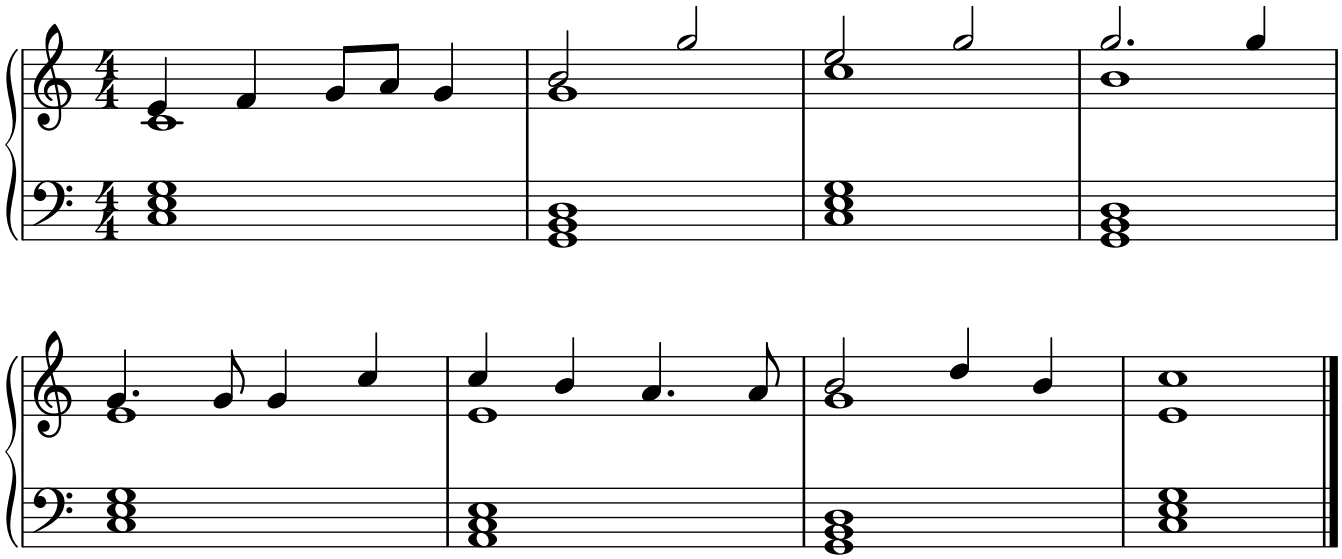


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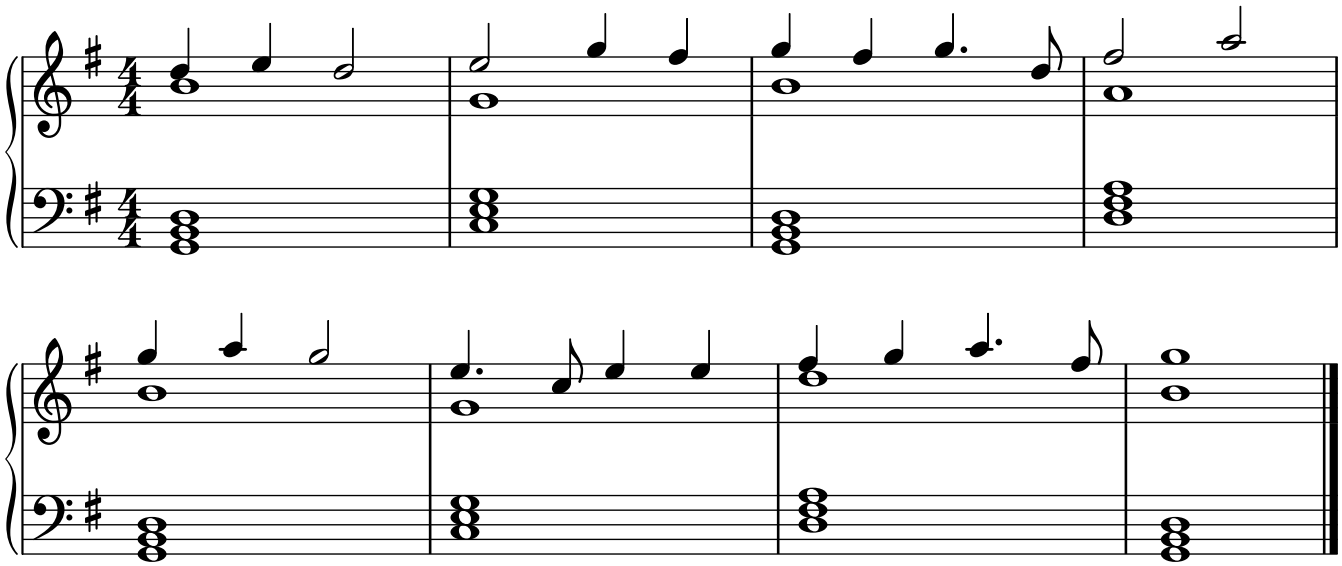
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☐ **1.7**
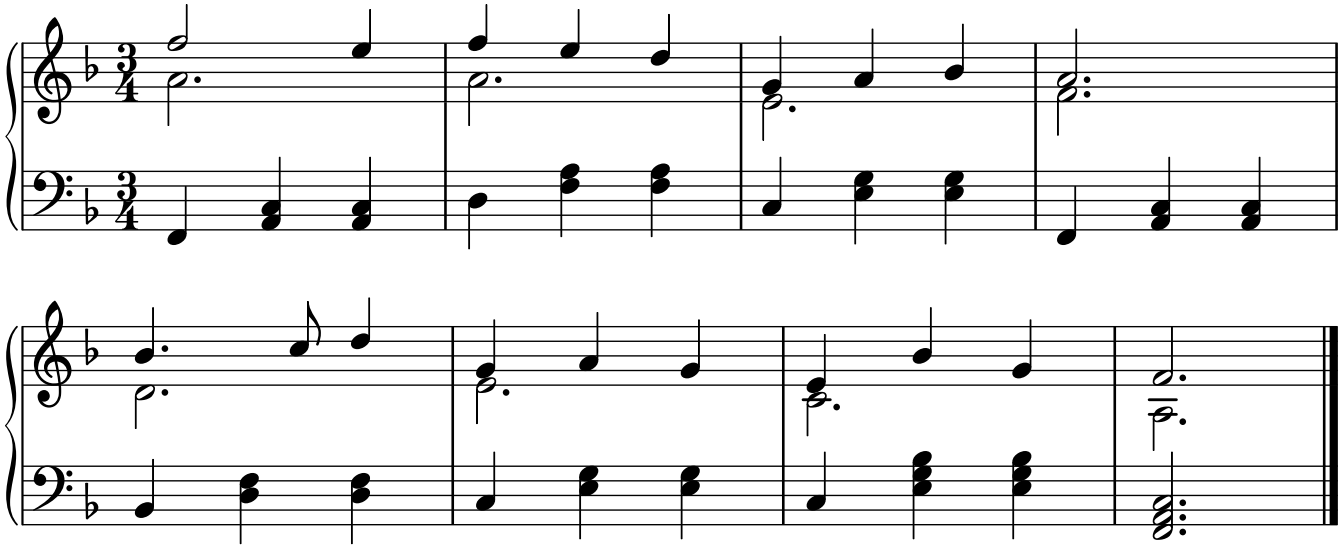


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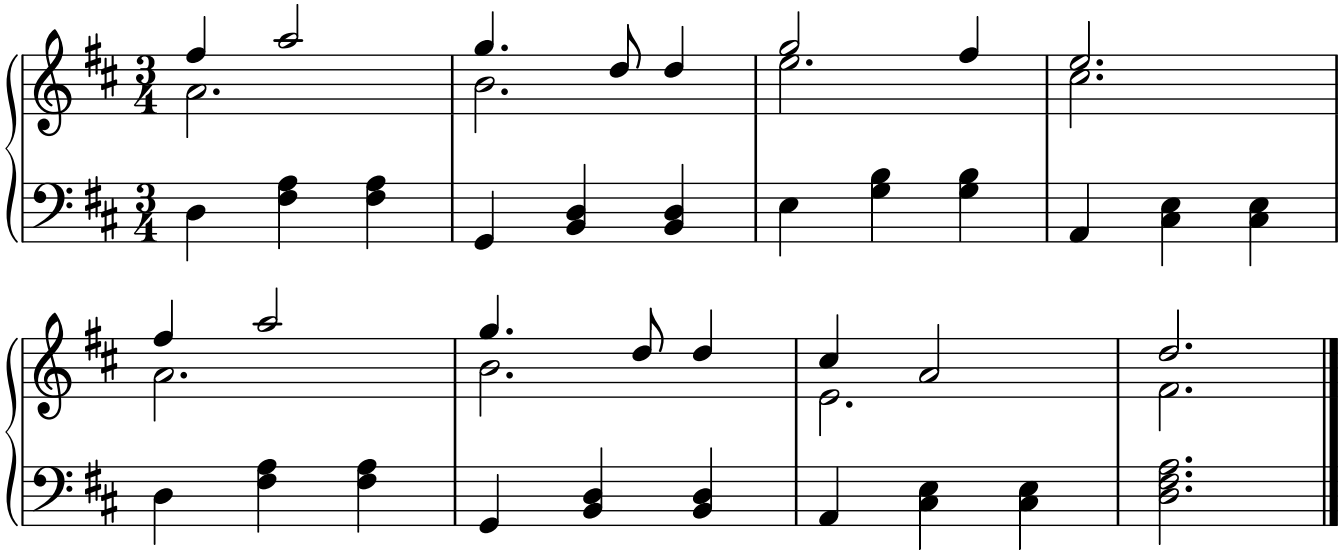


Part B: Held voices in 3/4 ♩ = 84

F major and D major in 3/4. The same two voices in the right hand, over a waltz bass.
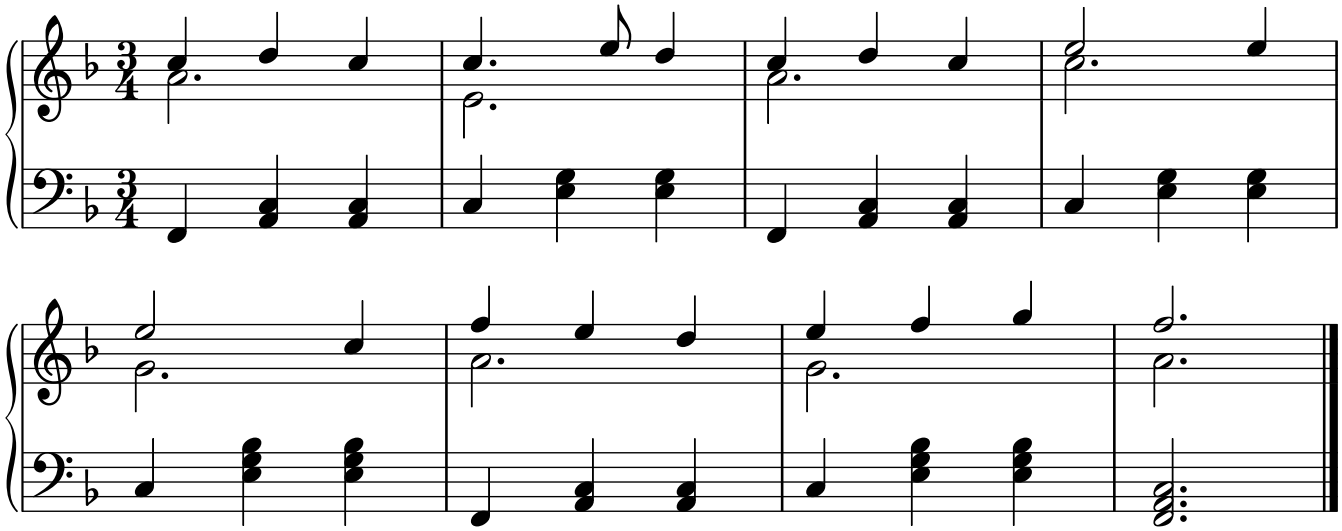
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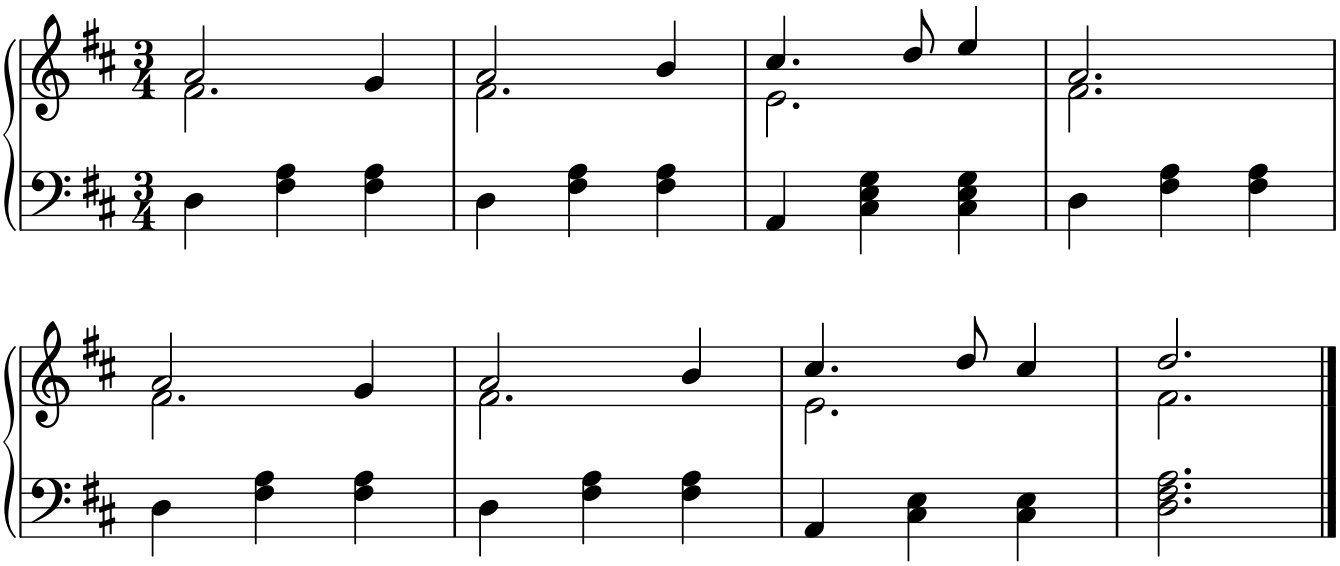


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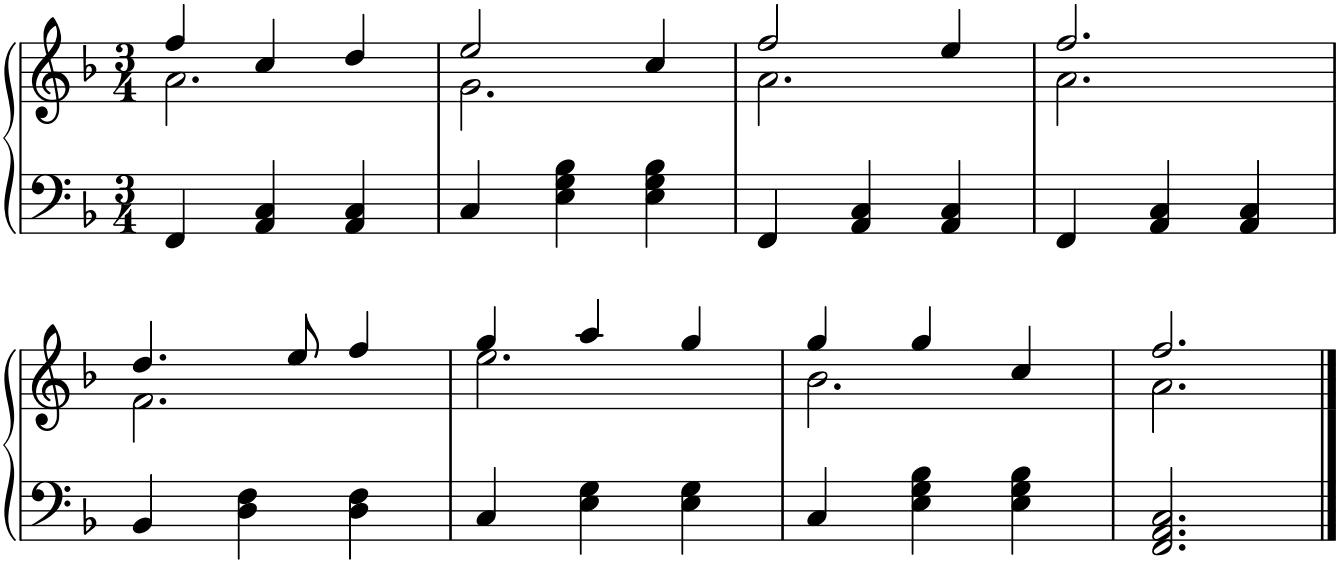


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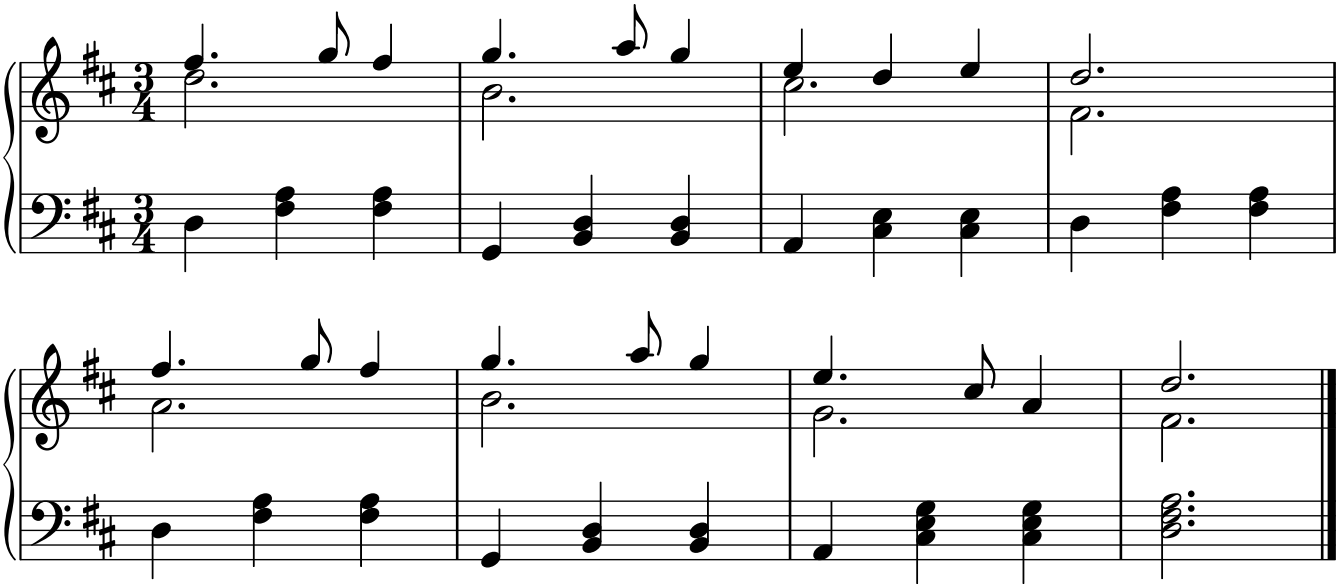


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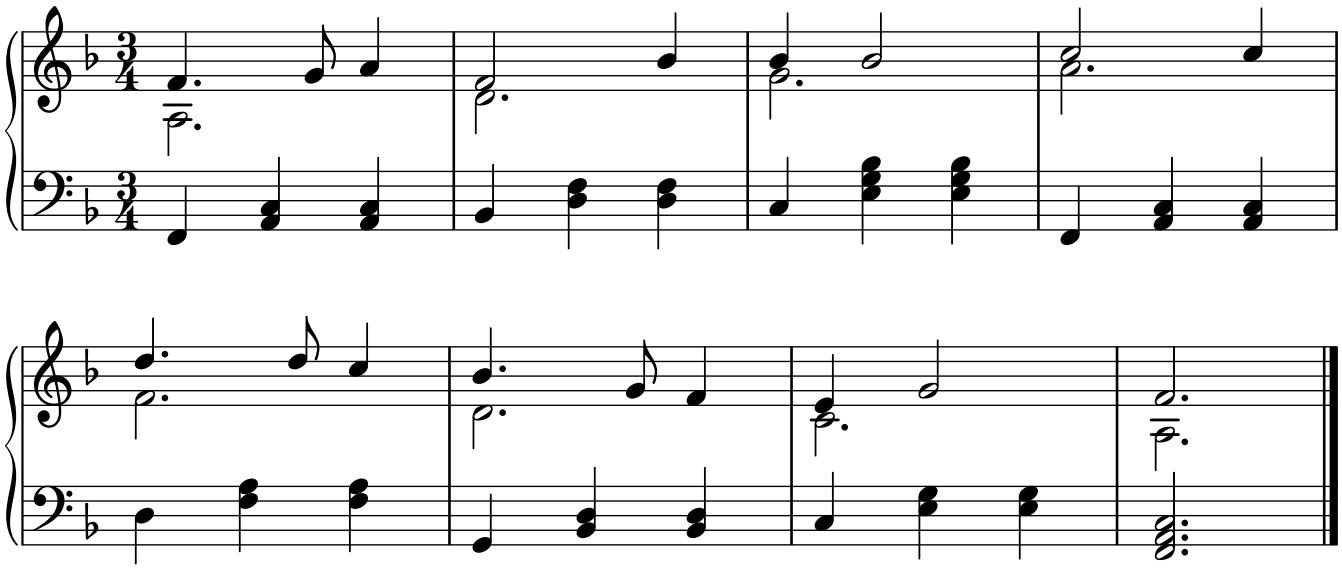


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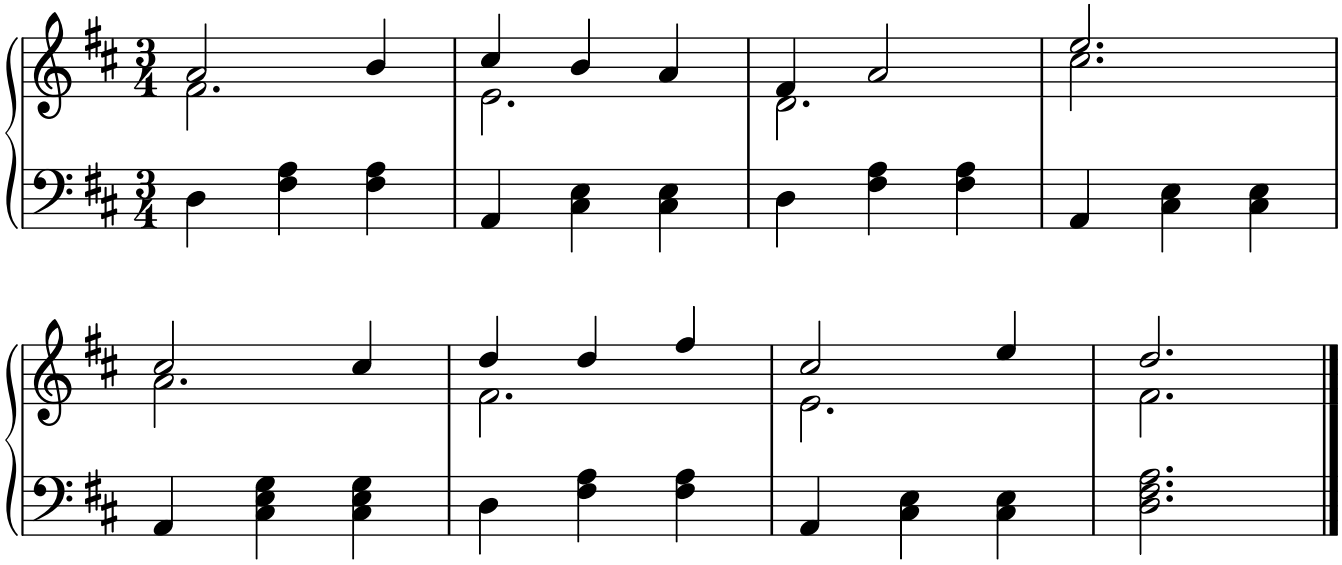


☐ **1.14**



1.15



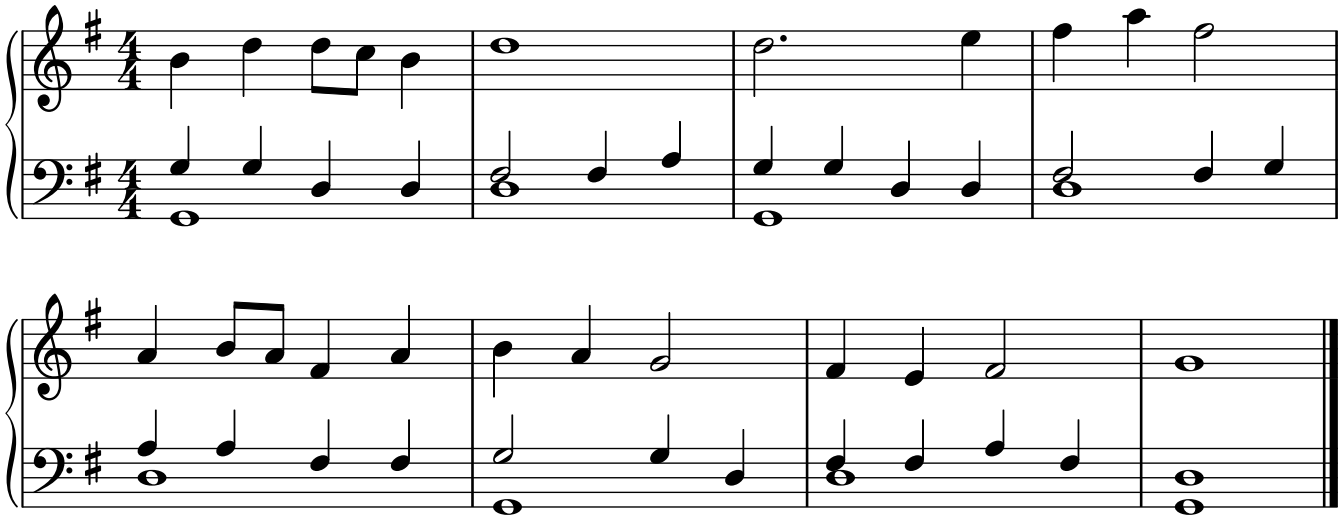
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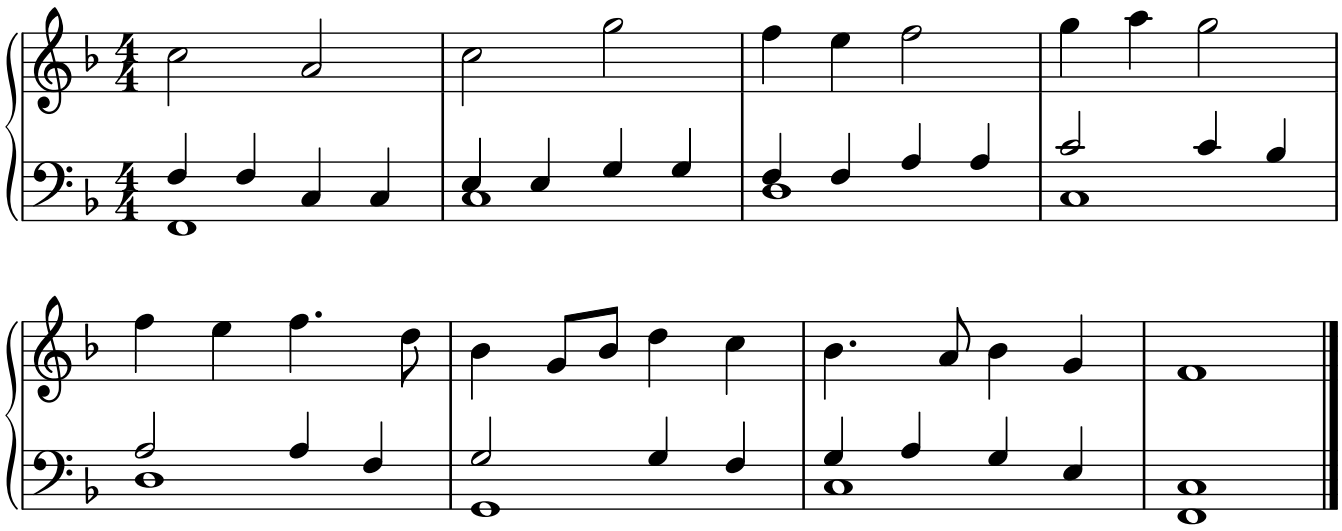


Part C: Two voices in the left hand ♩ = 60

G, F and B-flat major. The left hand holds the bass and plays a tenor line above it; the tune is in the right hand.
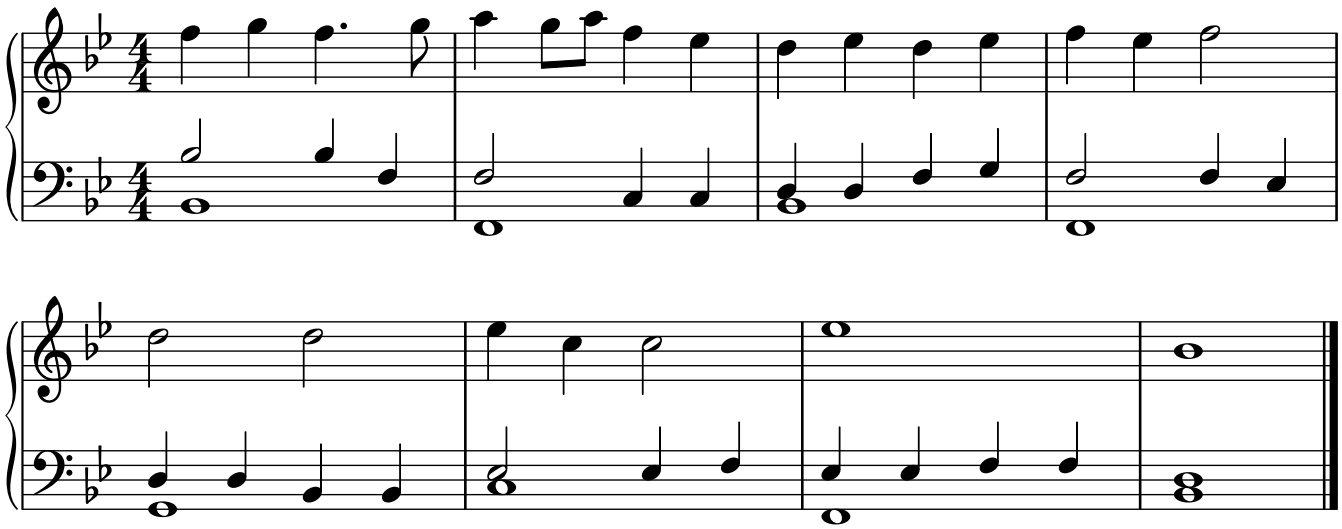
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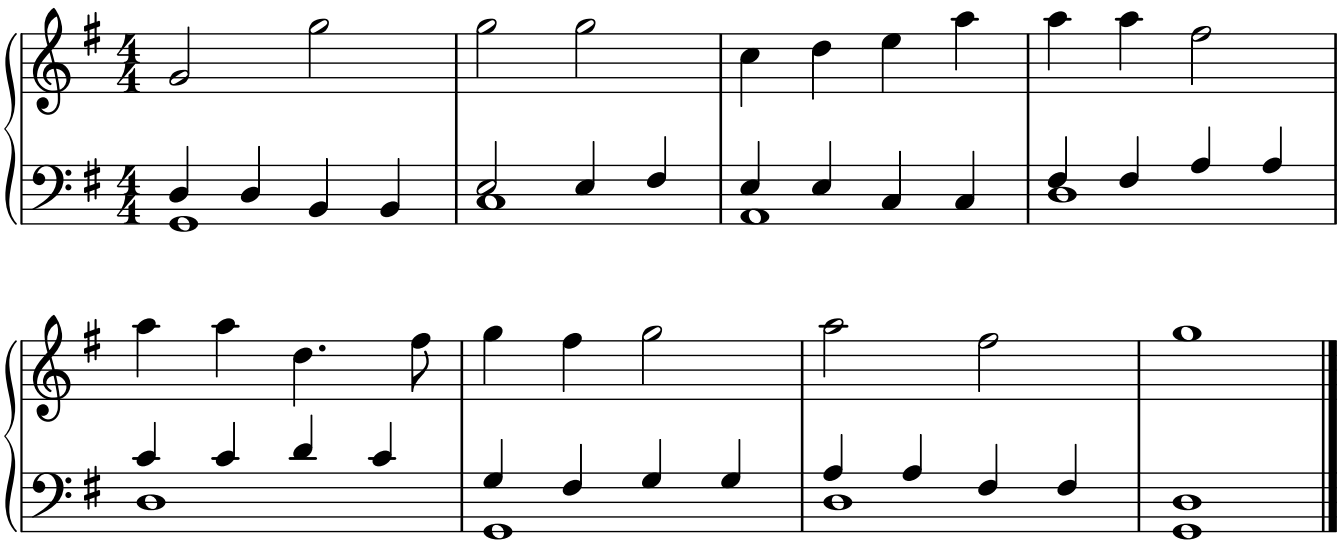
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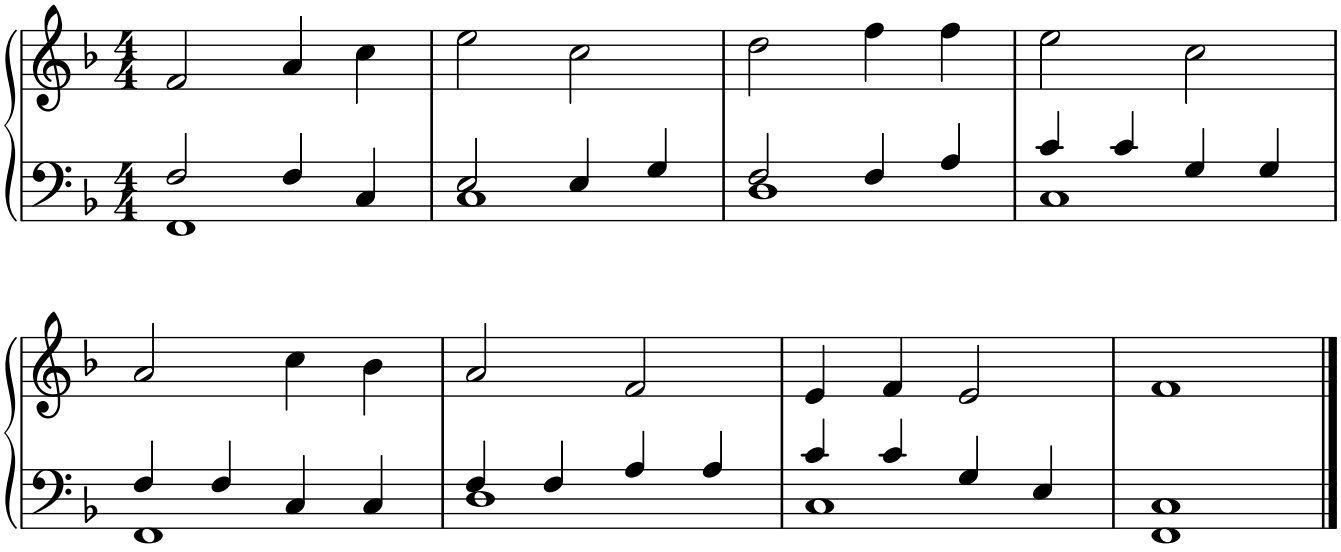
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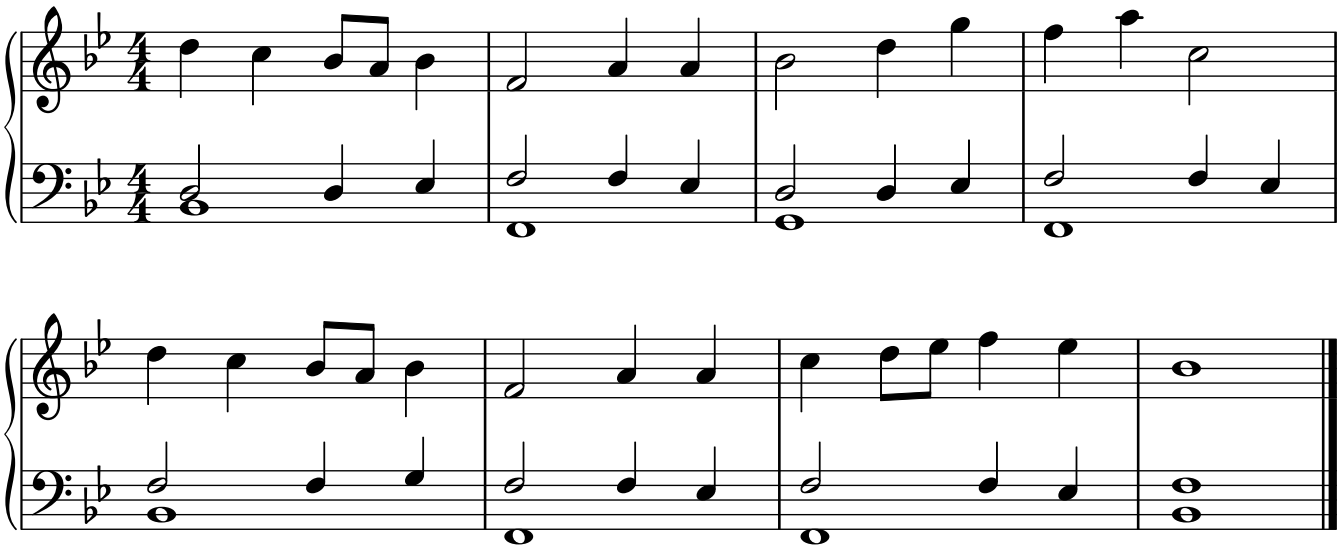


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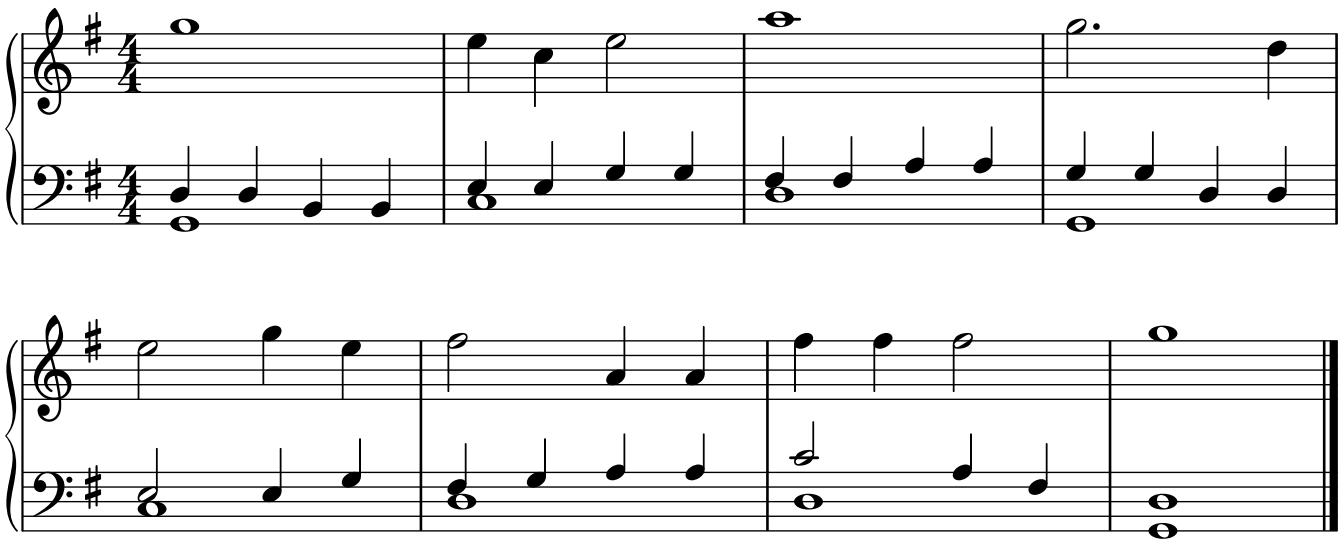
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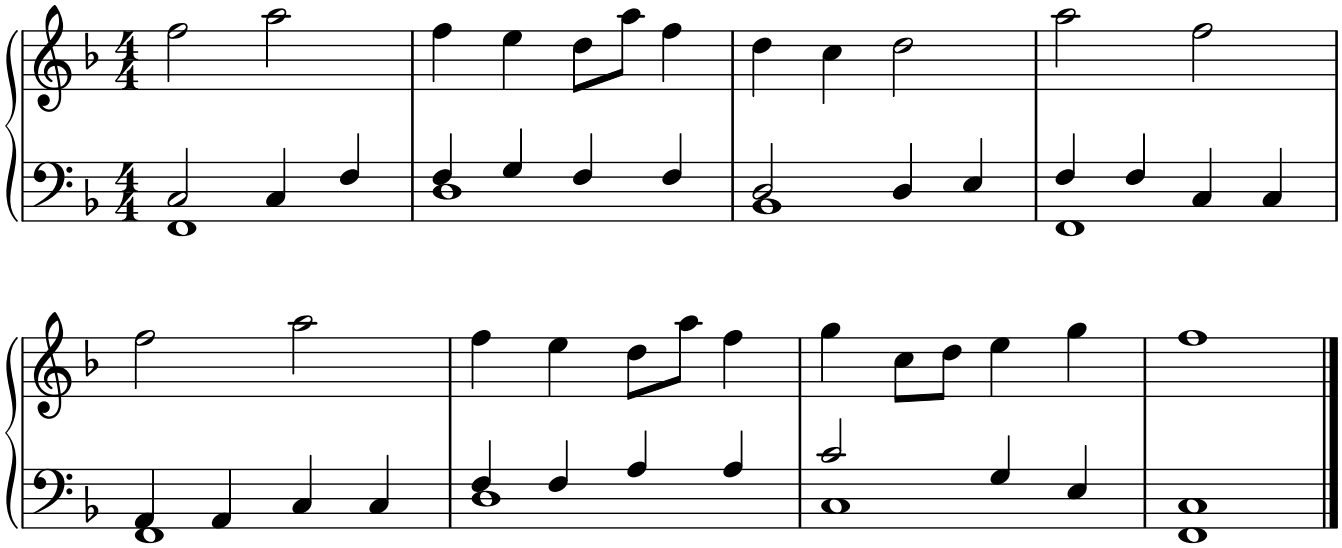


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☐ **1.23**



☐ **1.24**
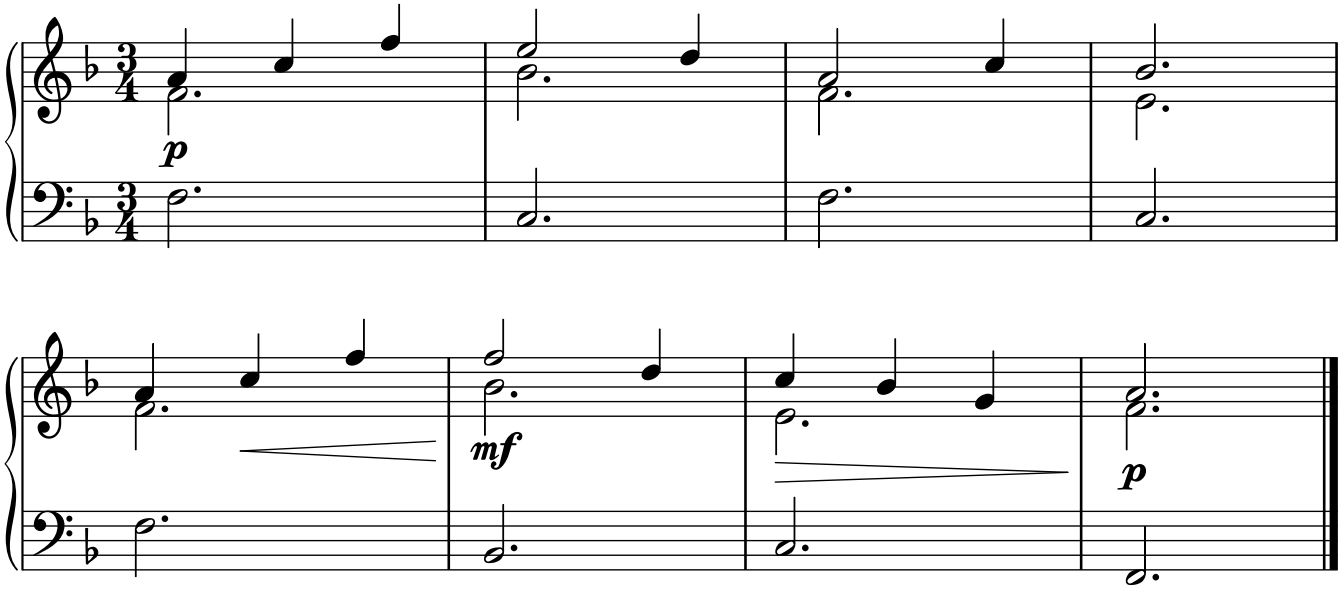


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Evening Bells ♩ = 80

Original
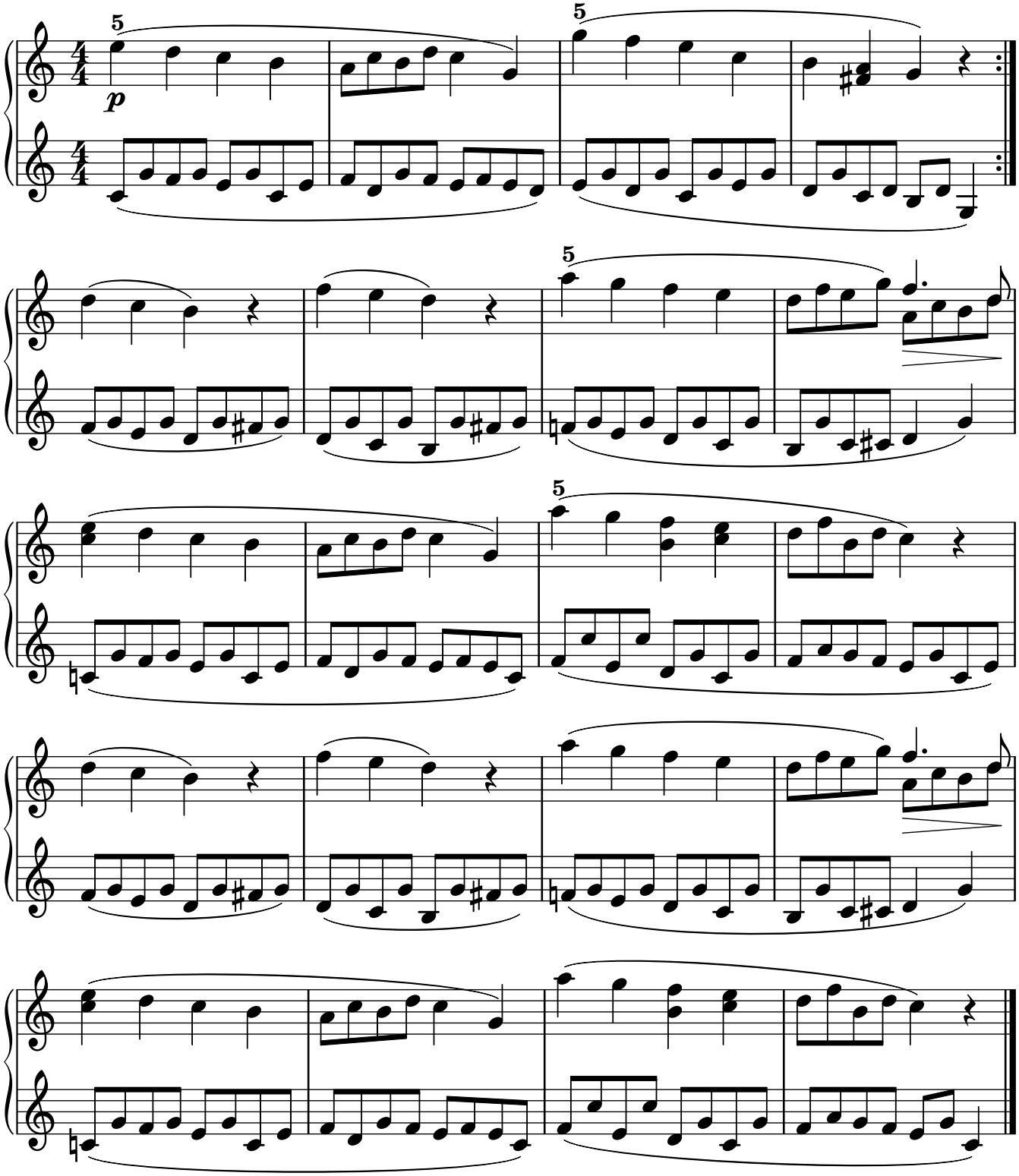
The right hand plays two voices: a tune with stems up, and a held note with stems down in every bar. Hold the lower note with the thumb (or finger 2 for the B-flats).



Melody ♩ = 72

Robert Schumann (1848), Album for the Young, Op. 68 No. 1 - complete
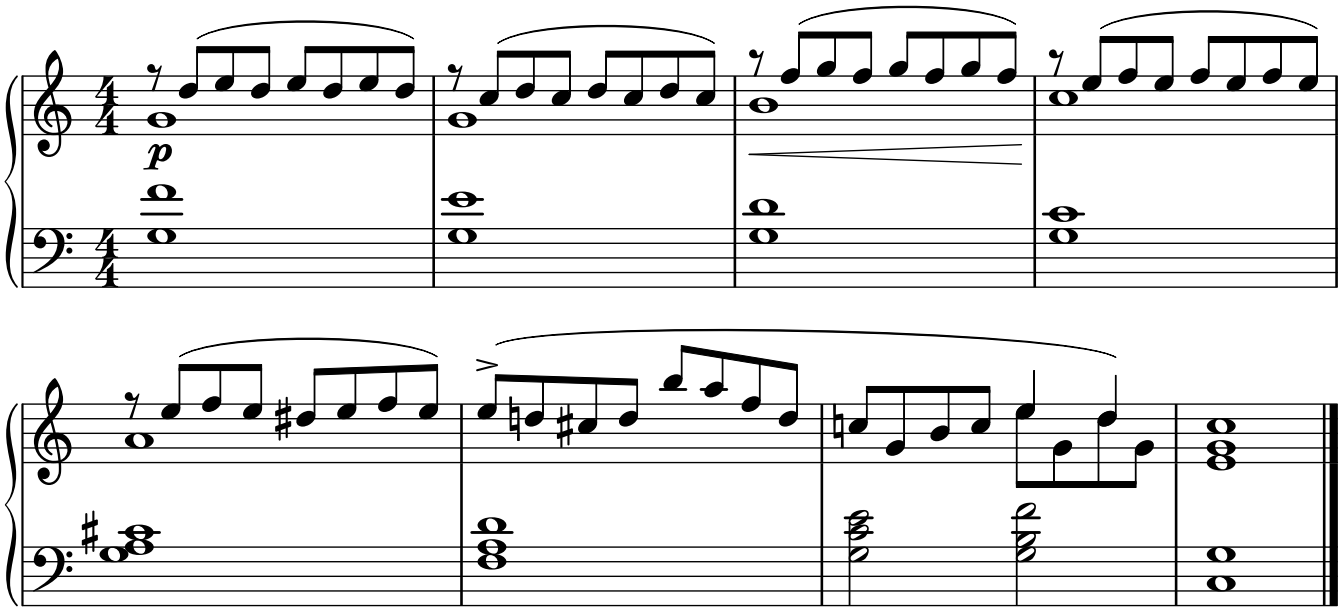
The first piece of Schumann's Album for the Young. The left hand plays above middle C, so it is written in the treble clef: read it like right-hand music. Its eighth notes are really two voices, a moving line and a repeated G above it. In bars 7 and 15 the right hand splits into two voices, and in bars 10 and 18 it jumps up from G to the high A. Play the repeat sign at bar 4: go back to the start once. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 647 by Philippe Hezaine (CC BY-SA 2.5).



Consolation ♩ = 72

Friedrich Burgmuller (1851), 25 Easy Studies, Op. 100 No. 13 - the introduction, with a closing chord added
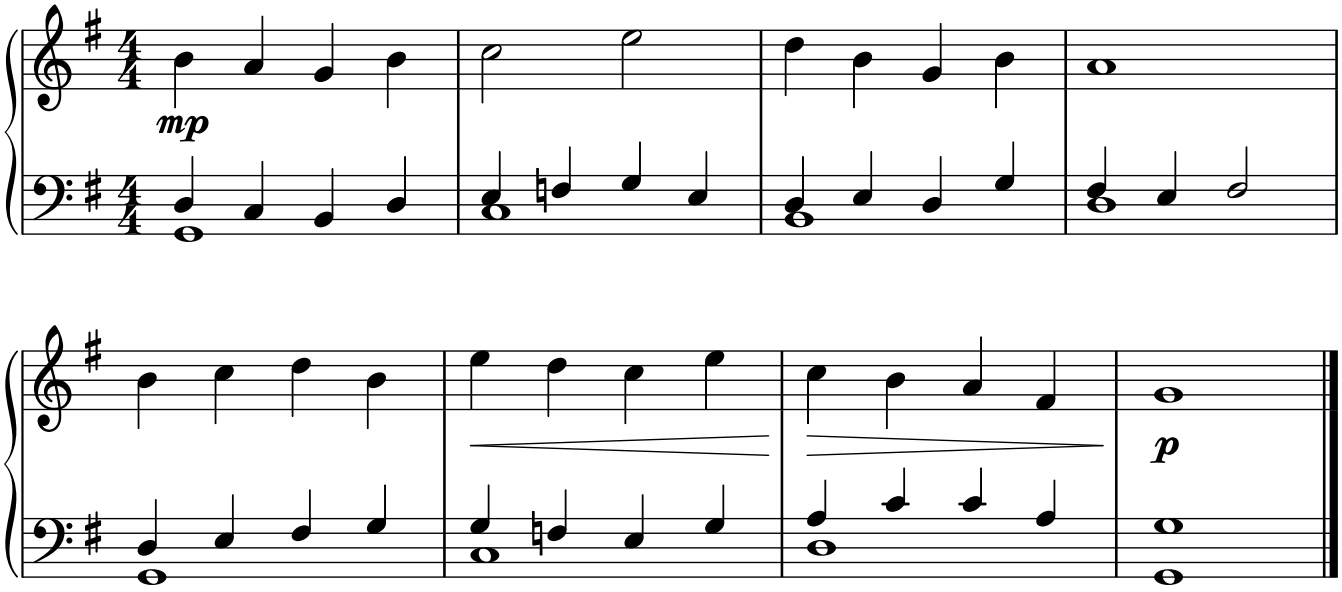
The right hand holds a long note (stems down) while its upper fingers rock between two notes. In bar 6 the two voices join into one line, and in bar 7 the tune (stems up) shares its notes with the eighth notes below it. The left hand reads above middle C with ledger lines. Source: Mutopia Project no. 224 (public domain).



Hymn with a Moving Tenor ♩ = 72

Original

Now the left hand has the two voices: the bass holds a whole note (stems down) while the tenor walks in quarter notes above it (stems up). Hold the bass with finger 5.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 2?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if every held note lasts its full length while the other voice keeps moving.
- Pass if you can play Evening Bells and the Hymn at sight, steadily, and Schumann's Melody after a week's practice.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 2.

Unit 2

Chorales

New: Four voices on two staves; chords on every degree of the scale, and first inversions

A chorale is a hymn tune harmonised in four voices: soprano, alto, tenor and bass. On the piano the right hand plays the soprano (stems up) and the alto (stems down) on the treble staff, and the left hand plays the tenor (stems up) and the bass (stems down) on the bass staff. Every beat is a new chord, so you read vertically: one chord at a time, top to bottom, then the next.

Bach harmonised hundreds of chorales, and organists and church pianists have read them at sight for three hundred years. They are the best training there is for reading chords.

What is new

Four voices on two staves

Soprano and alto share the treble staff, tenor and bass the bass staff. Stems up for the higher voice of each pair, stems down for the lower.

Chords on every degree

Besides I, IV and V you will meet ii (D F A in C major) and vi (A C E), and V7. In a minor key the chords are i, iv, V (with the raised 7th) and VI.

First inversion

A chord with its third in the bass, such as C major with E in the bass, is in first inversion. It sounds lighter than a root-position chord and helps the bass move by step.

Fermatas
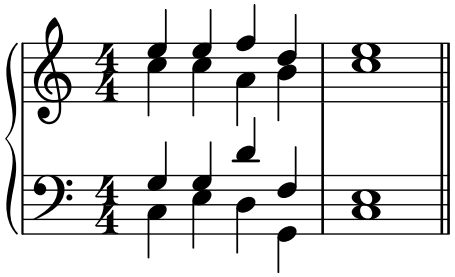
A fermata (a dot under an arch) marks the end of a line of the hymn. Hold the chord a little longer, breathe, and start the next line in time.

When the left hand can't reach

Sometimes the tenor sits more than an octave above the bass. Then the right hand takes the tenor note: an old organist's trick that every chorale player uses.

One chord, four voices

Soprano E, alto C (right hand); tenor G, bass C (left hand). Then the same chord in first inversion (E in the bass), then ii (D F A), V7 and I. The 7th of V7 (F, in the tenor) falls to E.
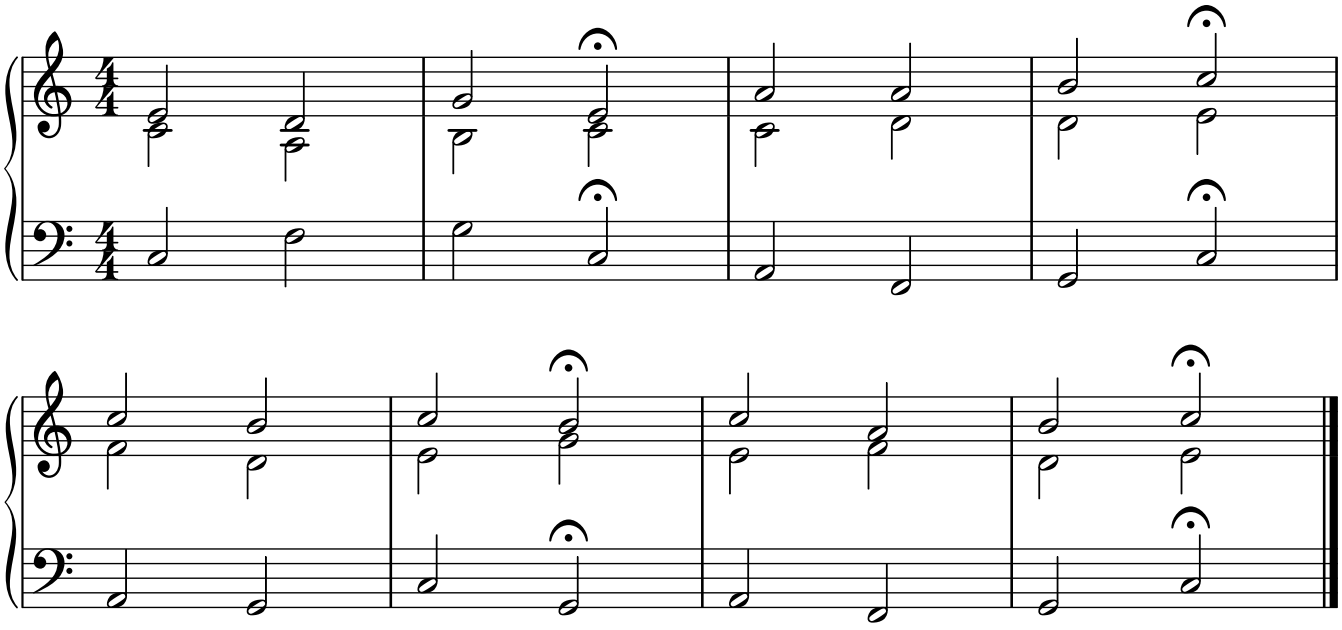


Reading tips

1. Read each chord from the bass up: it tells you which chord it is and whether it is inverted.
2. Most voices move by step or stay on the same note. Look for the notes that don't move: hold them.
3. Breathe at every fermata, as a choir would, but keep the beat underneath.
4. If four voices are too many at first, play soprano and bass only, then add the inner voices.

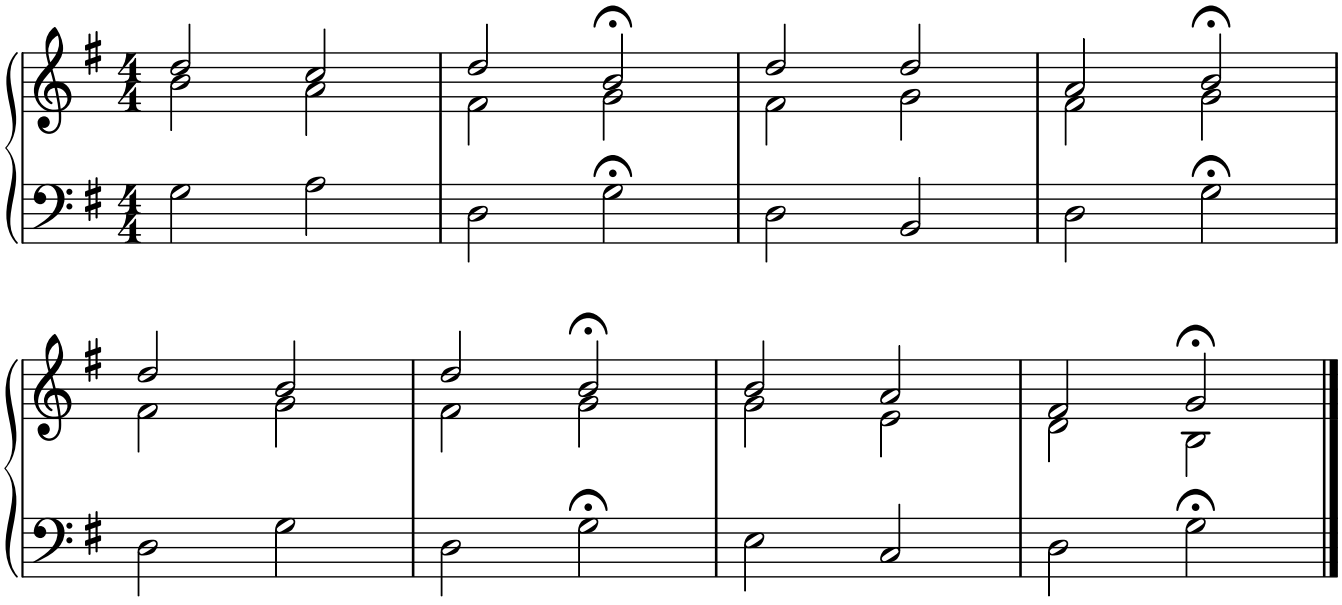
Part A: Three voices in half notes ♩ = 60

Three voices in half notes: soprano and alto in the right hand, the bass in the left. C, G and F major.

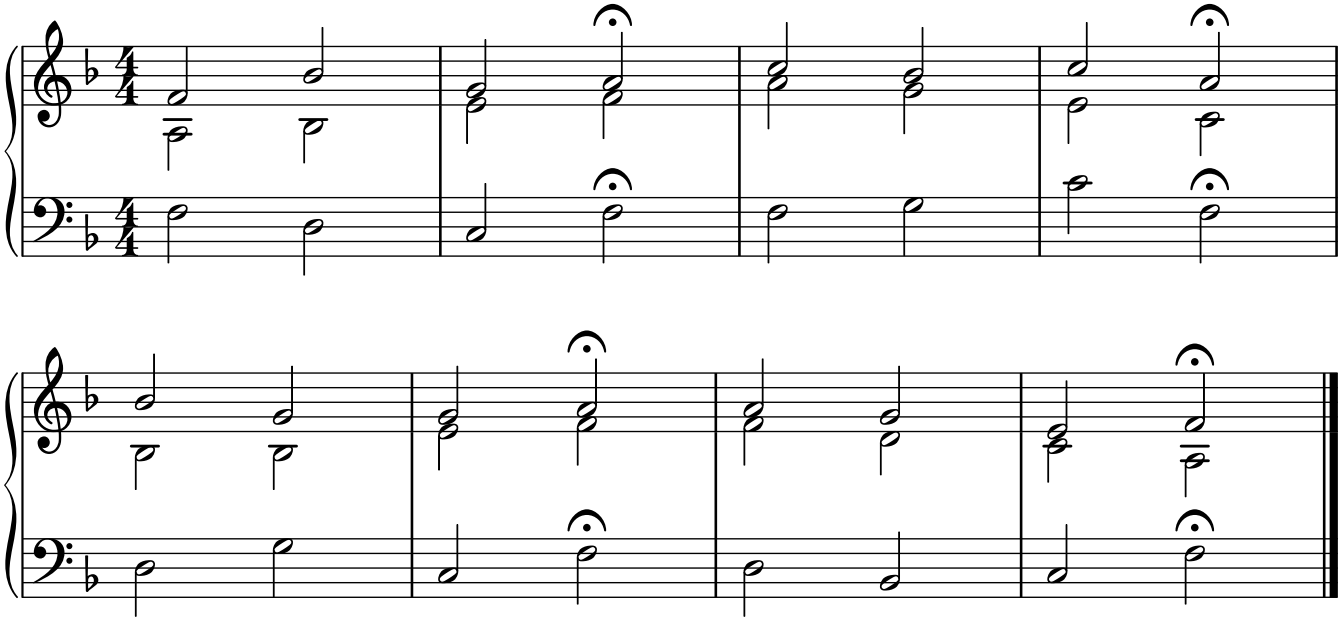
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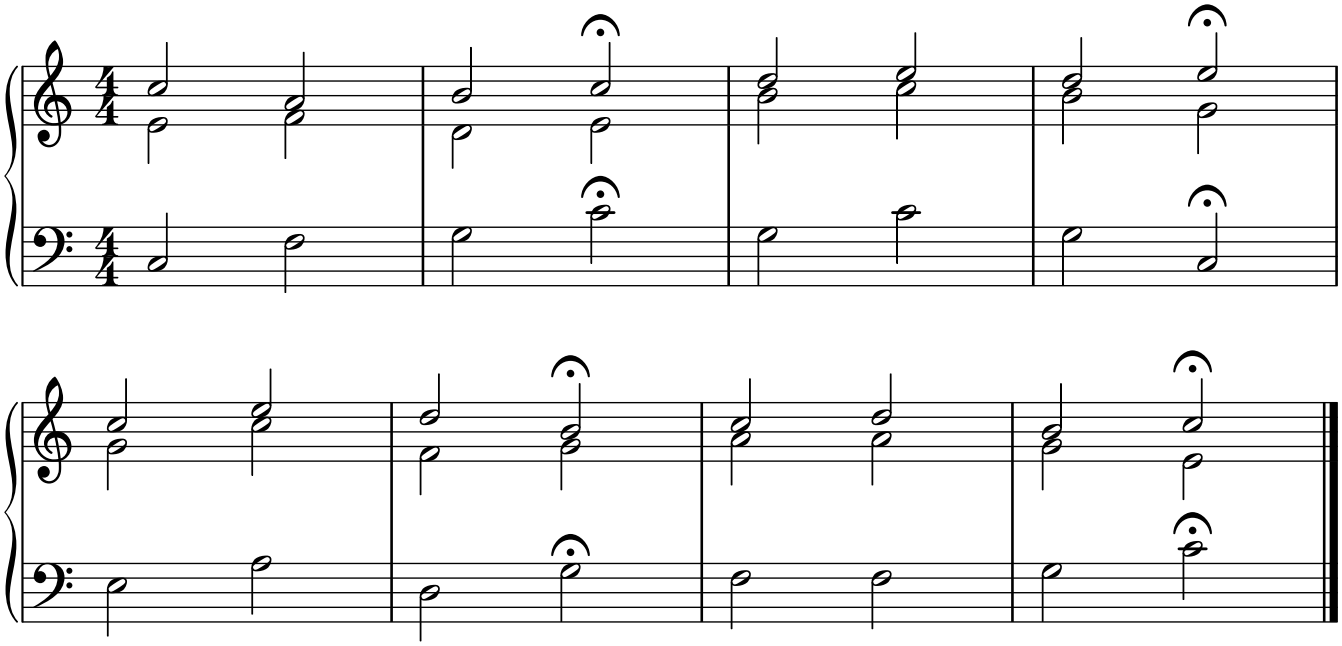


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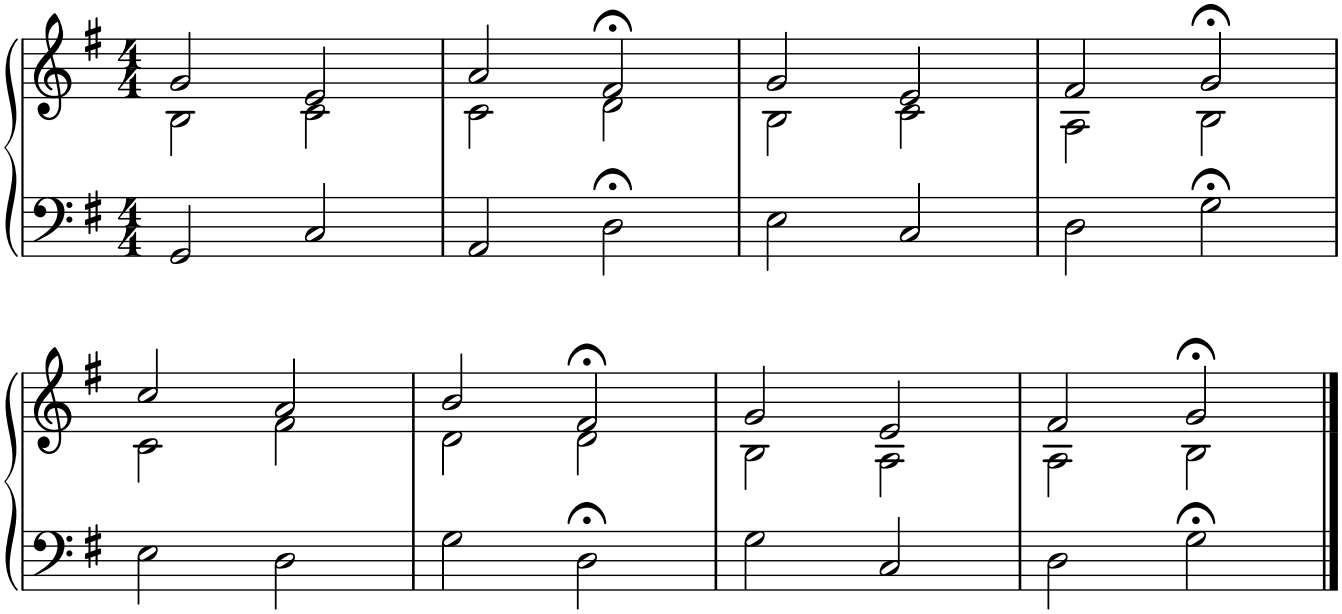


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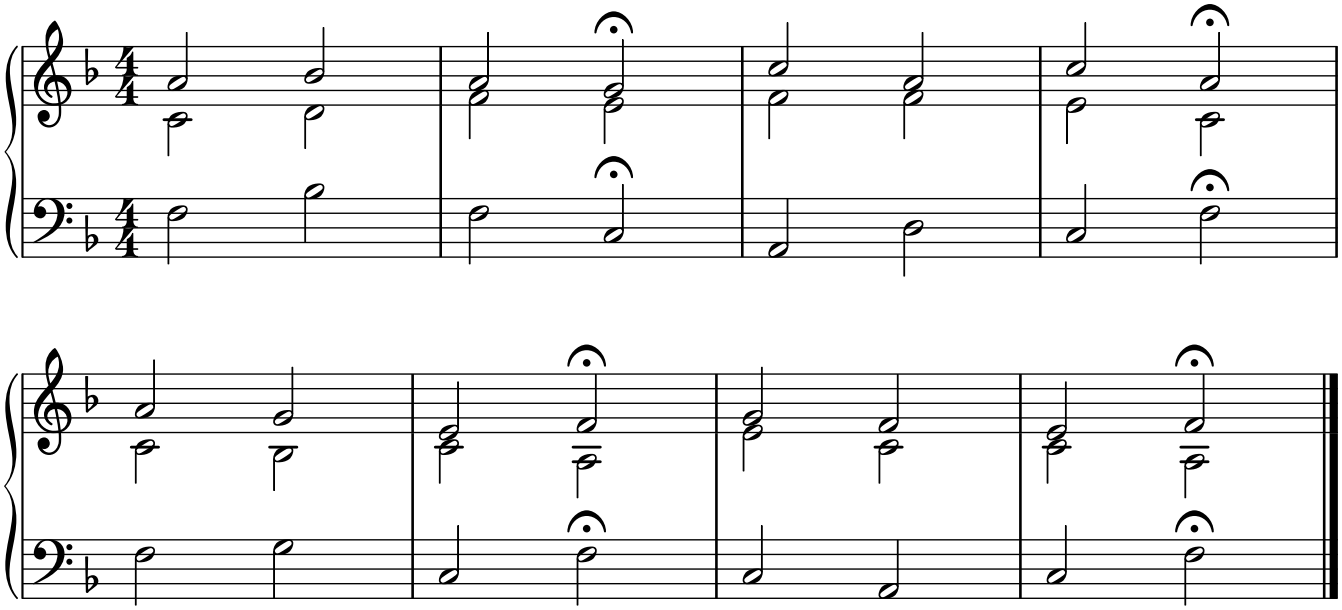


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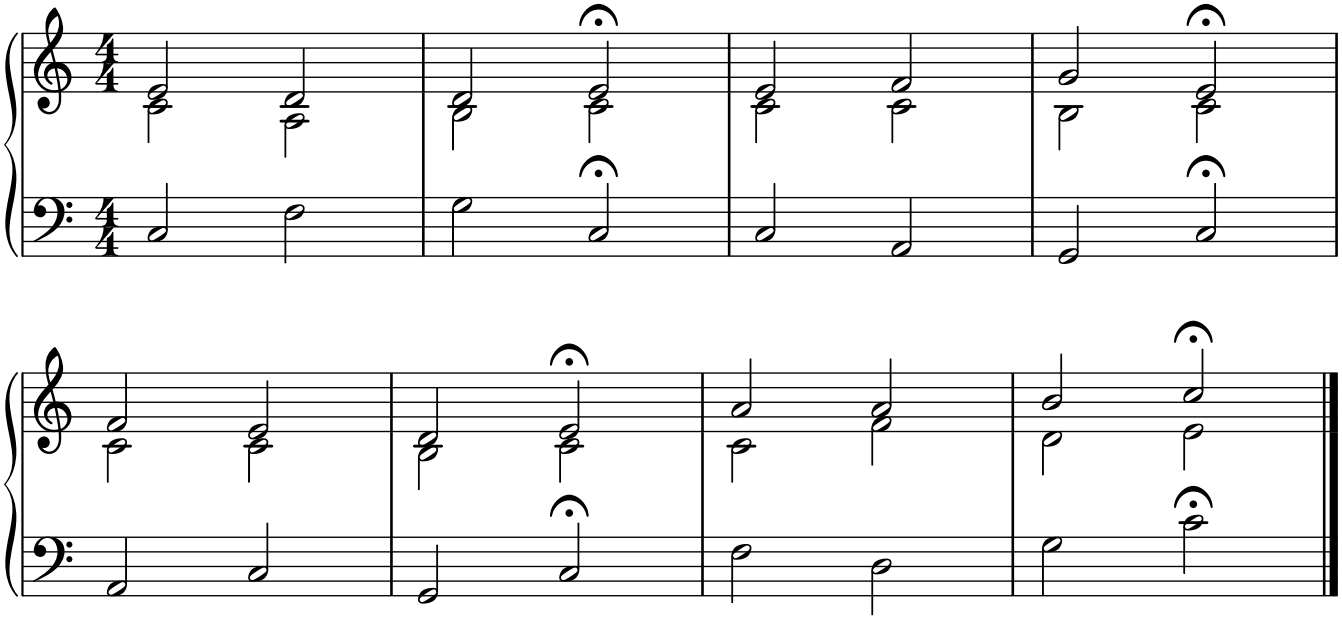


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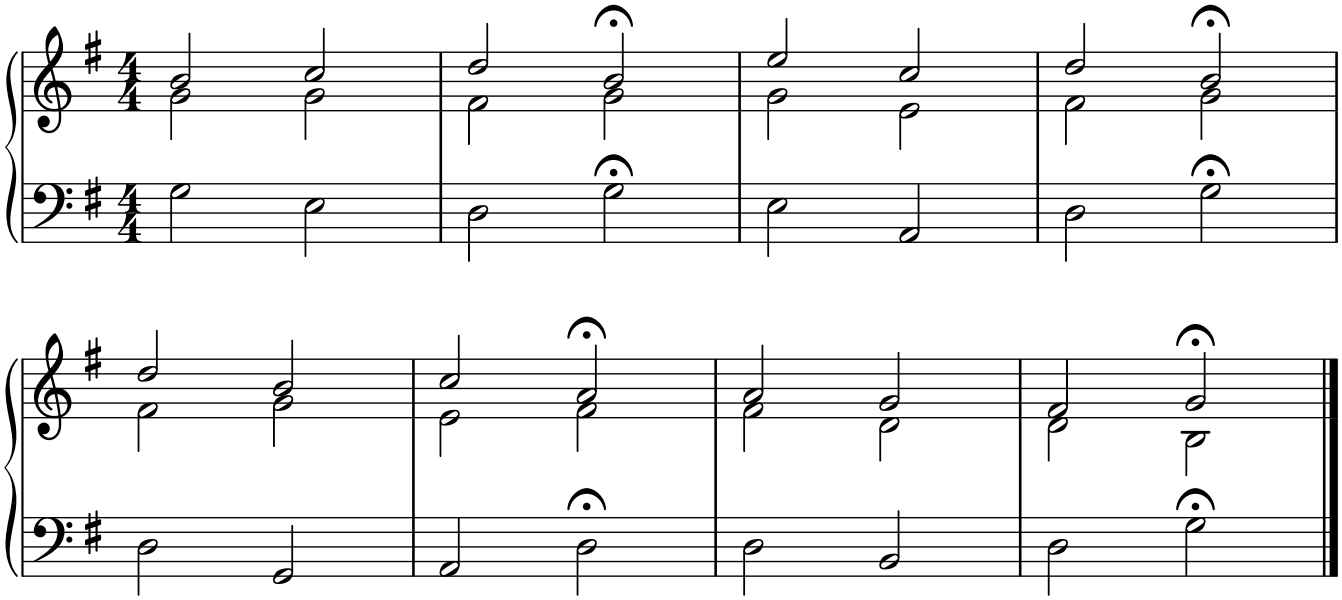
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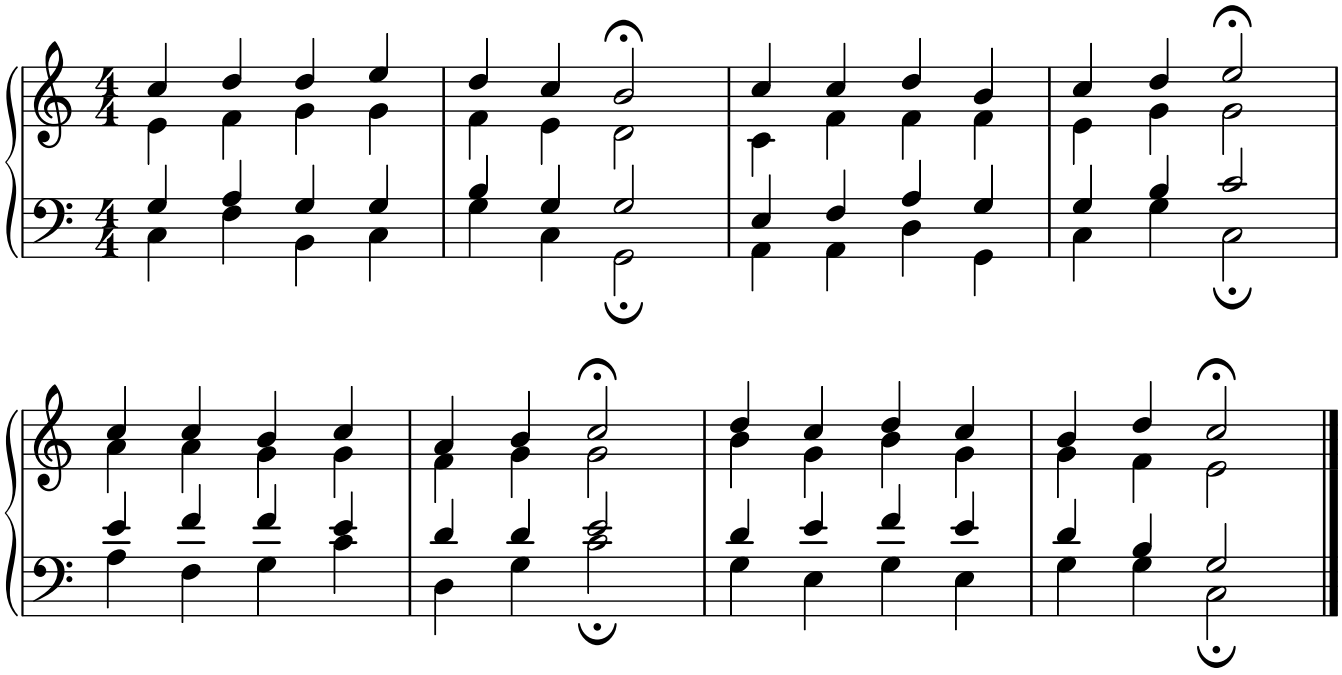


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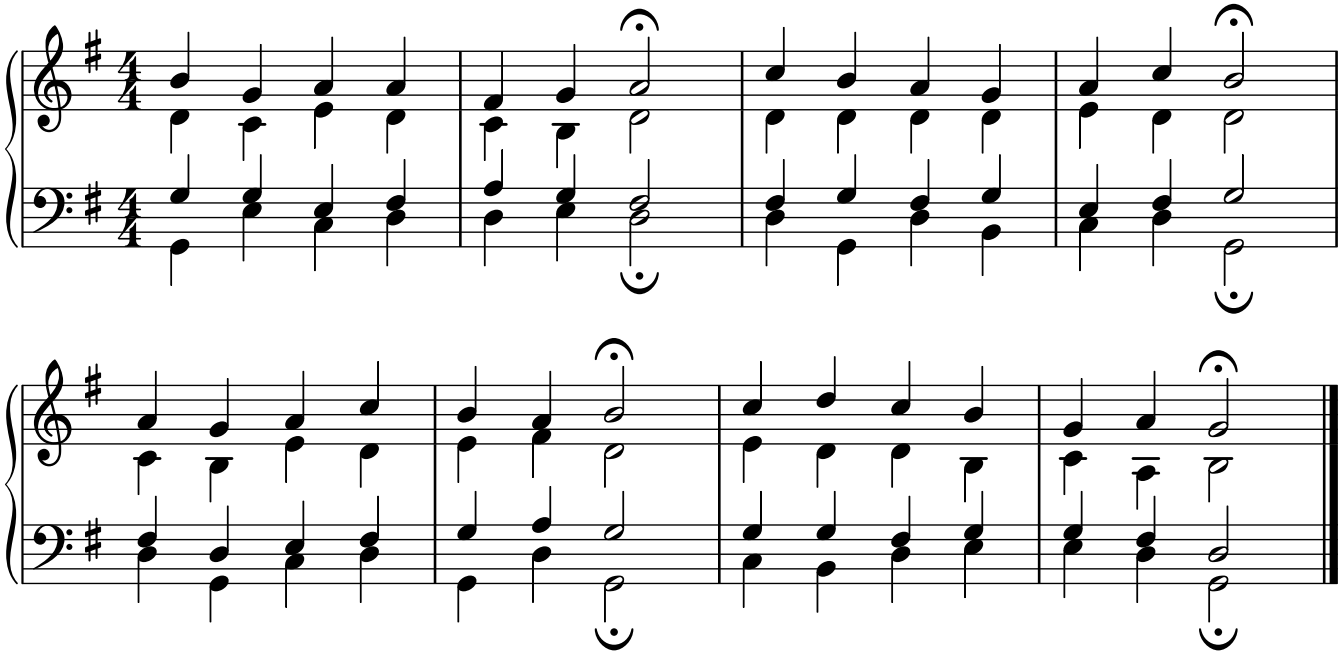
Part B: Four voices (SATB) ♩ = 60

Four voices in quarter notes, with fermatas at the end of each line. Look out for first inversions and for ii and vi. Keys with up to two sharps or flats.

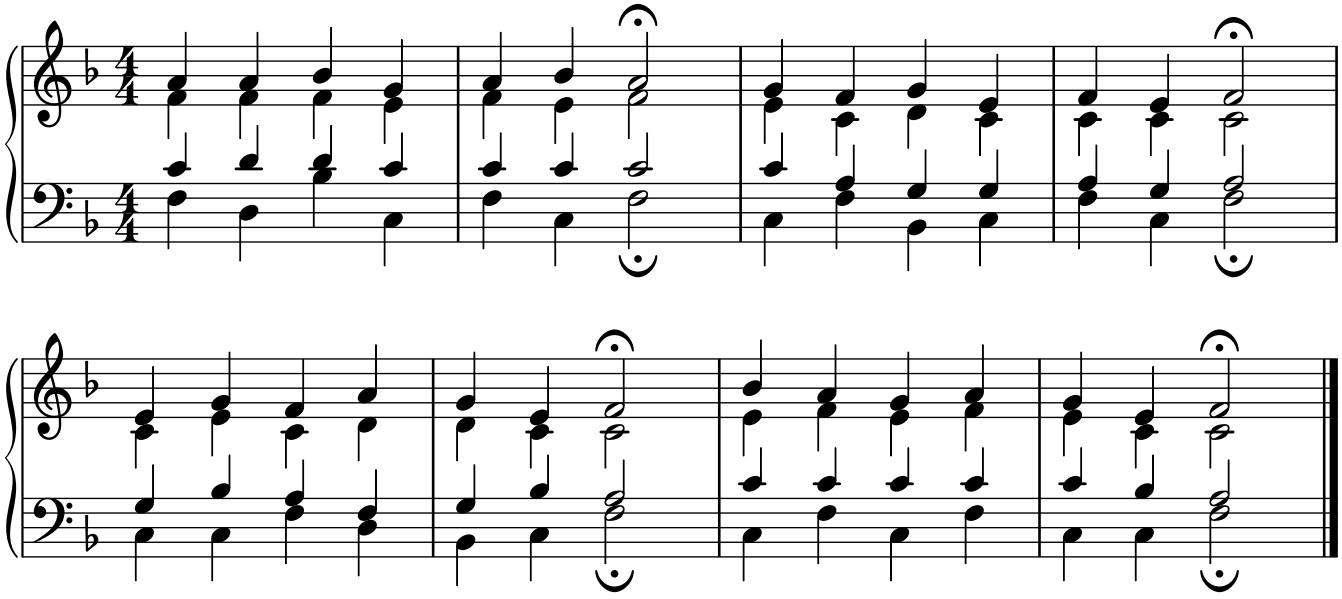
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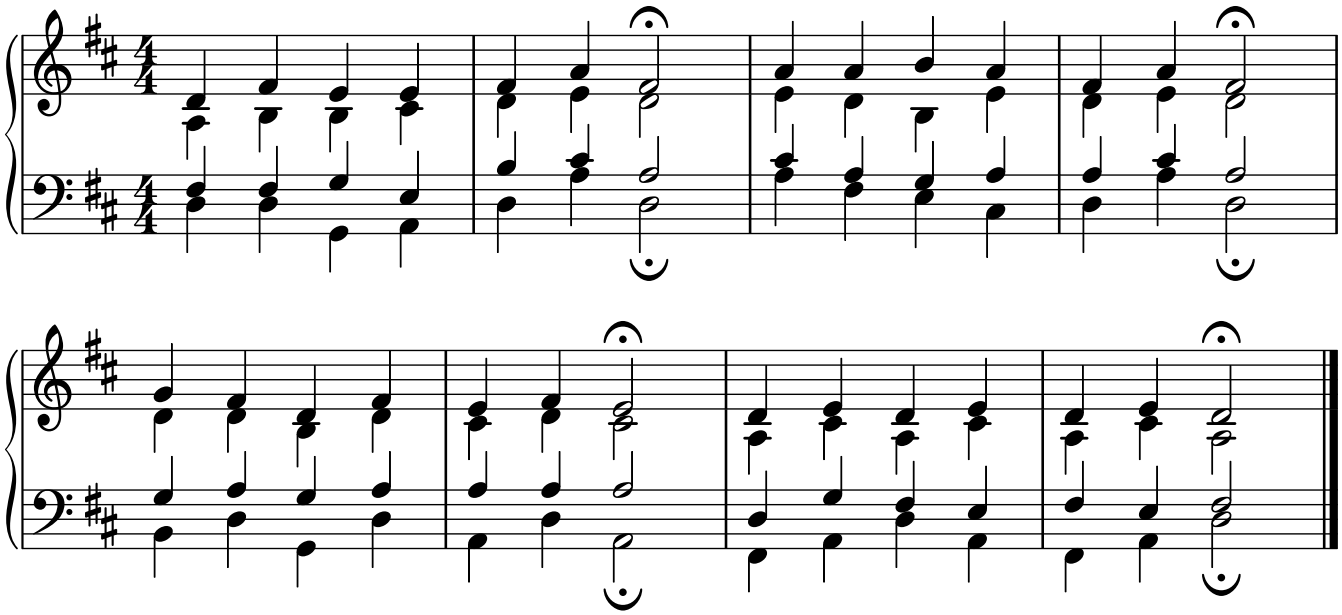
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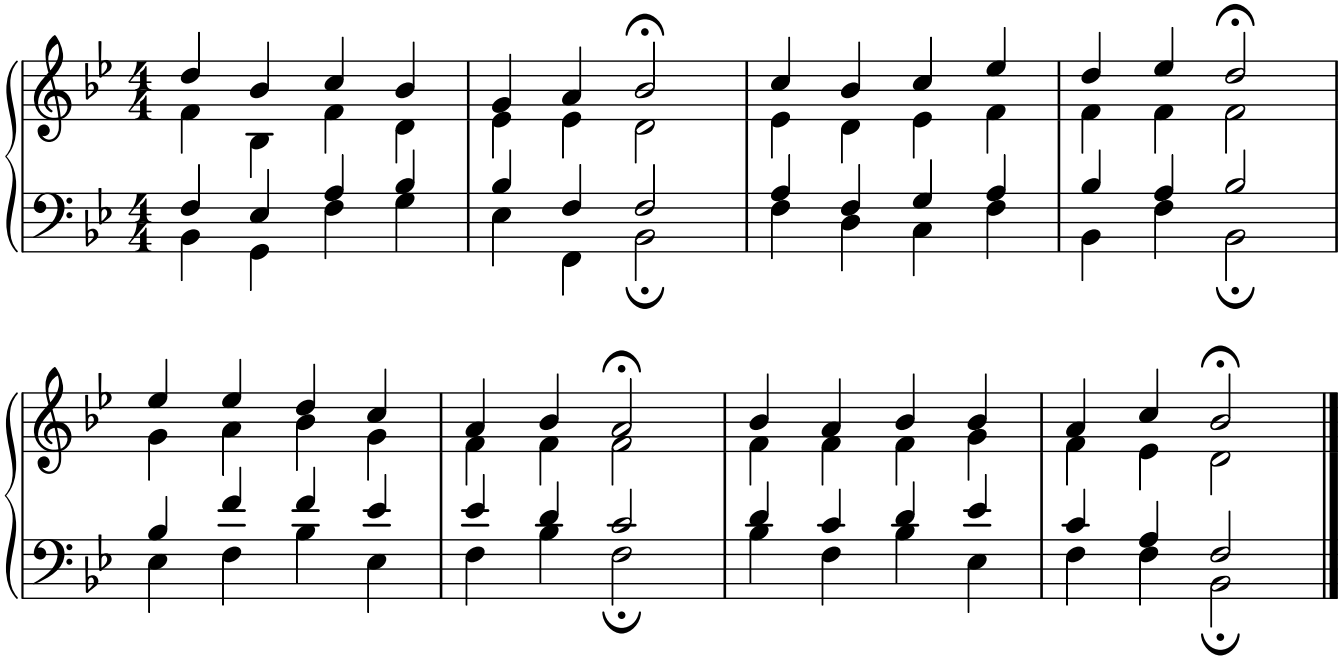


☐ **2.11**



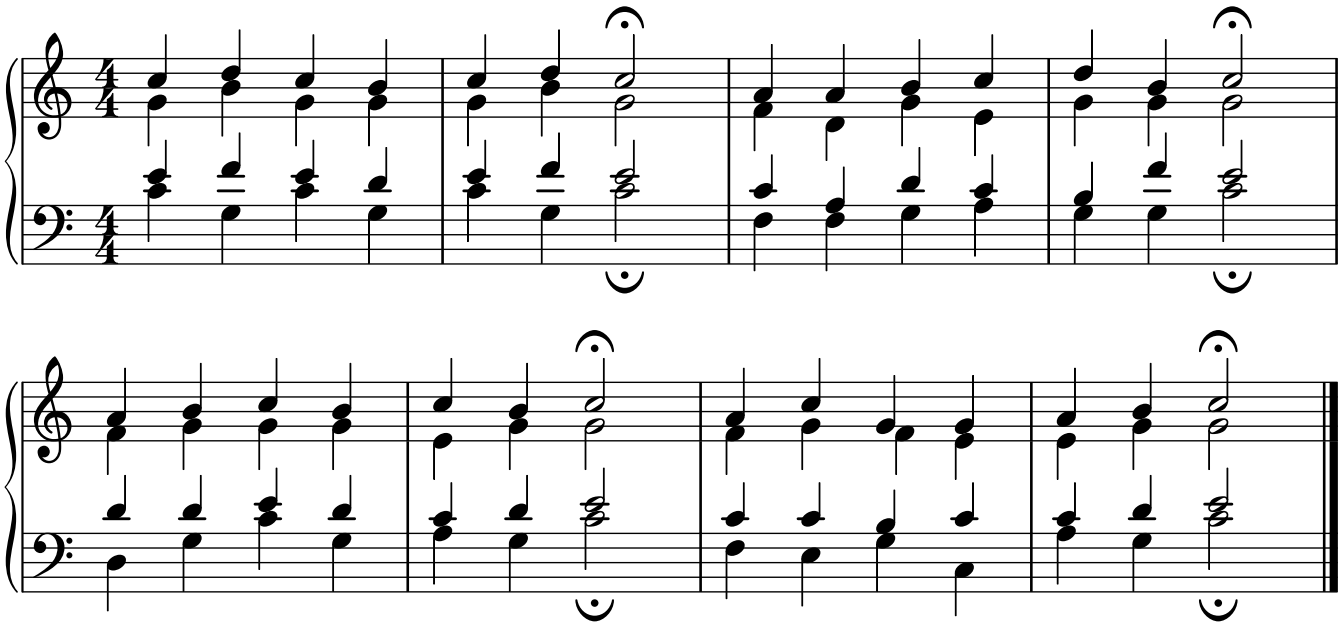
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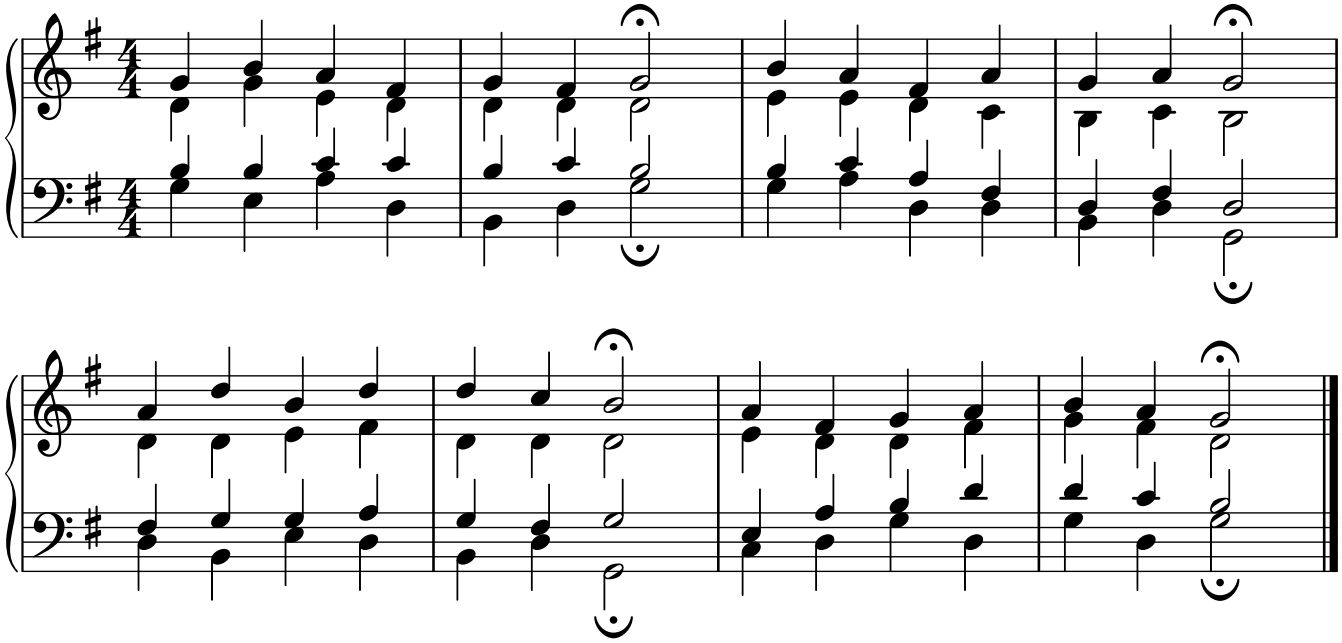


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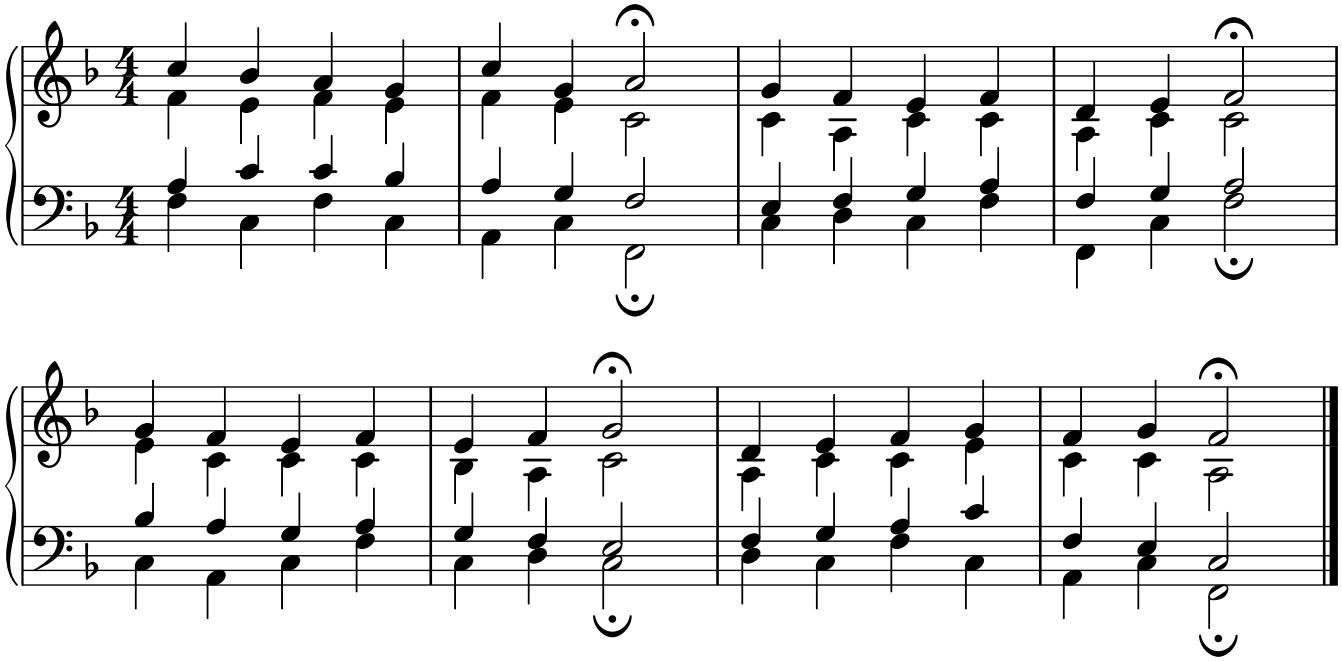
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☐ **2.15**
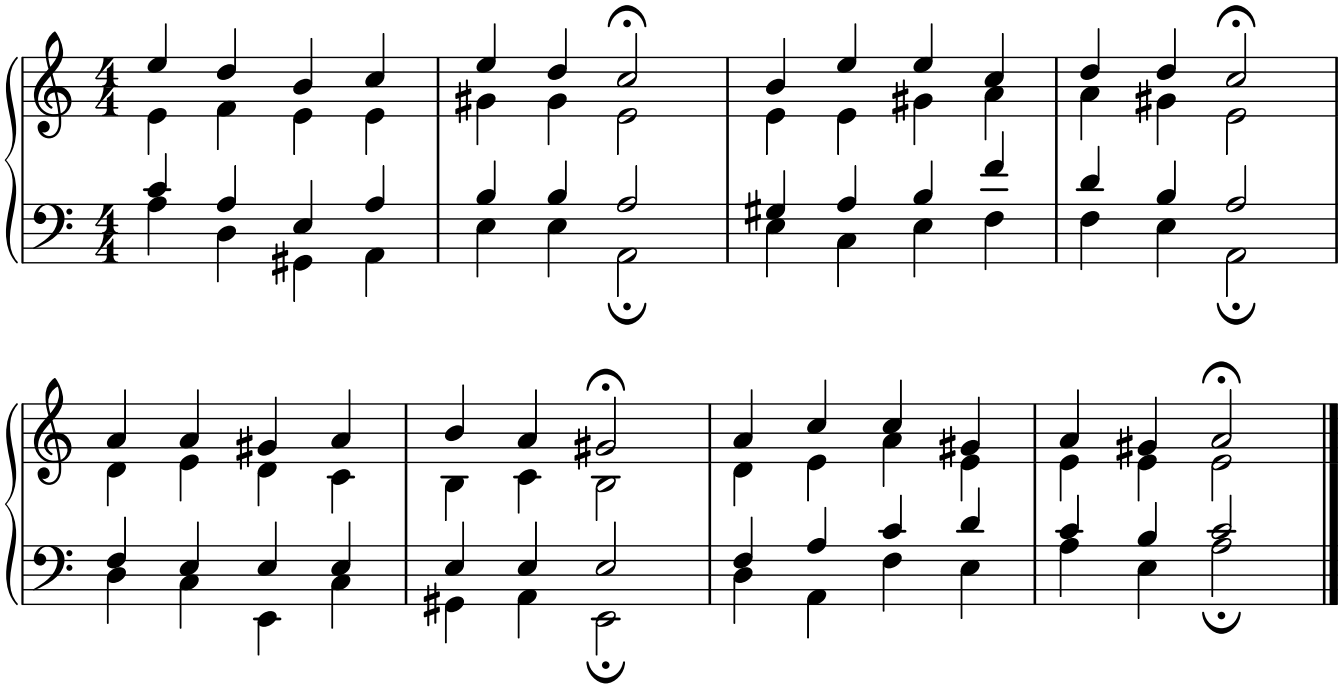


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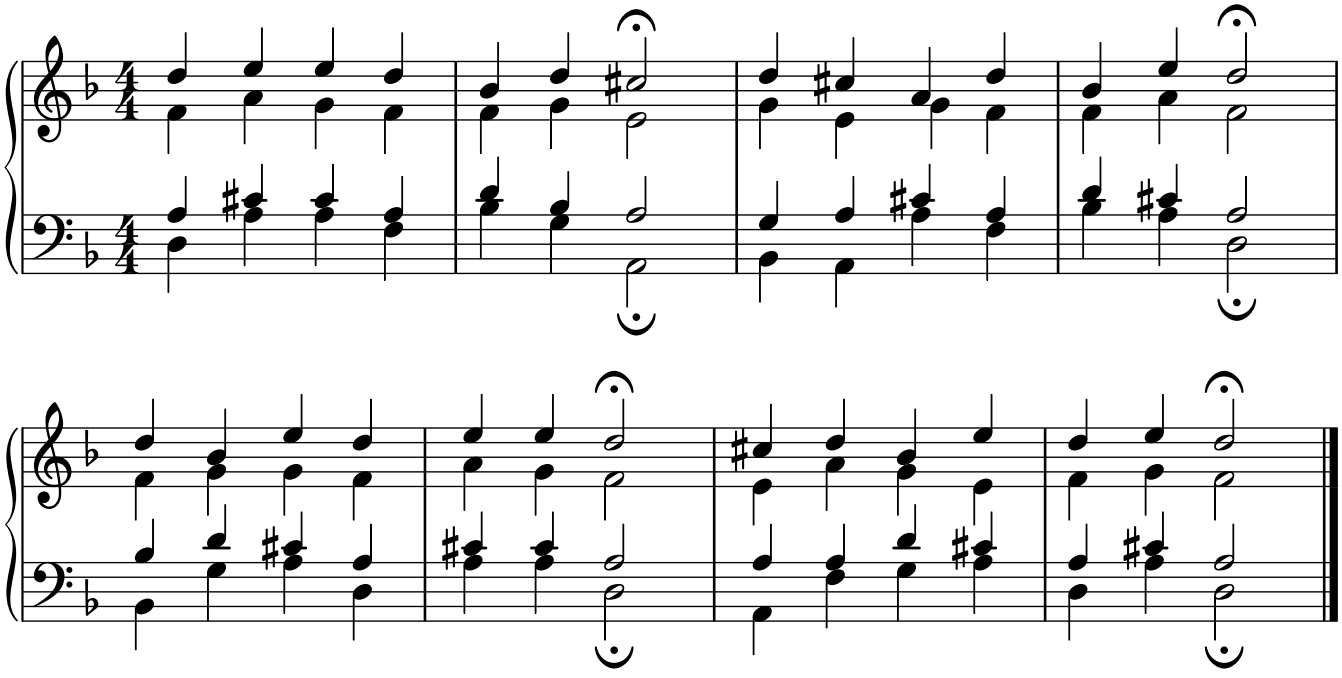


Part C: Chorales in minor keys ♩ = 60

Four-voice chorales in A, D and E minor. The raised 7th (G-sharp, C-sharp, D-sharp) appears in every V chord.
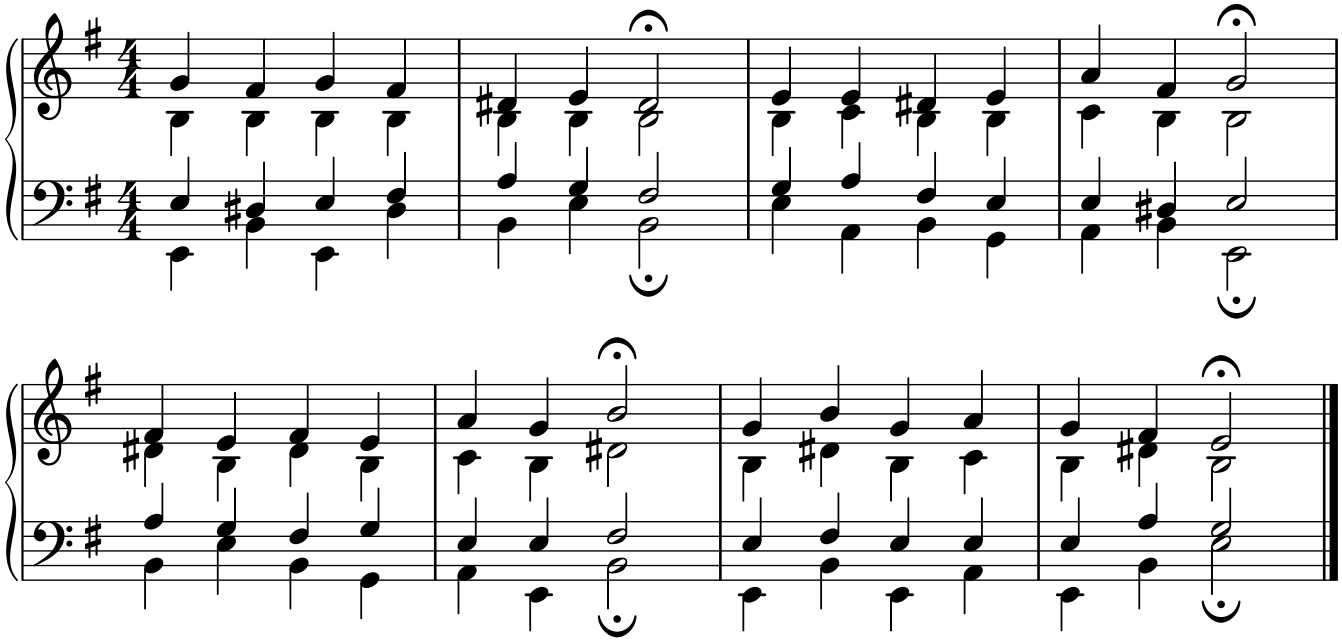
☐ **2.17**



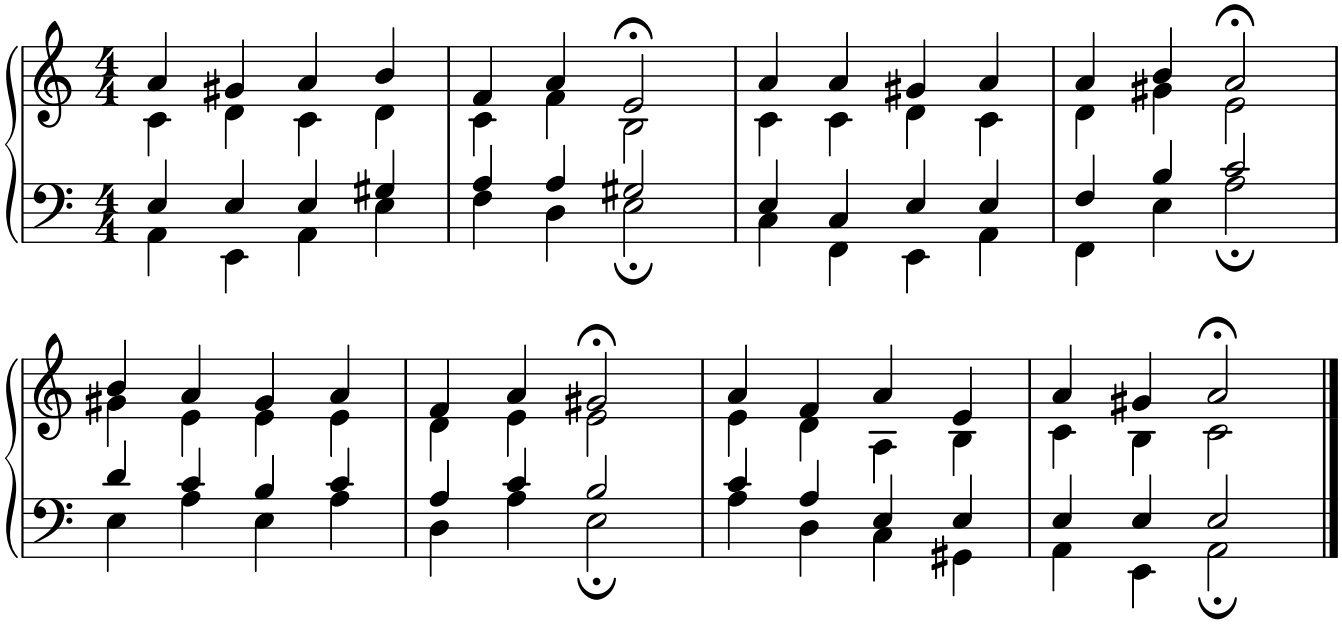
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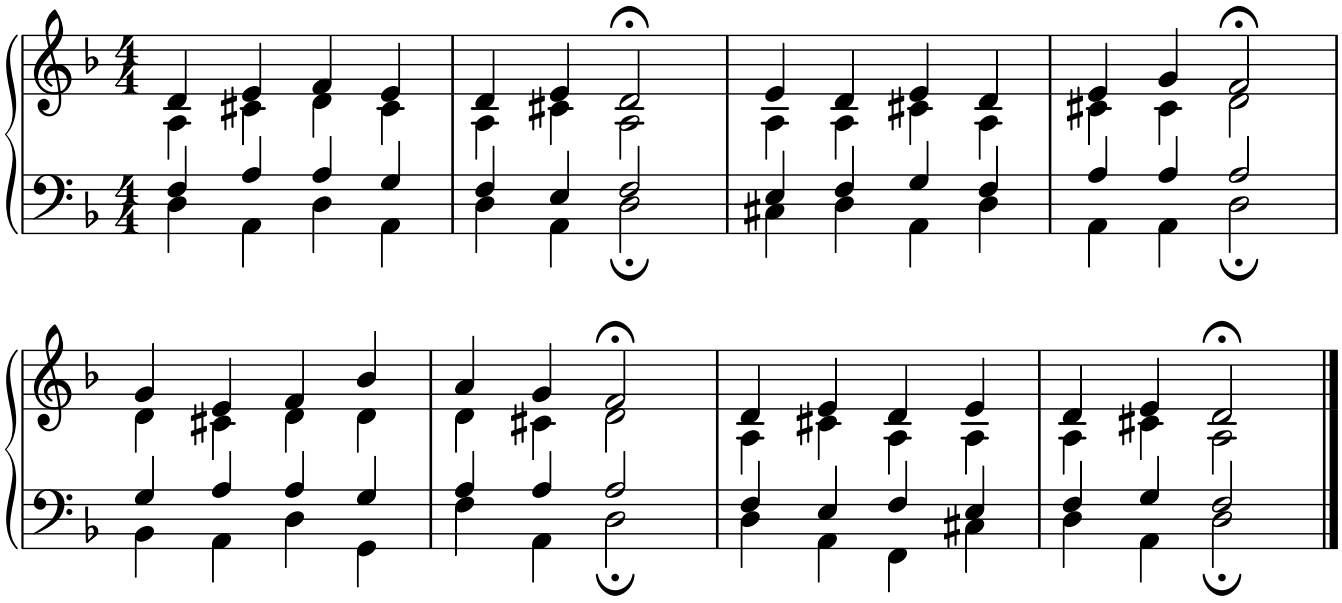
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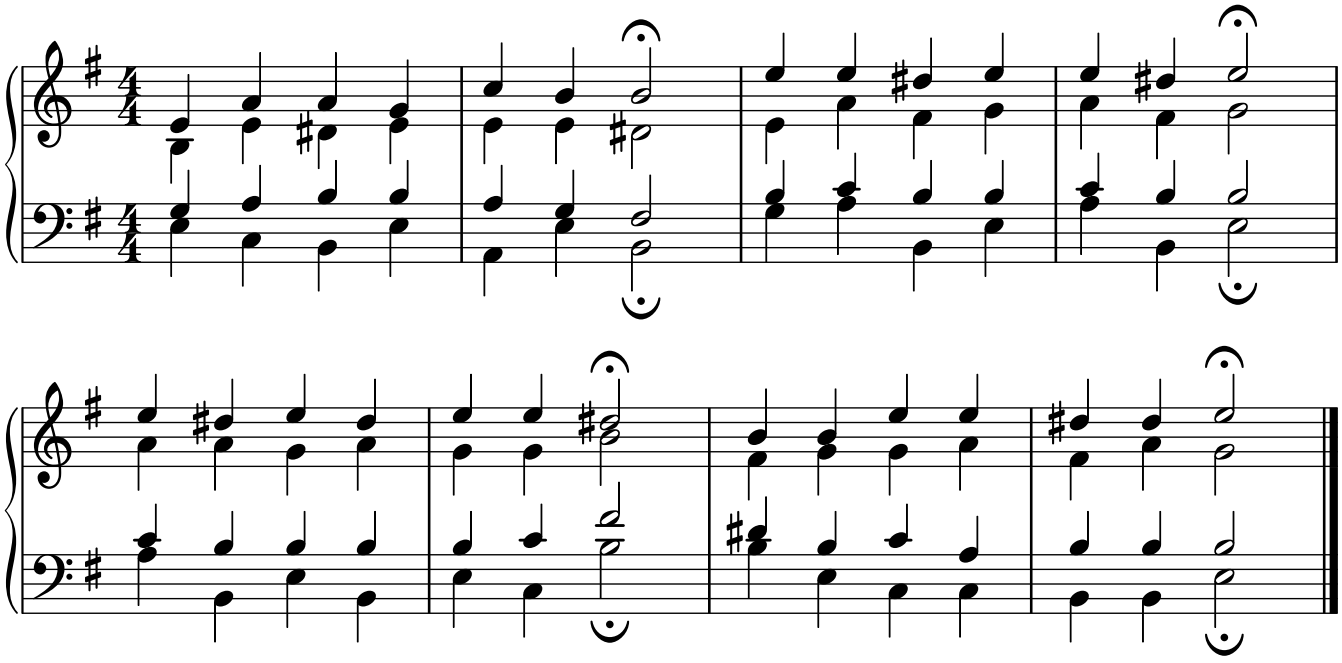


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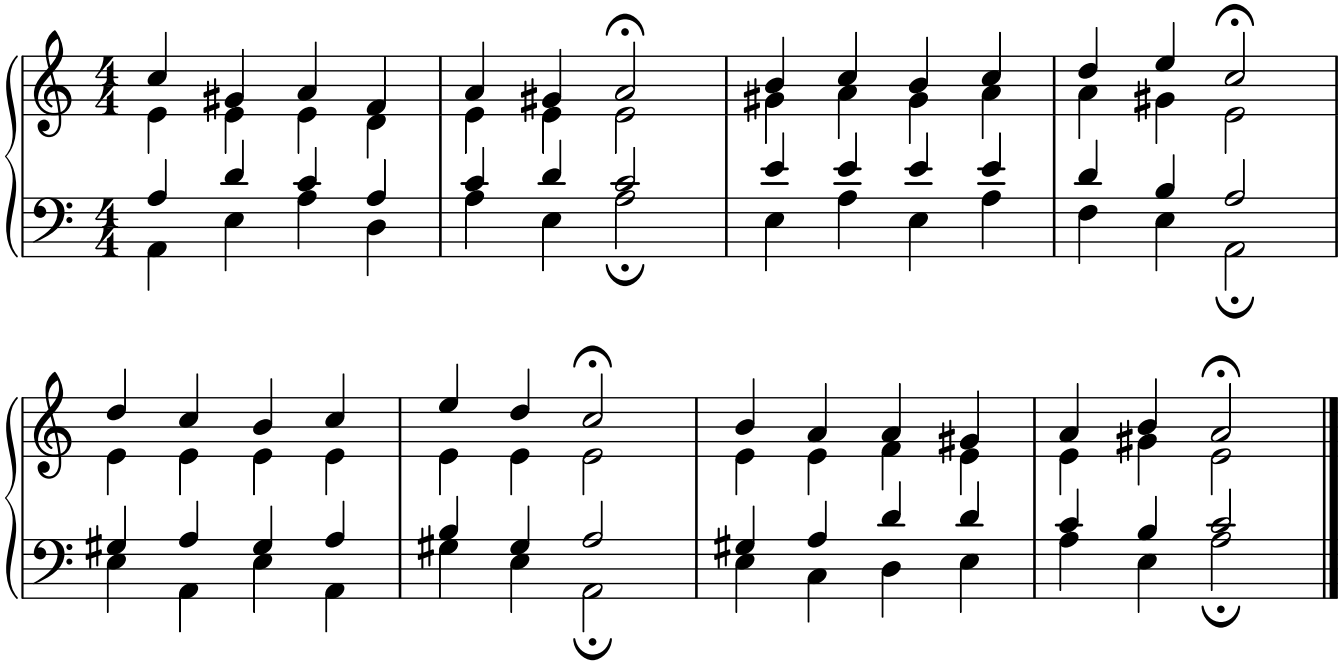


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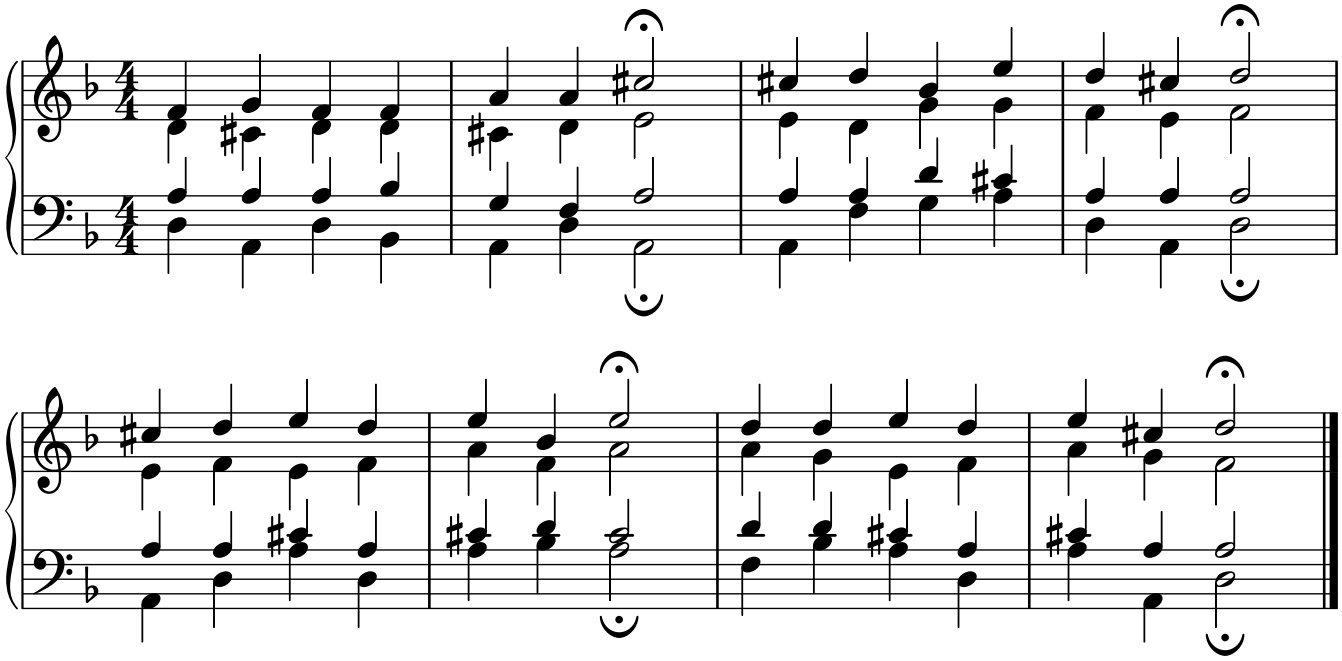


2.22



☐ **2.23**



☐ **2.24**
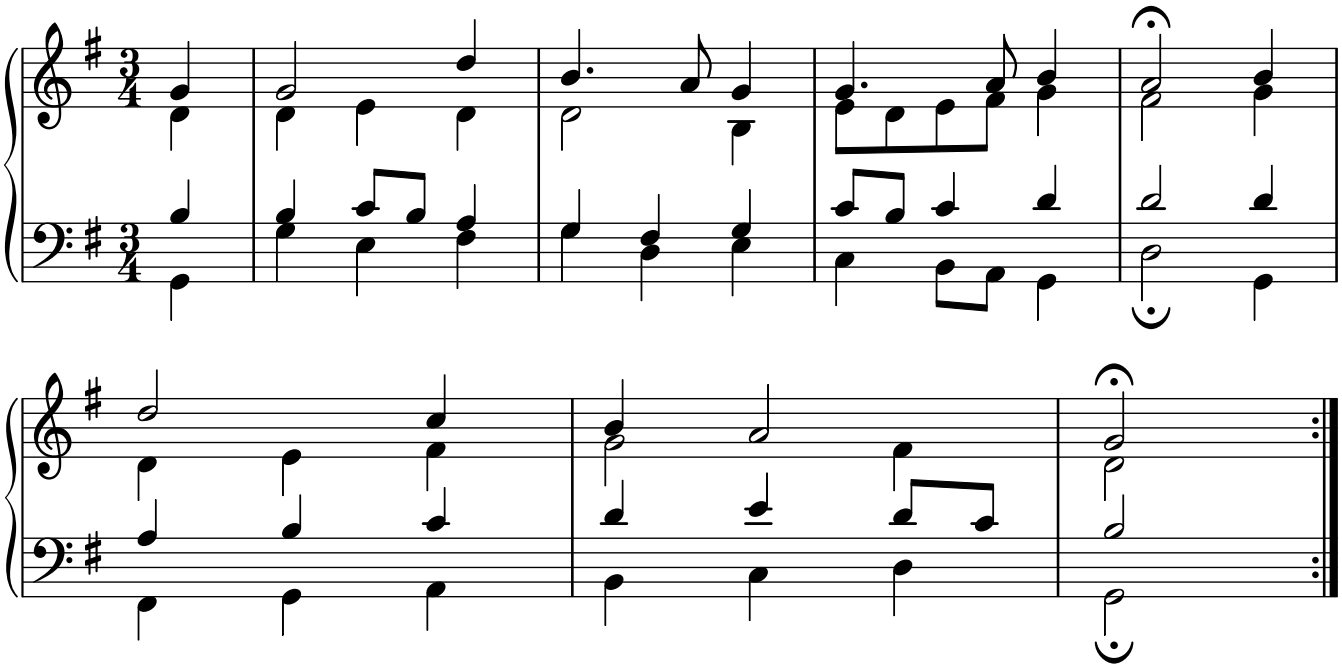


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Aus meines Herzens Grunde ♩ = 72

J. S. Bach, chorale, BWV 269 - first two lines
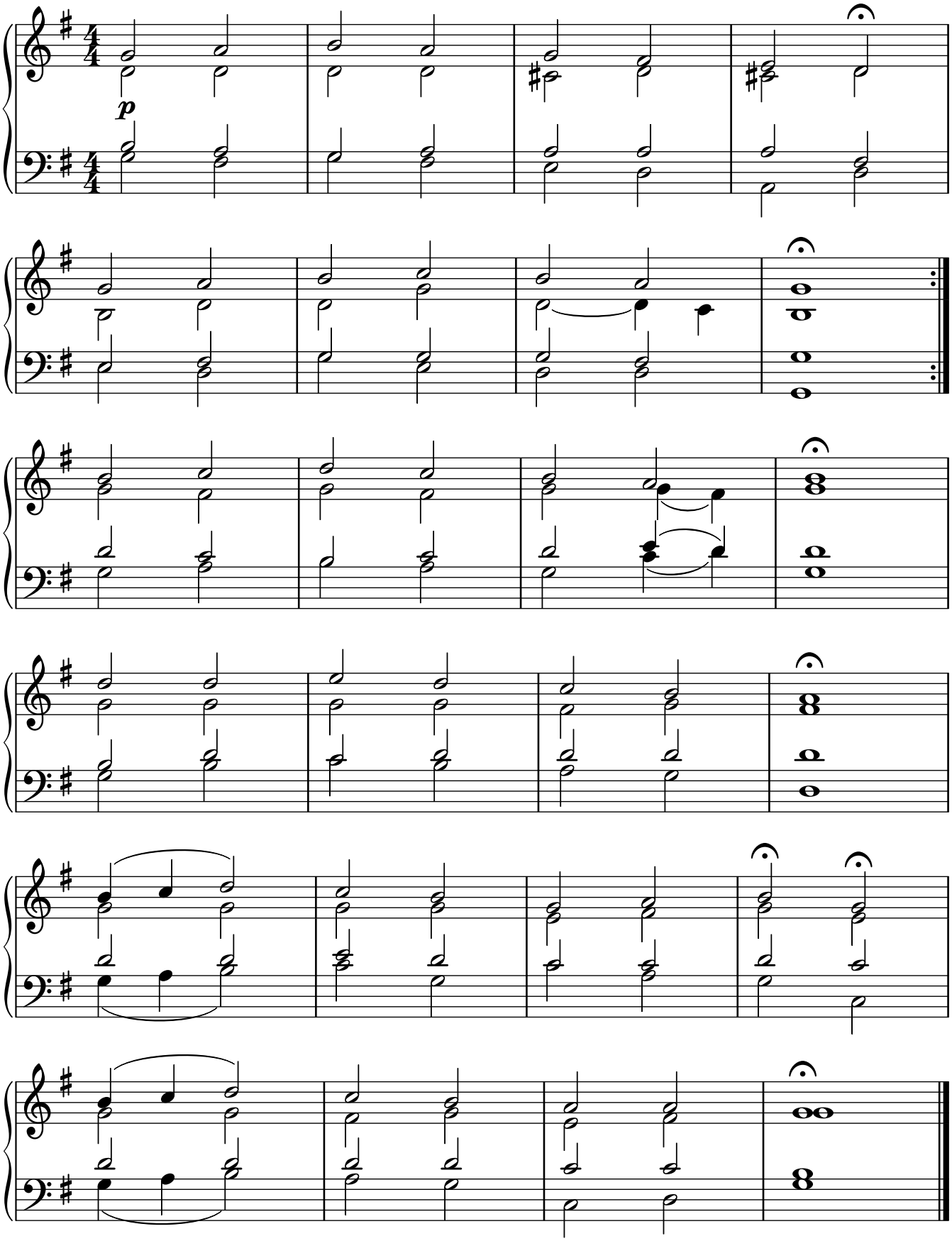
A chorale in 3/4 that begins with an upbeat (one beat before the first bar line). Play the whole passage twice, as the repeat sign asks. The tenor and bass are often more than an octave apart: take the tenor with the right hand wherever the left hand cannot reach. Source: Mutopia Project no. 378 (public domain).



Chorale ♩ = 92

Robert Schumann (1848), Album for the Young, Op. 68 No. 4 - complete
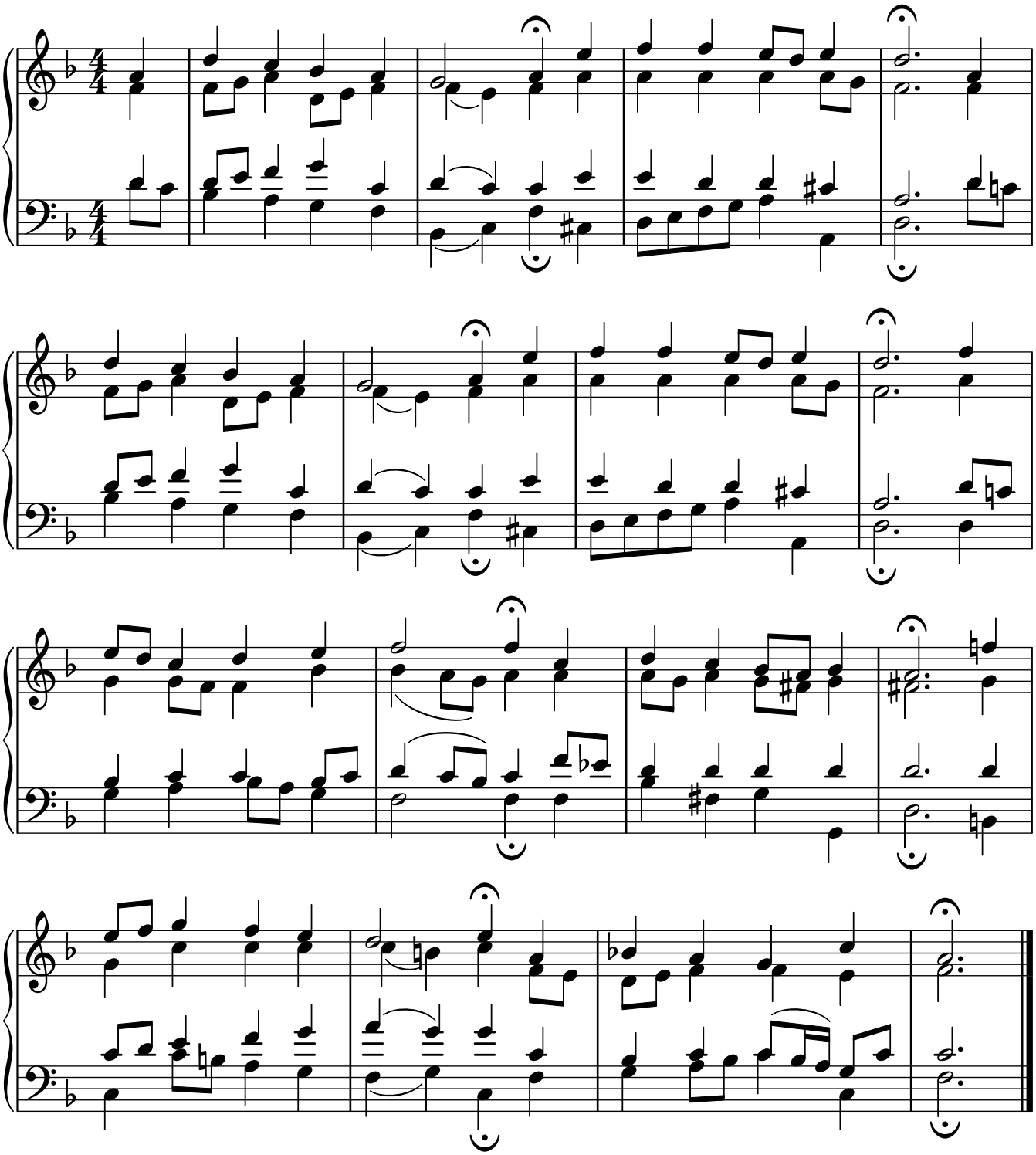
Schumann's setting of the chorale 'Freue dich, o meine Seele', in half notes: each half note is a new chord. Play bars 1-8 twice. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 782 by Philippe Hezaine (CC BY-SA 2.5).



O Haupt voll Blut und Wunden ♩= 60

J. S. Bach, chorale from the St Matthew Passion - complete
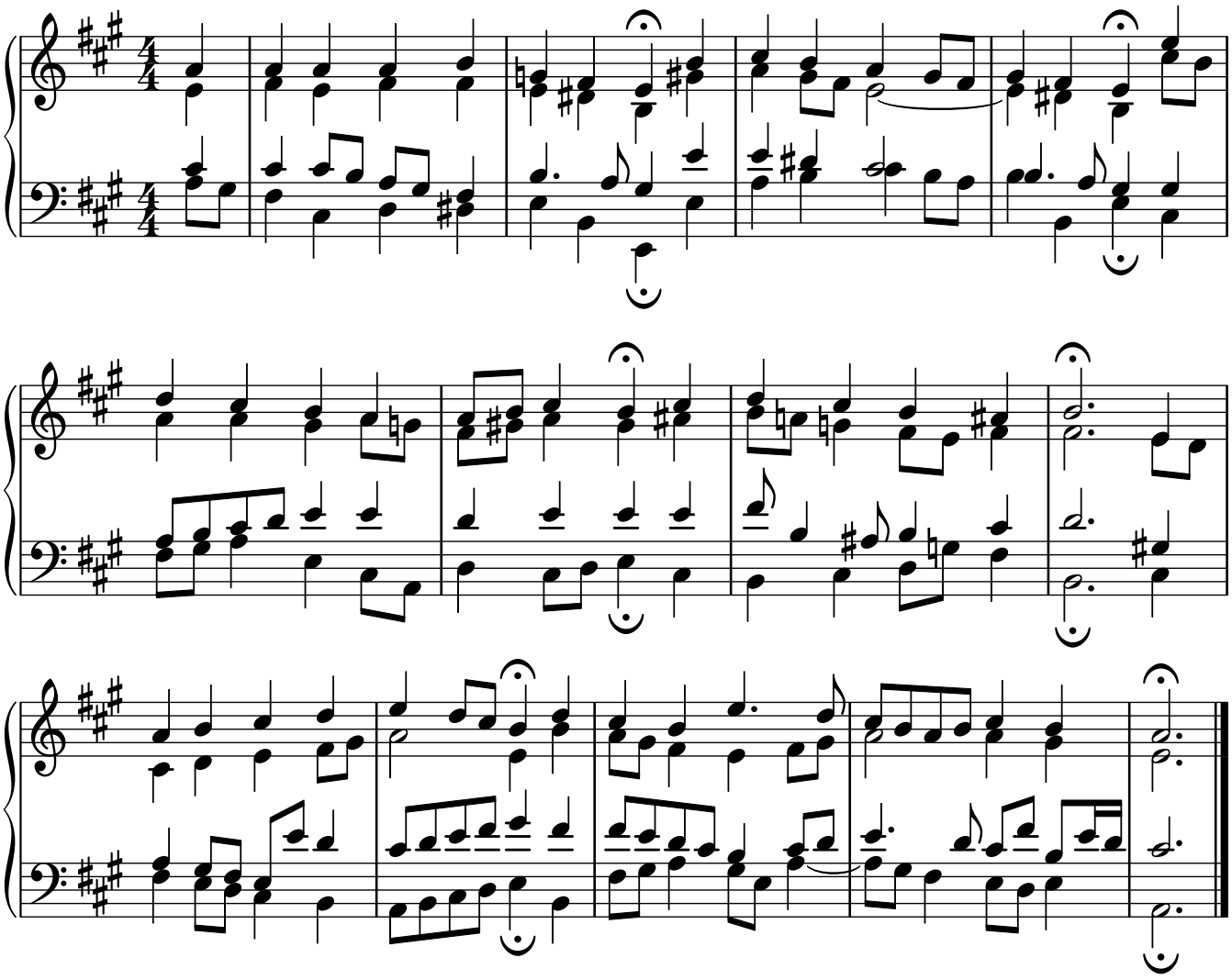
The Passion Chorale. It begins in D minor and ends on an F major chord. C-sharp is the raised 7th of D minor; F-sharp in bar 11 leads to G minor. Bach often puts the tenor more than an octave above the bass: wherever your left hand cannot reach both, take the tenor note with the right hand. Source: Mutopia Project no. 107 (public domain).



Ich dank dir, lieber Herre ♩ = 66

J. S. Bach, chorale, BWV 347 - complete, without the repeat

Three sharps: F, C and G. In bar 2 Bach writes G-natural for a moment; in bar 7 A-sharp leads to B minor. The tenor has a few eighth notes and two sixteenths of its own: keep them light. Where the left hand cannot reach, take the tenor with the right hand. Source: Mutopia Project no. 379 (public domain).



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 3?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if you can say, before you play, which bars end with a fermata and whether each of those lines ends on I or on V.
- Pass if you can read the Bach chorale 'Aus meines Herzens Grunde' at sight with soprano and bass, then with all four voices after a few days.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 3.

Unit 3

Chromatic Notes

New: Chromatic passing and neighbour notes, V7 of V, the melodic minor

A chromatic note is a note outside the key: a sharp, flat or natural that is not in the key signature. In this unit they come in three ways: as quick passing and neighbour notes in the tune, as the raised 4th of a chord that leads to V (V7 of V), and as the raised 6th and 7th of the melodic minor scale.

What is new

An accidental lasts to the bar line

A sharp, flat or natural applies to every later note on the same line or space until the end of the bar. The next bar is back to the key signature. A reminder in the next bar (a 'courtesy' accidental) is only there to help you.

Chromatic passing notes

Between two notes a whole step apart, the tune can slip through the half step in between: C C-sharp D going up, E E-flat D going down. They are short and fall between the beats.

Chromatic neighbours

A note can dip to the half step below and come back: E D-sharp E.

V7 of V
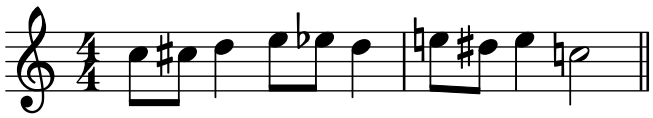
In C major the chord D F-sharp A C leads strongly to G (V). Its F-sharp is the raised 4th of the key; in G major it is C-sharp, in F major B-natural. After it, the natural sign cancels it again.

The melodic minor

Going up to the tonic, minor tunes often raise the 6th and the 7th (in A minor F-sharp and G-sharp); coming down they use the natural notes of the key signature (G and F).
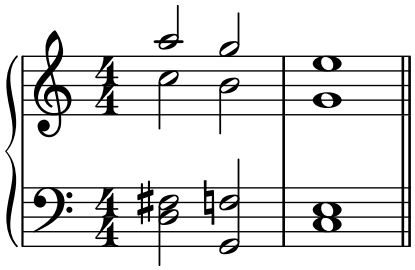
Chromatic passing and neighbour notes

C C-sharp D (passing, going up), E E-flat D (passing, going down), E D-sharp E (neighbour). The sharp in bar 1 does not carry into bar 2.
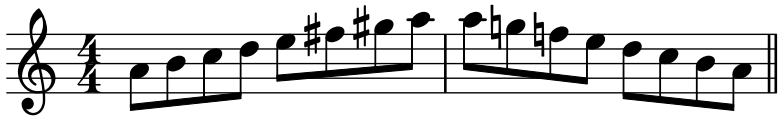


V7 of V in C major, then V and I

D F-sharp A C leads to G B D F, then to C. In V7 the natural sign cancels the F-sharp.



A melodic minor, up and down

Up: F-sharp and G-sharp. Down: G and F, as in the key signature.



Reading tips

1. Scan for accidentals before you play, and decide which notes they change for the rest of the bar.

2. A chromatic passing note always moves on in the same direction by a half step: let your finger slide.

3. In minor keys, expect the raised 7th whenever the music leans towards the tonic.
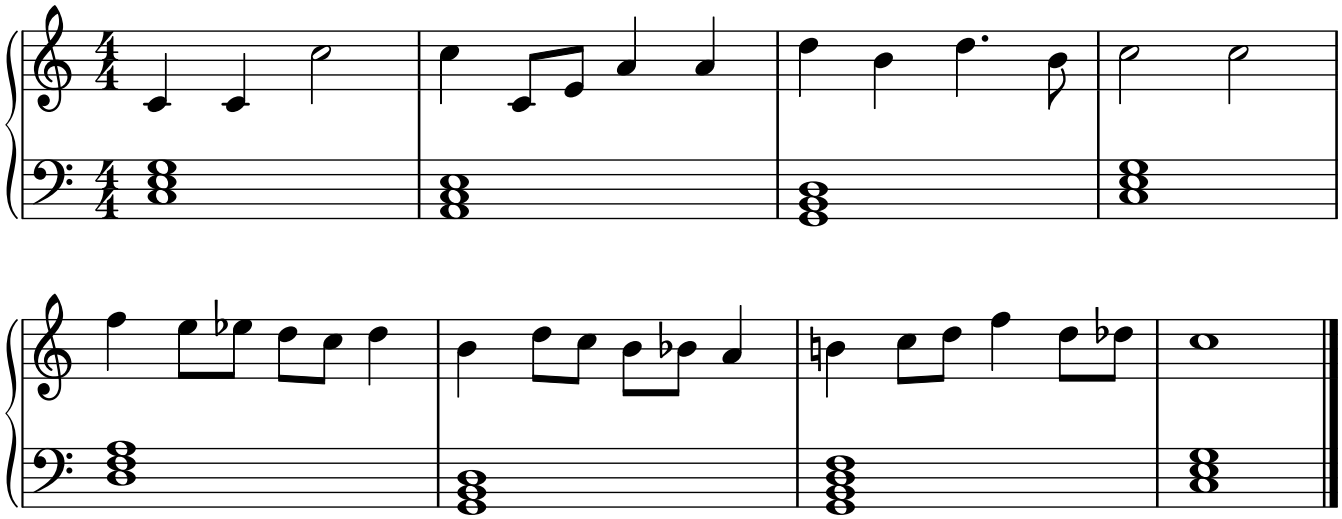
4. After a bar full of sharps, check the next bar: the key signature is back.

Part A: Chromatic passing and neighbour notes
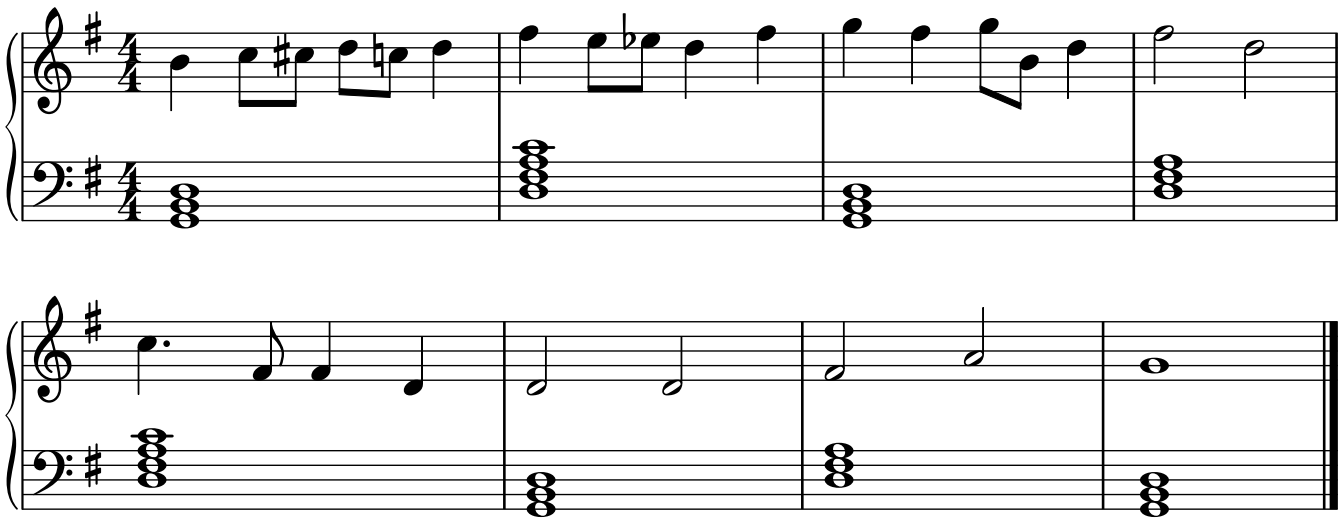
♩ = 66

C, G and F major: chromatic passing notes (between two notes a whole step apart) and lower neighbours, always on the second half of a beat.
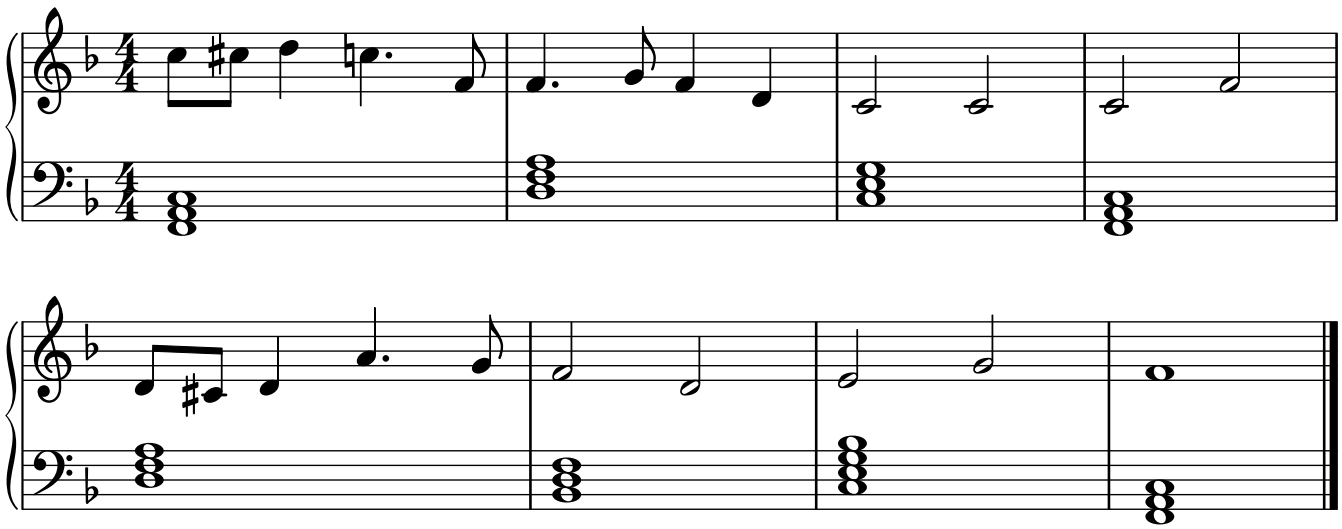
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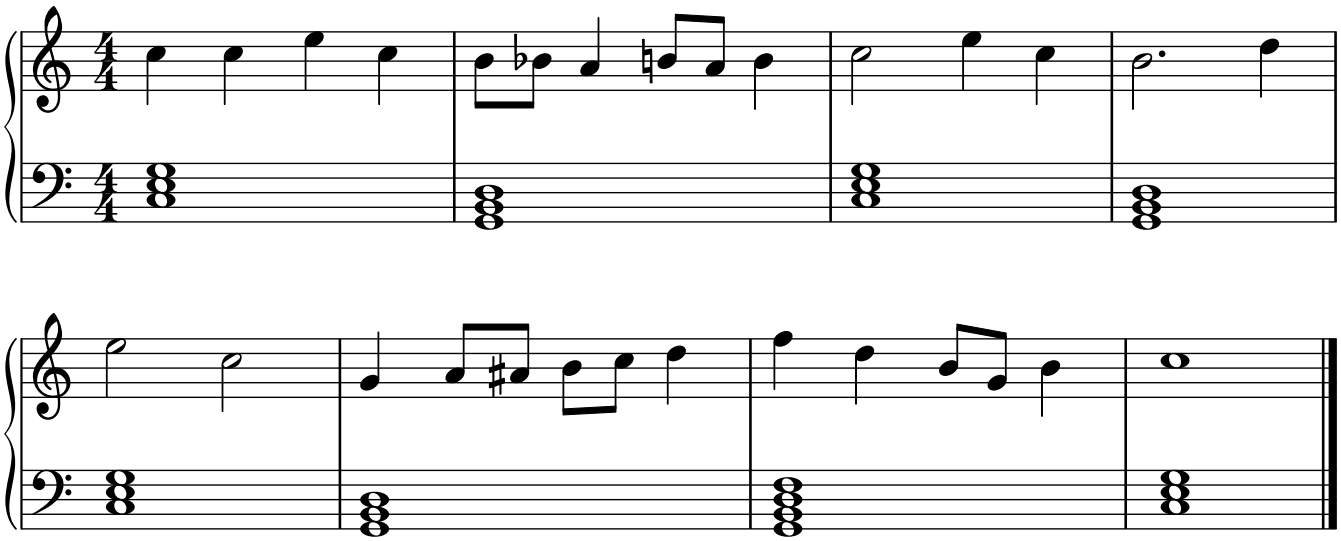


☐ **3.2**
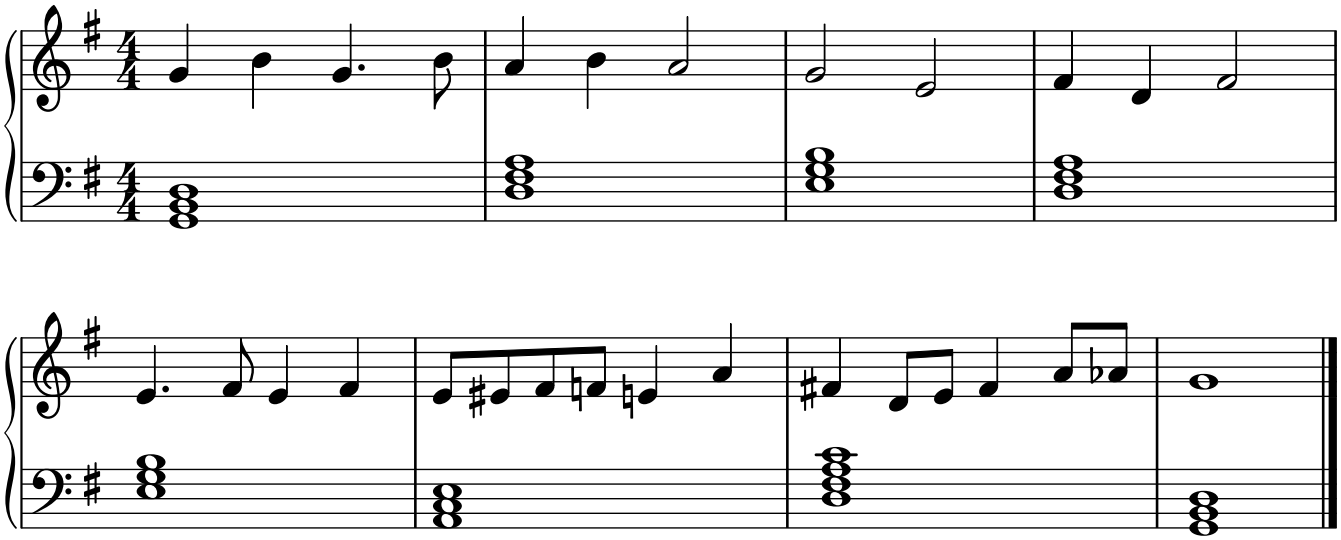


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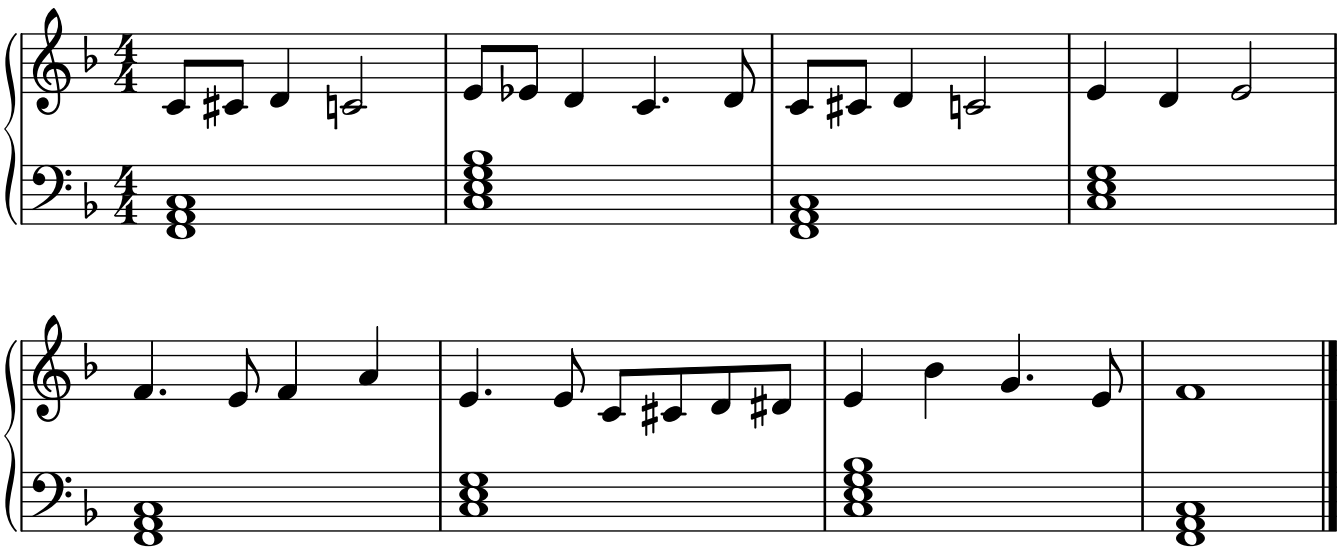


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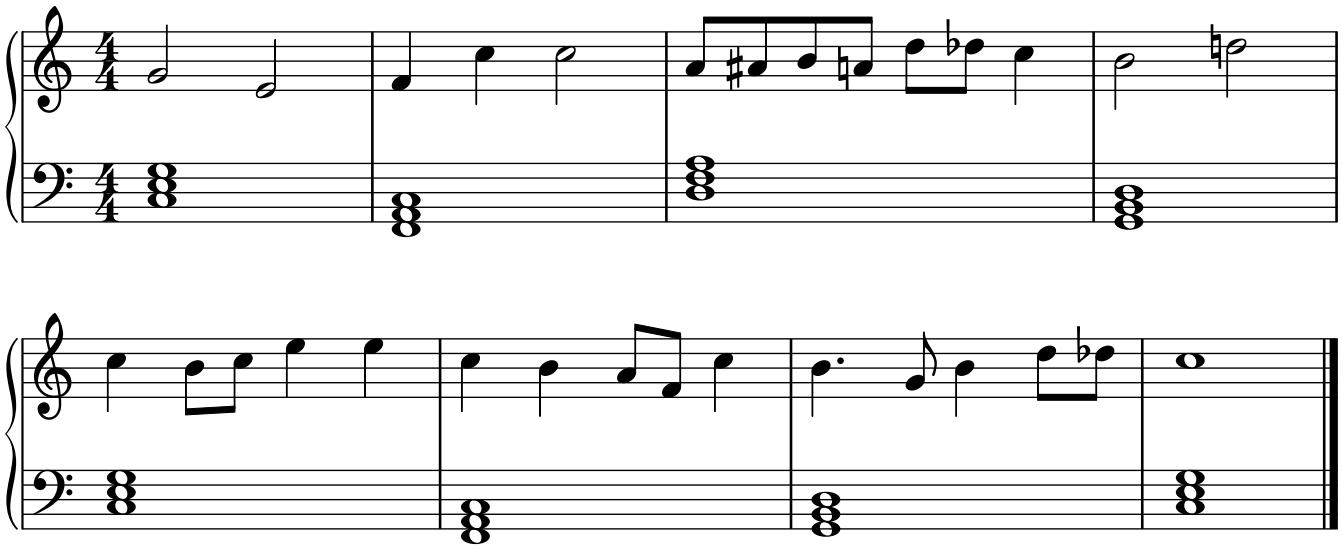


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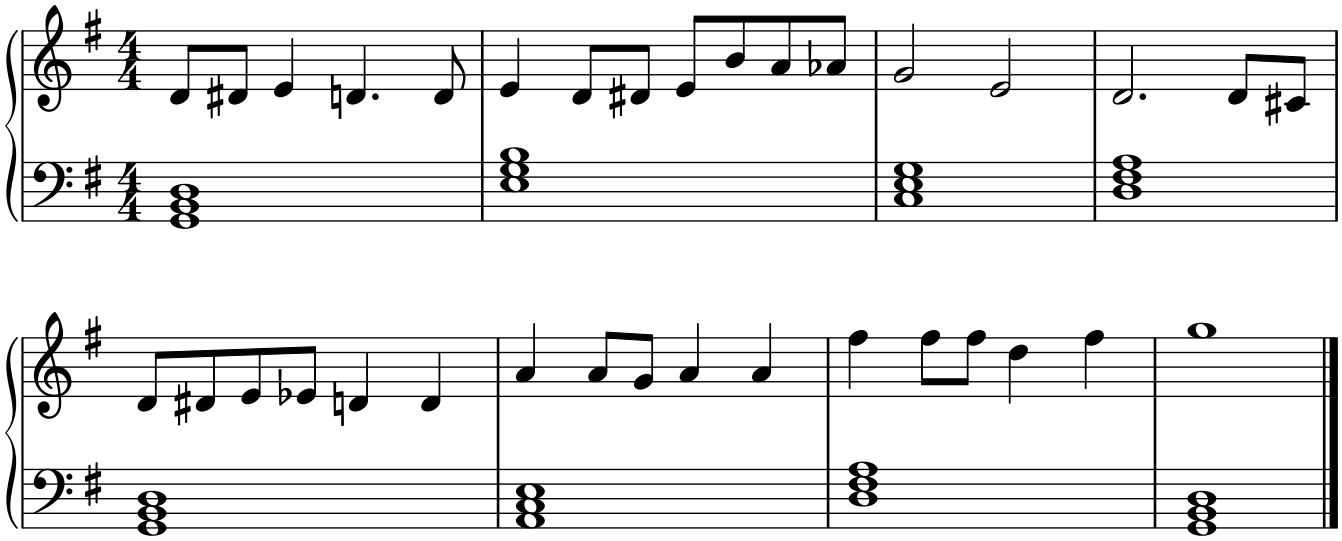


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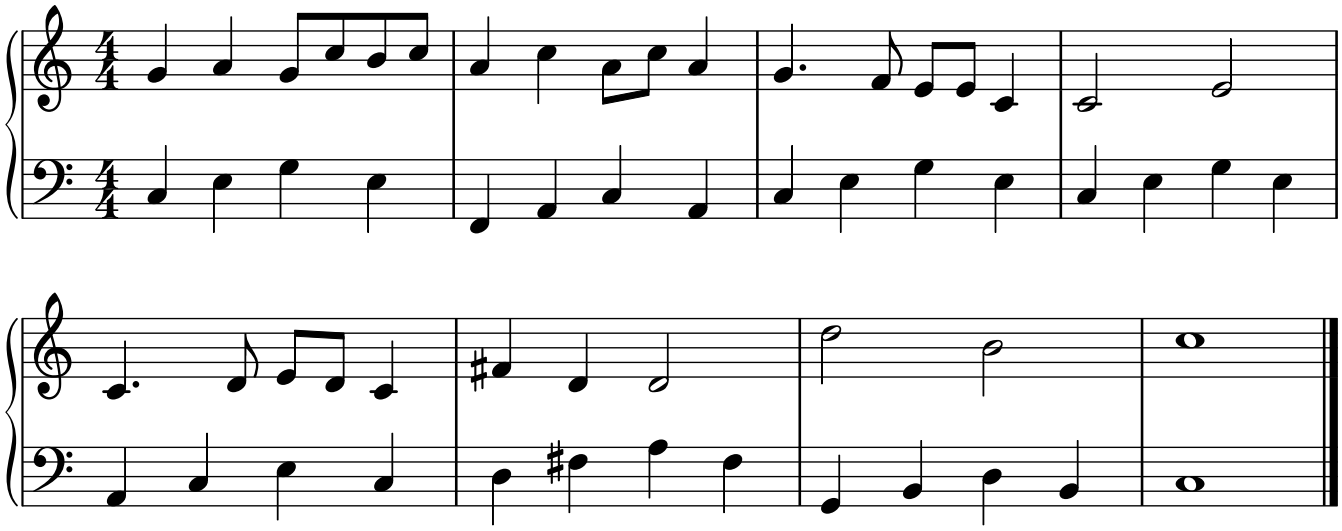


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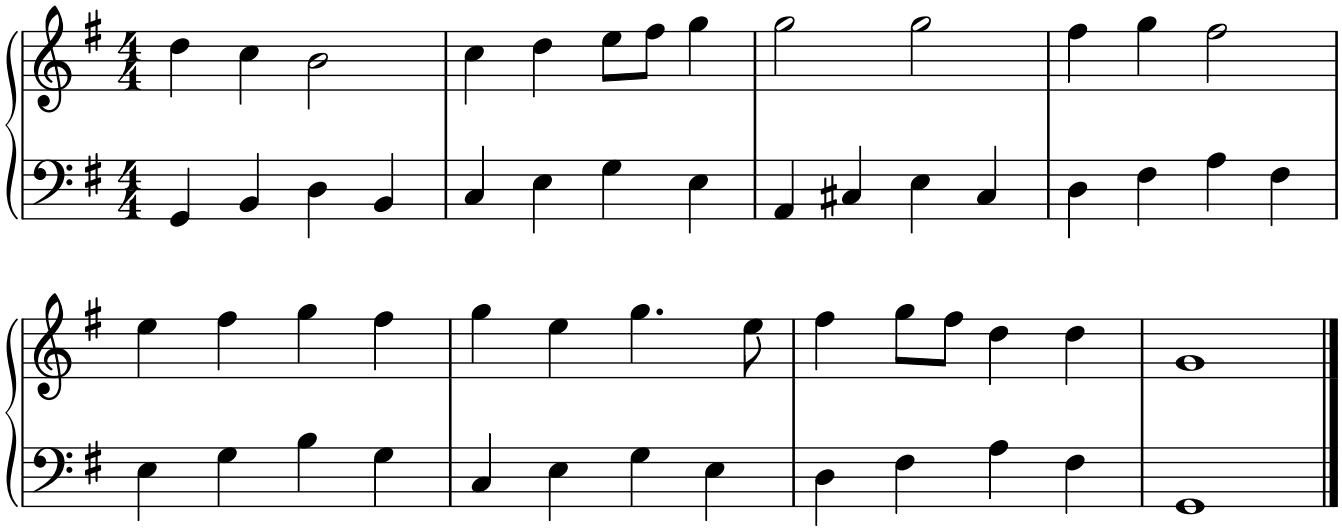


Part B: V7 of V: the raised 4th ♩ = 72

V7 of V comes before V: listen for F-sharp in C major, C-sharp in G major and B-natural in F major.
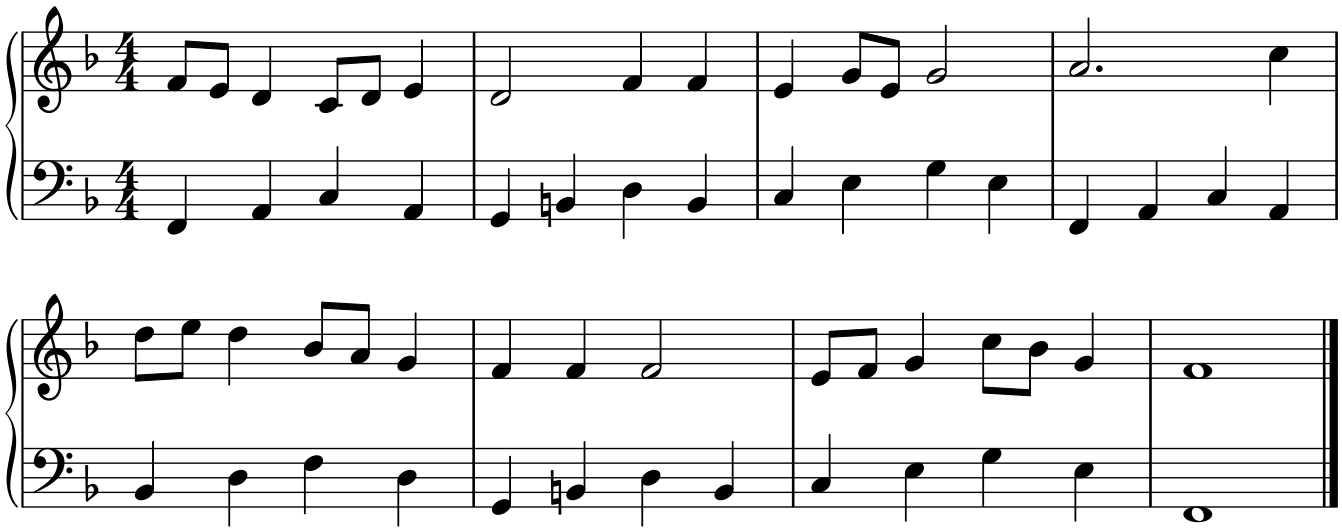
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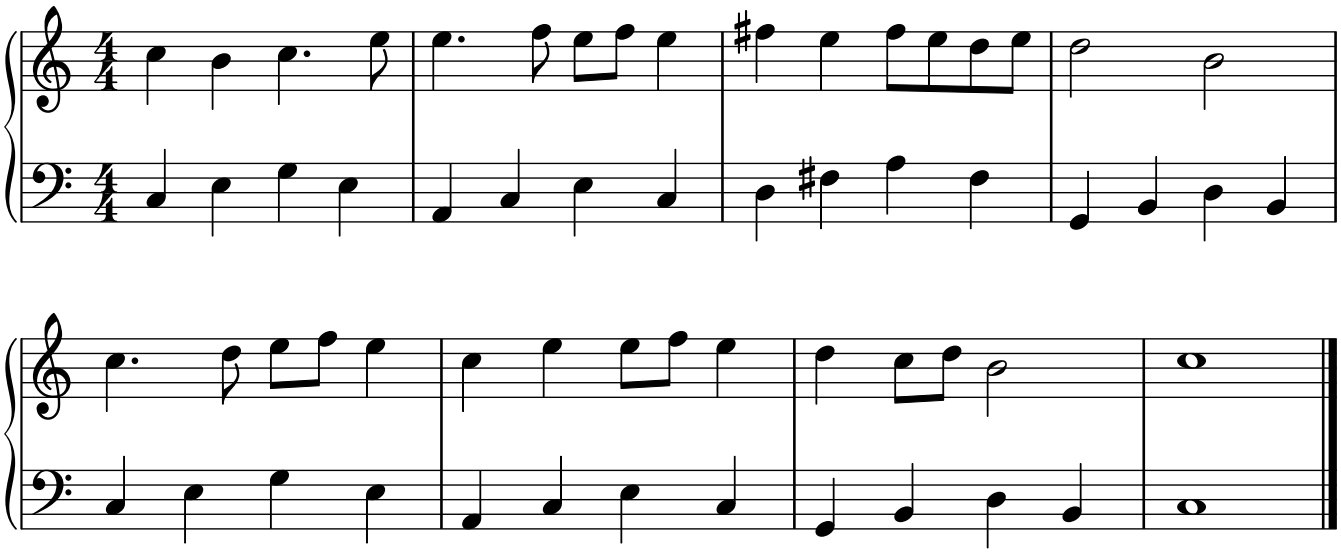


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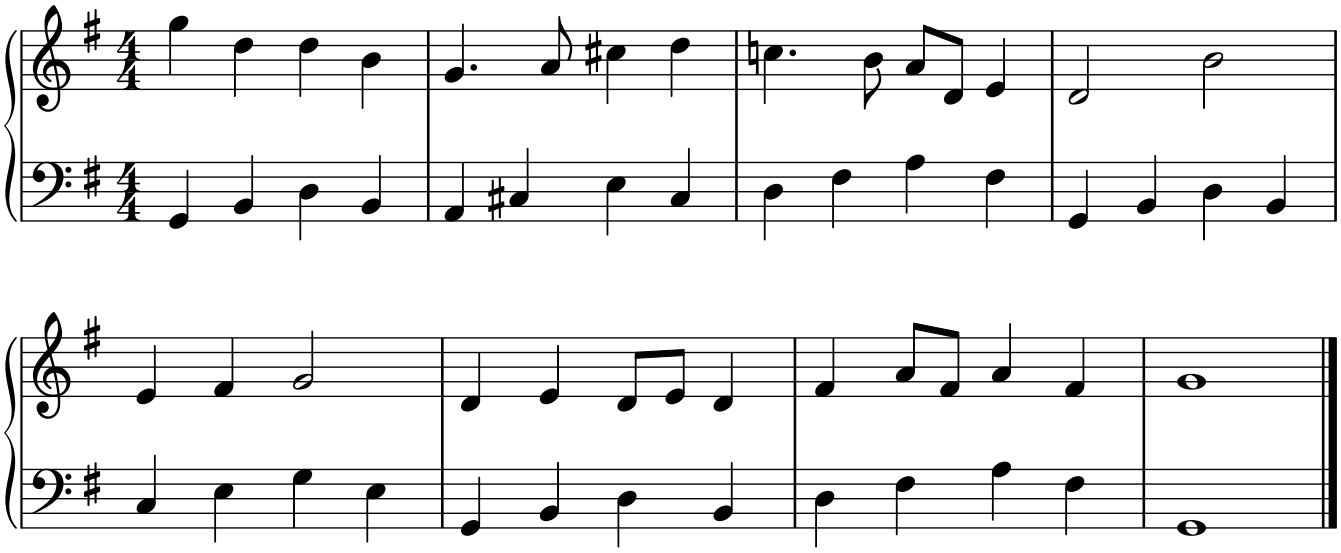


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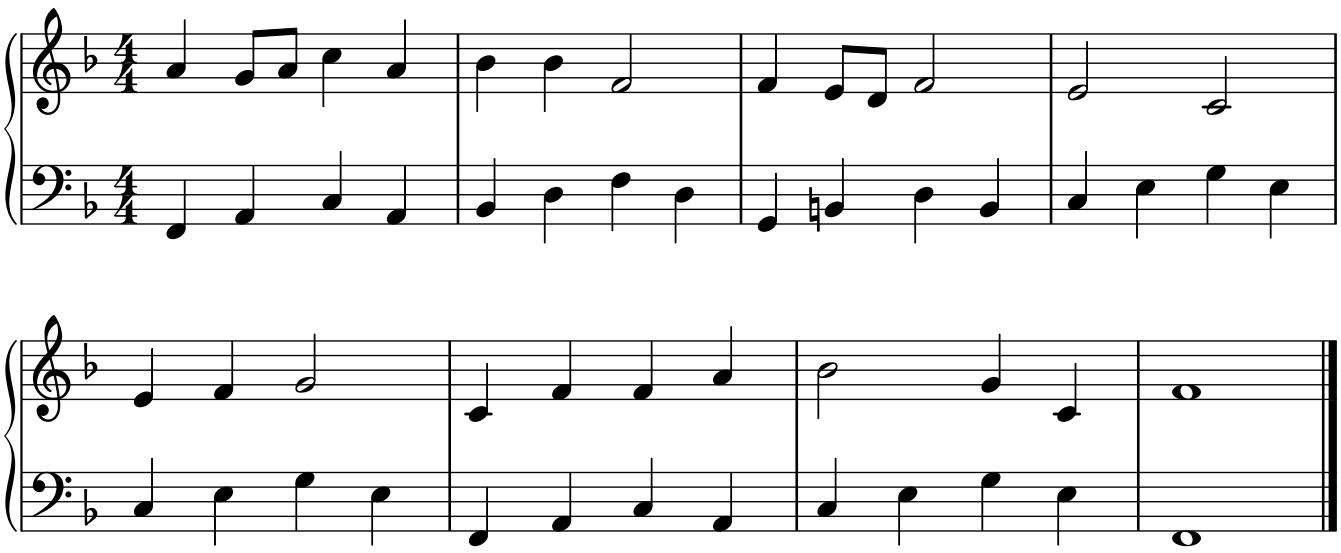


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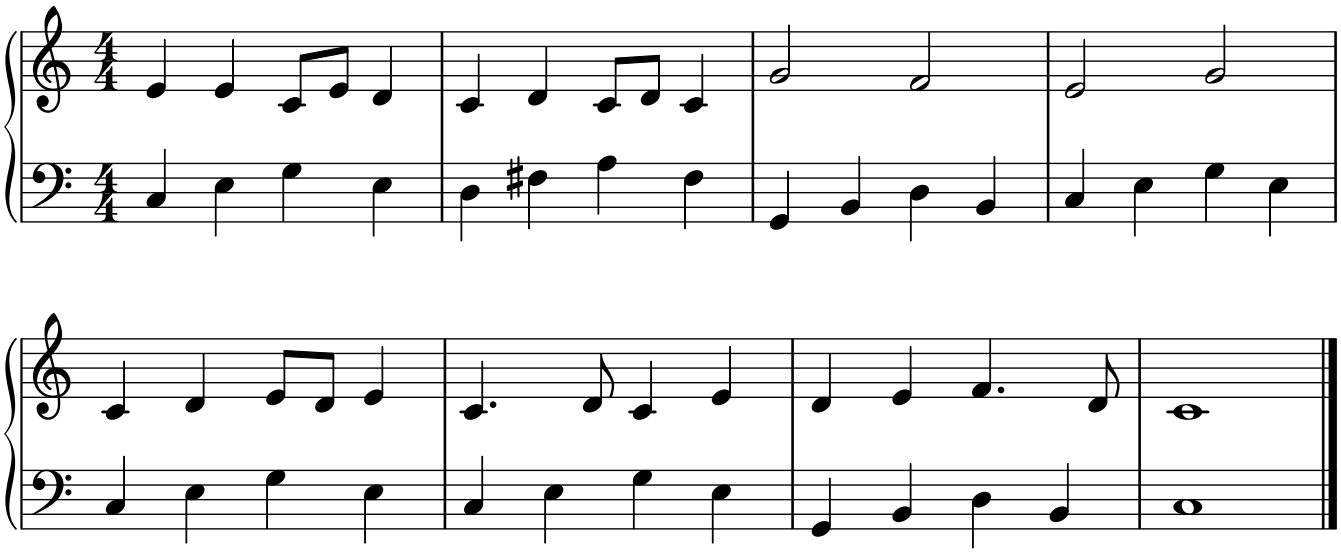


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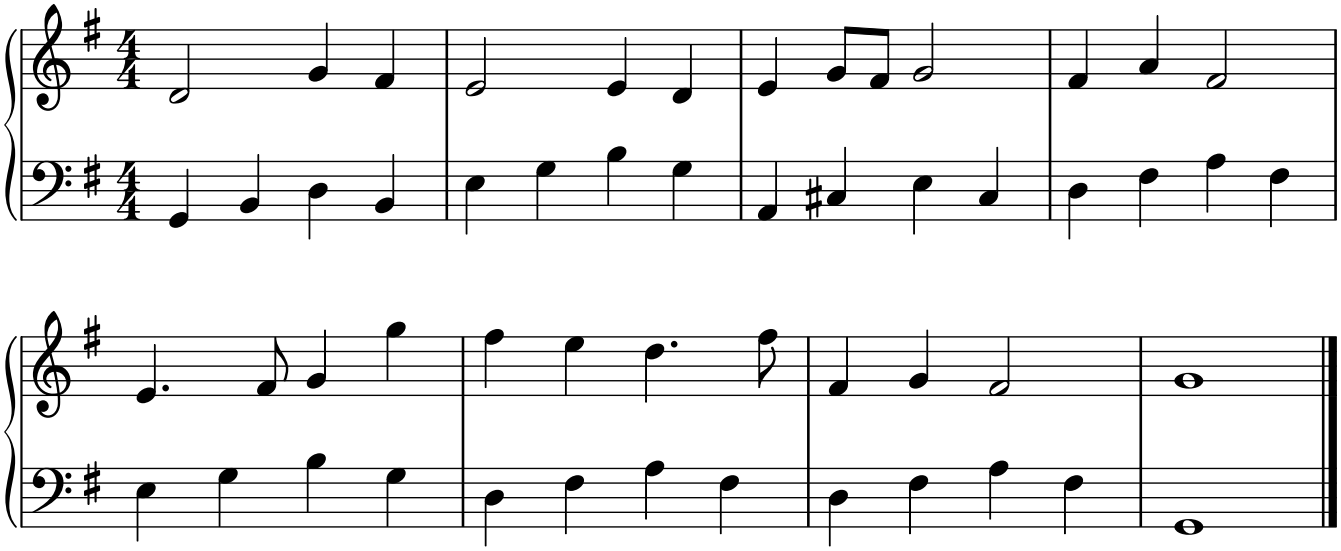


☐ **3.14**



☐ **3.15**
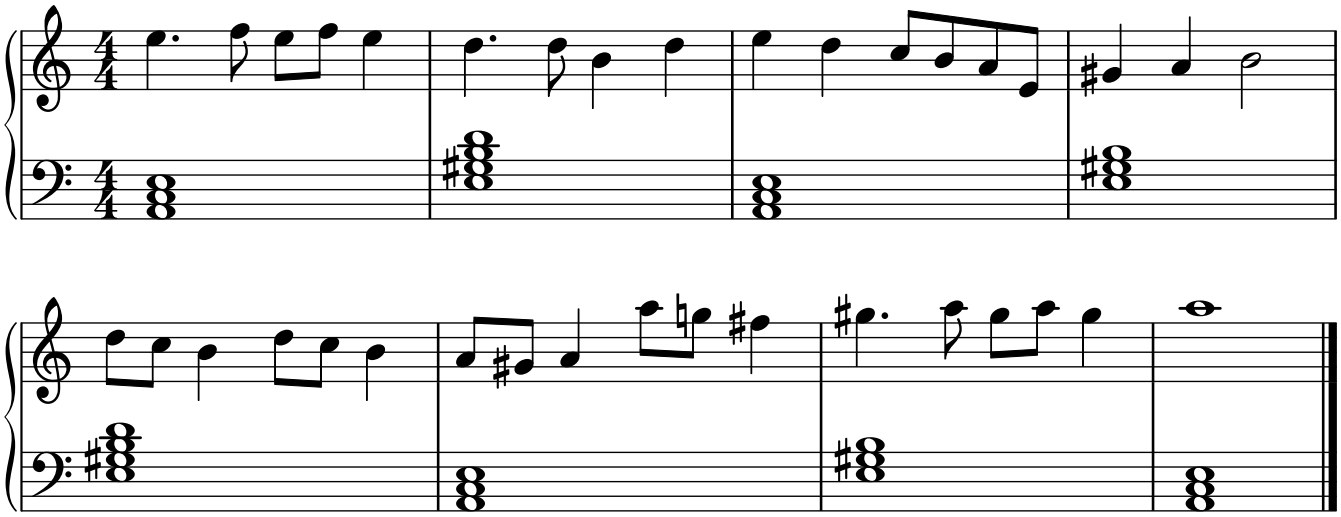


☐ **3.16**



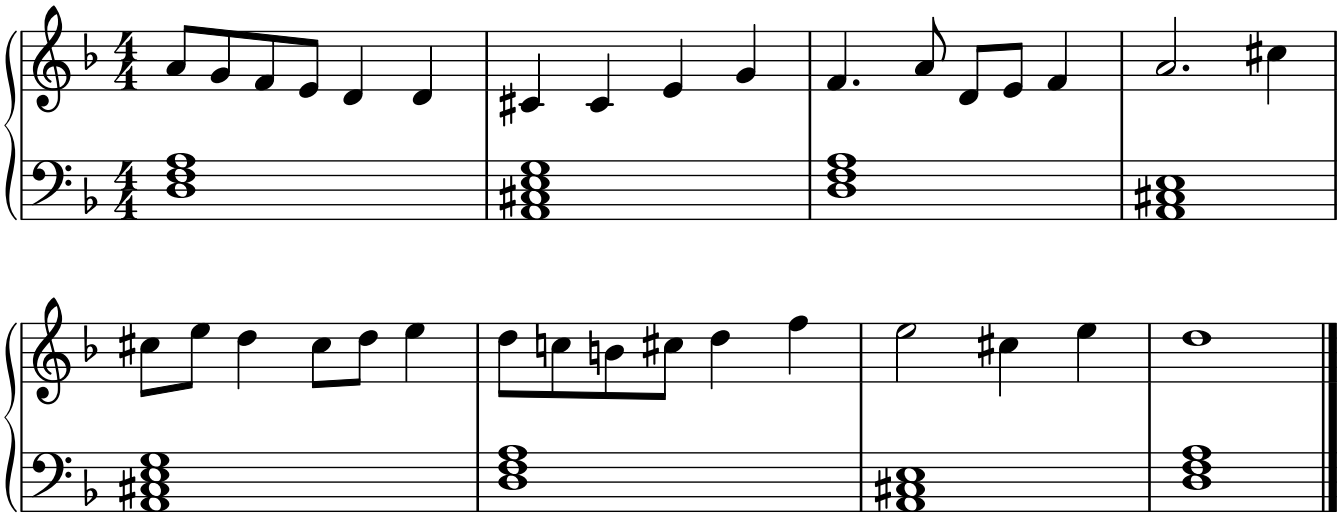
Part C: The melodic minor ♩= 66

A, D and E minor with the melodic minor: raised 6th and 7th going up, natural notes coming down.
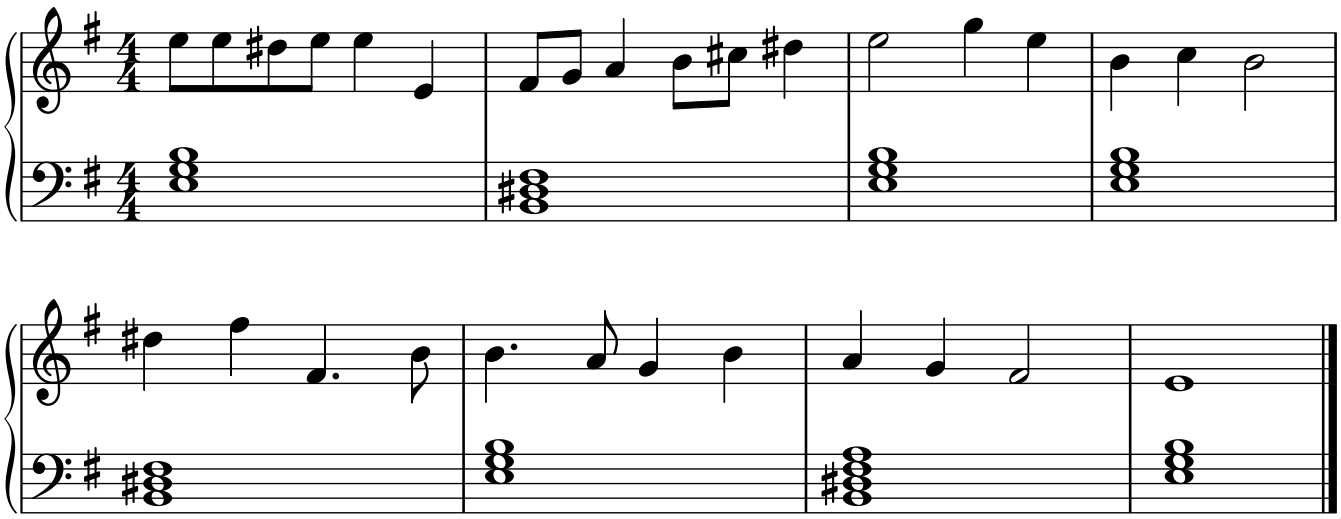
☐ **3.17**
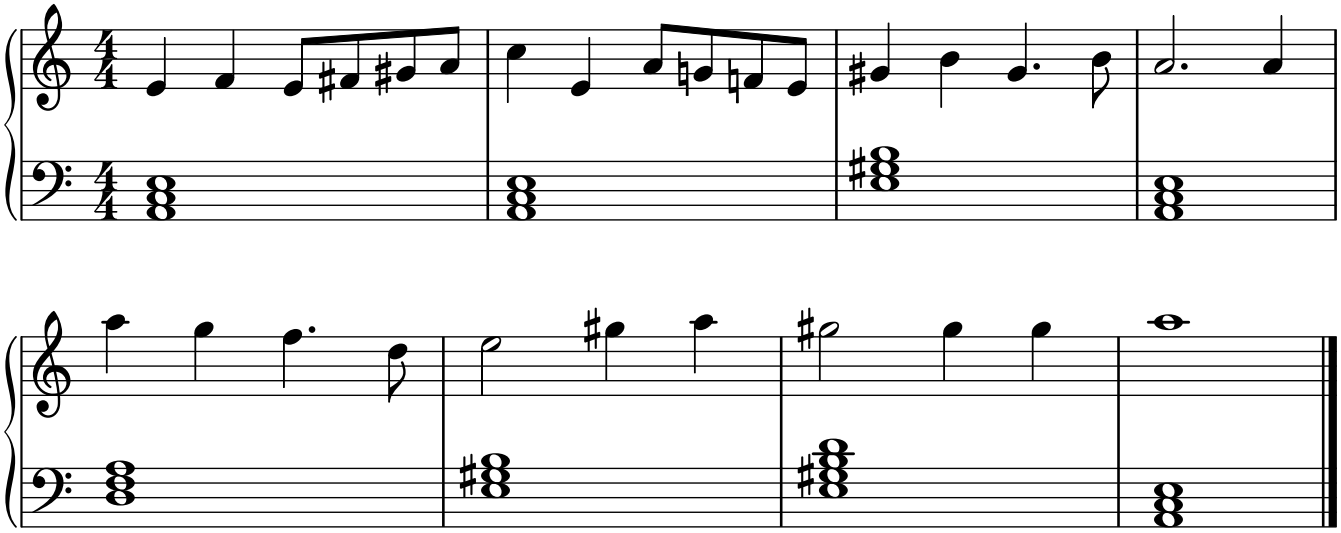


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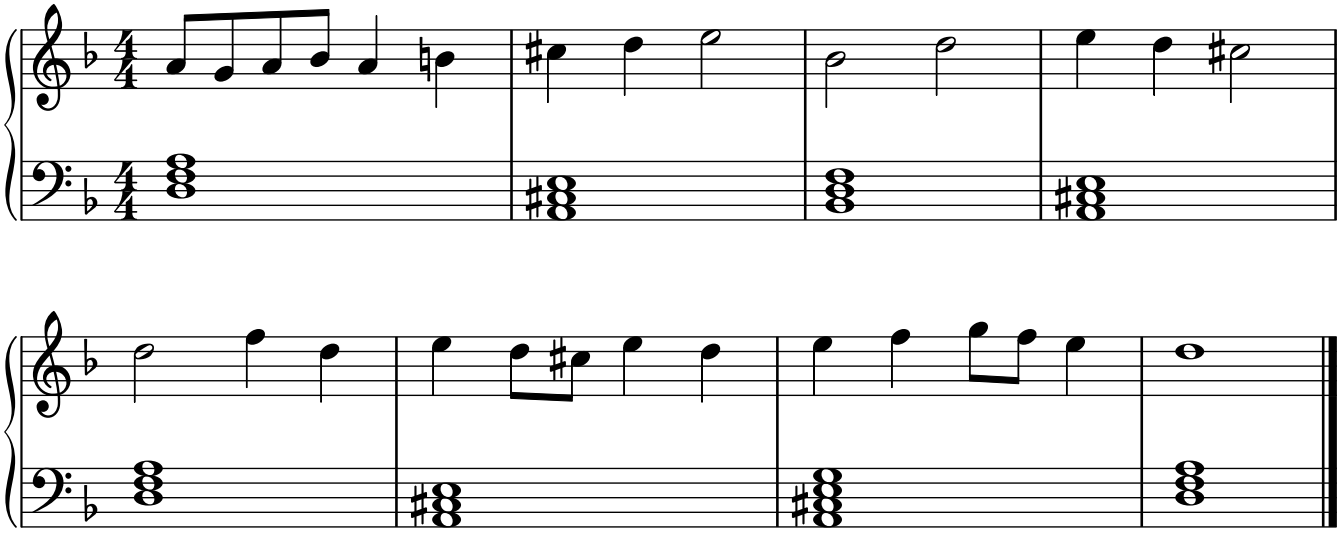


☐ **3.19**
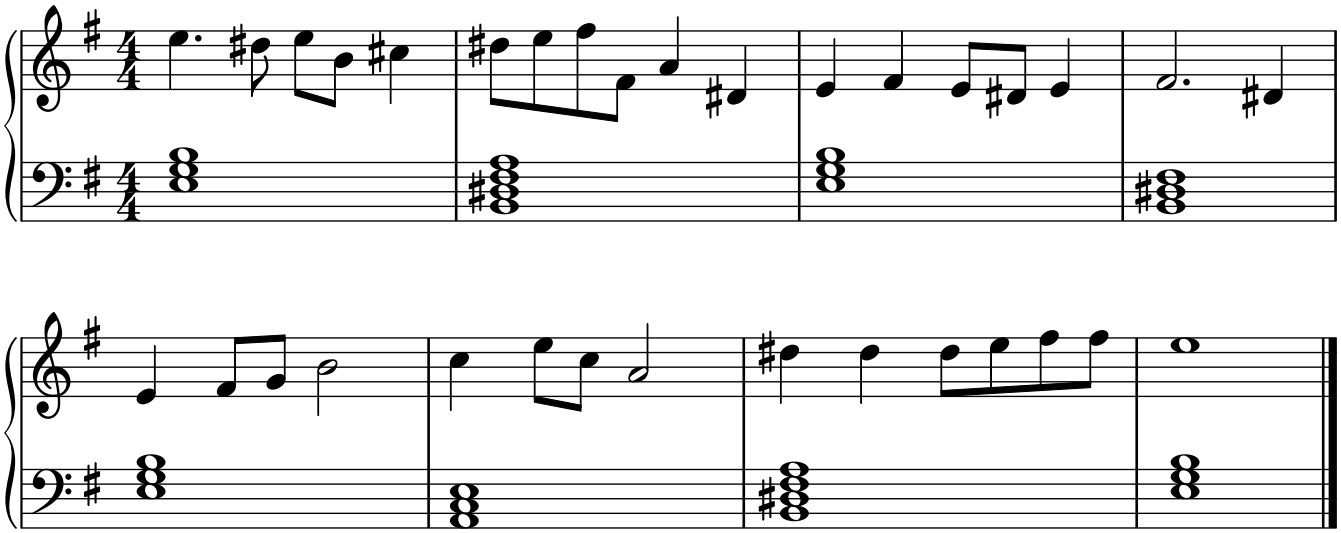


☐ **3.20**



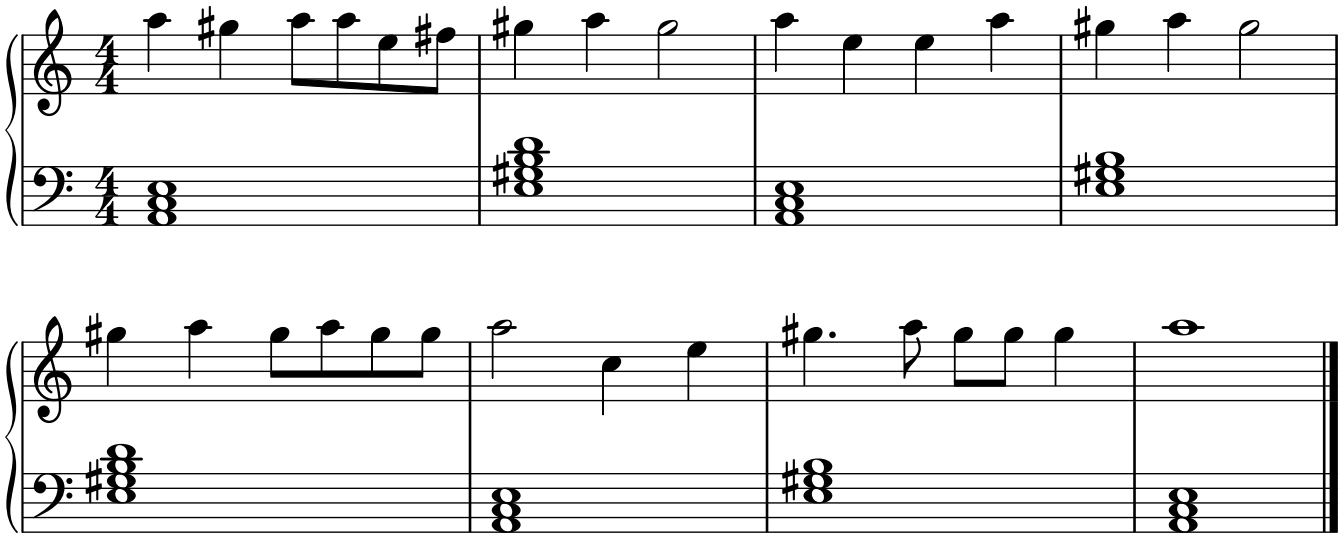
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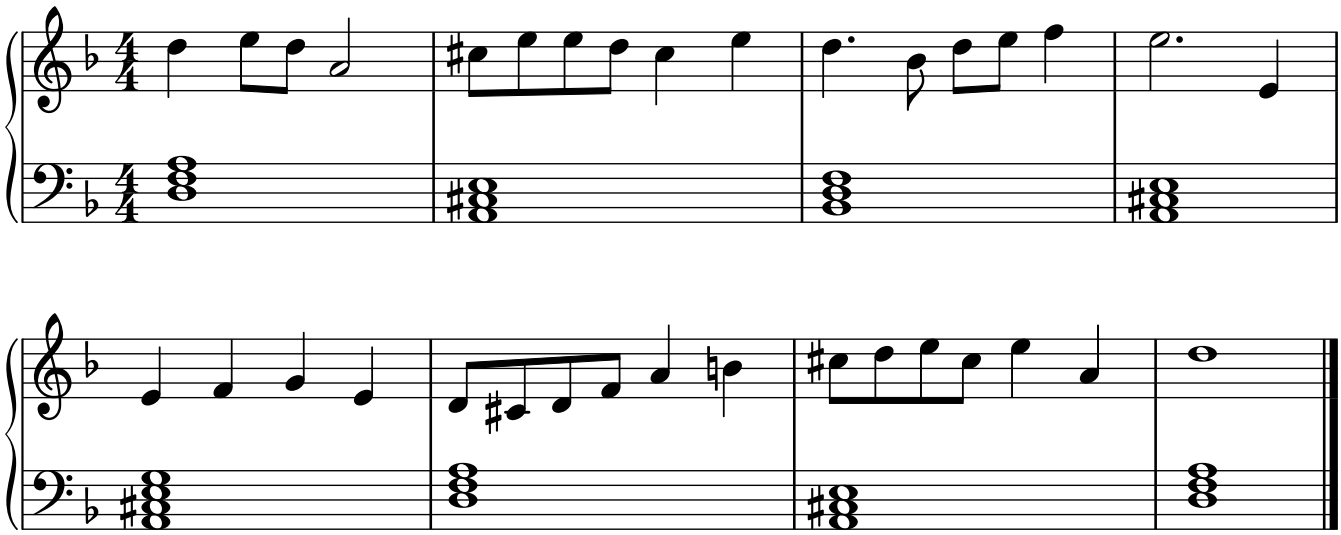


☐ **3.22**



☐ **3.23**



☐ **3.24**
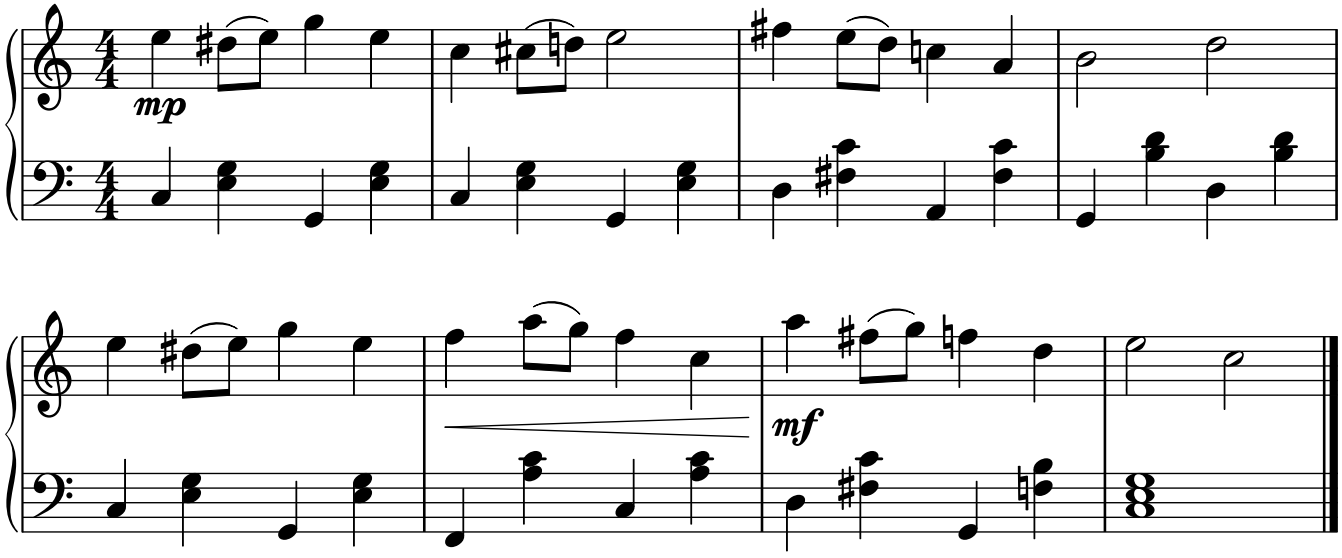


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Chromatic Walk ♩ = 76

Original
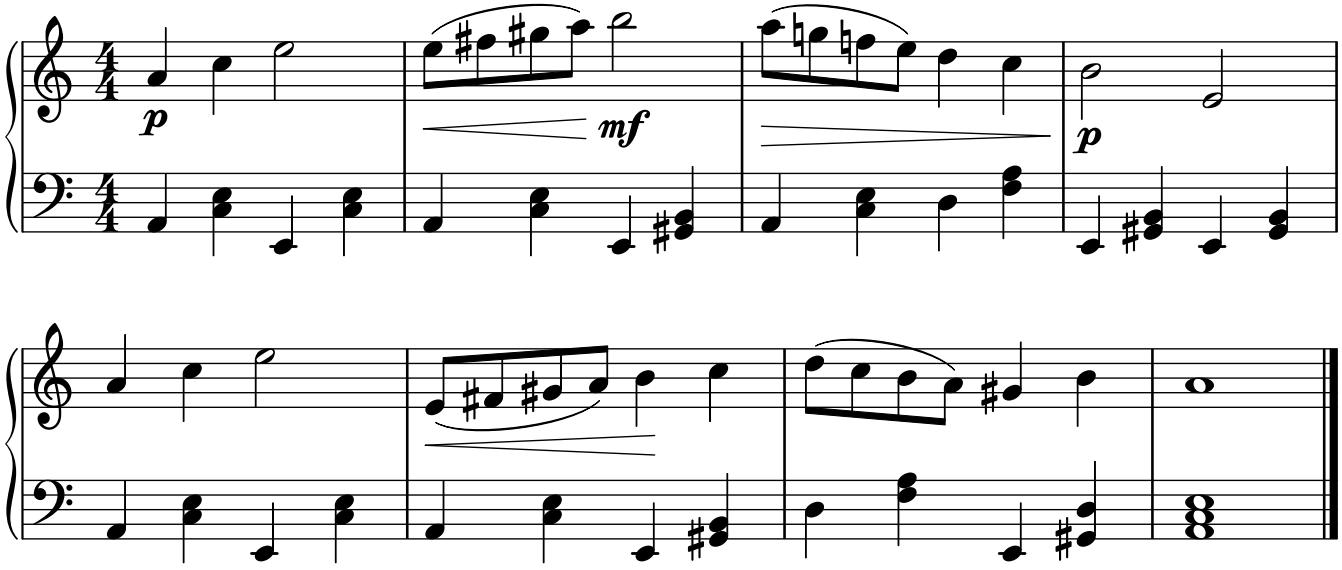
D-sharp and C-sharp are chromatic neighbour and passing notes. In bars 3 and 7, V7 of V brings F-sharp into both hands; the natural sign on F in bar 7 cancels it.



Up the Melodic Minor ♩ = 72

Original
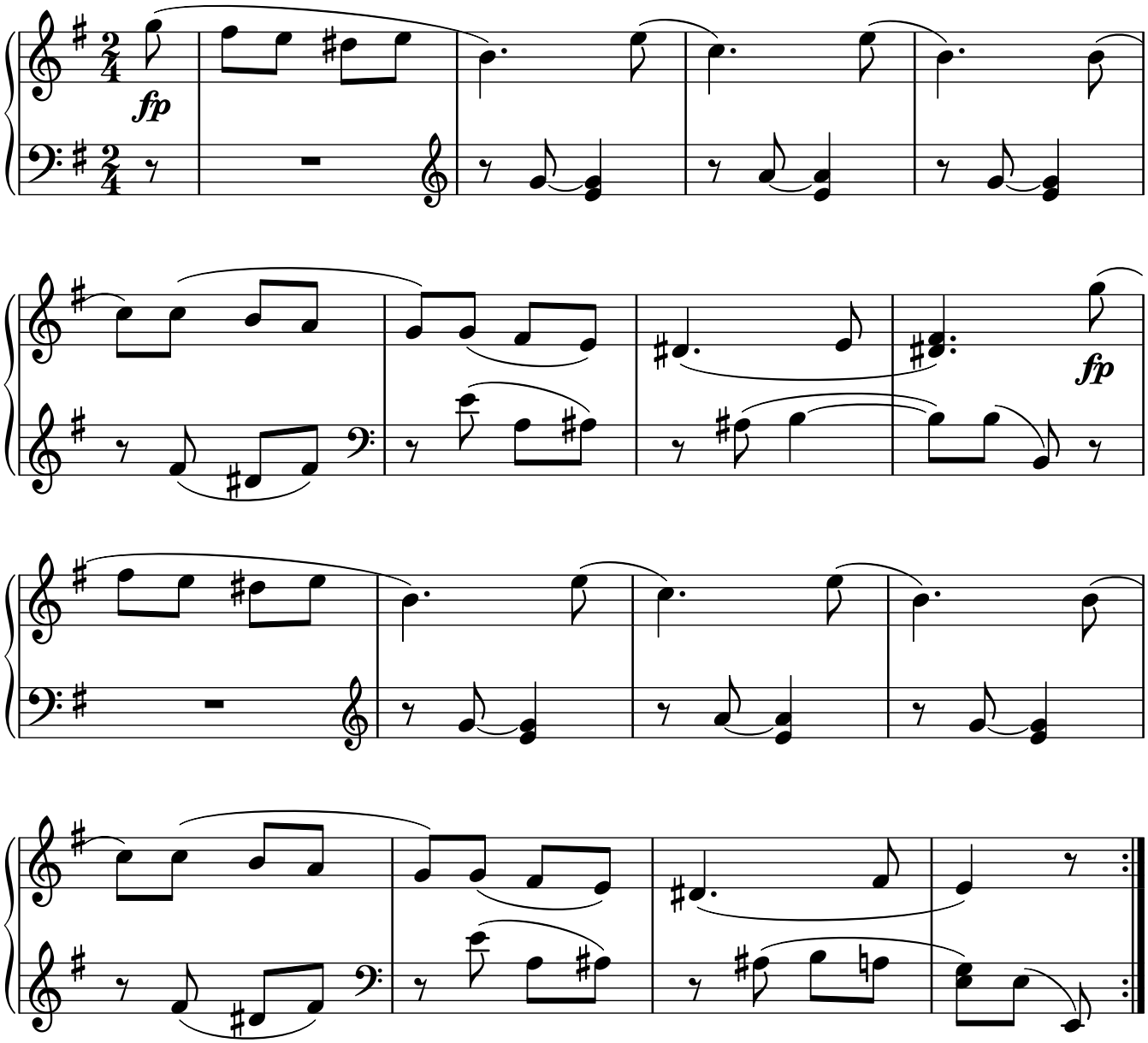
Going up (bars 2 and 6) the tune uses F-sharp and G-sharp; coming down (bar 3) it uses G and F from the key signature. The left hand's G-sharp belongs to the E major chord (V).



First Loss ♩= 66

Robert Schumann (1848), Album for the Young, Op. 68 No. 16 - first part
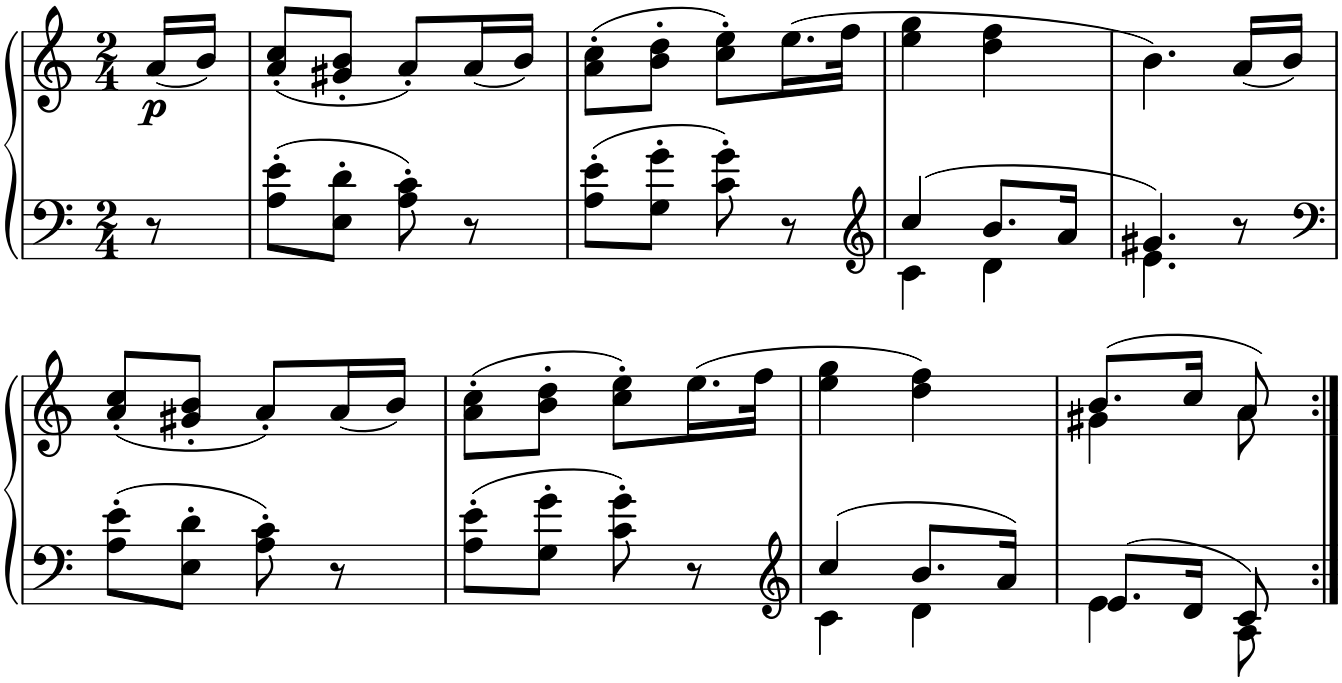
D-sharp is the raised 7th of E minor; the left hand climbs chromatically A, A-sharp, B in bars 6, 7 and 14-15. The left hand moves into the treble clef for its off-beat chords and back into the bass clef (watch the clef signs: Unit 7 is about them). Play the whole passage twice. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 676 by Philippe Hezaine (CC BY-SA 2.5).



Poor Orphan ♩= 60

Robert Schumann (1848), Album for the Young, Op. 68 No. 6 - first part

Two voices in each hand. G-sharp, the raised 7th, is in the right hand; in bar 2 the left hand has G-natural (the natural minor). The tune in bars 3-4 and 7-8 is in the left hand, which moves into the treble clef. In bar 2 the F is a thirty-second note: very short, just before the beat. Play the passage twice. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 687 by Philippe Hezaine (CC BY-SA 2.5).



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 4?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if every accidental is right, including notes later in the same bar, and the key signature returns in the next bar.
- Pass if you can play Chromatic Walk and Up the Melodic Minor at sight, and First Loss after a few days.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 4.

Unit 4

Triplets and New Time Signatures

New: Eighth-note triplets; 3/8, 9/8, 12/8 and 2/2 (alla breve)

Two new ways of counting. A triplet squeezes three notes into the time of two: three eighth notes in one beat, marked with a small 3. And four new time signatures: 3/8 (one beat in a bar, three eighths), 9/8 and 12/8 (three and four dotted-quarter beats), and 2/2, which counts two half-note beats in a bar and is often written as a C with a line through it (alla breve, 'cut time').

What is new

Triplets

Three eighth notes with a 3 above or below them fill one quarter-note beat. Count '1-trip-let 2-trip-let'. A triplet can also be a quarter and an eighth (long-short).

3/8

Three eighths in a bar, felt as one beat. Count 'one-and-a', one bar at a time. Für Elise is in 3/8.

9/8 and 12/8
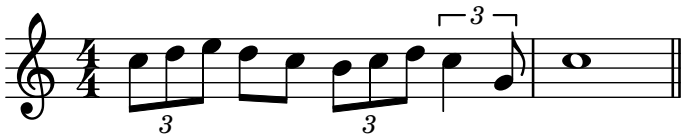
Like 6/8, but with three or four dotted-quarter beats in a bar. Look for the groups of three eighths: each group is one beat.

2/2 (alla breve)

Four quarter notes in a bar, as in 4/4, but counted in two half-note beats. The metronome mark is for the half note. The sign is a C with a vertical line.
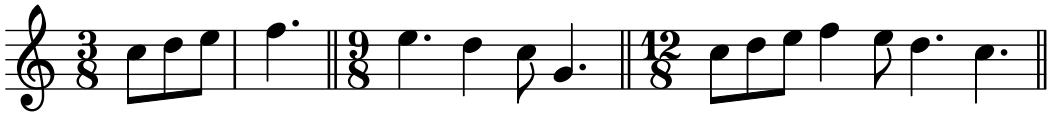
Triplets in 4/4

Beats 1 and 3 have triplets; beat 2 has two ordinary eighths; beat 4 is a triplet quarter and eighth.
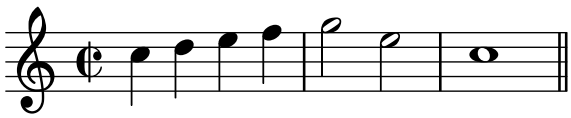


3/8, 9/8 and 12/8

Each group of three eighths is one beat: one beat in 3/8, three in 9/8, four in 12/8.



2/2: alla breve

The same notes as 4/4, counted in two: 'one - two -'.



Reading tips

1. Before you play, find the time signature and decide what one beat is: a quarter, a dotted quarter or a half.

2. Count triplets 'trip-let' only where they are; elsewhere count ordinary eighths 'and'.
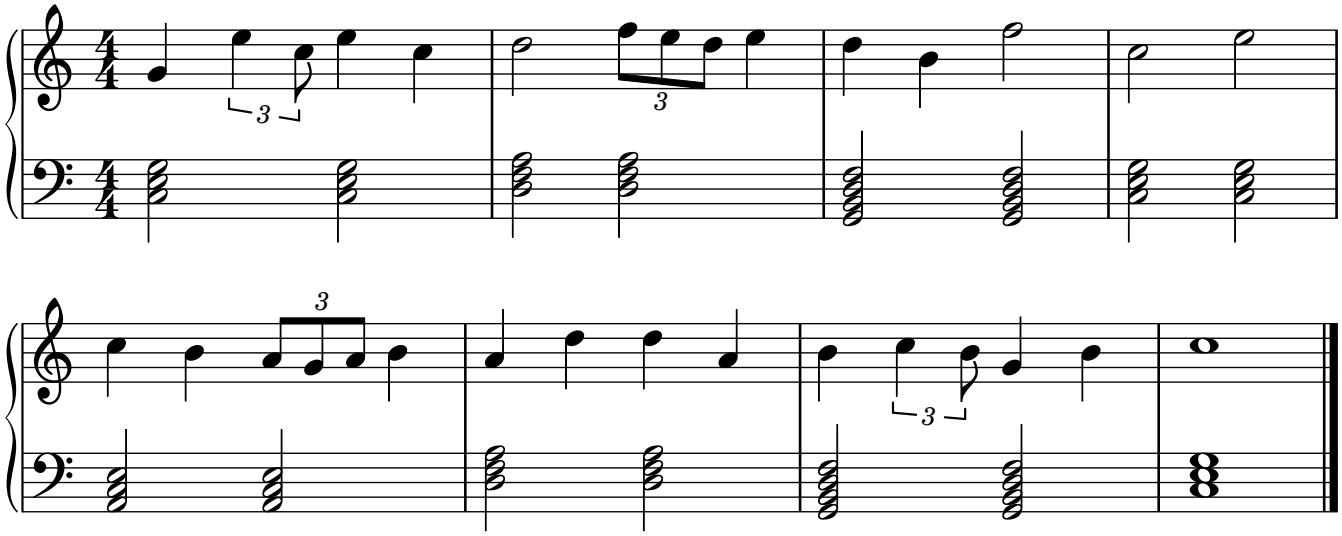
3. In 3/8, feel one strong beat per bar and read four bars at a time, like one bar of 12/8.

4. In 2/2, set the metronome to the half note and keep the quarters light.
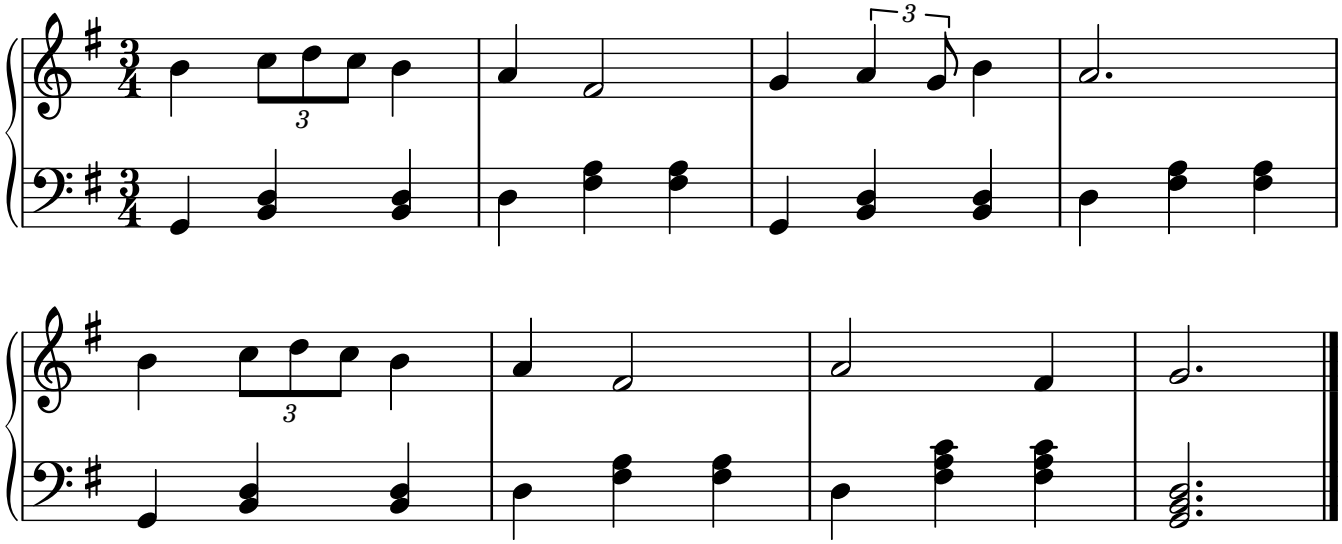
Part A: Triplets ♩ = 66

Triplets in the right hand over held chords (4/4) and waltz basses (3/4).
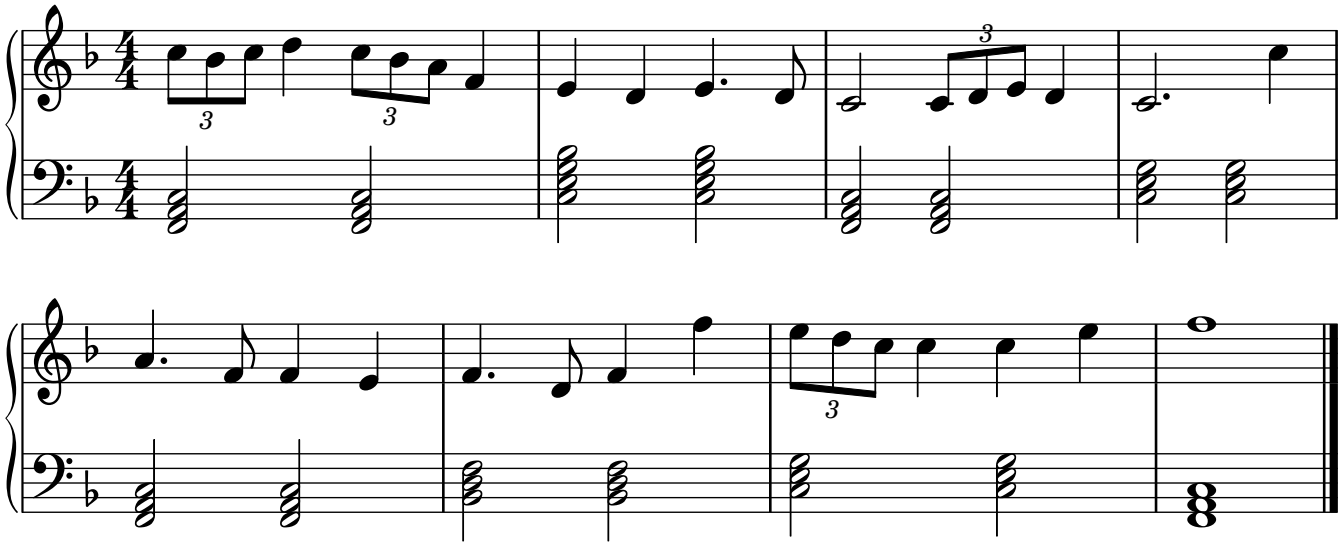
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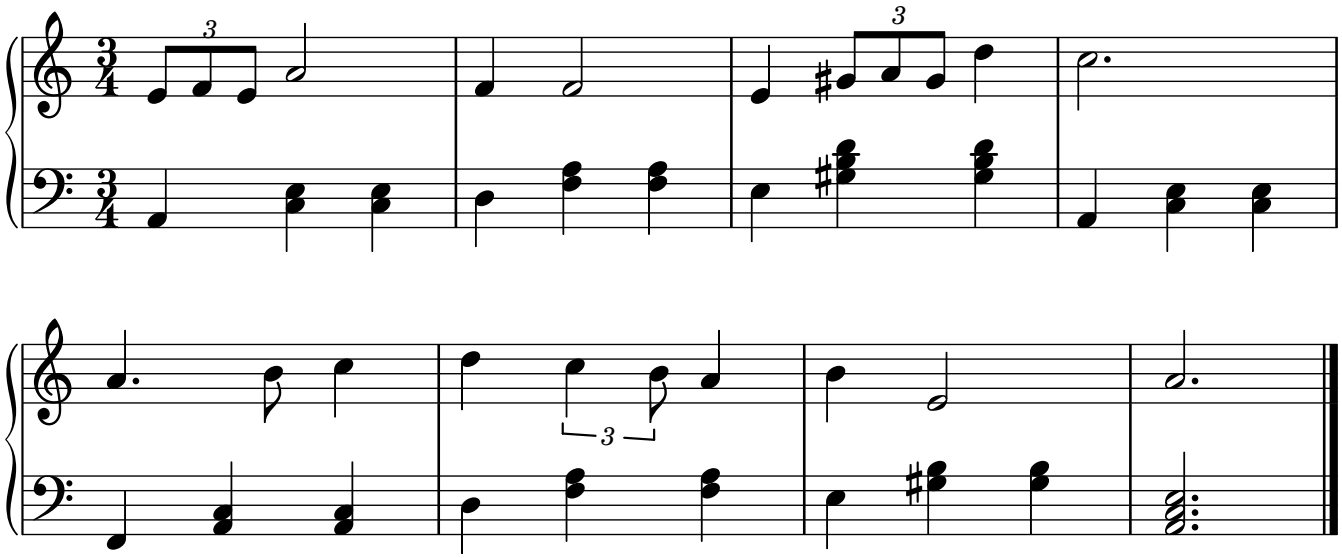


☐ **4.2**
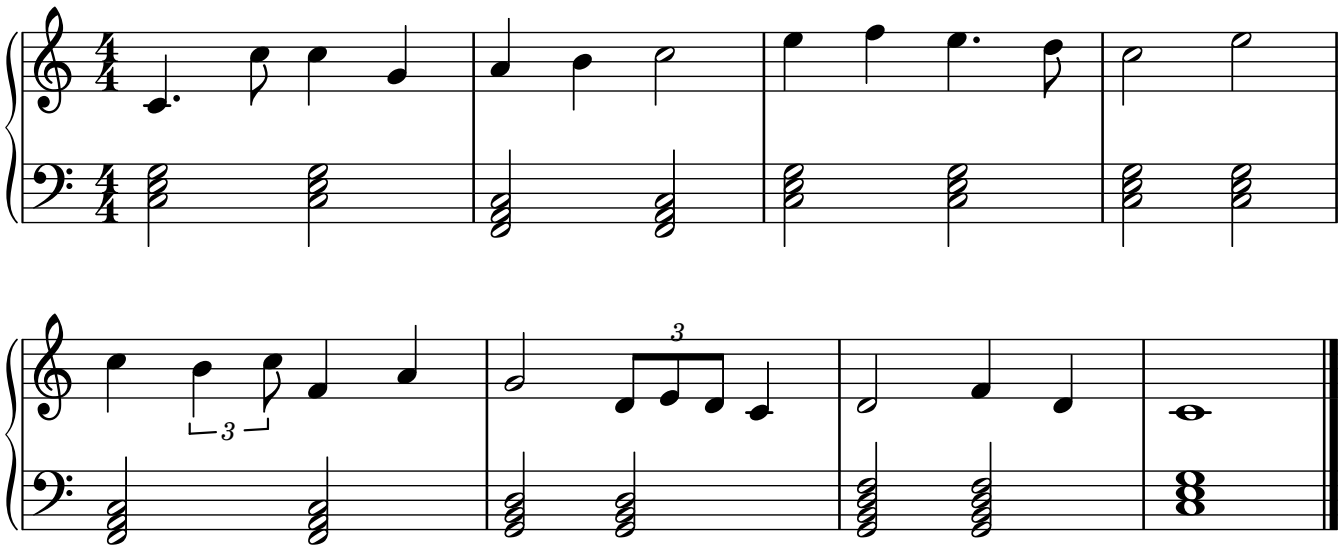


☐ **4.3**
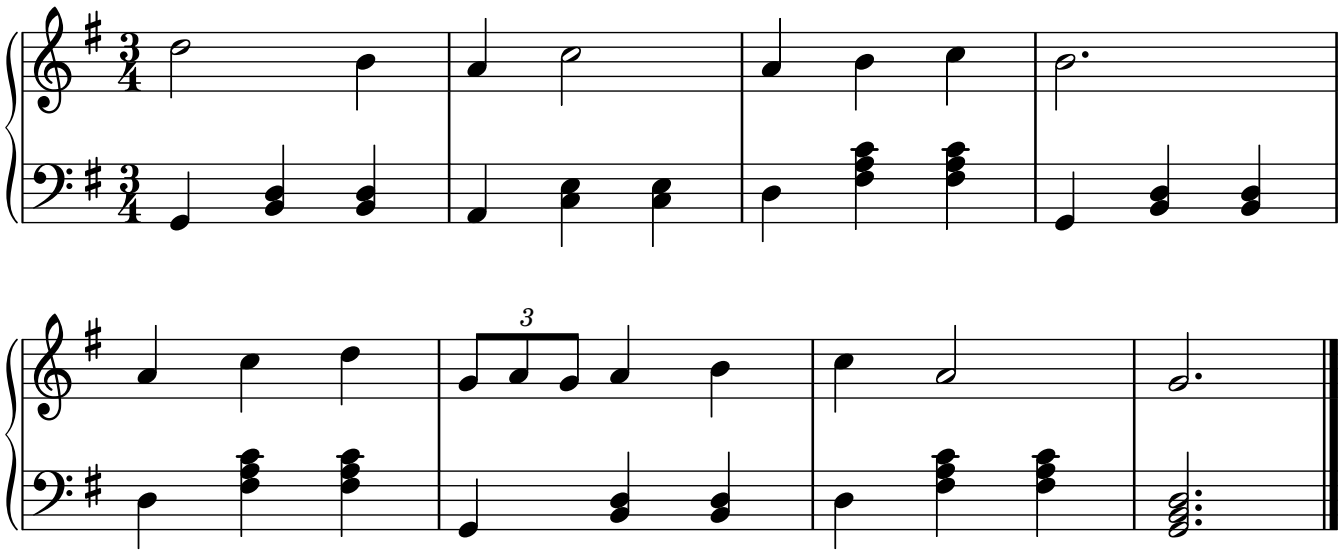


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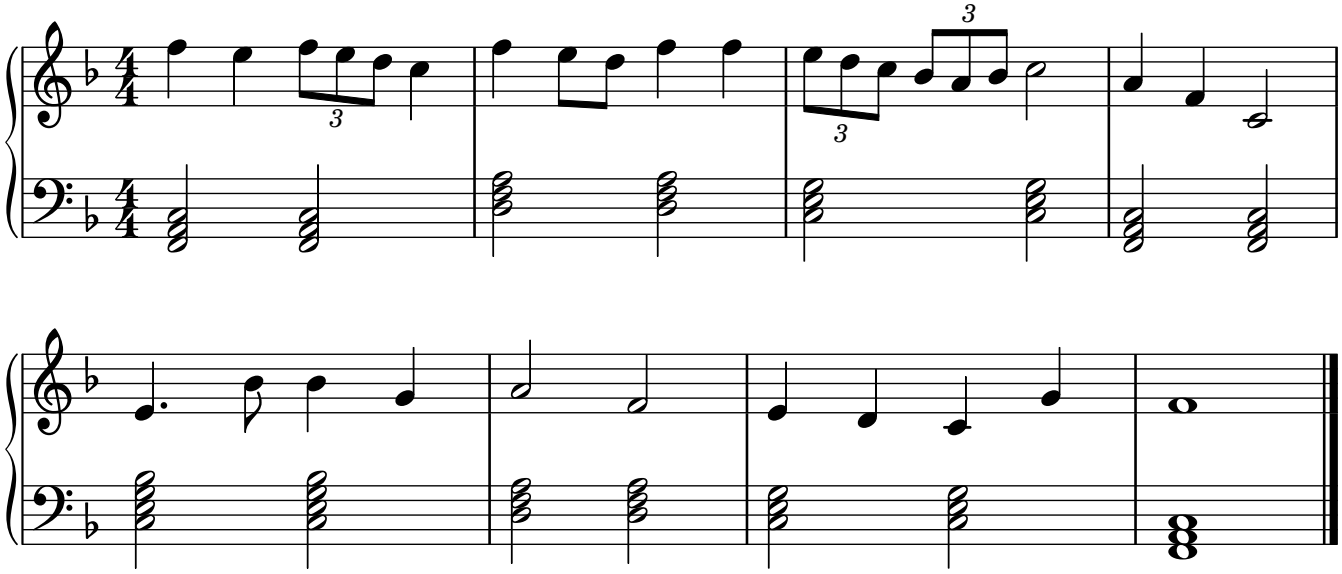


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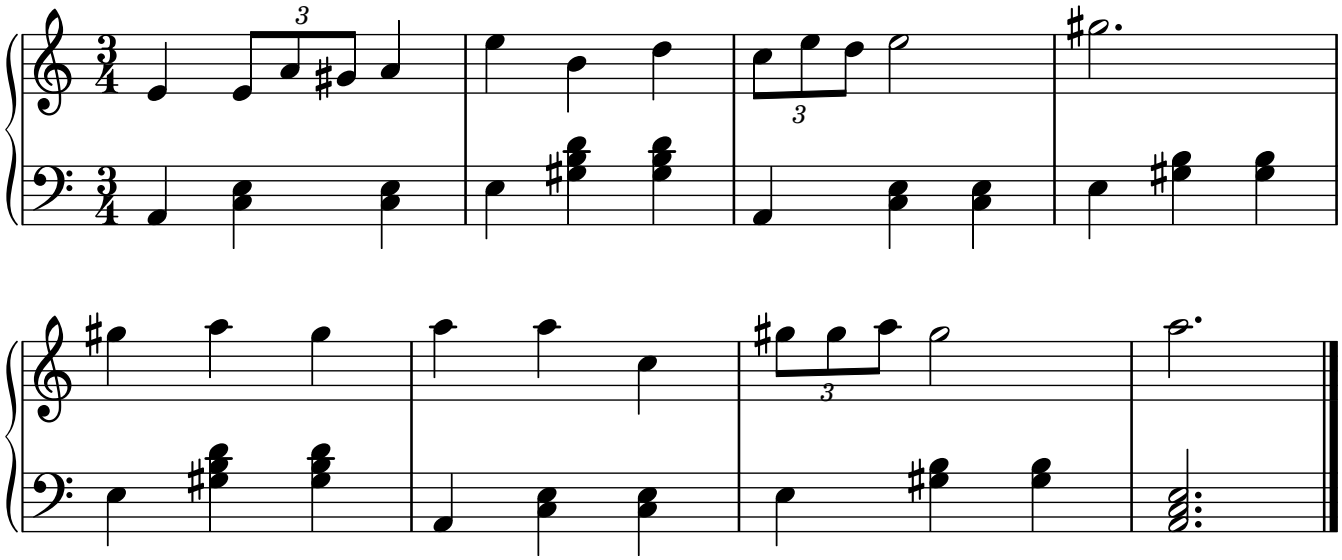


☐ **4.6**



4.7
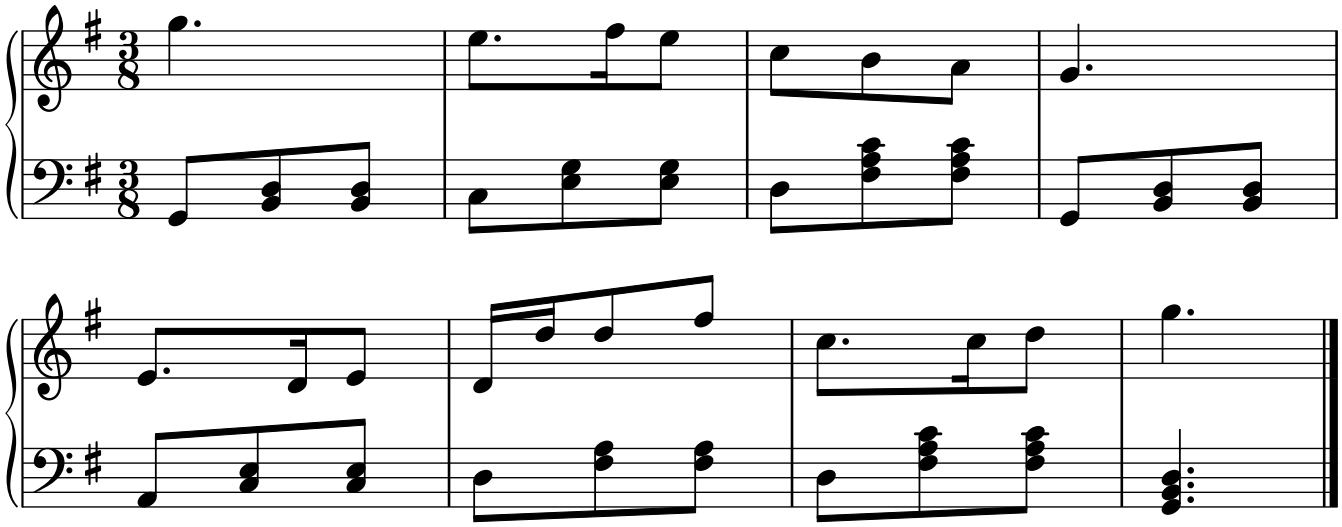


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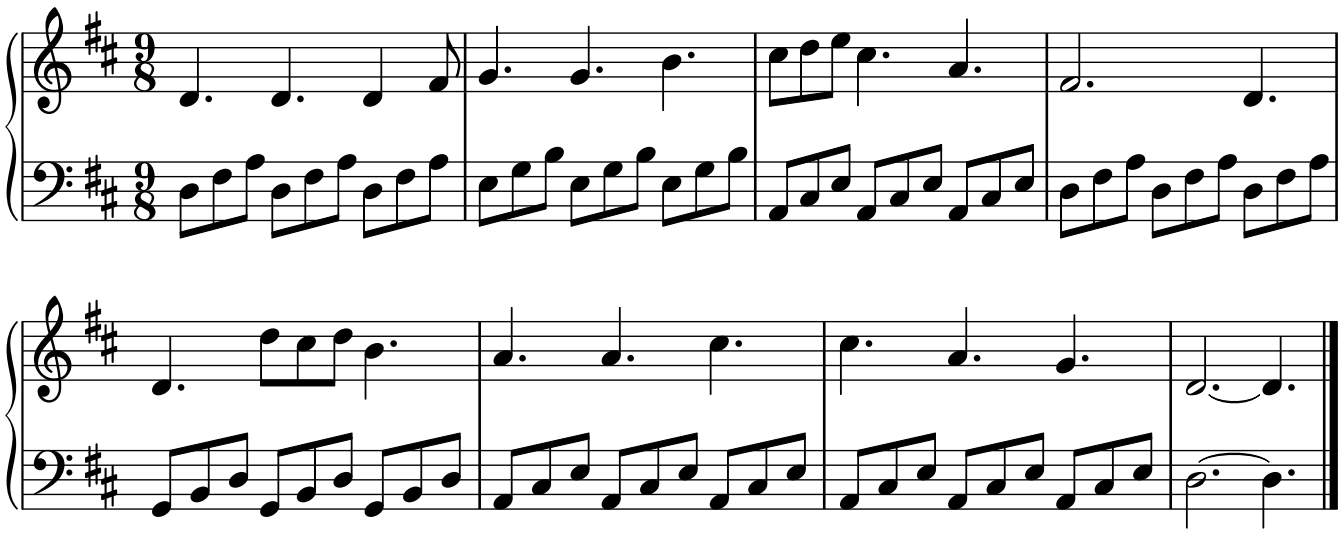


Part B: 3/8 and 9/8 ♩. = 60

3/8 (one beat, waltz bass) and 9/8 (three dotted-quarter beats, broken chords). The metronome beats dotted quarters.
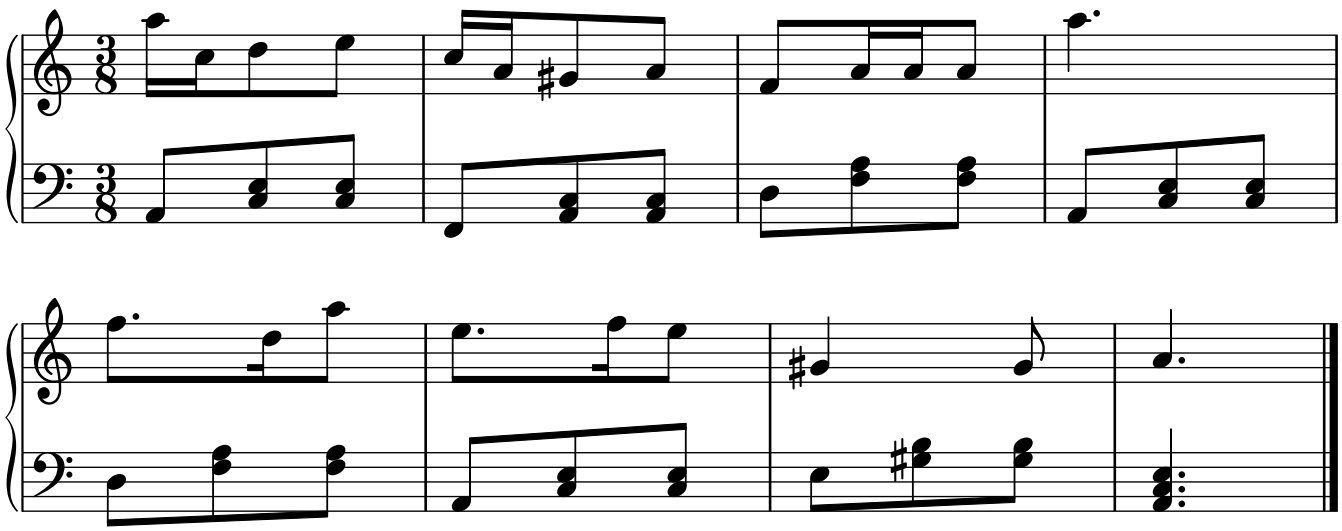
☐ **4.9**
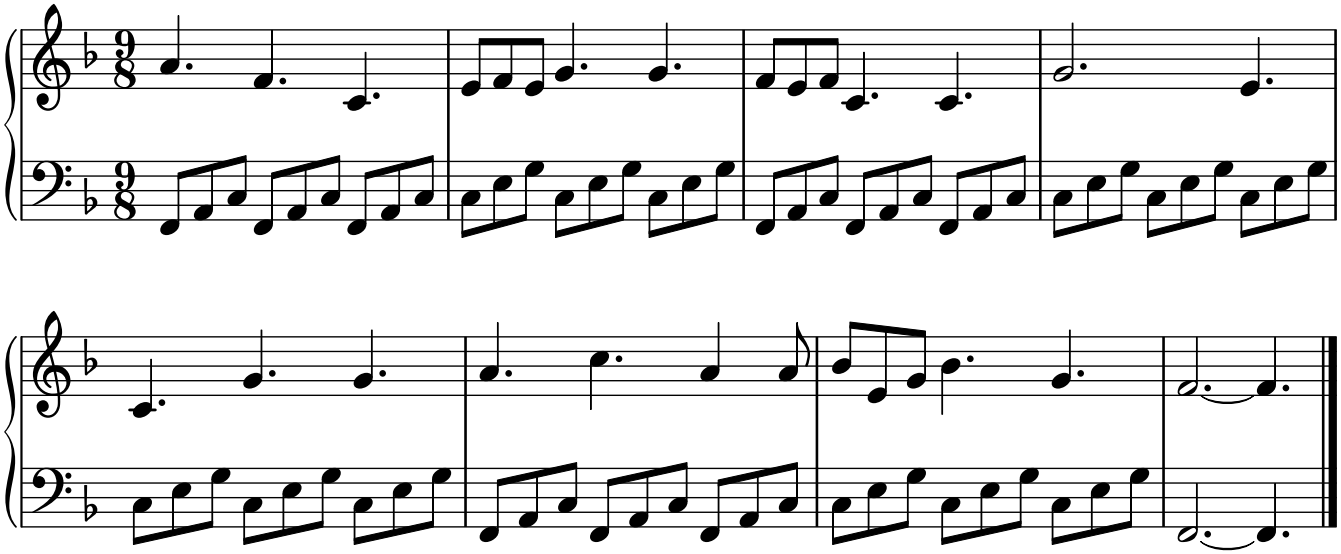


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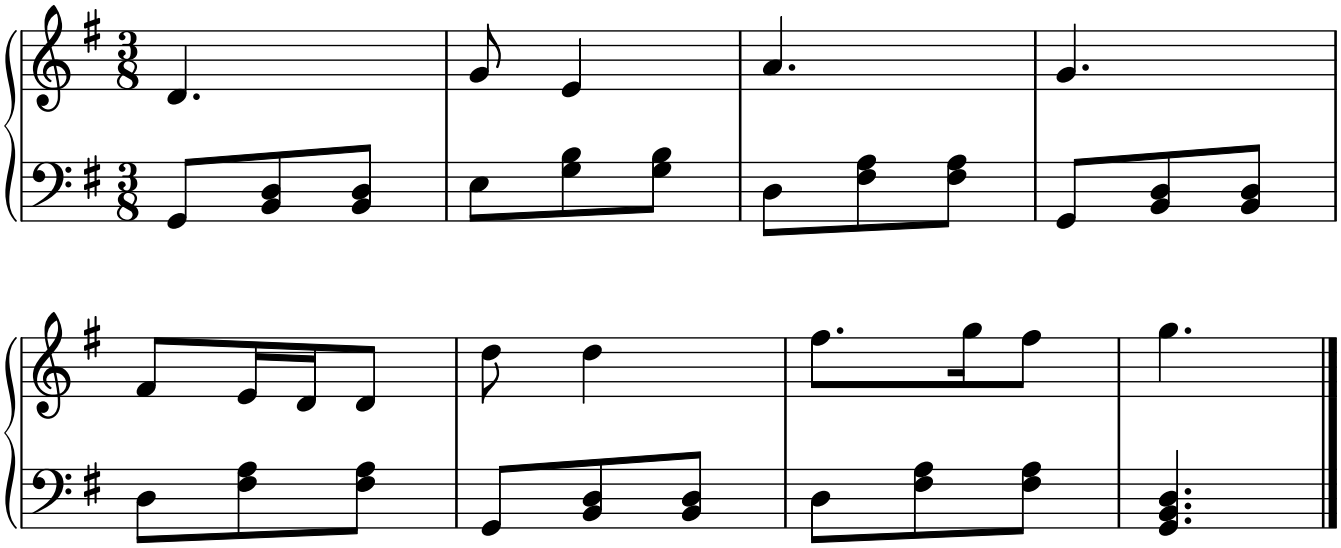


☐ **4.11**
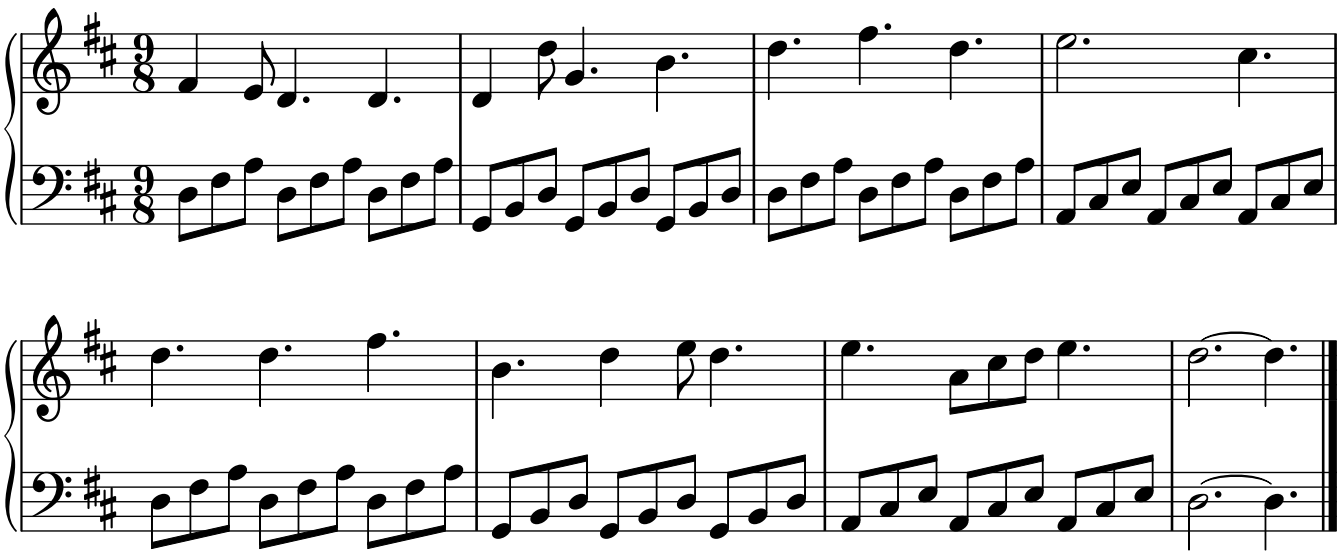


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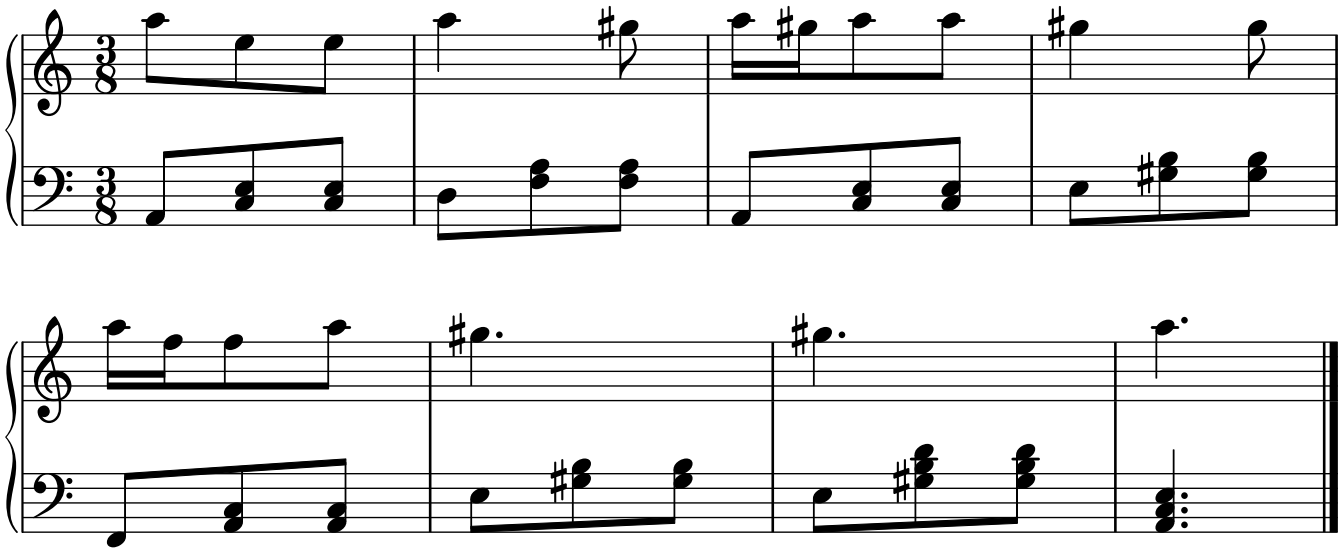


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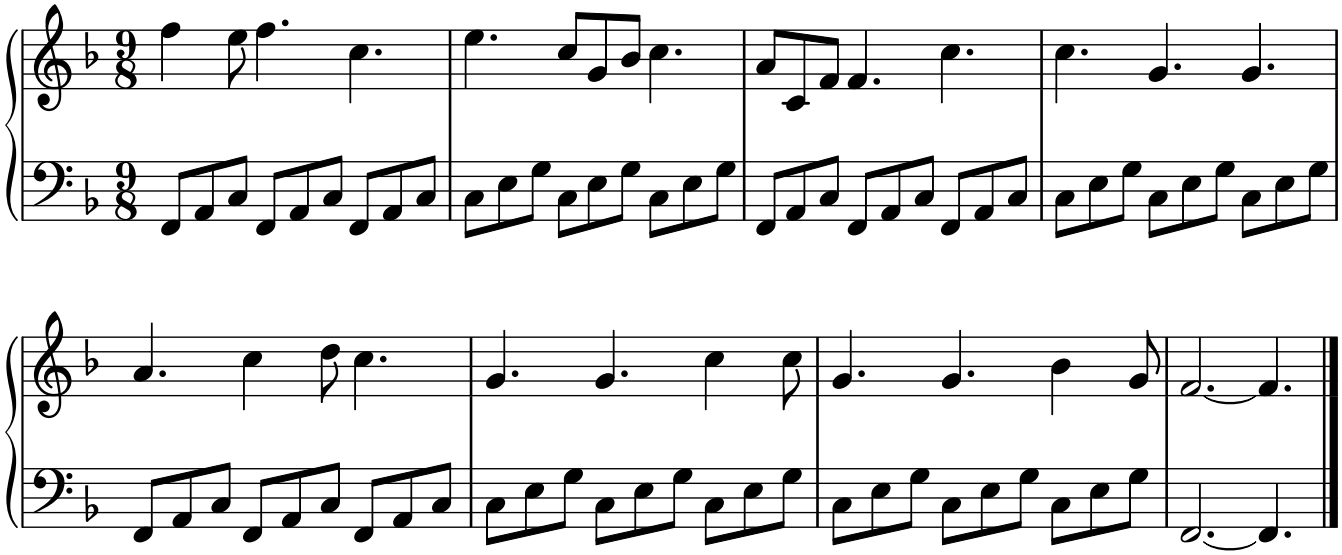


☐ **4.14**



4.15
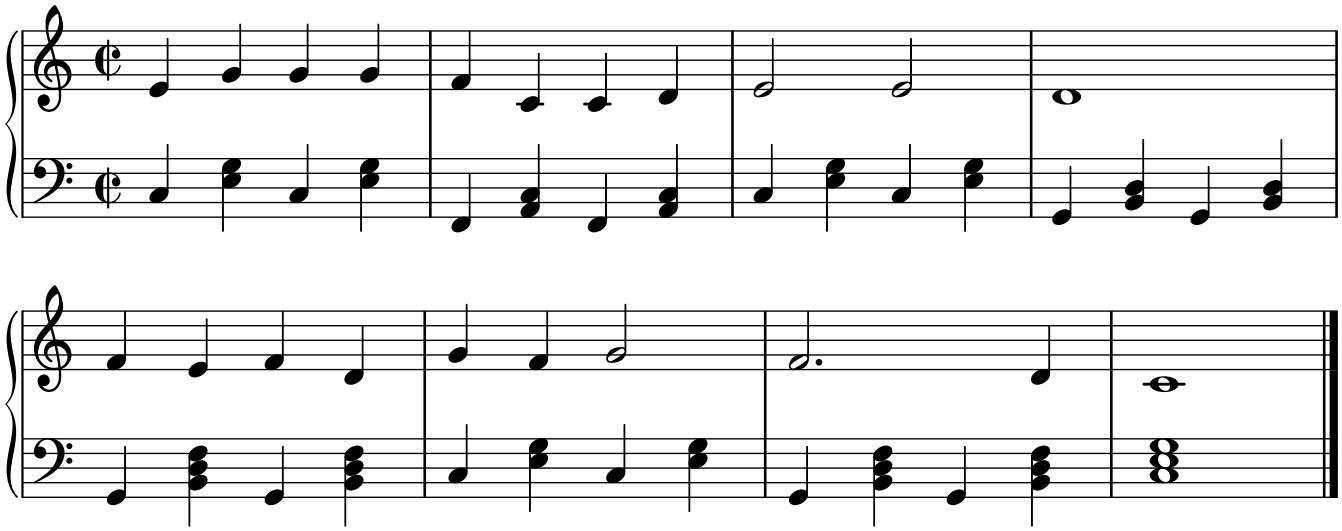


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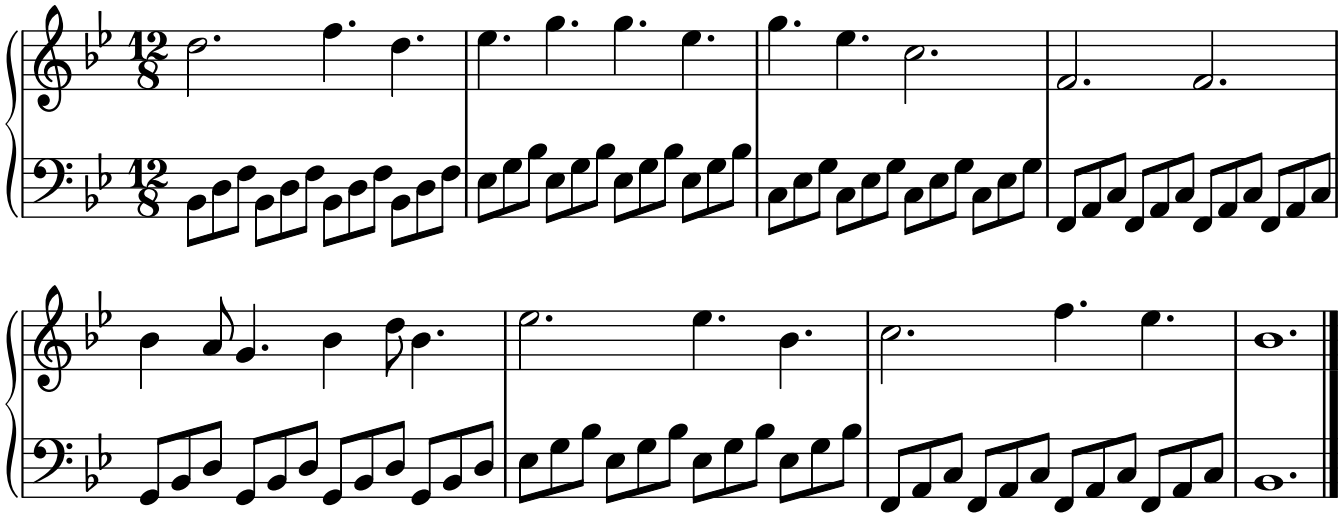


Part C: 2/2 and 12/8 $\mathbb{d}$ = 60

2/2 (two half-note beats; the metronome beats half notes) and 12/8 (four dotted-quarter beats).
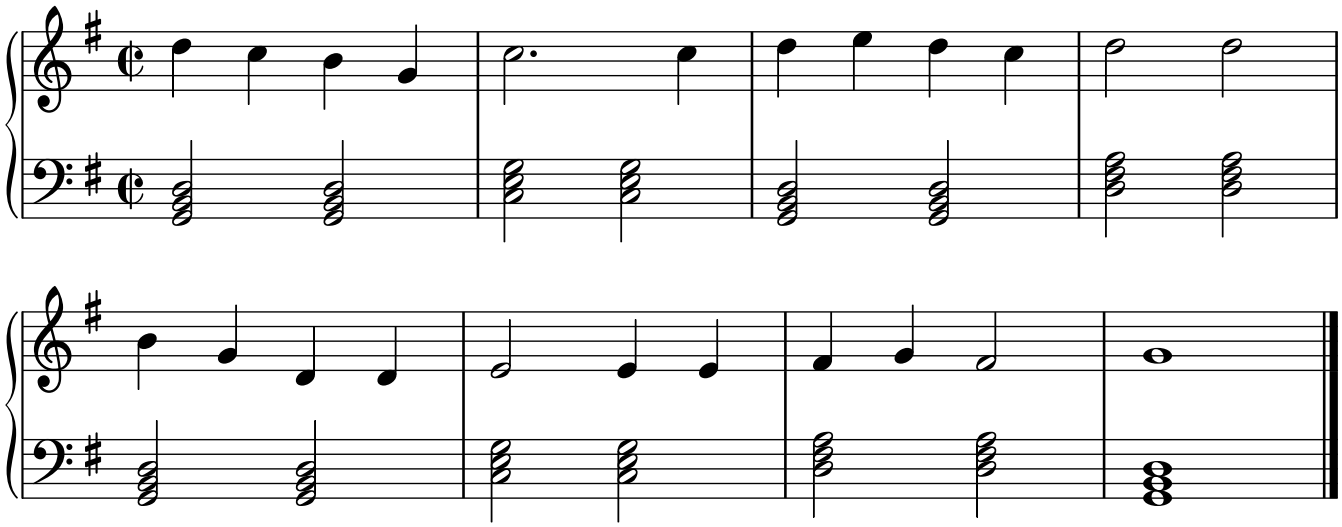
☐ **4.17**
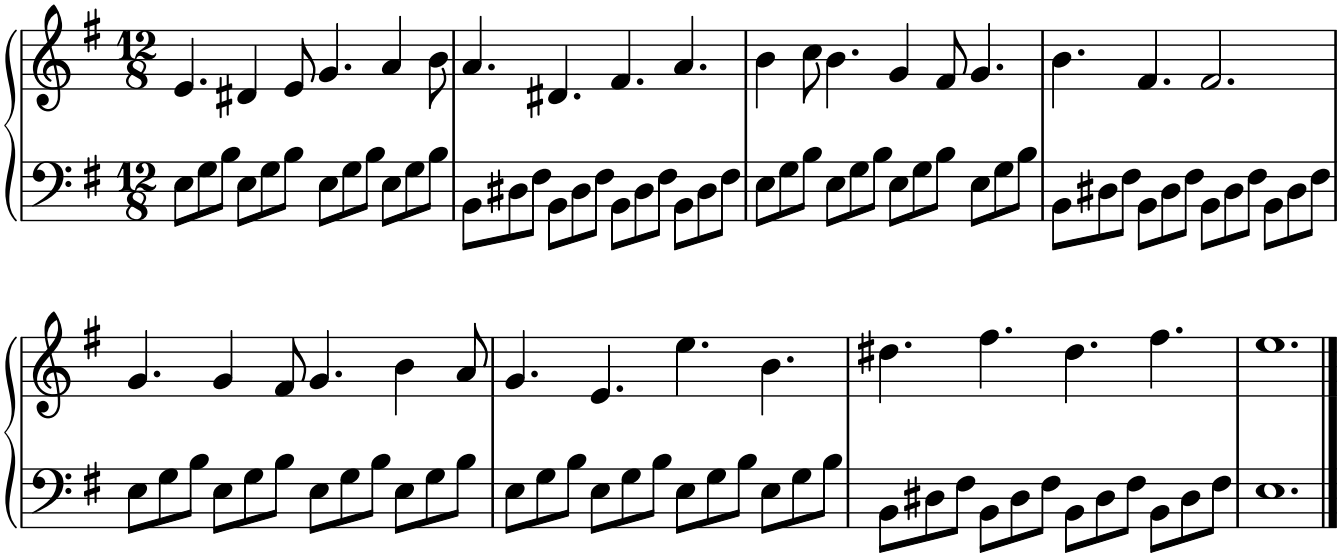


☐ **4.18** $\mathbb{d}.$ = 50
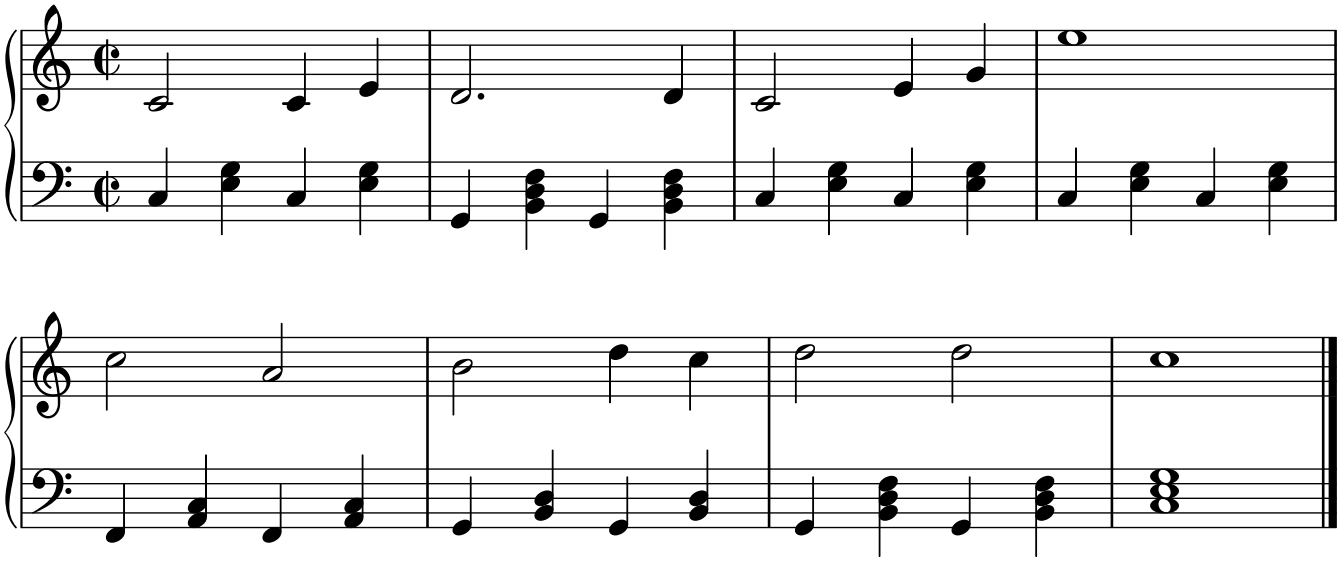


☐ **4.19**
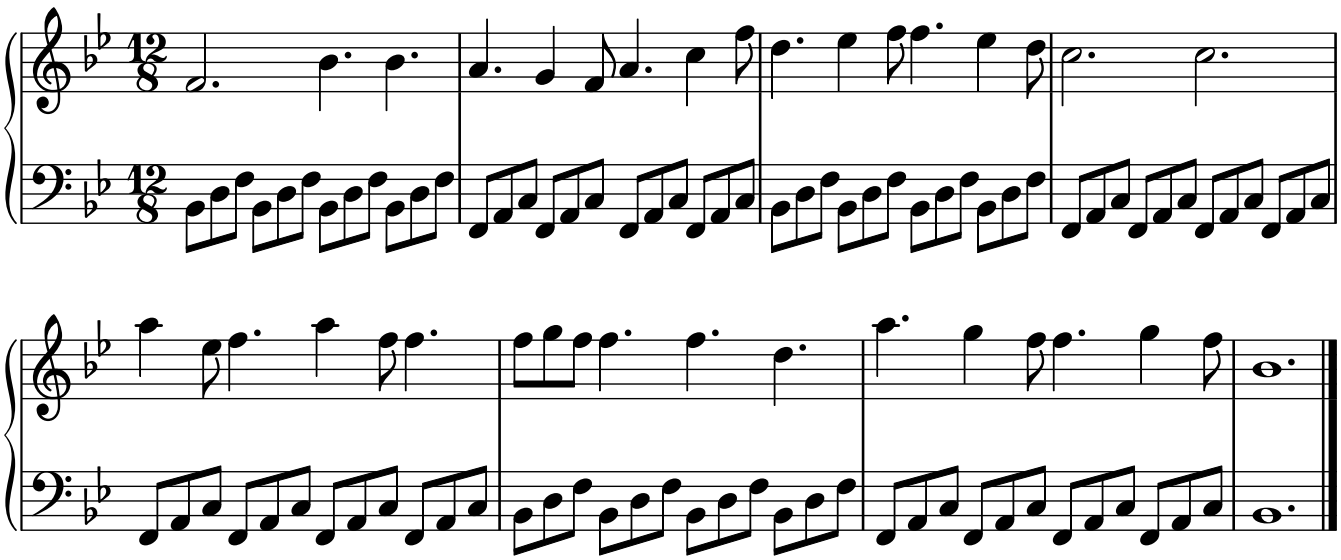


4.20 ♩. = 50
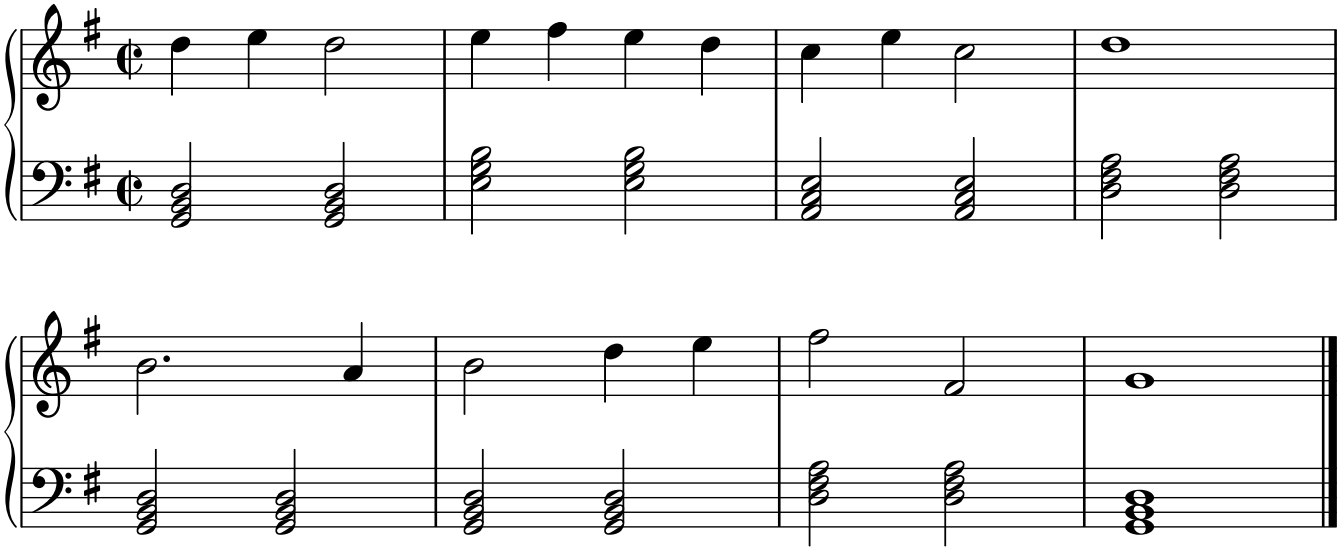


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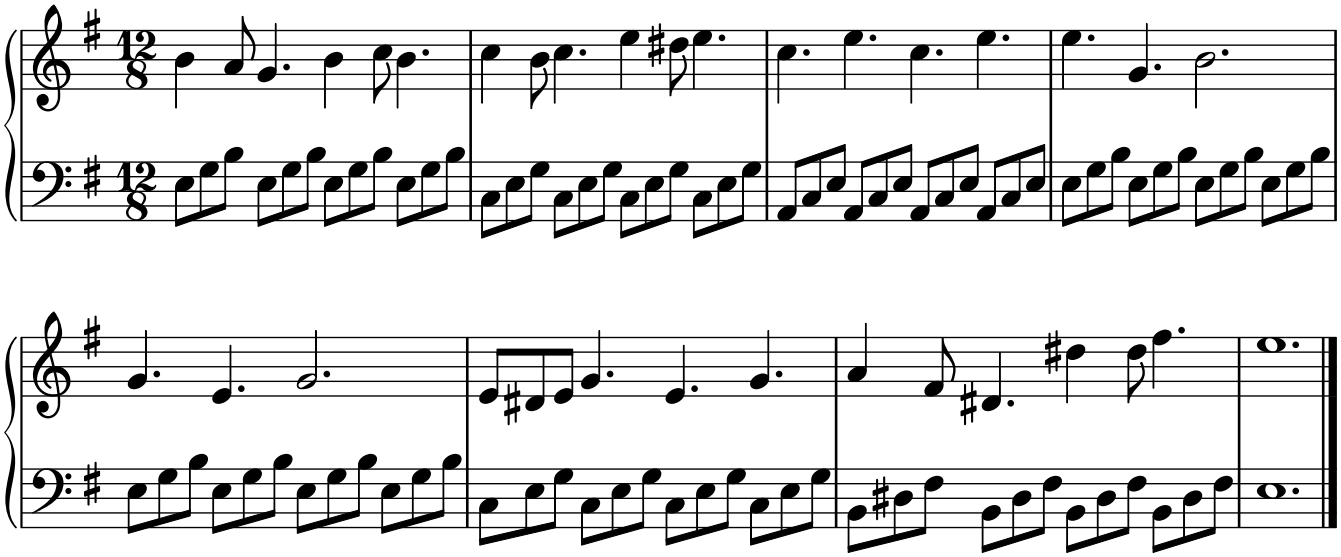


4.22 ♩. = 50



4.23



4.24 ♩. = 50
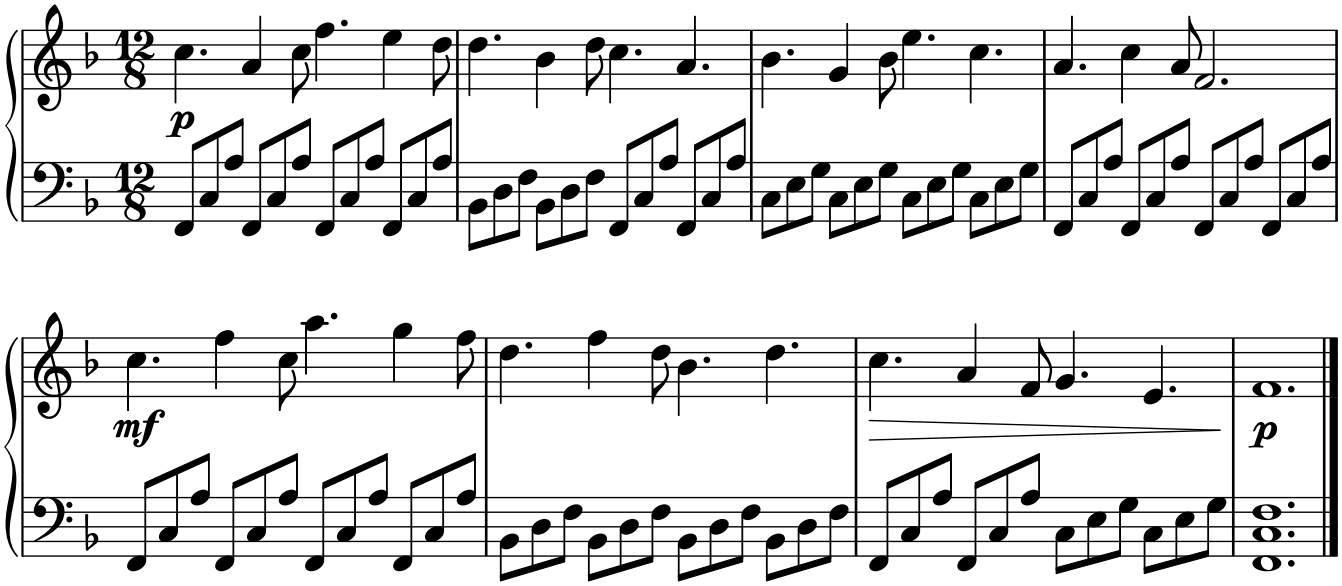


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Rowing Song ♩. = 52

Original
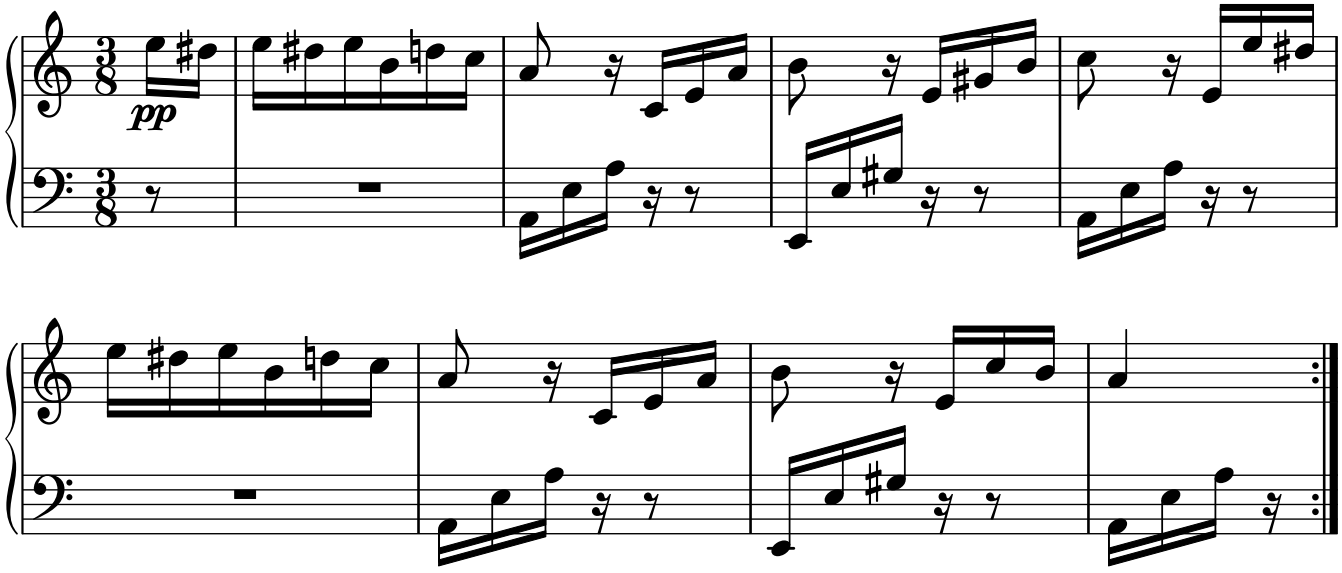
Four dotted-quarter beats in each bar: the left hand rows in groups of three eighths, one group to a beat. Count '1-and-a 2-and-a 3-and-a 4-and-a'.



Für Elise ♩. = 60

Ludwig van Beethoven (1810), Bagatelle in A minor, WoO 59 - the opening theme
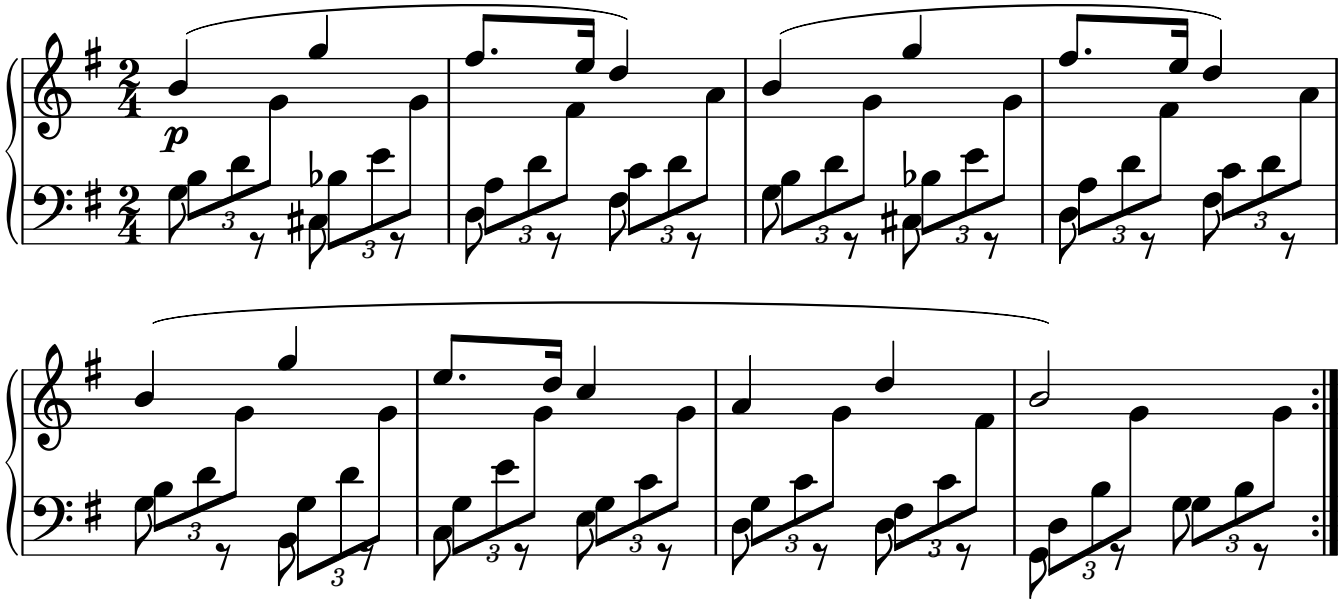
3/8: feel one beat in each bar. The tune starts on an upbeat and passes from the right hand to the left and back: the left hand's broken chords (A minor and E major, with G-sharp) lead into the right hand's next notes. D-sharp is a chromatic neighbour of E. Play the theme twice. Pedal marks are left out until Unit 7. Source: Mutopia Project no. 931 (public domain).



Of Foreign Lands and Peoples ♩= 80

Robert Schumann (1838), Scenes from Childhood, Op. 15 No. 1 - first part
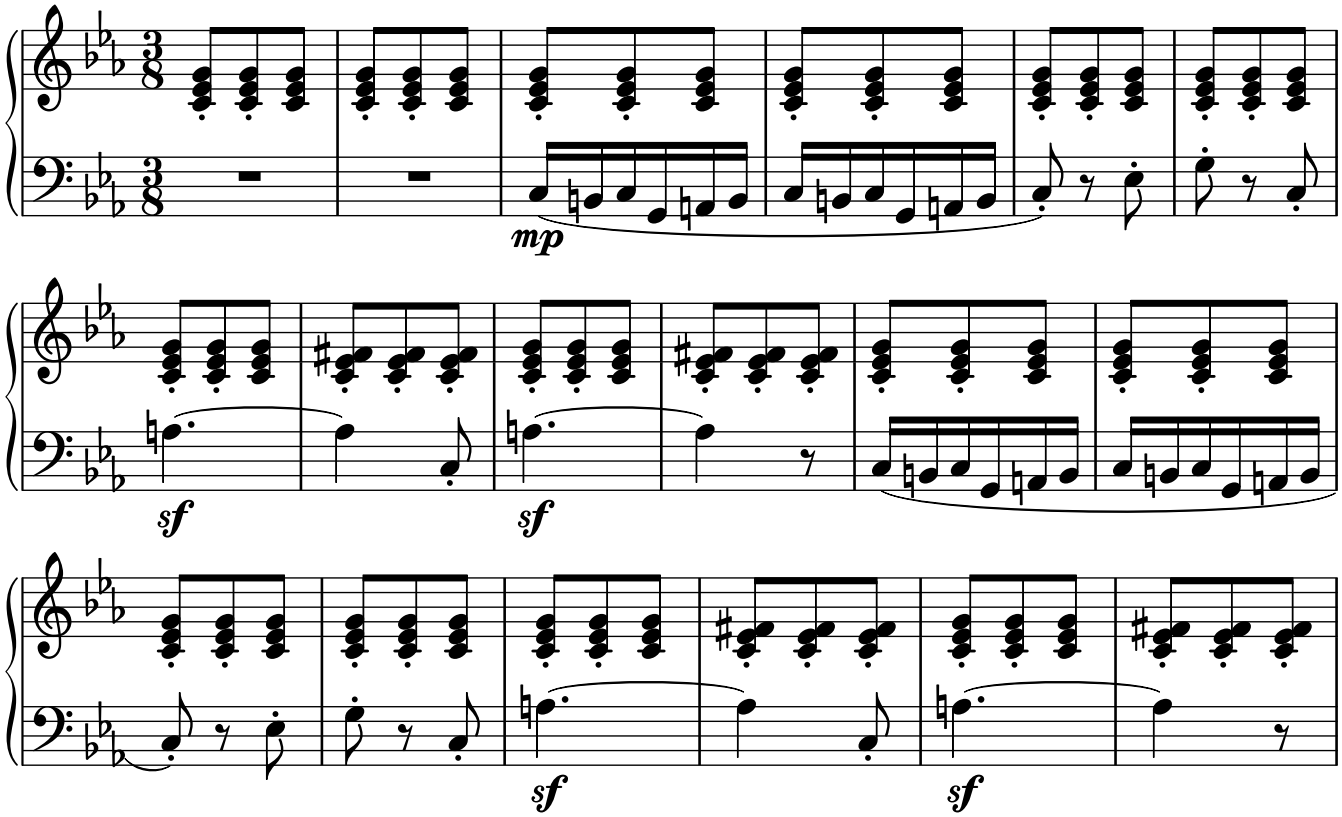
The tune (stems up) floats over triplets that are shared between the hands: the left hand plays the first two notes of each triplet (the beam crosses to the bass staff), the right hand the third. The left hand also plays the bass on the beat. C-sharp and B-flat are chromatic. Play the passage twice. Source: Mutopia Project no. 354 (public domain).
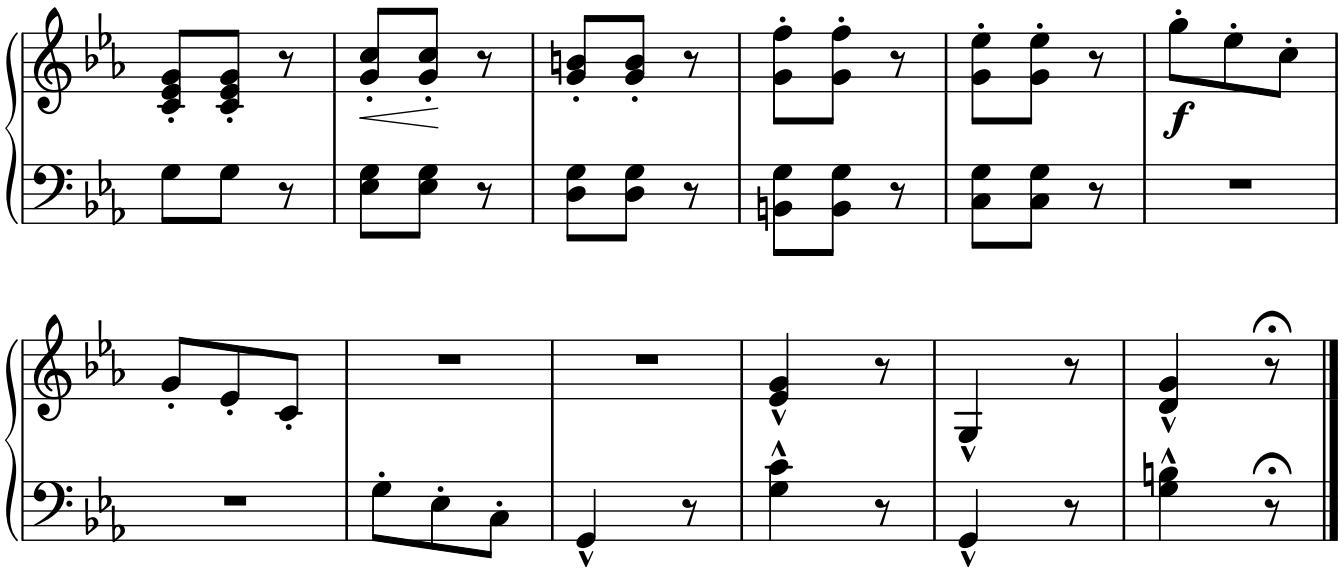


Ballade ♩. = 60

Friedrich Burgmuller (1851), 25 Easy Studies, Op. 100 No. 15 - first part

The tune is in the left hand, low and mysterious, under quiet repeated chords. Read the left hand in groups of bars: two bars of sixteenths, two of eighths, four of long A-naturals under an F-sharp chord. The section ends on a G major chord, the dominant: in the whole piece a C major middle section follows. Source: Mutopia Project no. 227 (public domain).





Checkpoint: ready for Unit 5?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if every triplet is even and fits its beat, and you can say how many beats each time signature has.
- Pass if you can play Rowing Song at sight and the opening of Für Elise after a few days.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 5.

Unit 5

Four Sharps and Four Flats

New: E major and A-flat major; C-sharp minor (B-sharp) and F minor (E-natural)

Each new key adds one sharp or one flat to the last. E major has four sharps: F, C, G and D. A-flat major has four flats: B, E, A and D. Their relative minors share the key signatures: C-sharp minor (with B-sharp as its raised 7th) and F minor (with E-natural). The keyboard pictures show which keys each scale uses: in four-sharp and four-flat keys most of the black keys are in play.

What is new

Four sharps

F-sharp, C-sharp, G-sharp, D-sharp: E major and C-sharp minor. The last sharp (D-sharp) is the 7th note of E major.

Four flats

B-flat, E-flat, A-flat, D-flat: A-flat major and F minor. The second-last flat (A-flat) names the major key.

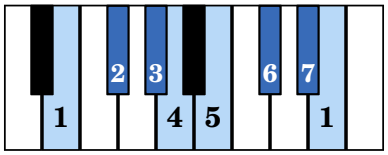
B-sharp and E-natural

The raised 7th of C-sharp minor is B-sharp (the white key C); the raised 7th of F minor is E-natural. Both appear in every V chord.

Think in shapes

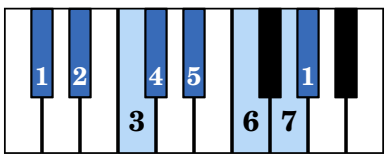
In these keys the hand sits on the black keys. Learn the I, IV and V chord shapes of each key: most passages are made of them.

E major: four sharps (F, C, G, D)



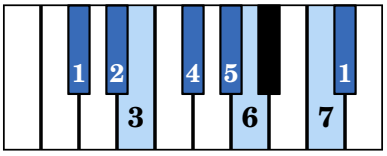
Scale degrees on the keys: E F♯ G♯ A B C♯ D♯ E

A-flat major: four flats (B, E, A, D)



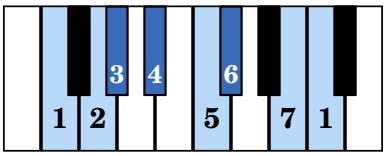
Scale degrees on the keys: A♭ B♭ C D♭ E♭ F G A♭

C-sharp minor: E major's relative minor; the raised 7th is B-sharp



Scale degrees on the keys: C♯ D♯ E F♯ G♯ A B♯ C♯

F minor: A-flat major's relative minor; the raised 7th is E-natural



Scale degrees on the keys: F G A♭ B♭ C D♭ E F
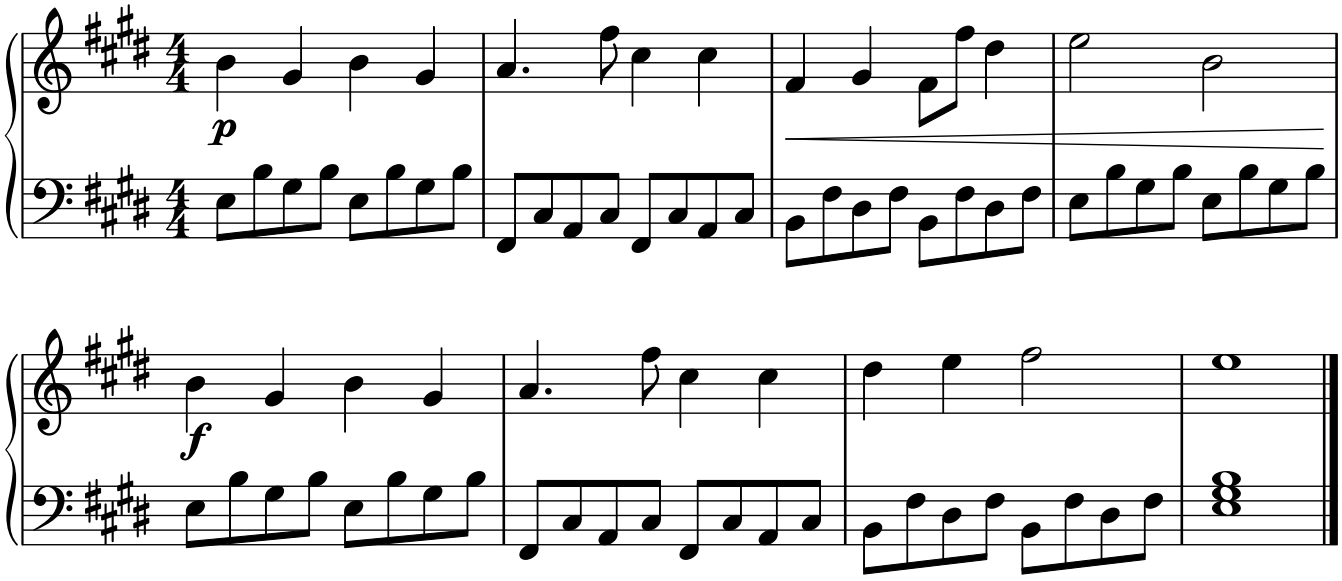
Reading tips

1. Name the key, then play the scale and the I, IV and V chords once before you read.
2. Watch for B-sharp and E-natural in the minor keys: they look strange but are the leading notes.
3. Remember the key signature in every octave and in both clefs.
4. If a passage is mostly on black keys, use your longer fingers (2, 3, 4) for them and thumbs on the white keys.
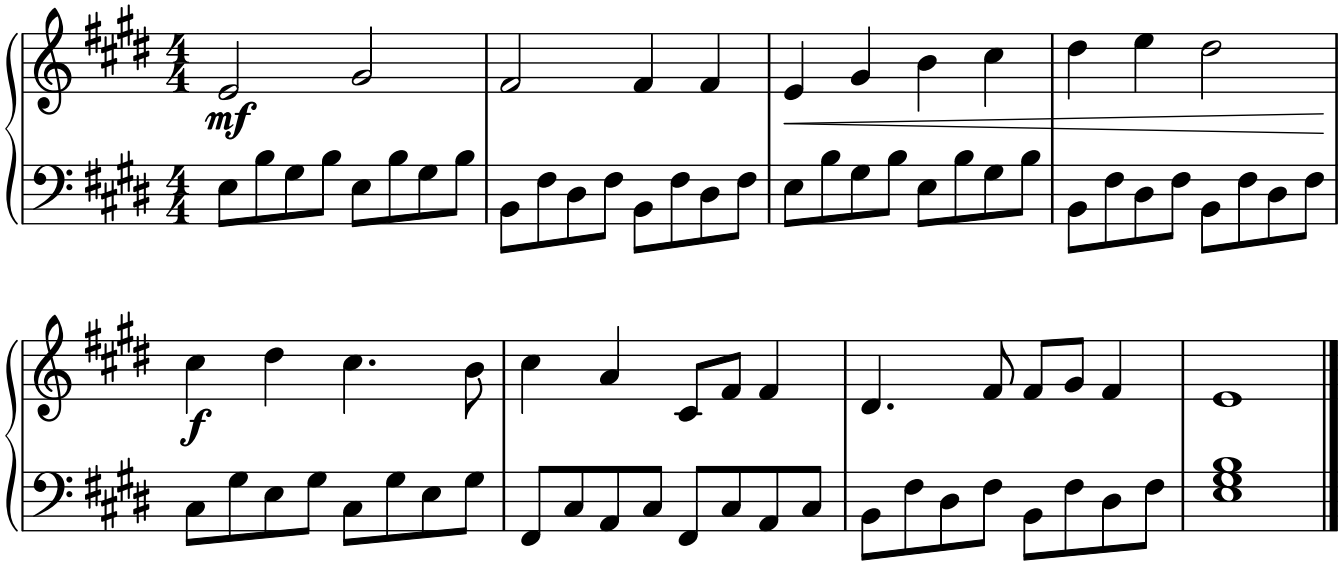
Part A: E major ♩ = 66

E major over an Alberti bass, with dynamics.
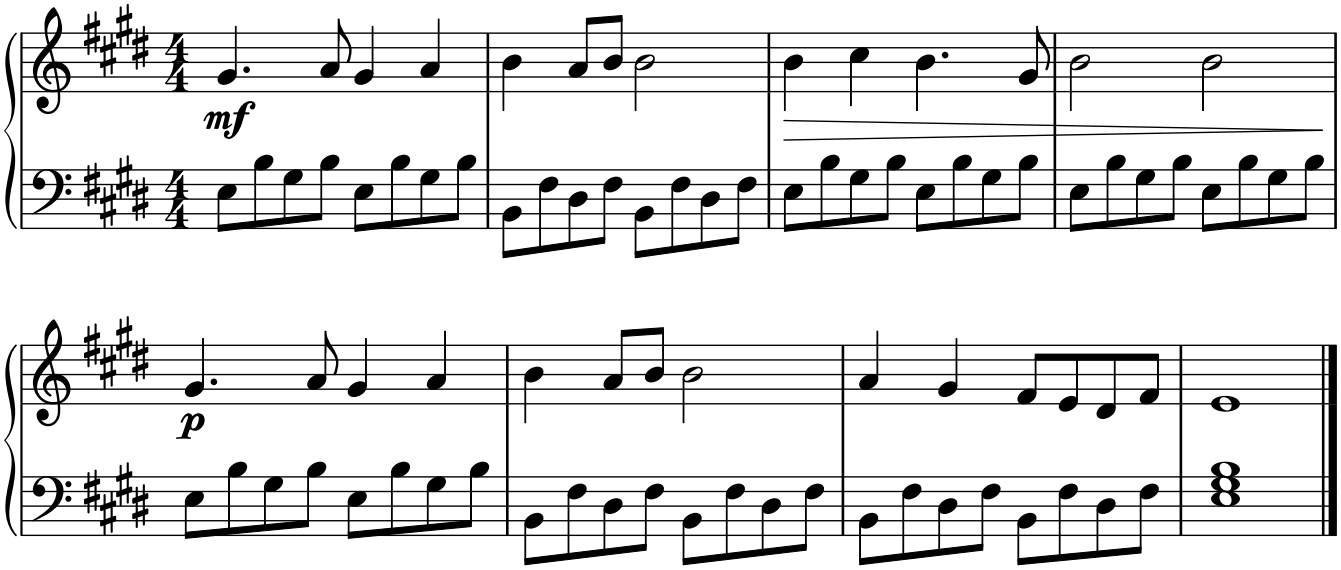
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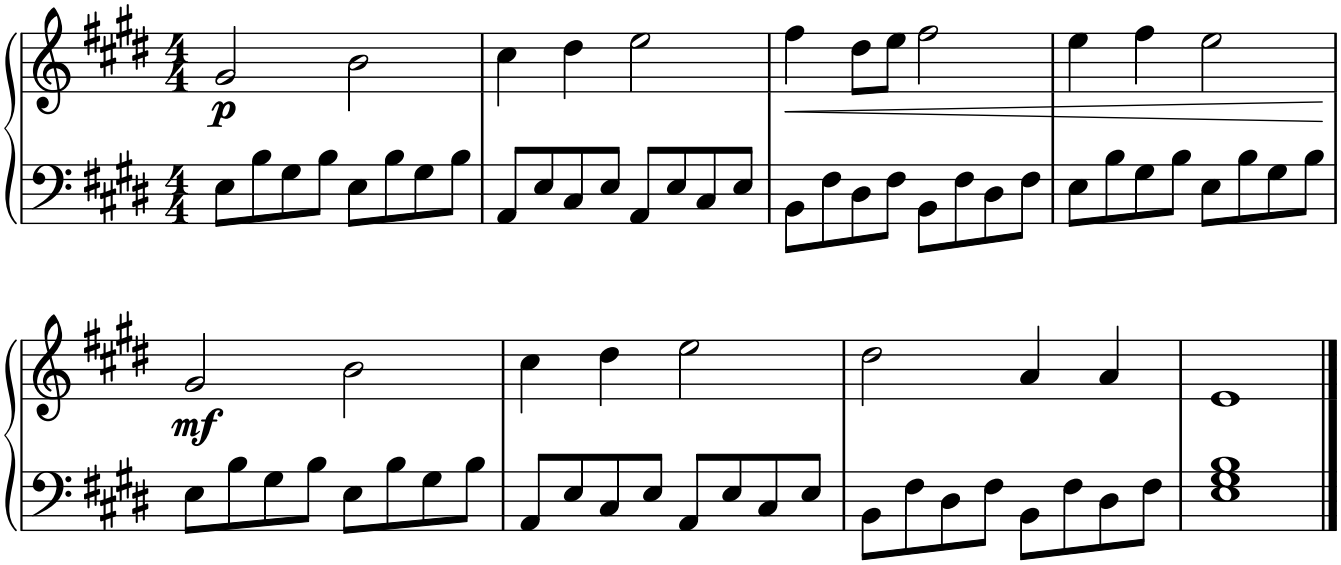


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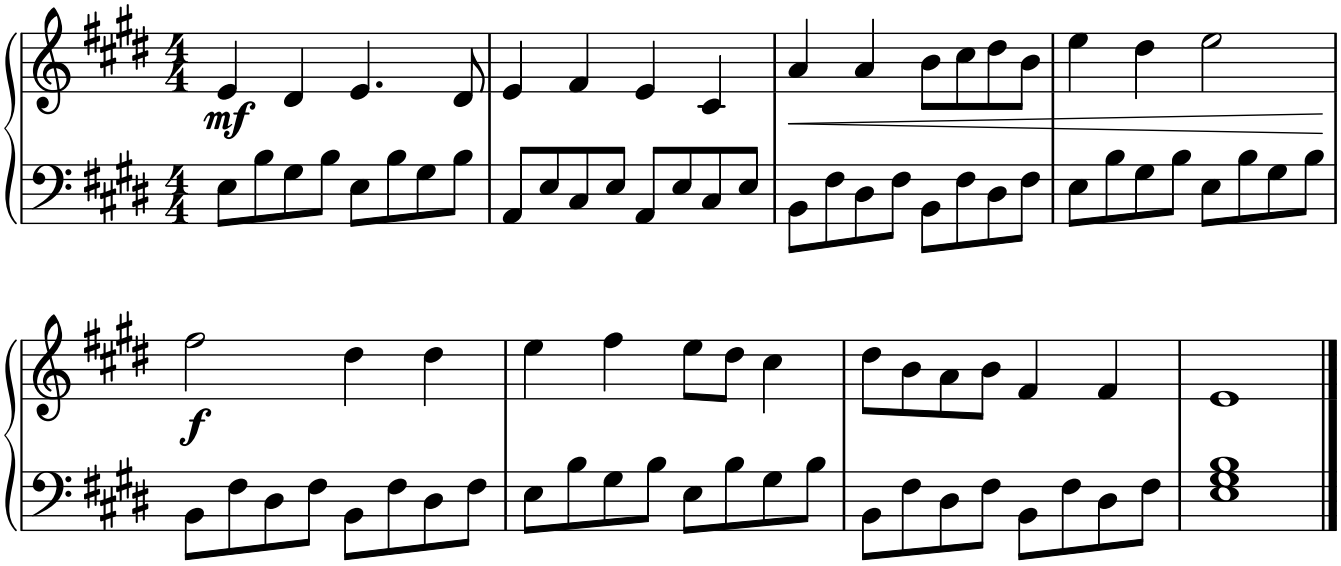


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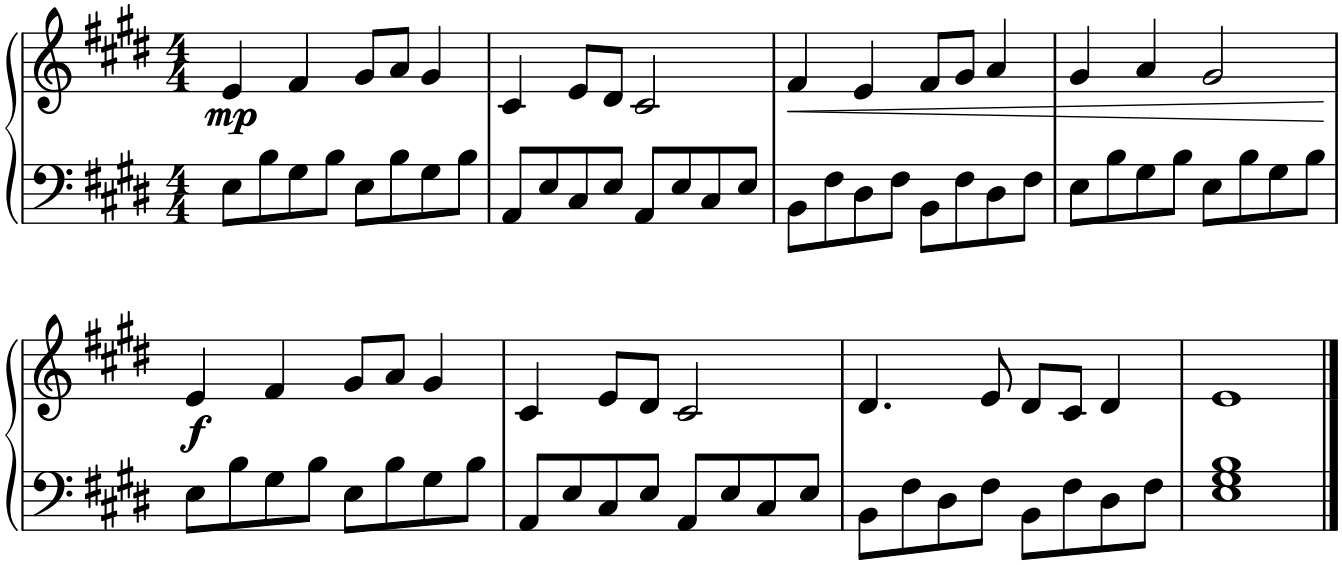


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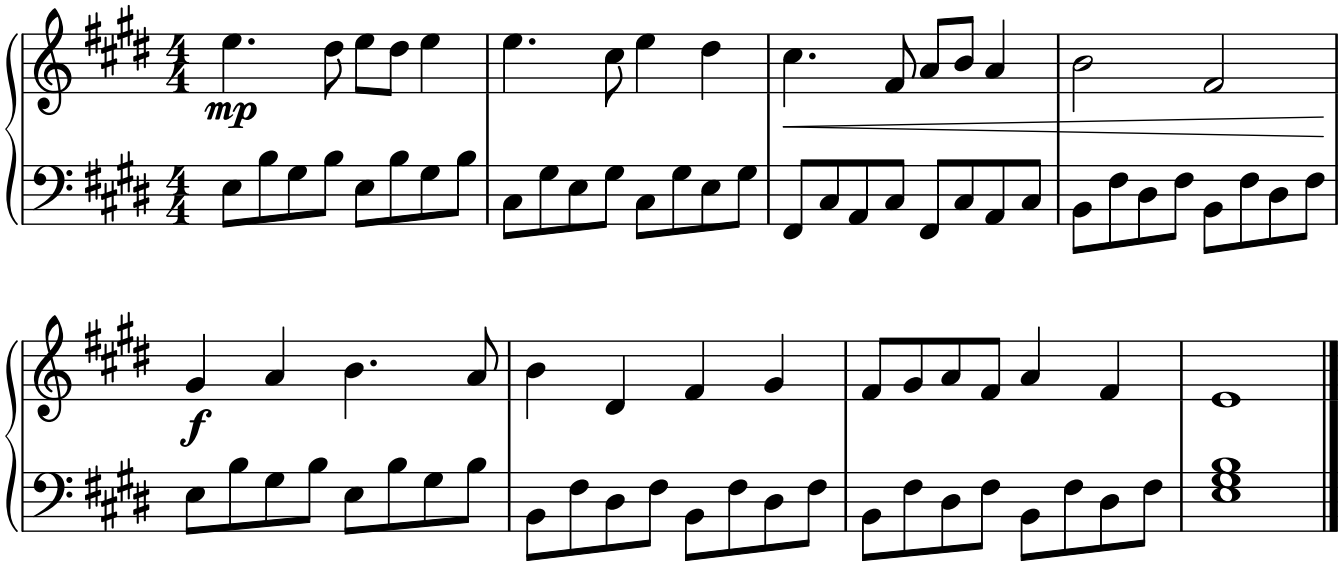


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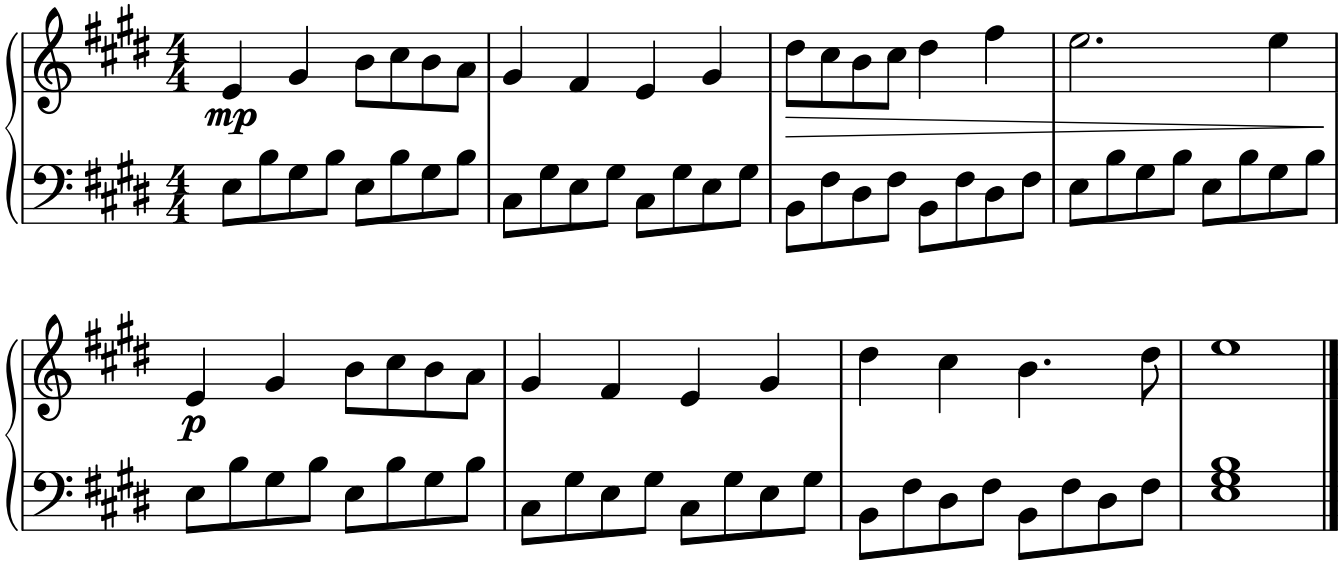


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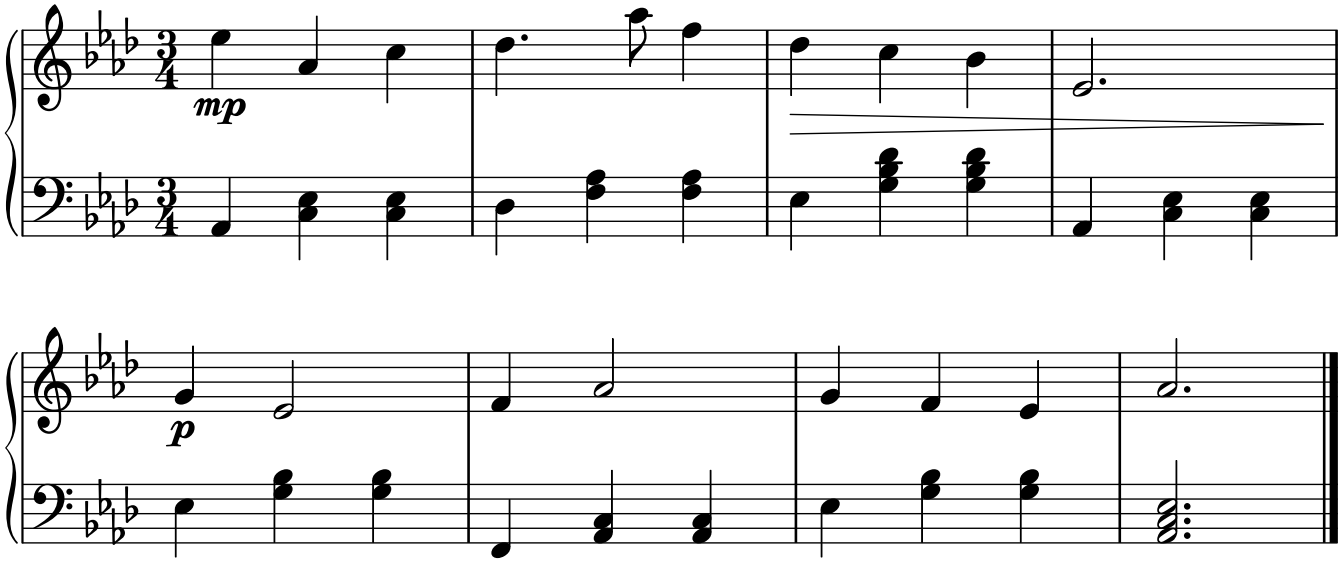


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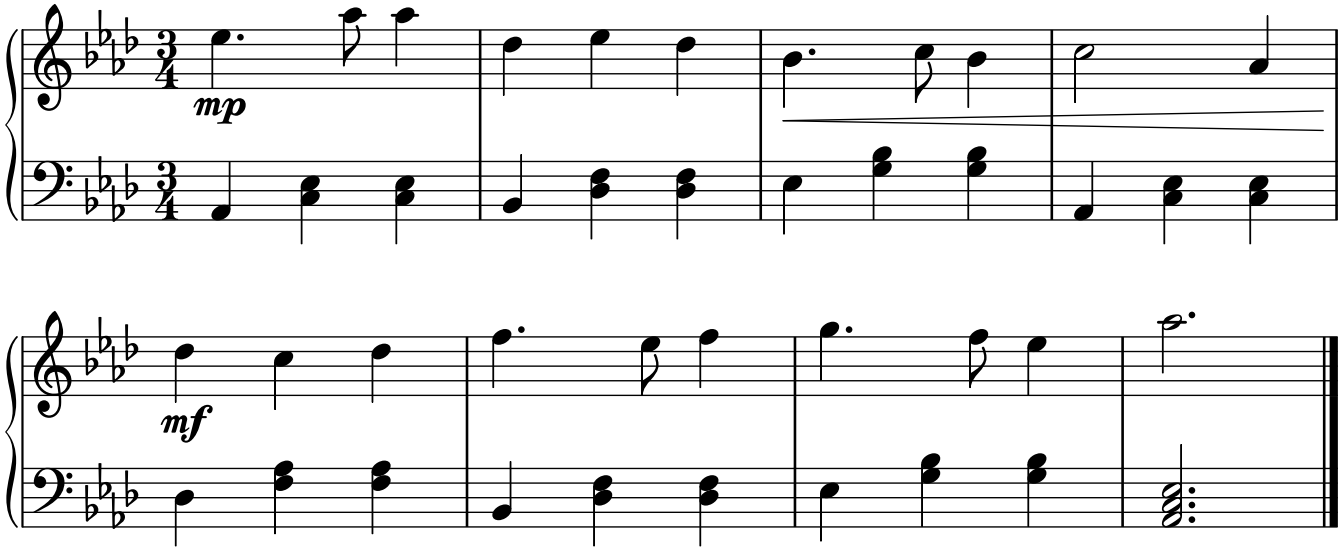


Part B: A-flat major ♩ = 80

A-flat major waltzes, with dynamics.
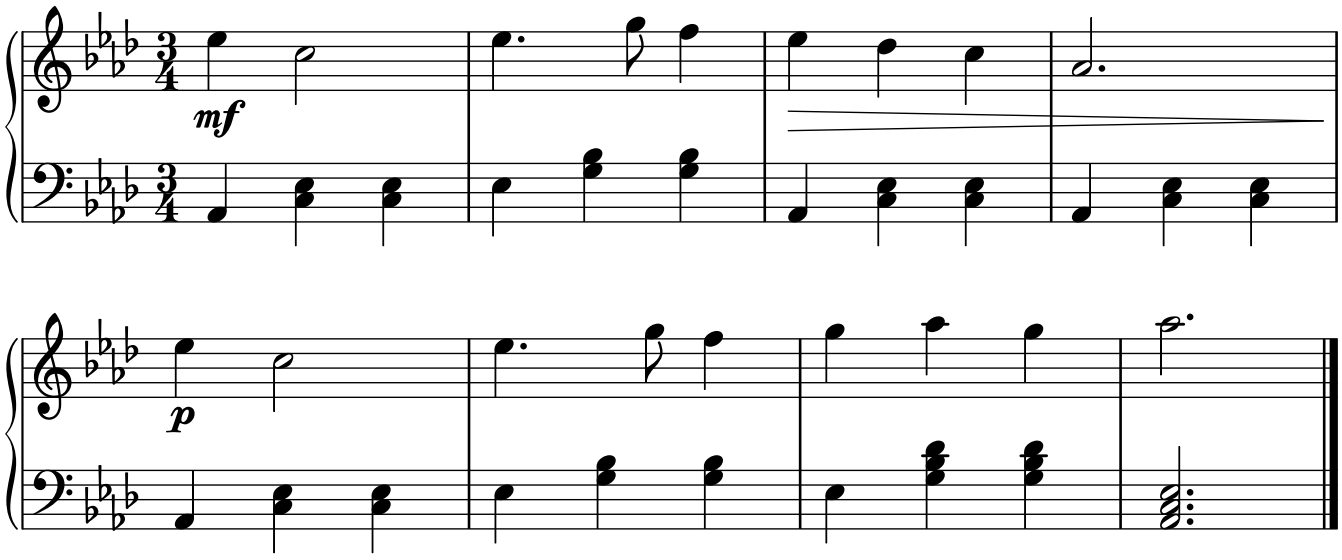
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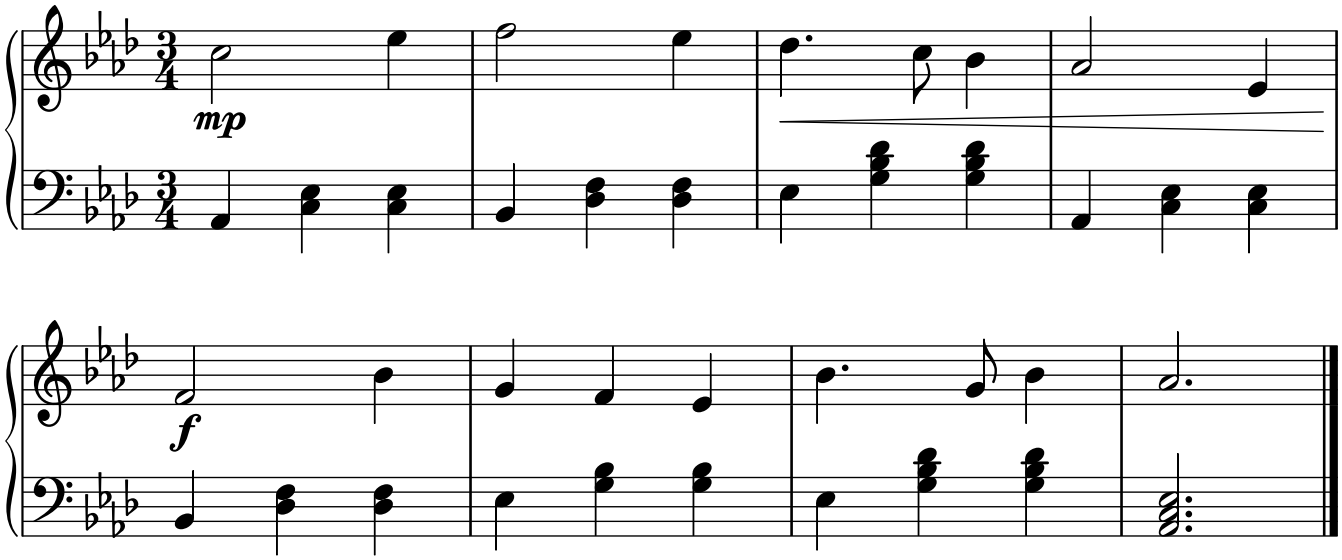


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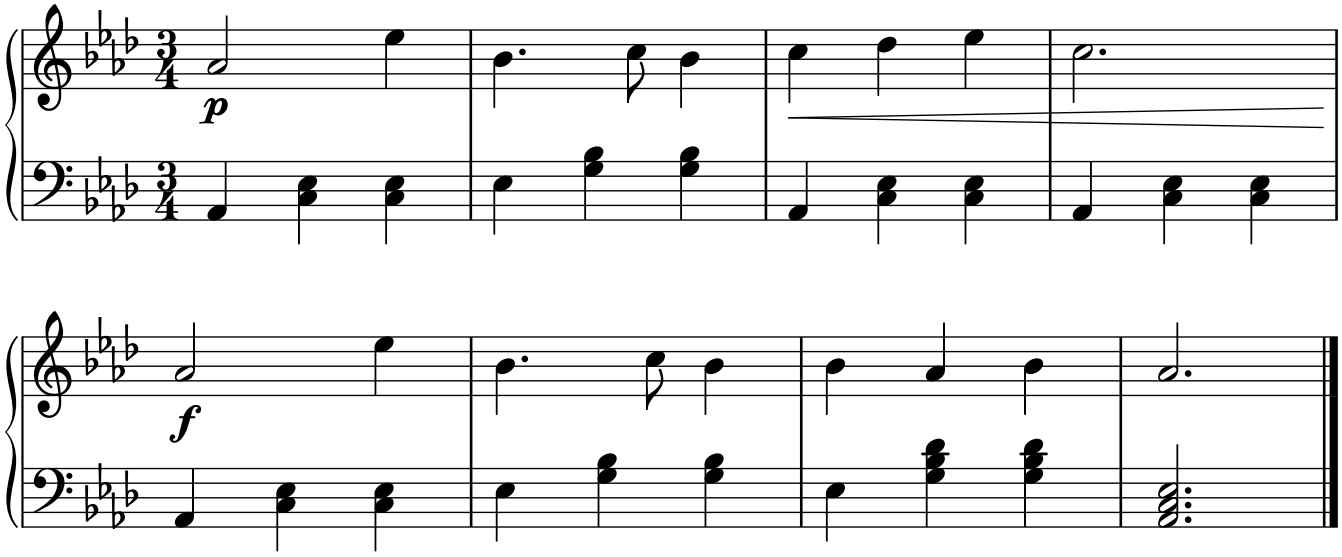


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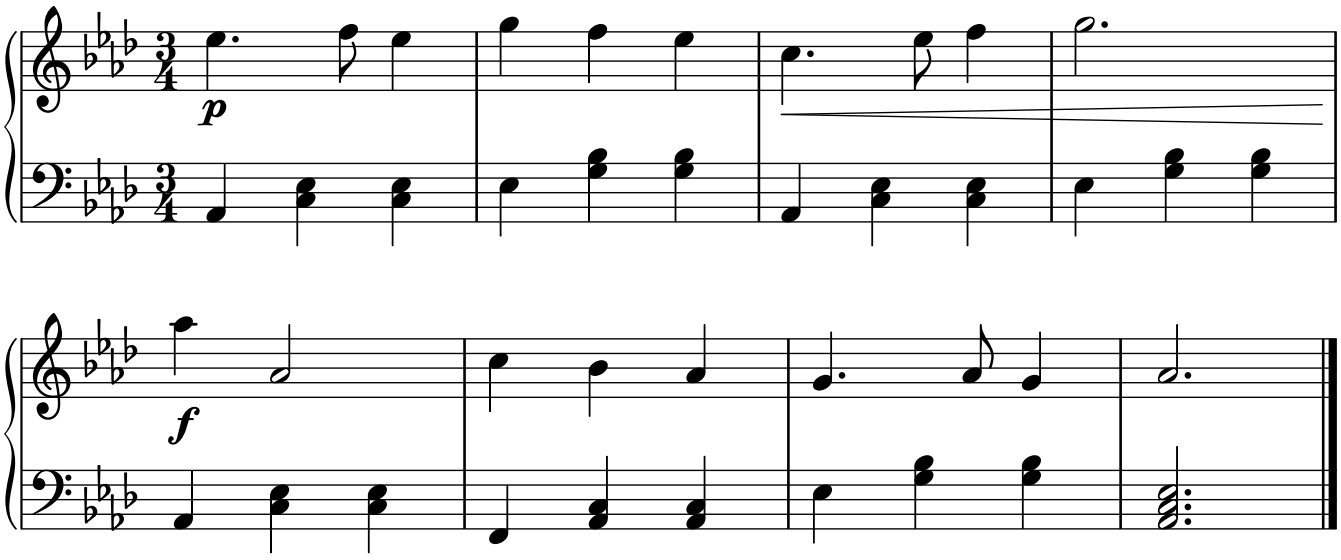


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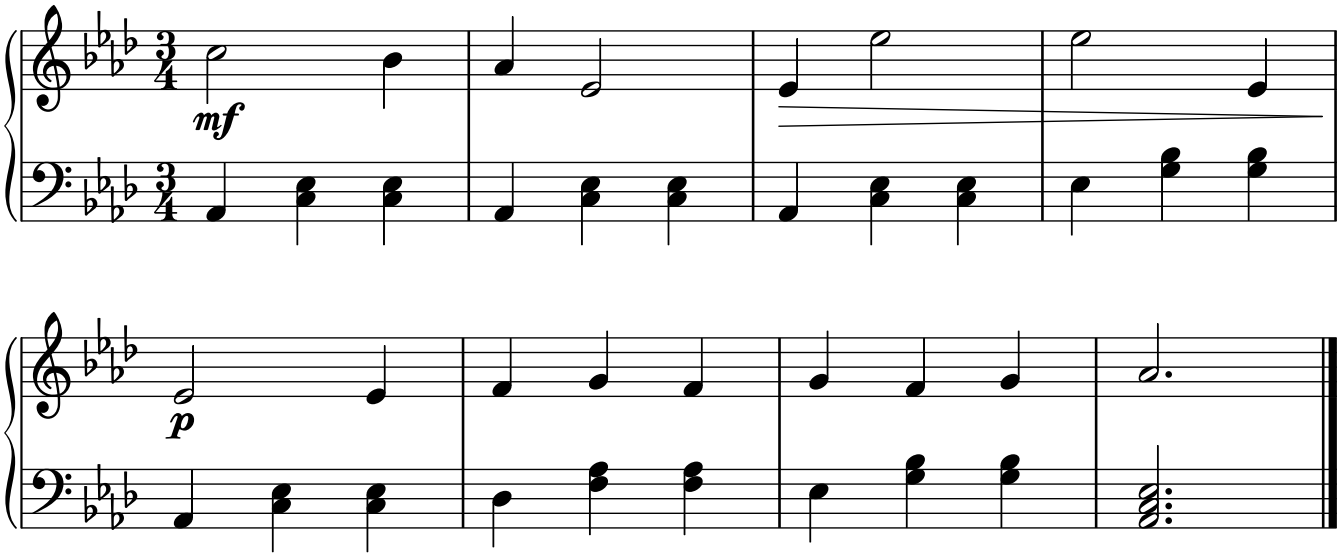


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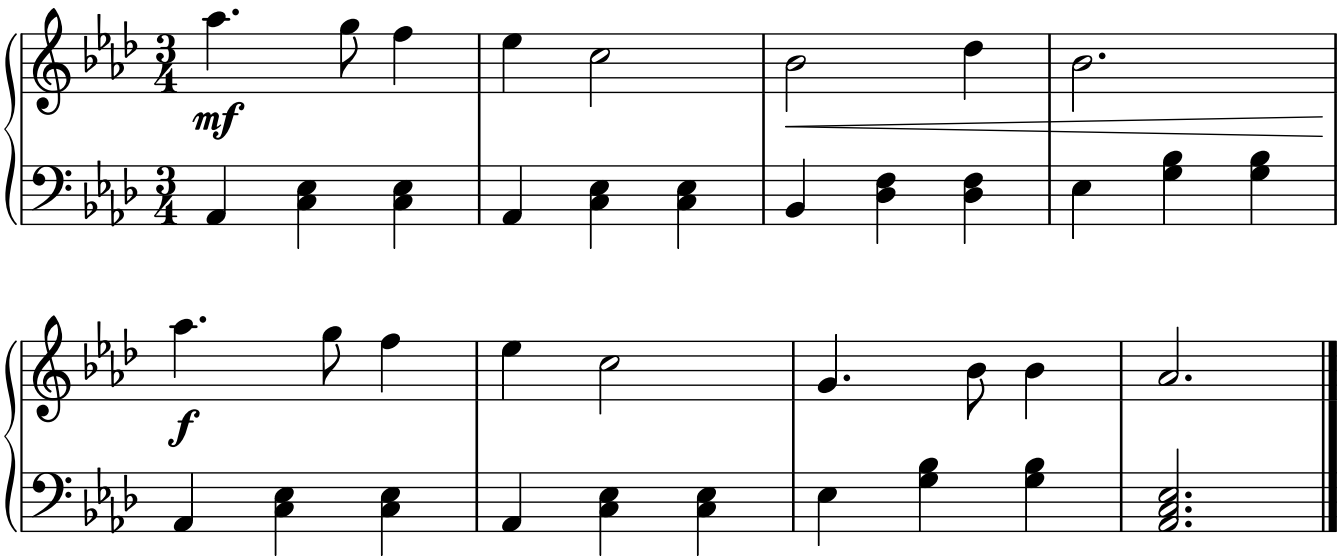


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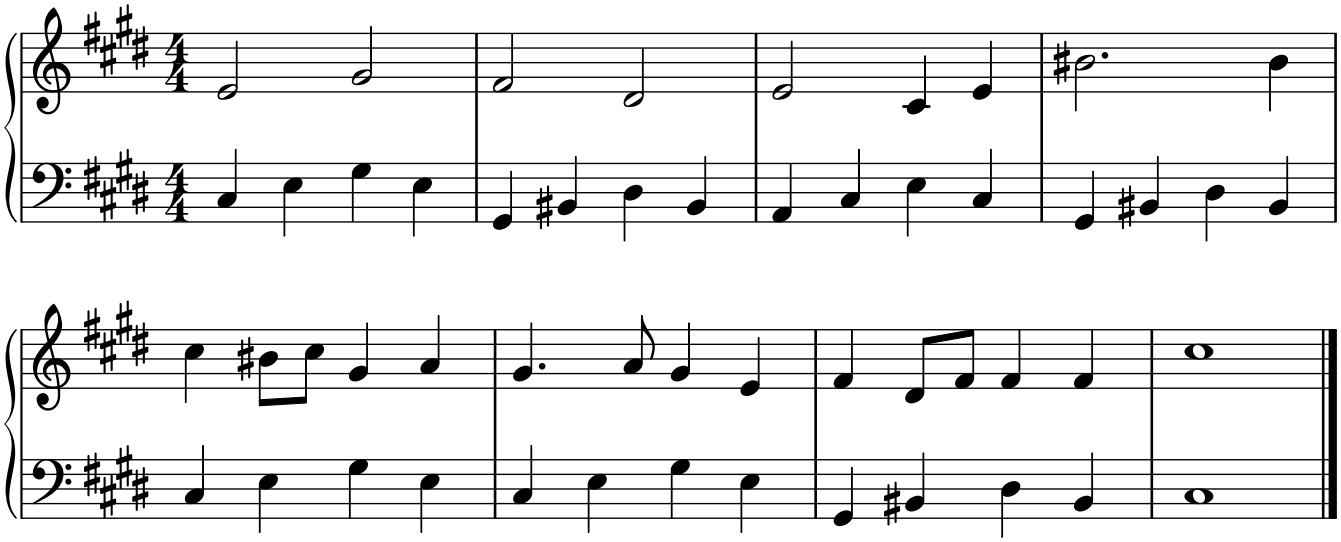


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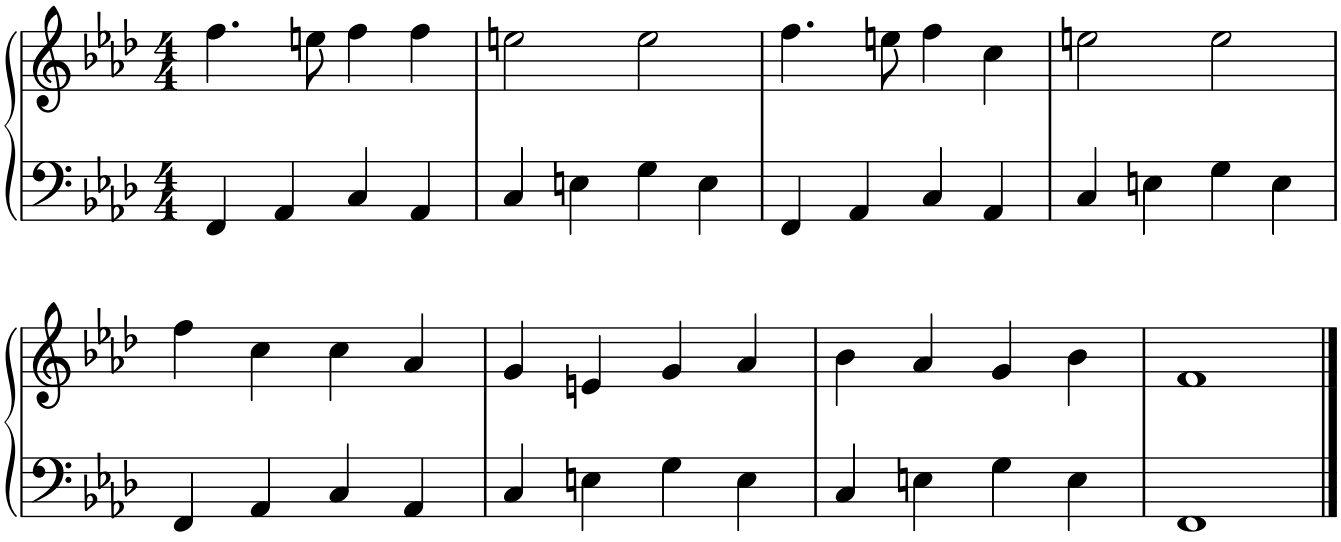


Part C: C-sharp minor and F minor ♩ = 66

C-sharp minor (B-sharp in the V chords) and F minor (E-natural), alternating.
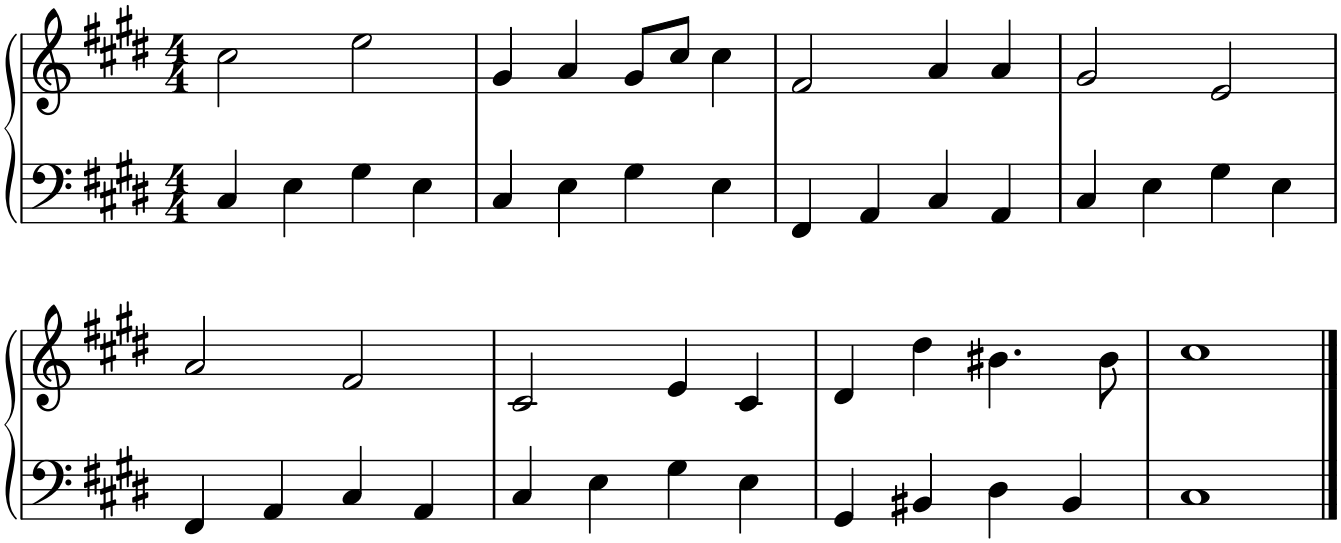
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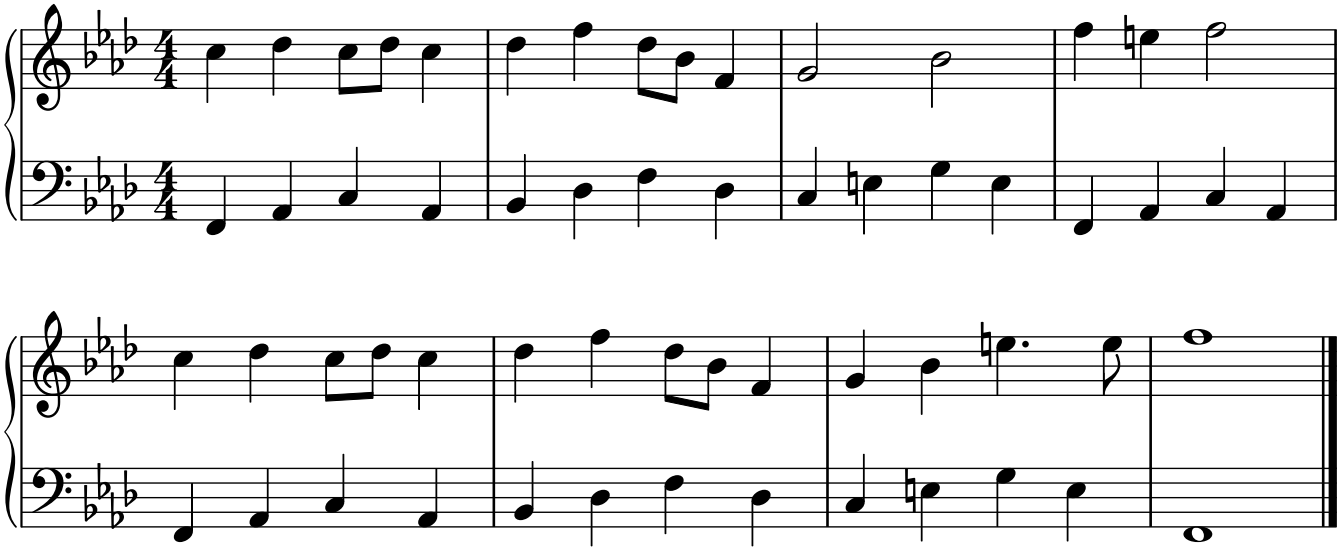


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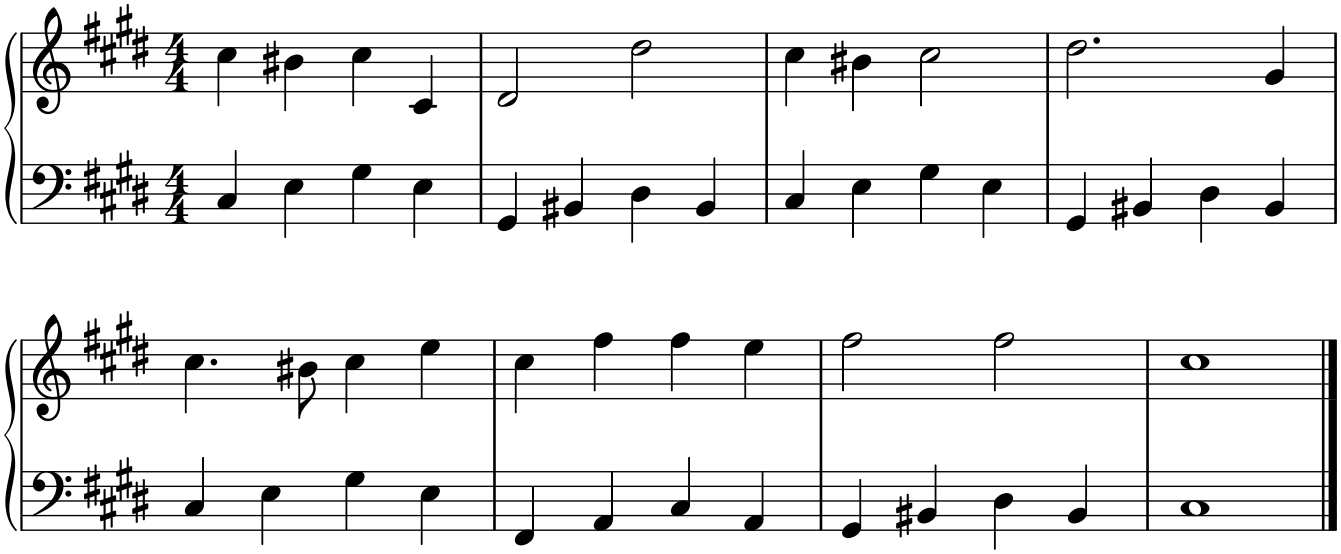


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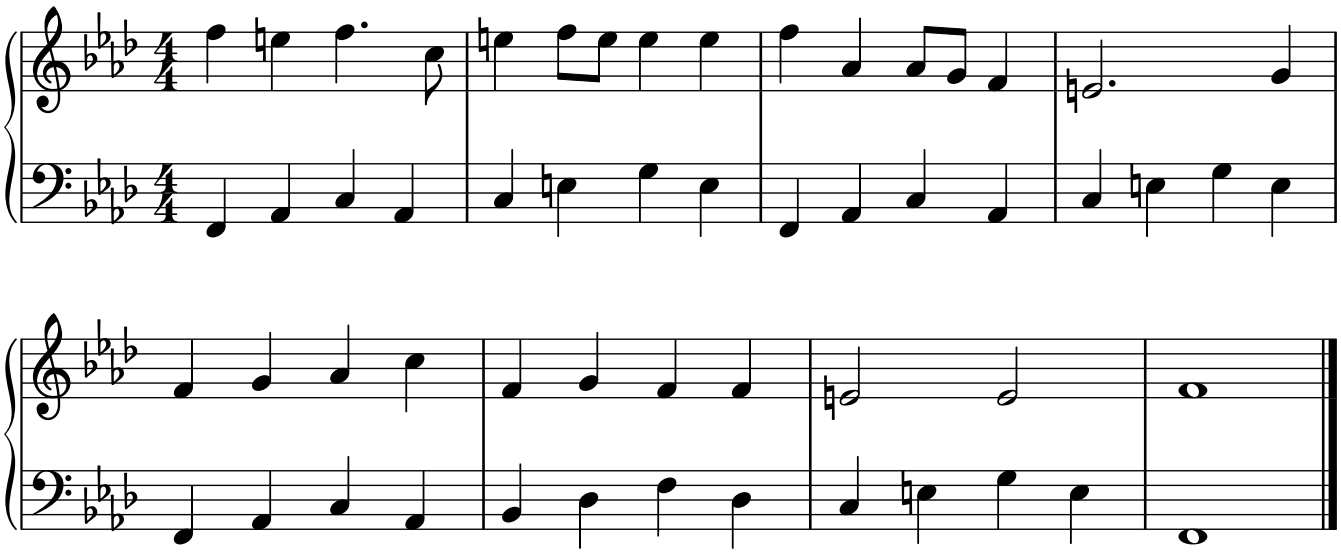


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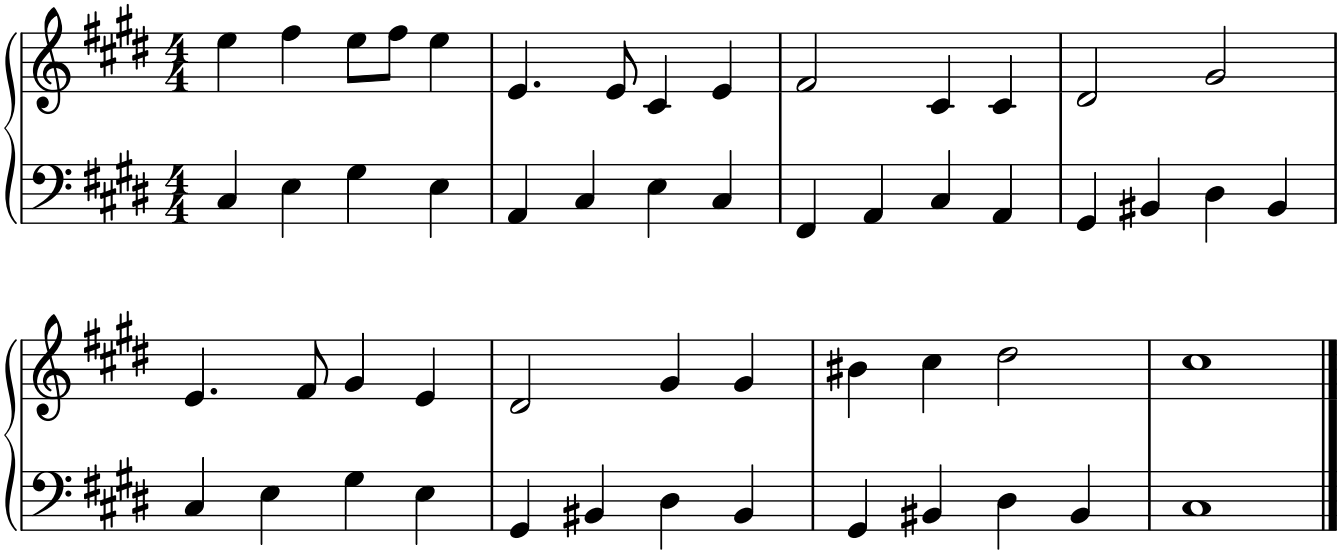


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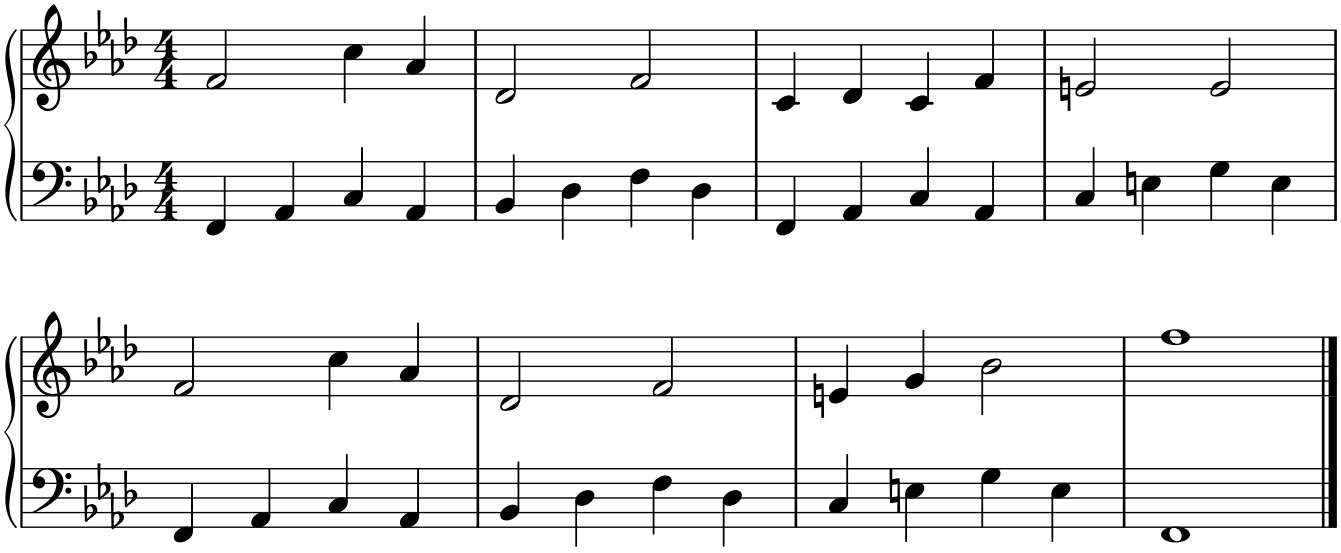


☐ **5.22**



☐ **5.23**



☐ **5.24**
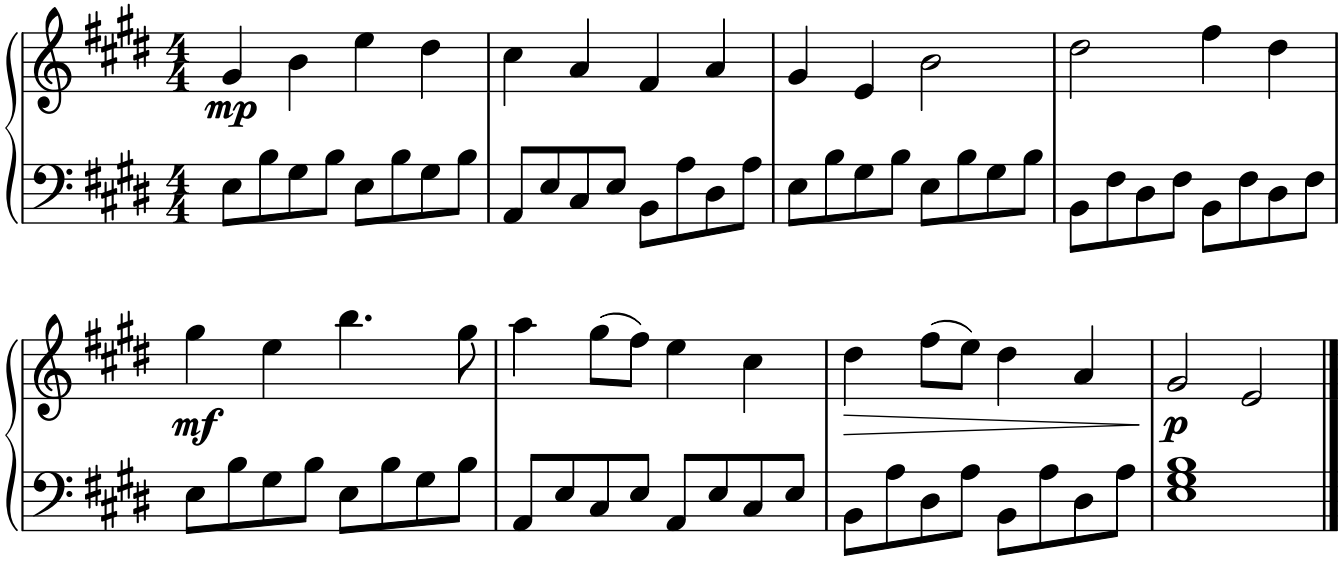


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

E Major Morning ♩ = 76

Original
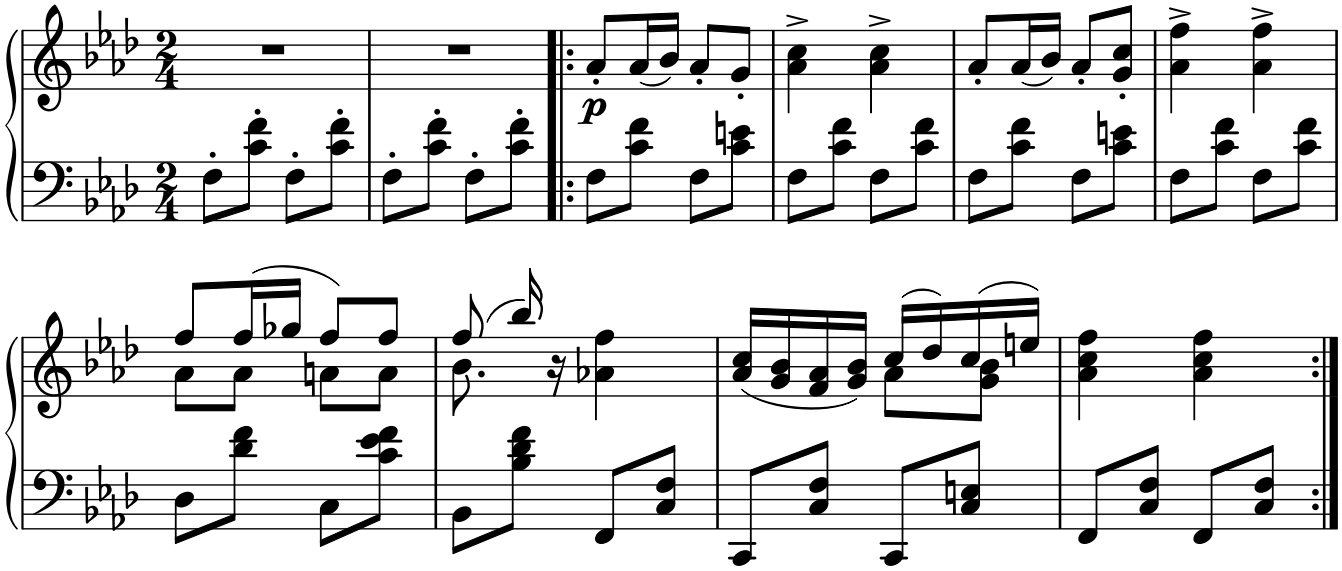
Four sharps. The left hand's Alberti bass uses the shapes of E (E G-sharp B), A (A C-sharp E) and B7 (B D-sharp F-sharp A).



Moment musical No. 3 ♩ = 80

Franz Schubert (1823), Moments musicaux, D. 780 No. 3 - the opening, grace notes left out
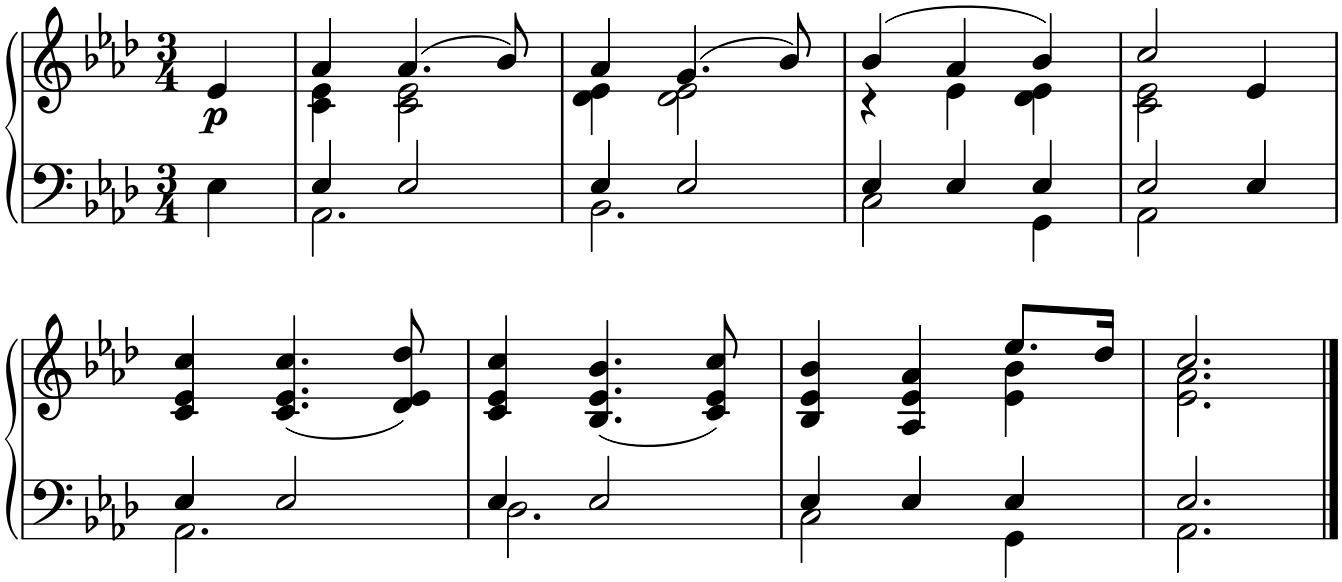
F minor (four flats). The left hand plays an oom-pah of a bass note and a chord; E-natural, the raised 7th, is in its C major chords. A-natural in bar 7 is chromatic; in bar 8 the left hand drops from its chord to a low F. The tune is staccato; the original's grace notes are left out (they come in Unit 8). Play bars 3-10 twice. Source: Mutopia Project no. 1023 (public domain).



Impromptu in A-flat ♩= 72

Franz Schubert (1827), Impromptu, D. 935 No. 2 - the first eight bars, the last chord lengthened
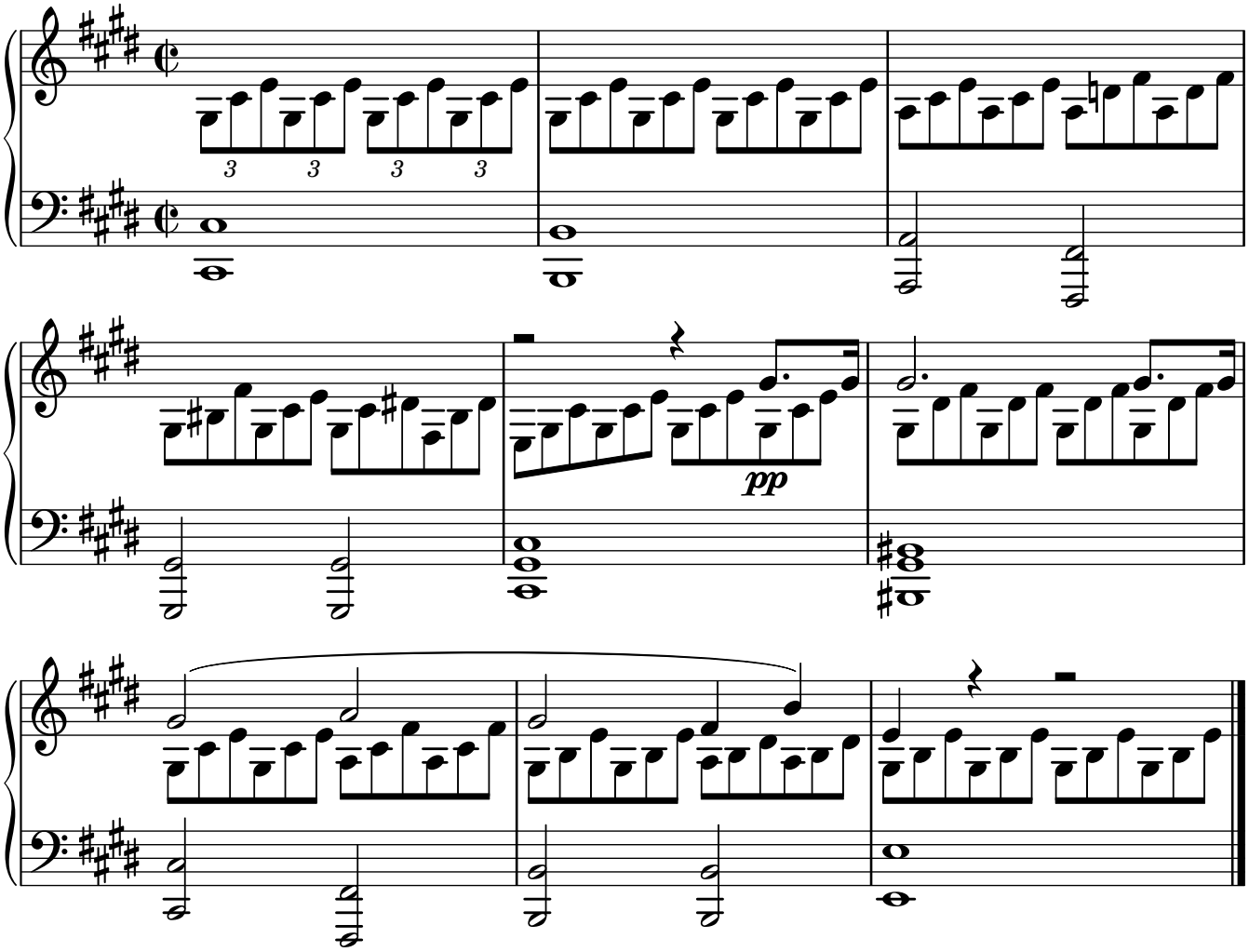
Four flats. A slow sarabande: the stress is often on the second beat (the dotted quarters). The right hand plays a tune over two held notes, then three-note chords; the left hand repeats E-flat (stems up) above a slow bass (stems down). Source: Mutopia Project no. 1195 (public domain).



Moonlight Sonata ♩ = 54

Ludwig van Beethoven (1801), Sonata Op. 27 No. 2, first movement - bars 1-9, simplified

C-sharp minor, four sharps; B-sharp in bars 4 and 6 is the raised 7th. The right hand plays triplets all through (stems down) and, from bar 5, the tune above them (stems up): the tune's sixteenth comes after the third note of the triplet. The figure 3 is printed only in the first bar: all the eighths are triplets. The time signature is alla breve, but at this slow speed count four quarter beats. The left hand plays octaves. In bar 8 the right hand stretches a ninth, from the A of the triplet to the B of the tune. Beethoven asks for the pedal throughout; play without it until Unit 7, holding the bass octaves for their full length. The first triplet of bar 5, which Beethoven gives to the left hand, is in the right hand here. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 276 (CC BY-SA 2.5).



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 6?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if you name the key of each exercise before you start, and play every B-sharp and E-natural.
- Pass if you can play E Major Morning at sight, and the opening of the Moonlight Sonata after a few days.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 6.

Unit 6

Every Key

New: Five, six and seven sharps or flats; enharmonic keys (F-sharp = G-flat)

There are fifteen major keys and fifteen minor keys. You have met the keys with up to four sharps or flats; now come the rest: five, six and seven. Three pairs of them sound exactly the same and use the same keys on the piano, but are written differently: B major and C-flat major, F-sharp major and G-flat major, C-sharp major and D-flat major. Such keys are called enharmonic.

Keys with many sharps or flats look frightening, but they lie well under the hand: most of their notes are black keys, and the long fingers fall on them naturally.

What is new

The circle of fifths

Each sharp key is a fifth above the last: C, G, D, A, E, B, F-sharp, C-sharp (0 to 7 sharps). Each flat key is a fifth below: C, F, B-flat, E-flat, A-flat, D-flat, G-flat, C-flat (0 to 7 flats). Round the circle they meet: F-sharp is G-flat.

Order of sharps and flats

Sharps: F C G D A E B. Flats: B E A D G C F, the same letters backwards.

Enharmonic notes

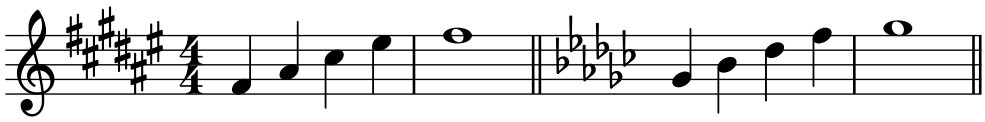
One key on the piano can have two names: F-sharp is G-flat, E-sharp is F, C-flat is B. In F-sharp major E-sharp is the 7th note; in G-flat major C-flat is the 4th.

Minor keys too

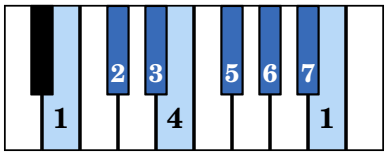
B-flat minor (five flats) and G-sharp minor (five sharps): their raised 7ths are A-natural and F-double-sharp (the white key G). A double sharp looks like a small x.

The same keys, two names

F-sharp major and G-flat major: every note sounds the same and uses the same key on the piano.

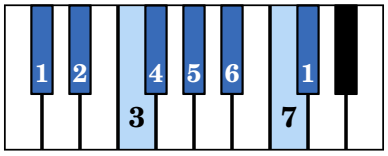


B major: five sharps



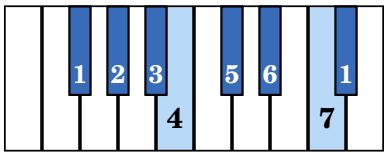
Scale degrees on the keys: B C♯ D♯ E F♯ G♯ A♯ B

D-flat major: five flats



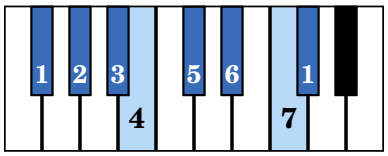
Scale degrees on the keys: D♭ E♭ F G♭ A♭ B♭ C D♭

F-sharp major: six sharps (E-sharp is the white key F)



Scale degrees on the keys: F♯ G♯ A♯ B C♯ D♯ E♯ F♯

G-flat major: six flats (C-flat is the white key B) - the same keys as F-sharp major



Scale degrees on the keys: G♭ A♭ B♭ C♭ D♭ E♭ F G♭
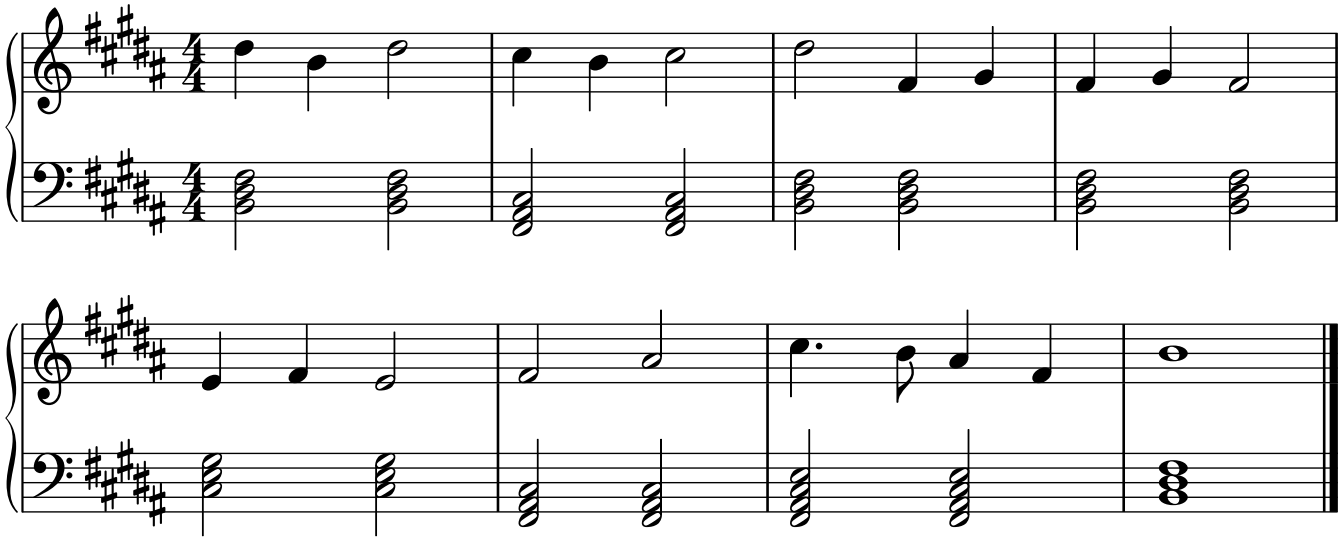
Reading tips

1. Count the sharps or flats, name the key, and say the black keys it uses before you play.
2. In five-, six- and seven-sharp or flat keys, think of the white keys as the exceptions.
3. E-sharp, B-sharp, C-flat and F-flat are white keys: read the name, find the key, and trust your hand.
4. Round the circle of fifths, each new key changes only one note: find it.
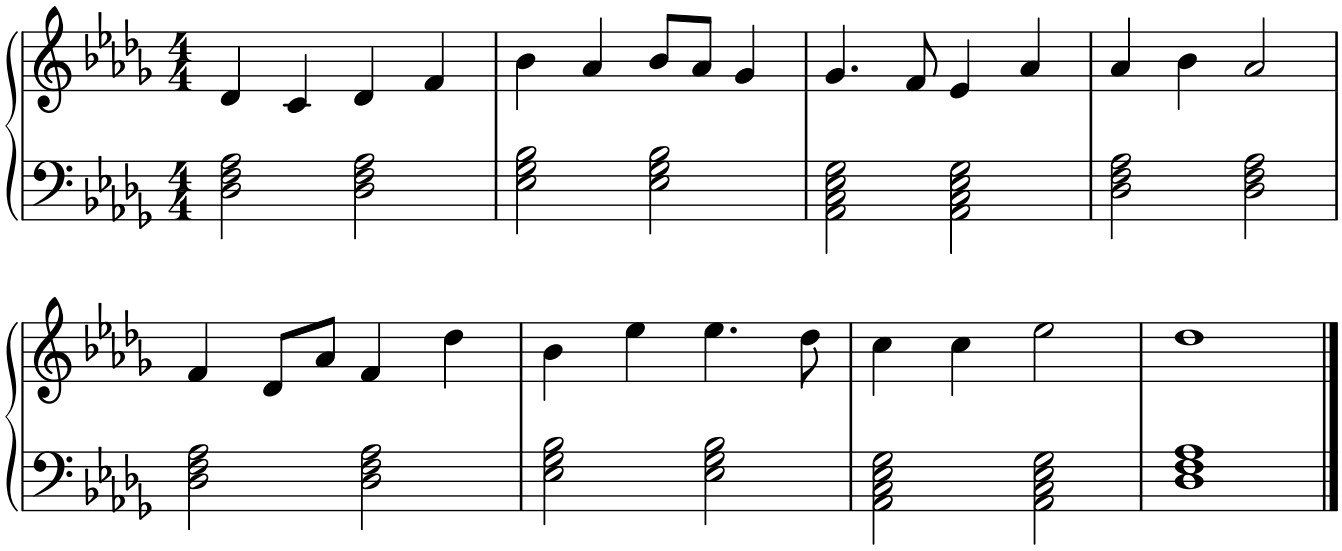
Part A: B major and D-flat major ♩ = 60

B major and D-flat major, with chords in half notes.
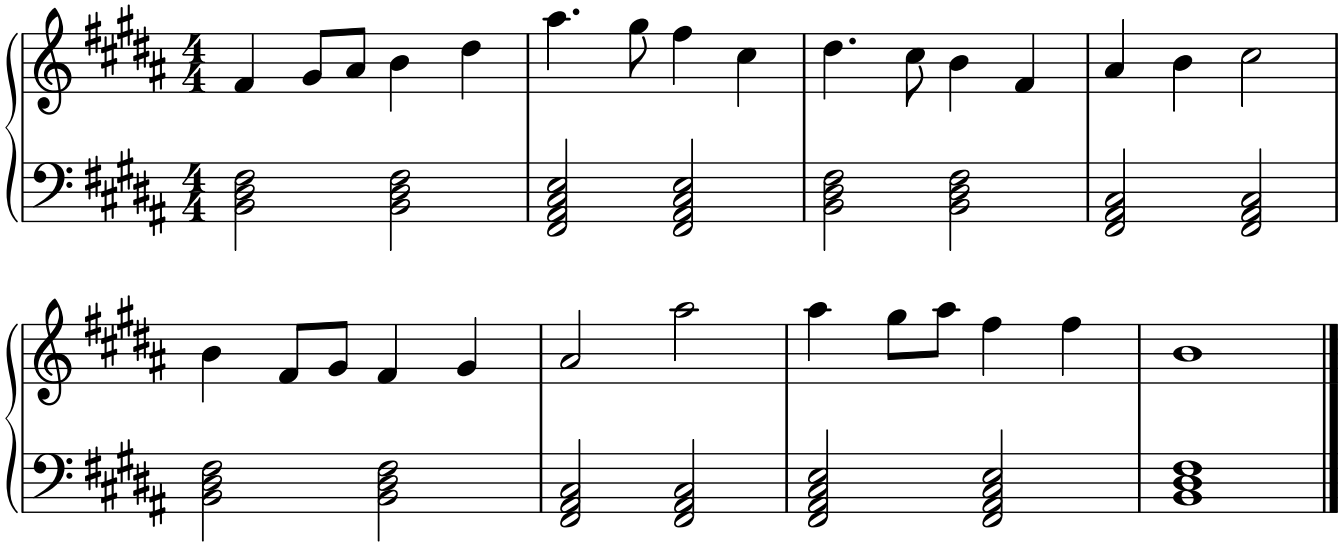
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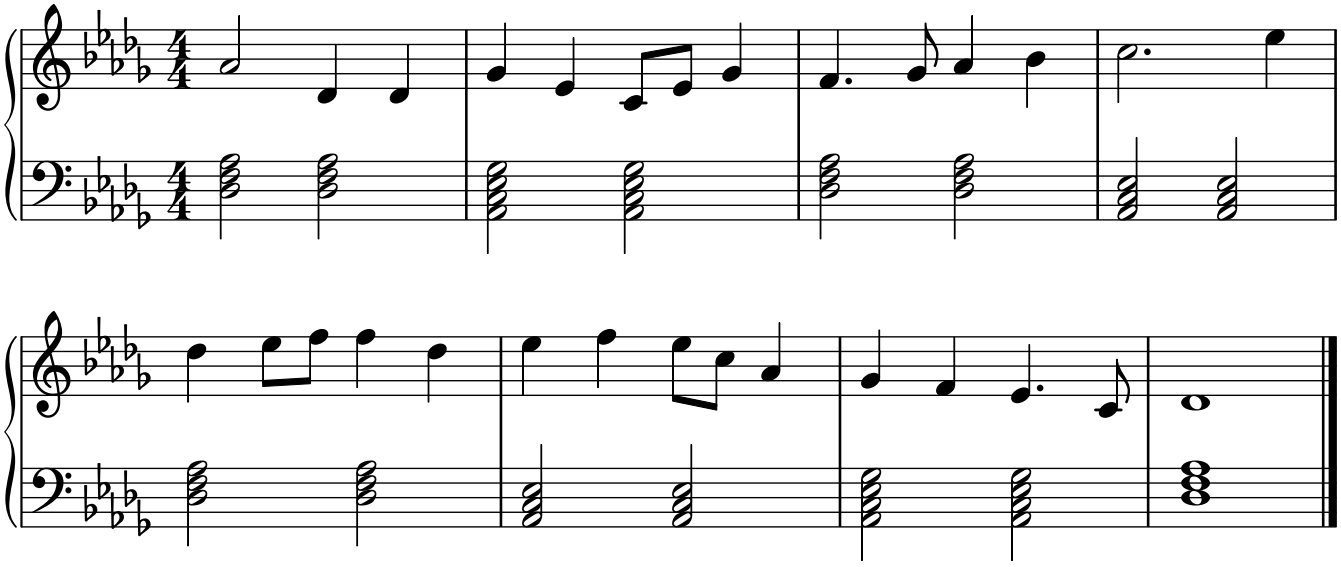


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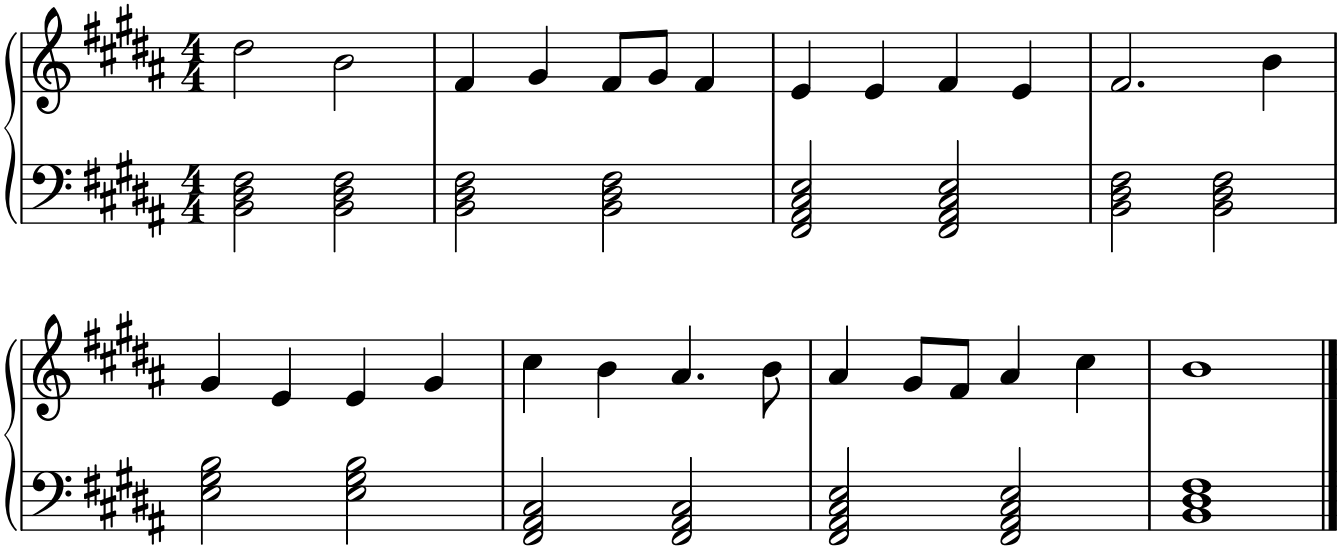


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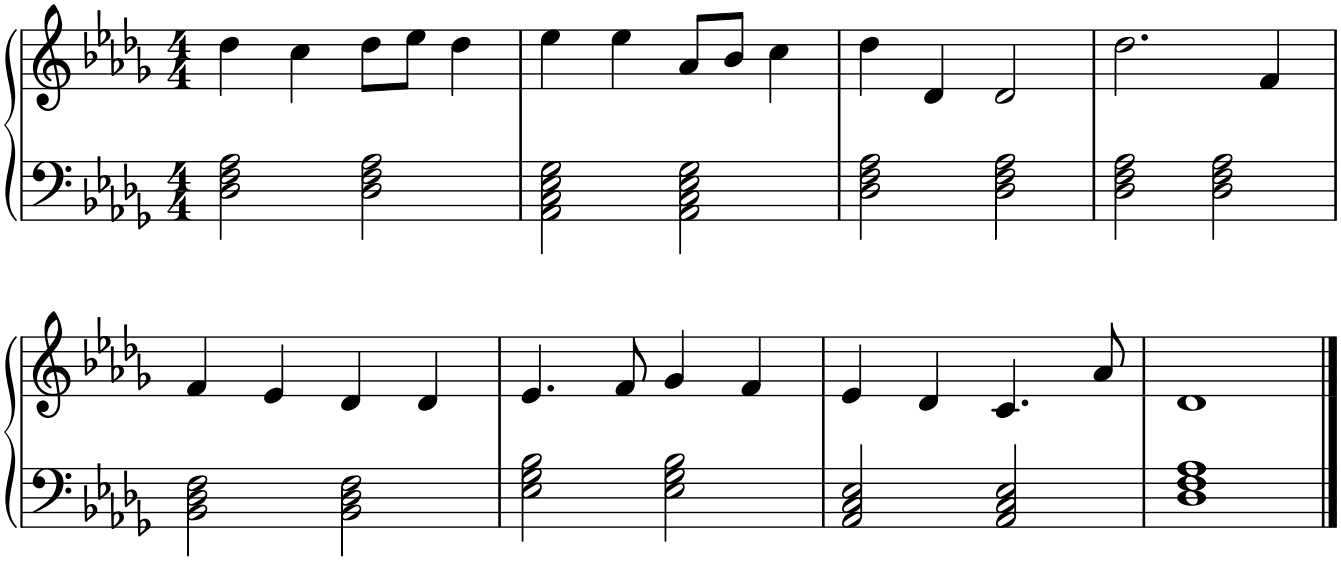


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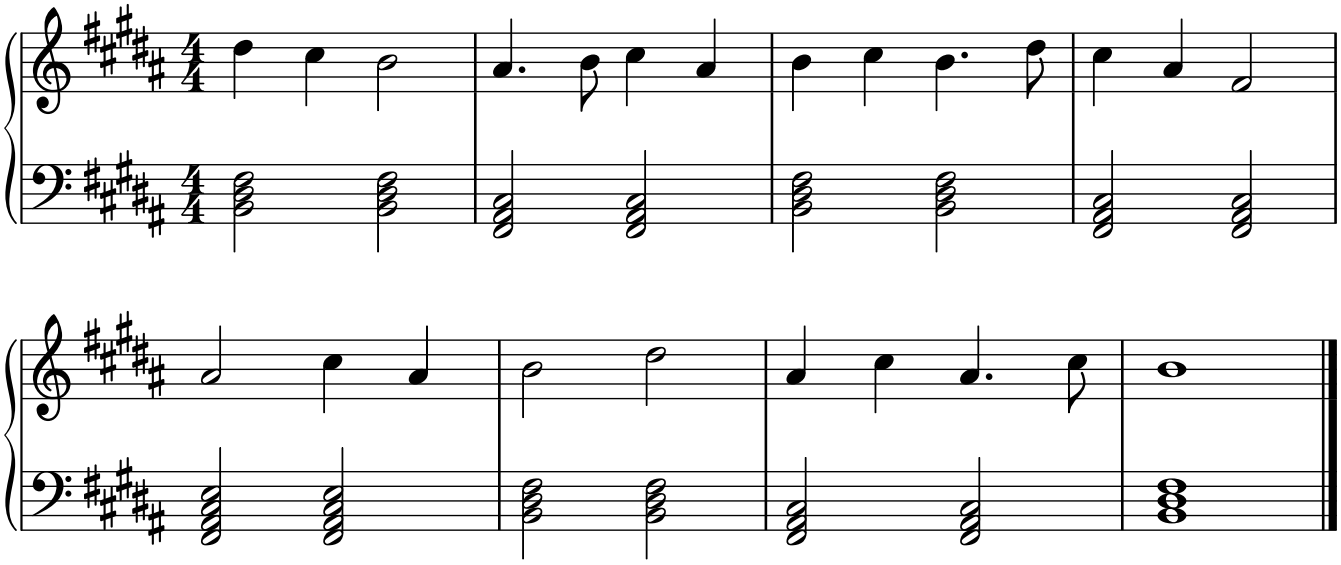


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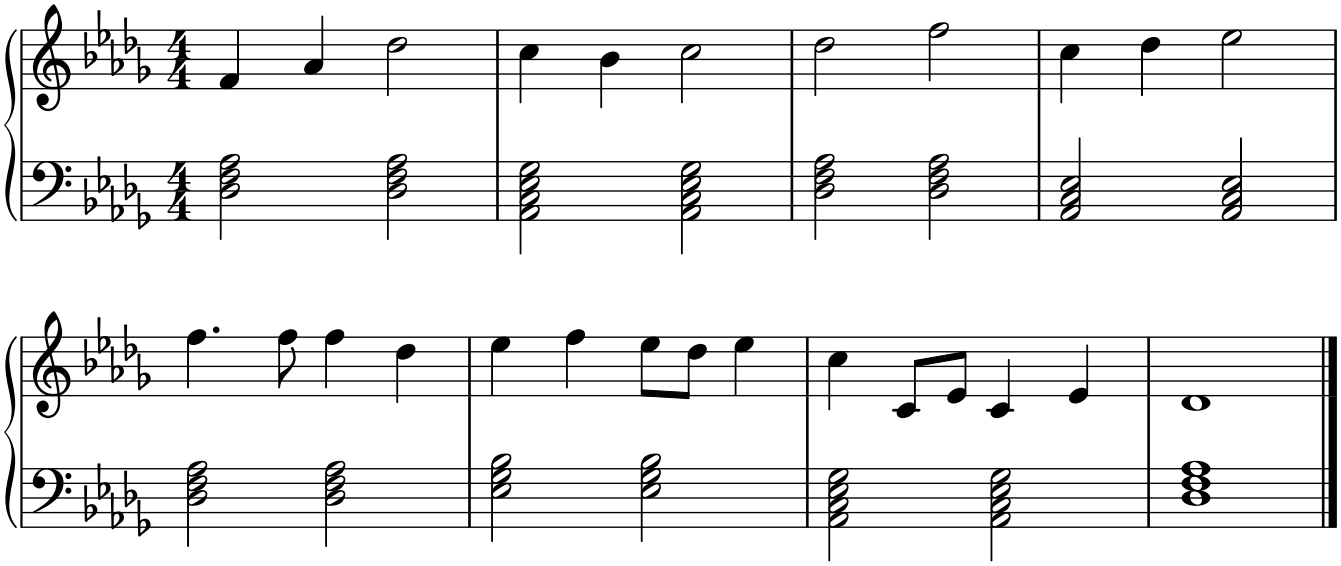


☐ **6.6**



6.7
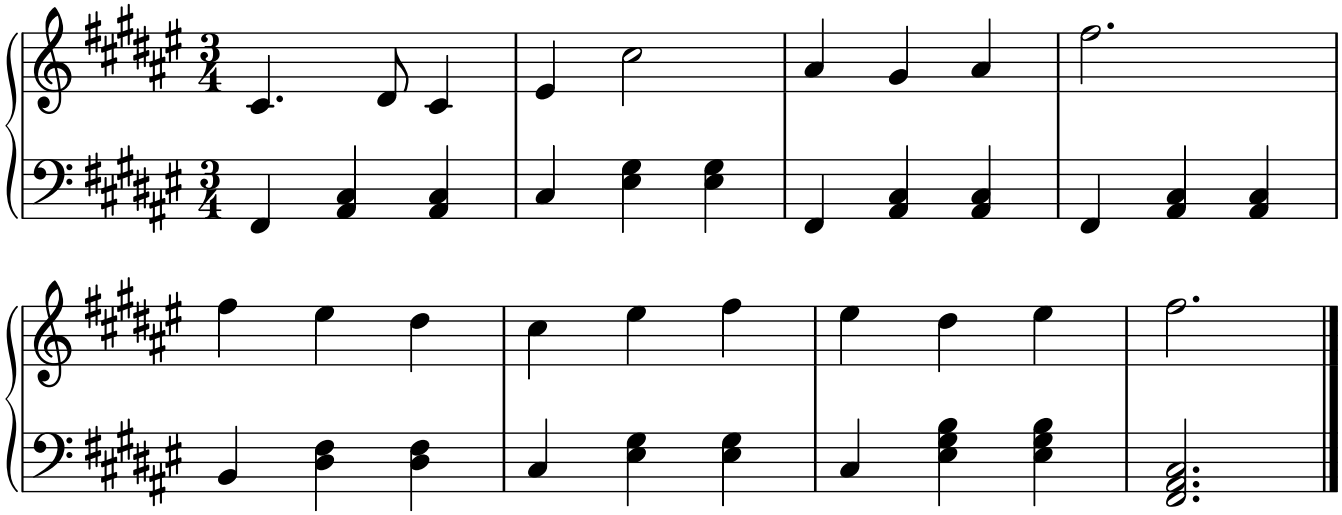


6.8
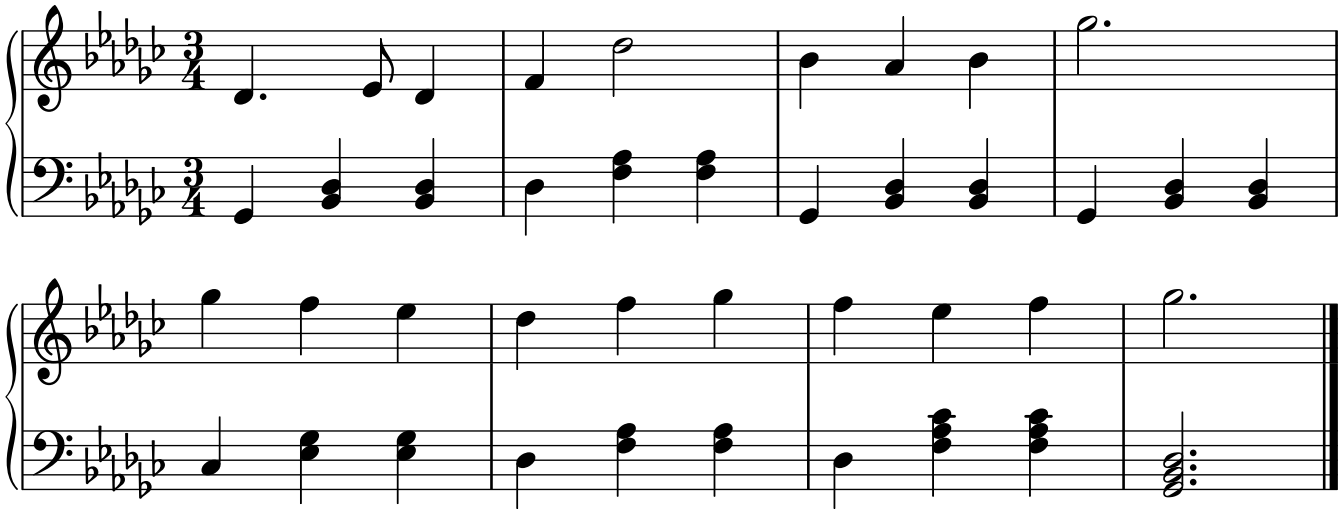


Part B: Twins, and two minor keys ♩ = 72

Twins: each F-sharp major exercise is printed again in G-flat major (a and b): play both and hear that they are the same. Between them, B-flat minor and G-sharp minor waltzes.
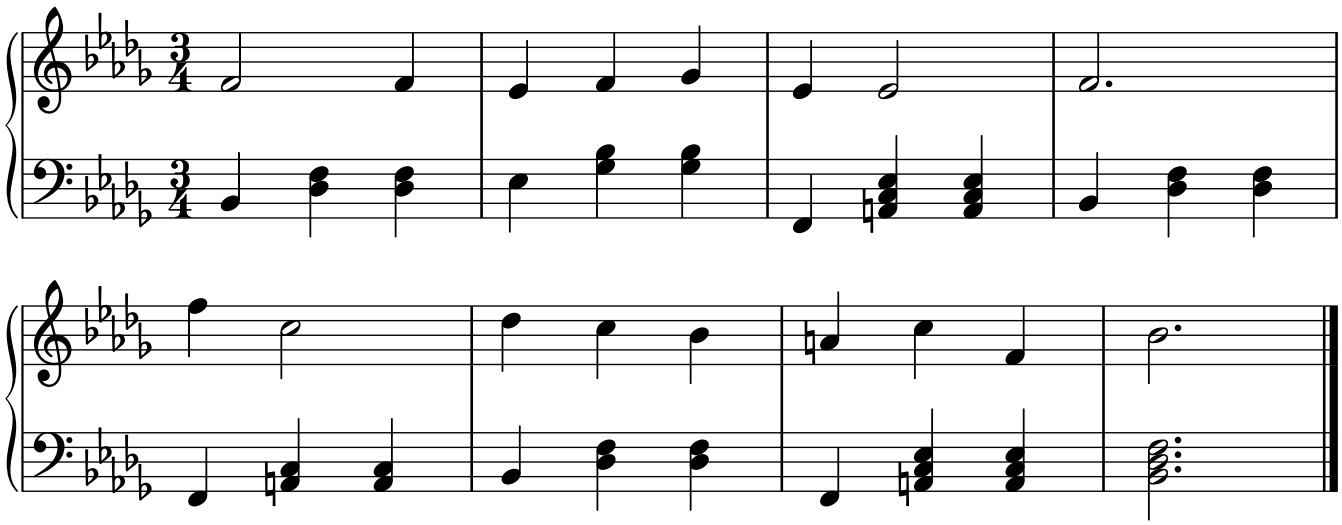
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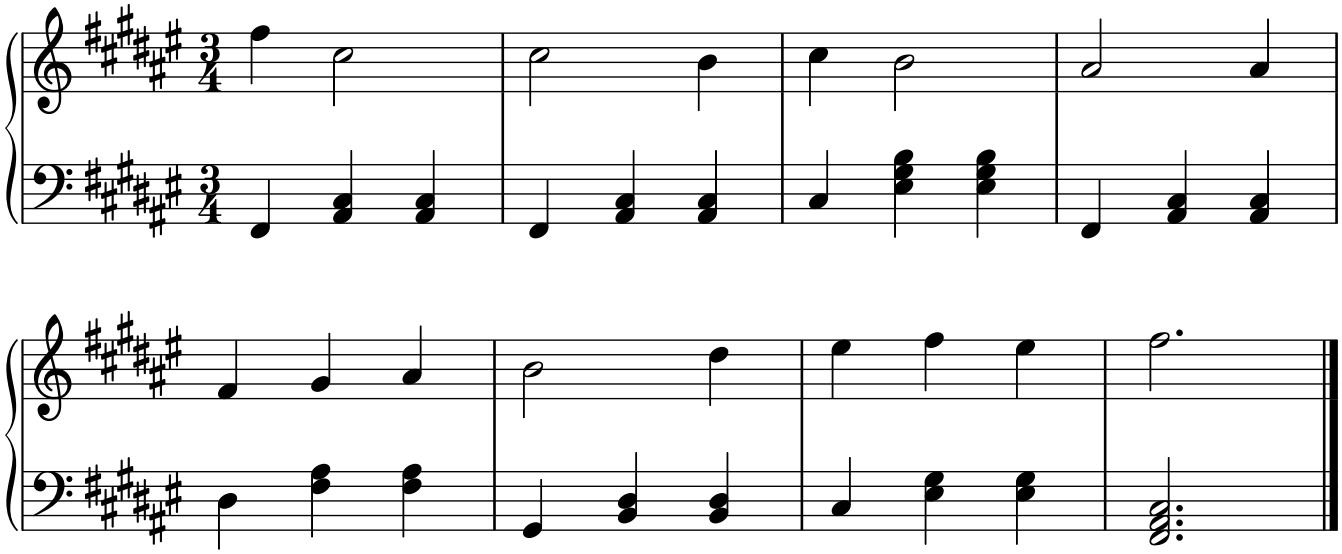


☐ **6.9b**
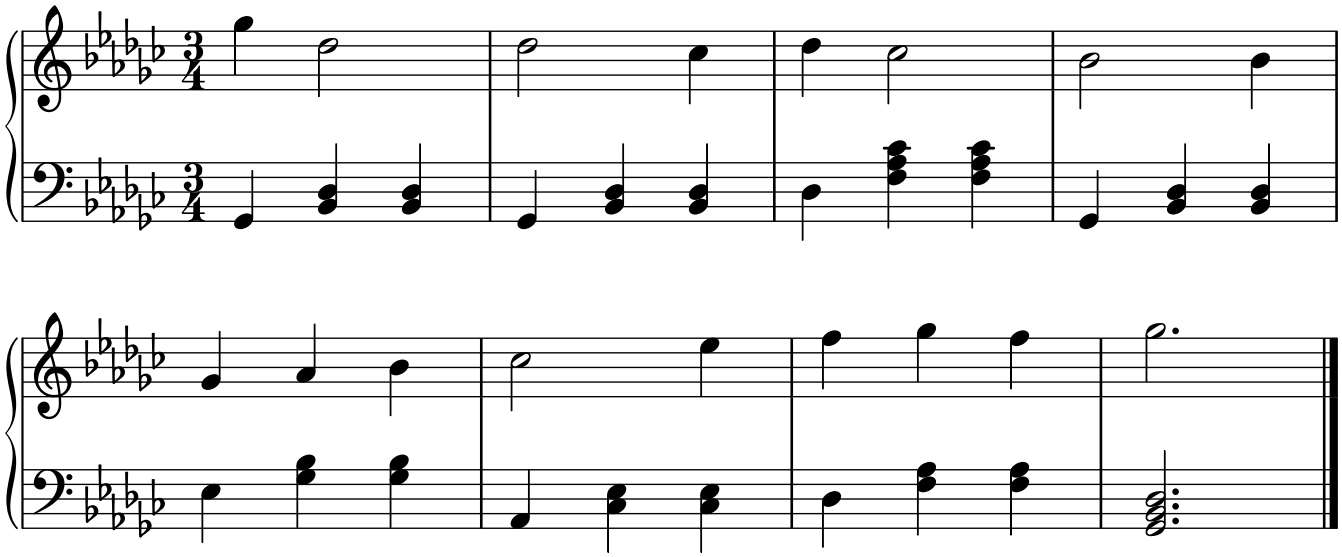


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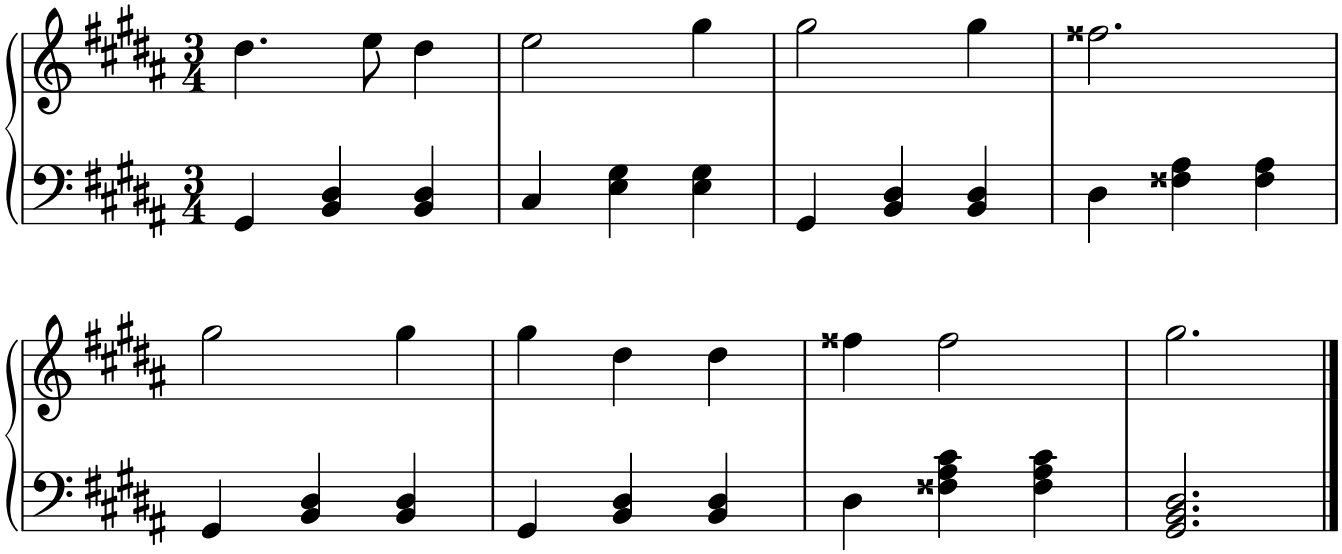


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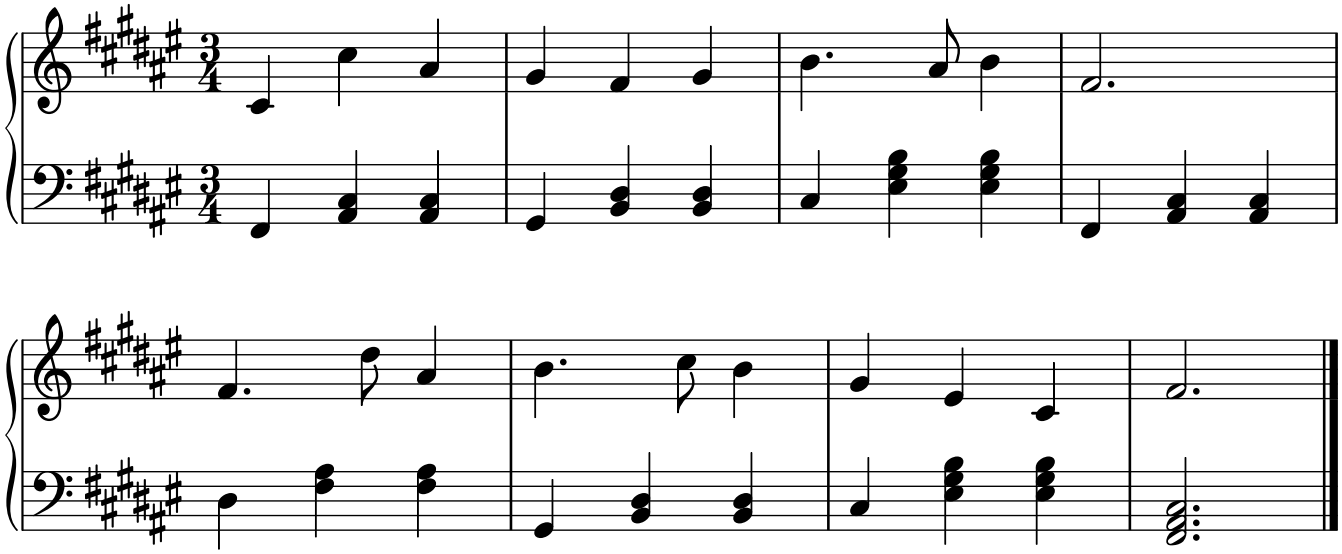


☐ **6.11b**
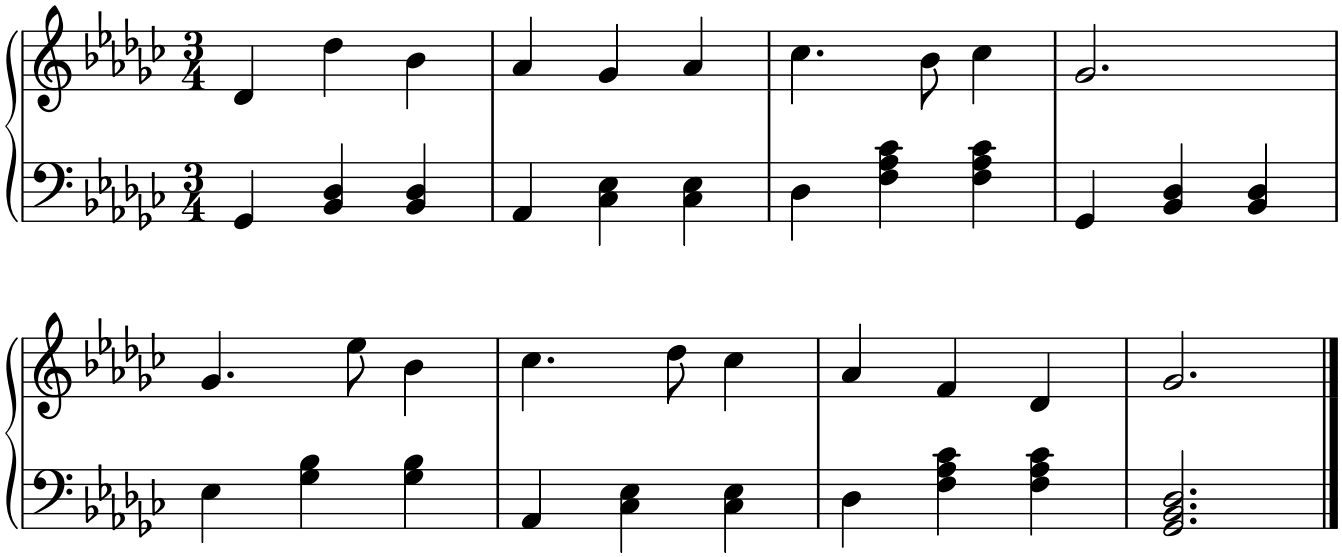


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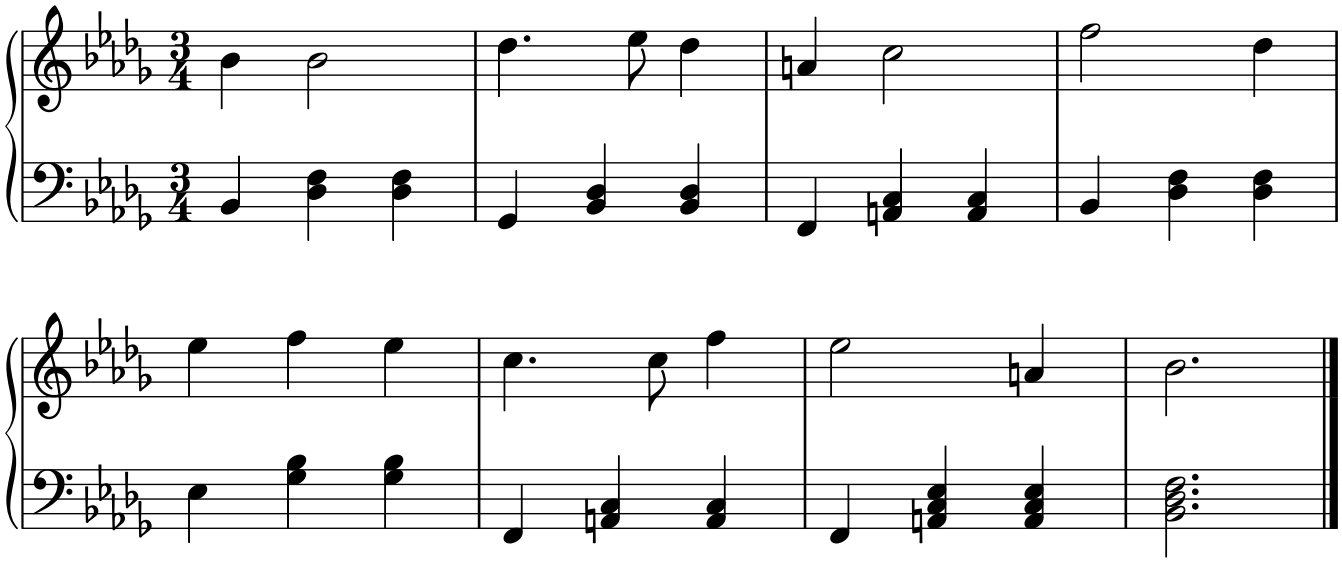


☐ **6.13a**
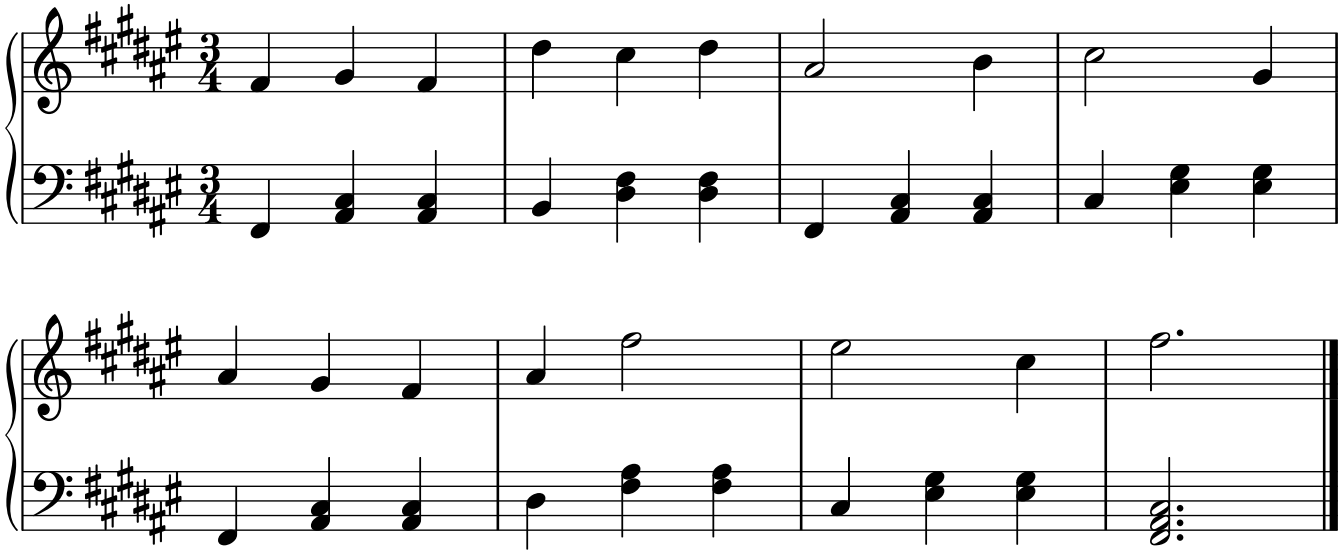


☐ **6.13b**
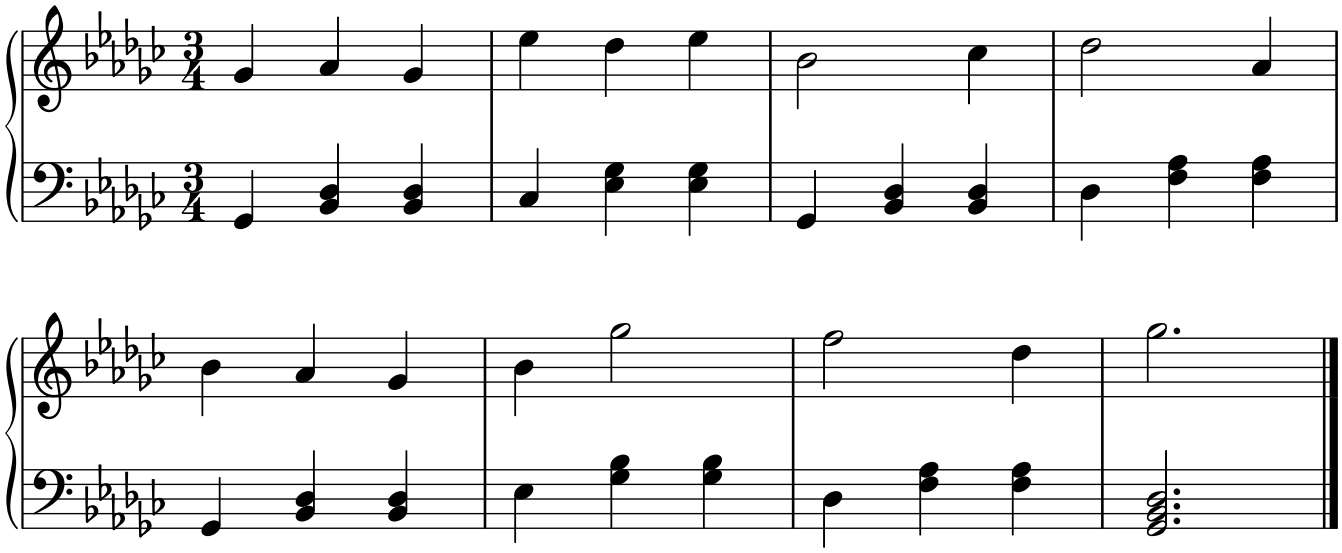


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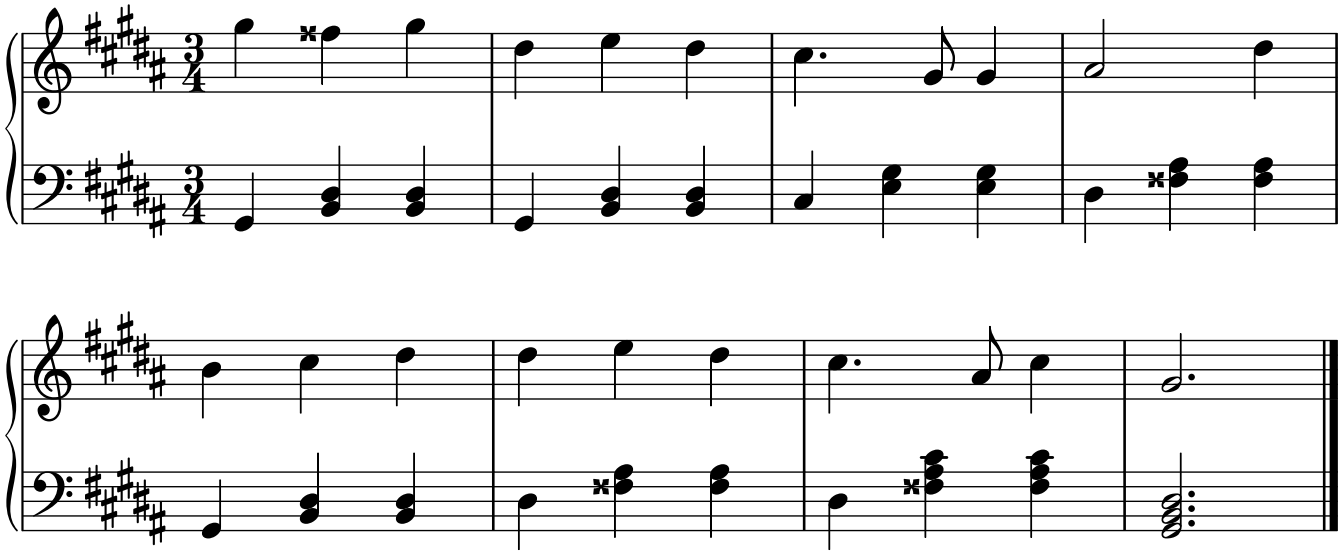


☐ **6.15a**



☐ **6.15b**



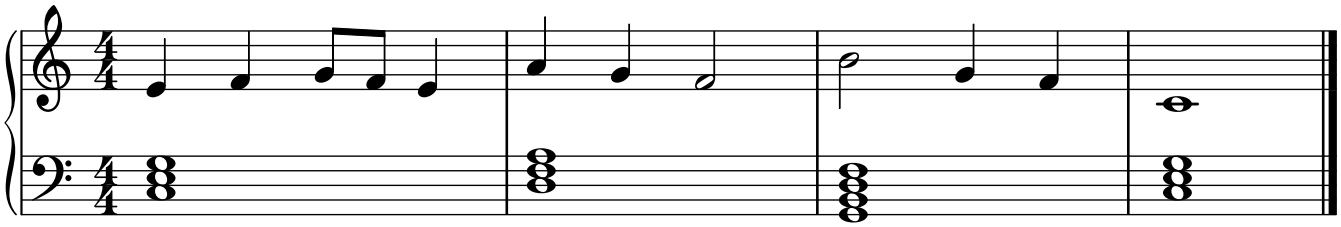
☐ **6.16**



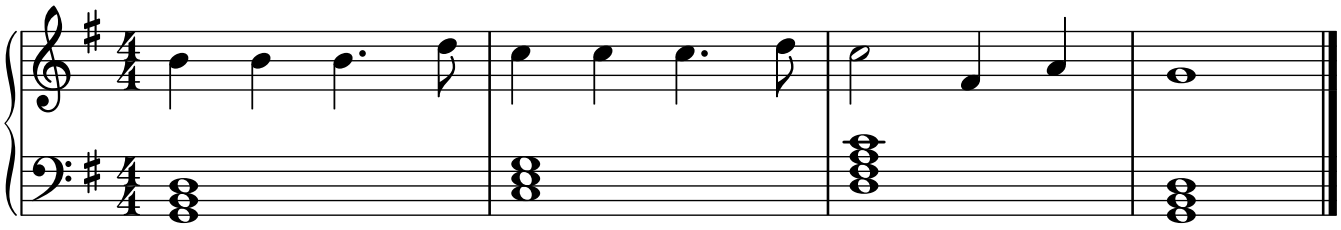
Part C: Round the circle of fifths ♩ = 60

Round the circle of fifths: each four-bar exercise is in a new key, sharps first, then flats.

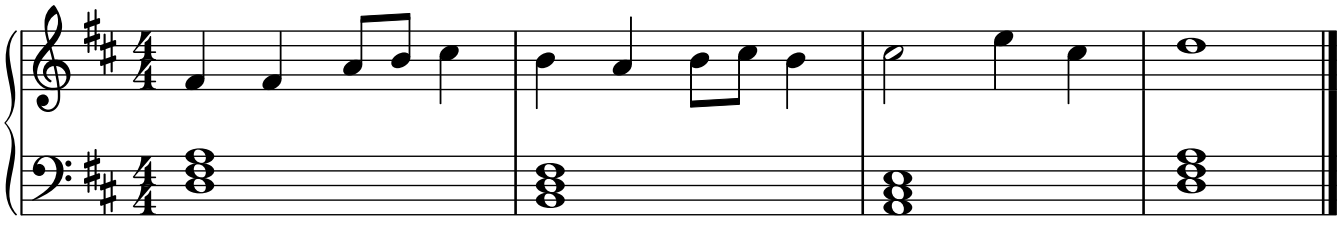
☐ **6.17**



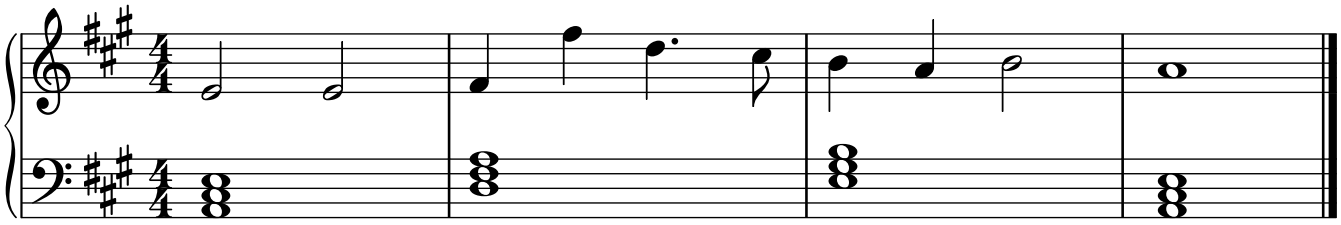
☐ **6.18**



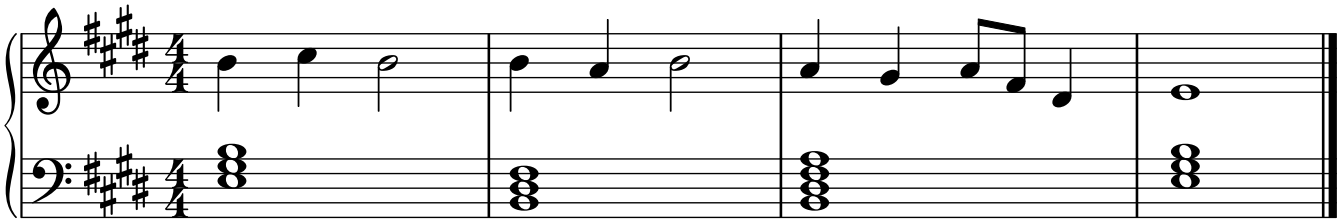
☐ **6.19**



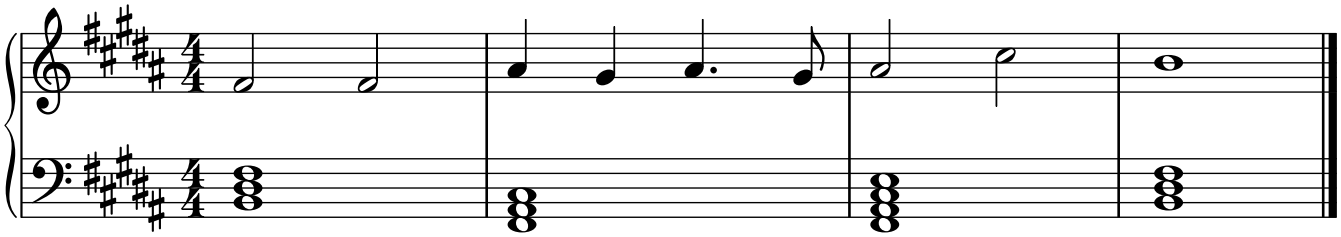
☐ **6.20**



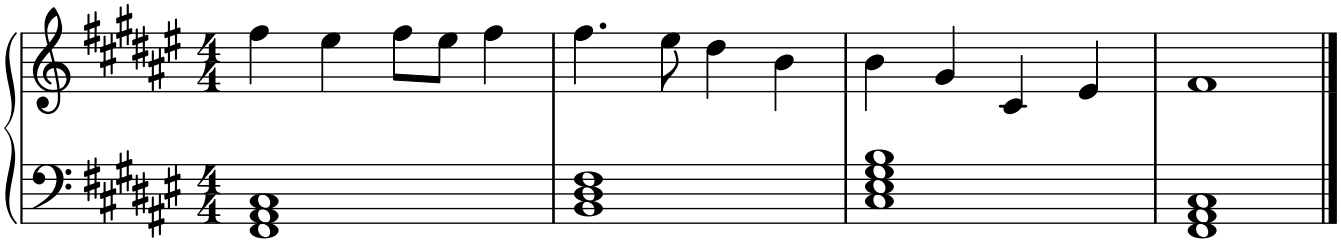
☐ **6.21**



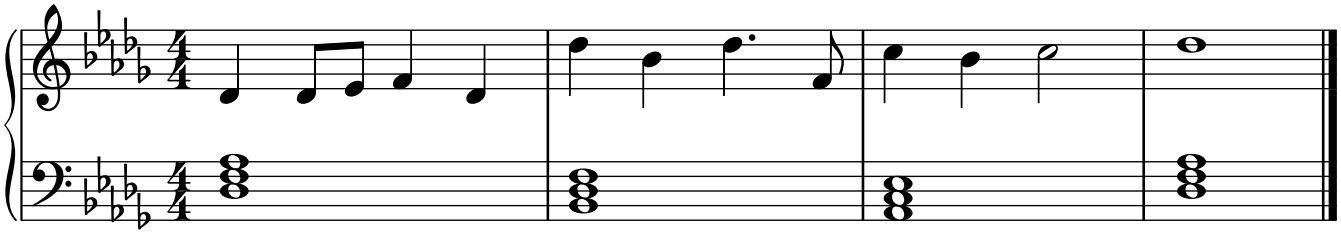
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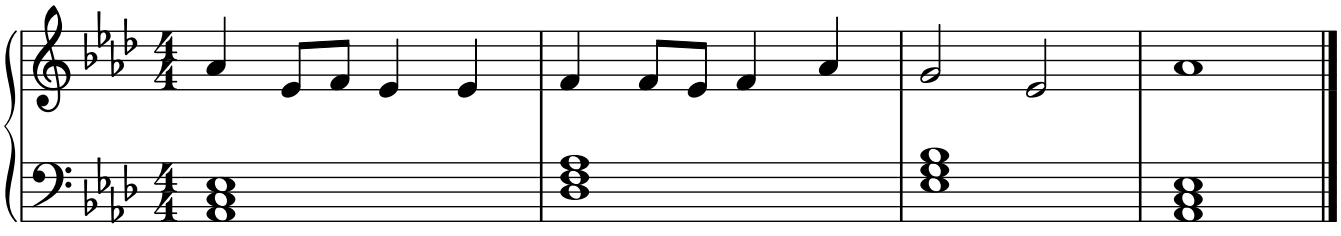
☐ **6.23**



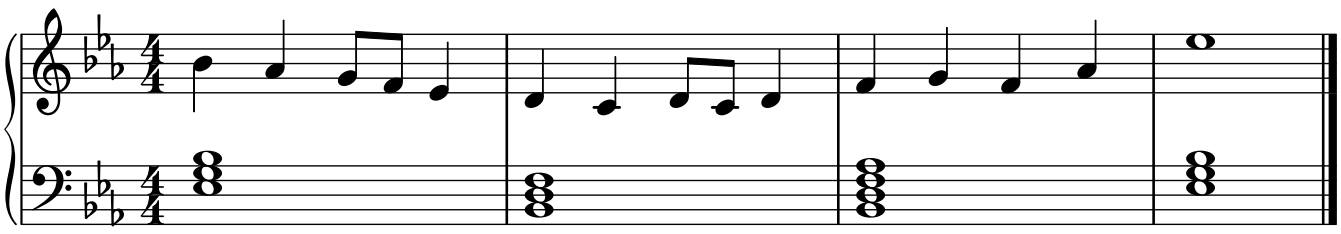
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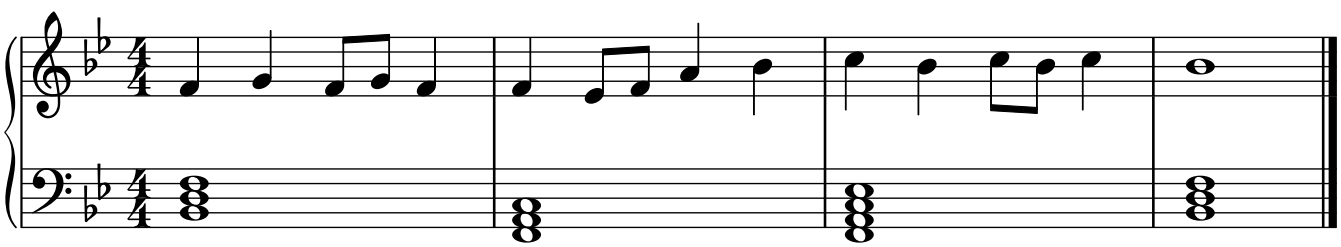


☐ **6.25**



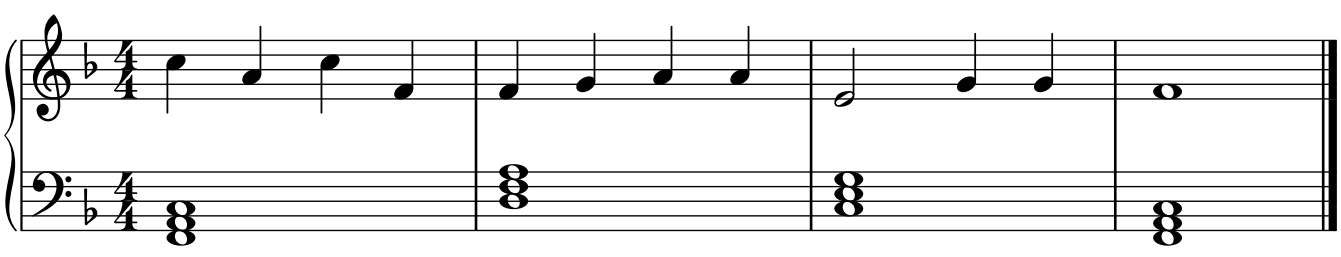
☐ **6.26**



☐ **6.27**



☐ **6.28**
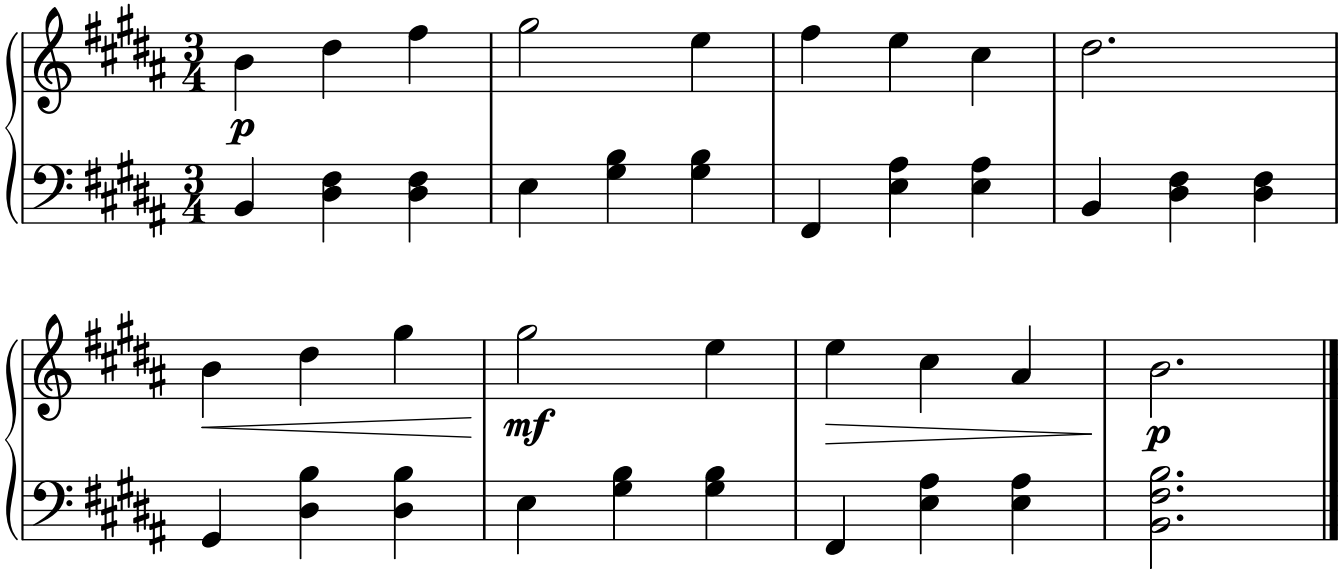


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Night Song in B ♩ = 84

Original

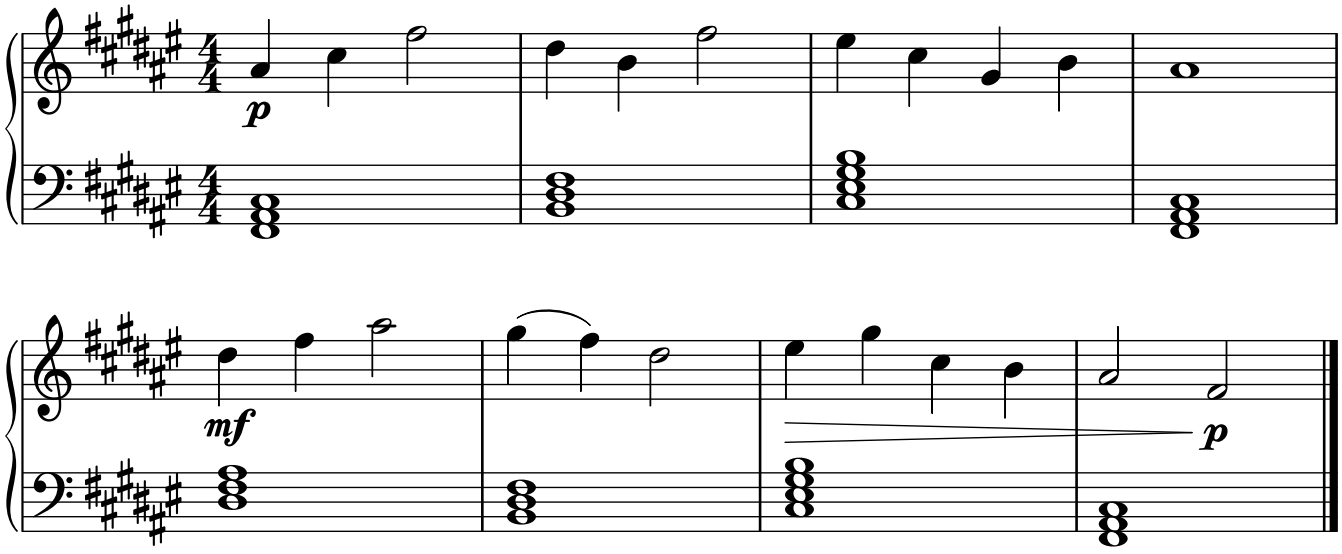
Five sharps: F, C, G, D and A. The left hand plays a waltz bass; the chords are B, E, F-sharp7 (with A-sharp) and G-sharp minor.



Enharmonic Twins (1): F-sharp major ♩ = 72

Original

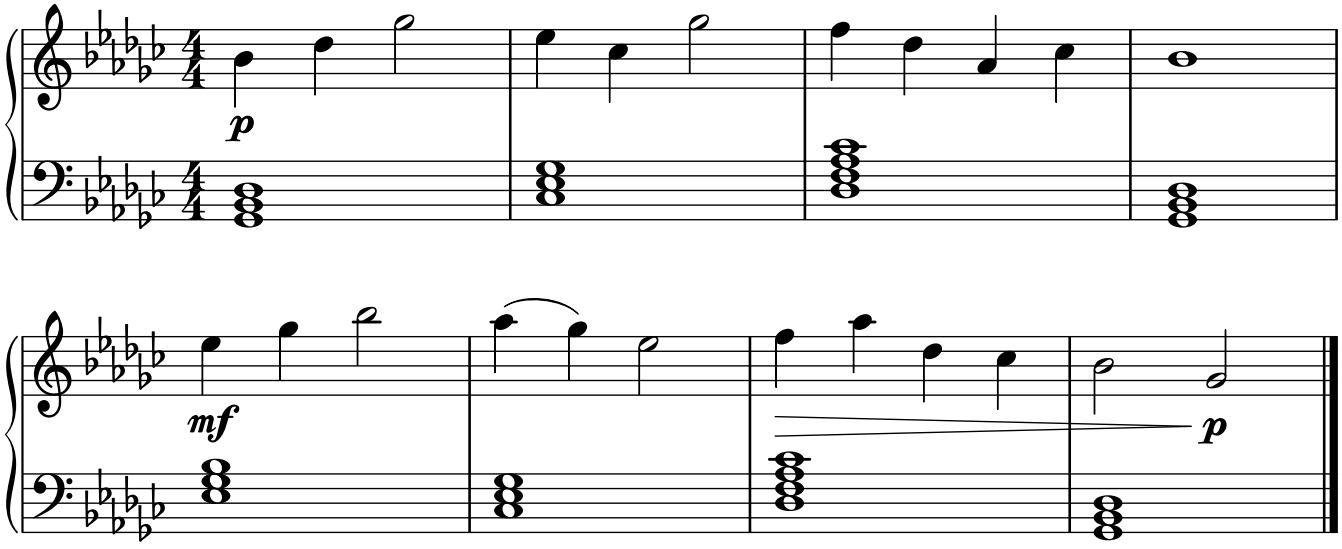
Six sharps. E-sharp (the white key F) is in the C-sharp7 chord. Play this, then the next piece: it is the same music in G-flat major.



Enharmonic Twins (2): G-flat major ♩= 72

Original

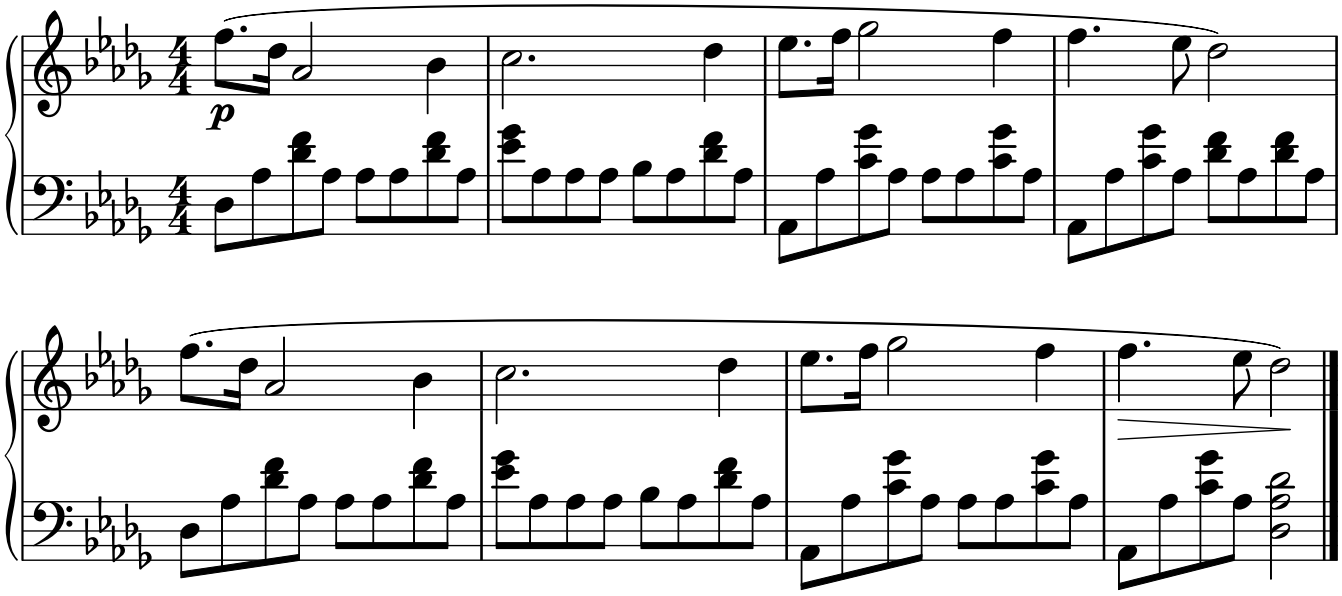
Six flats: the same keys on the piano as the F-sharp major piece, every note with a new name. C-flat is the white key B; F is in the D-flat7 chord.



Raindrop Prelude ♩= 60

Frederic Chopin (1839), Prelude in D-flat, Op. 28 No. 15 - bars 1-8, simplified
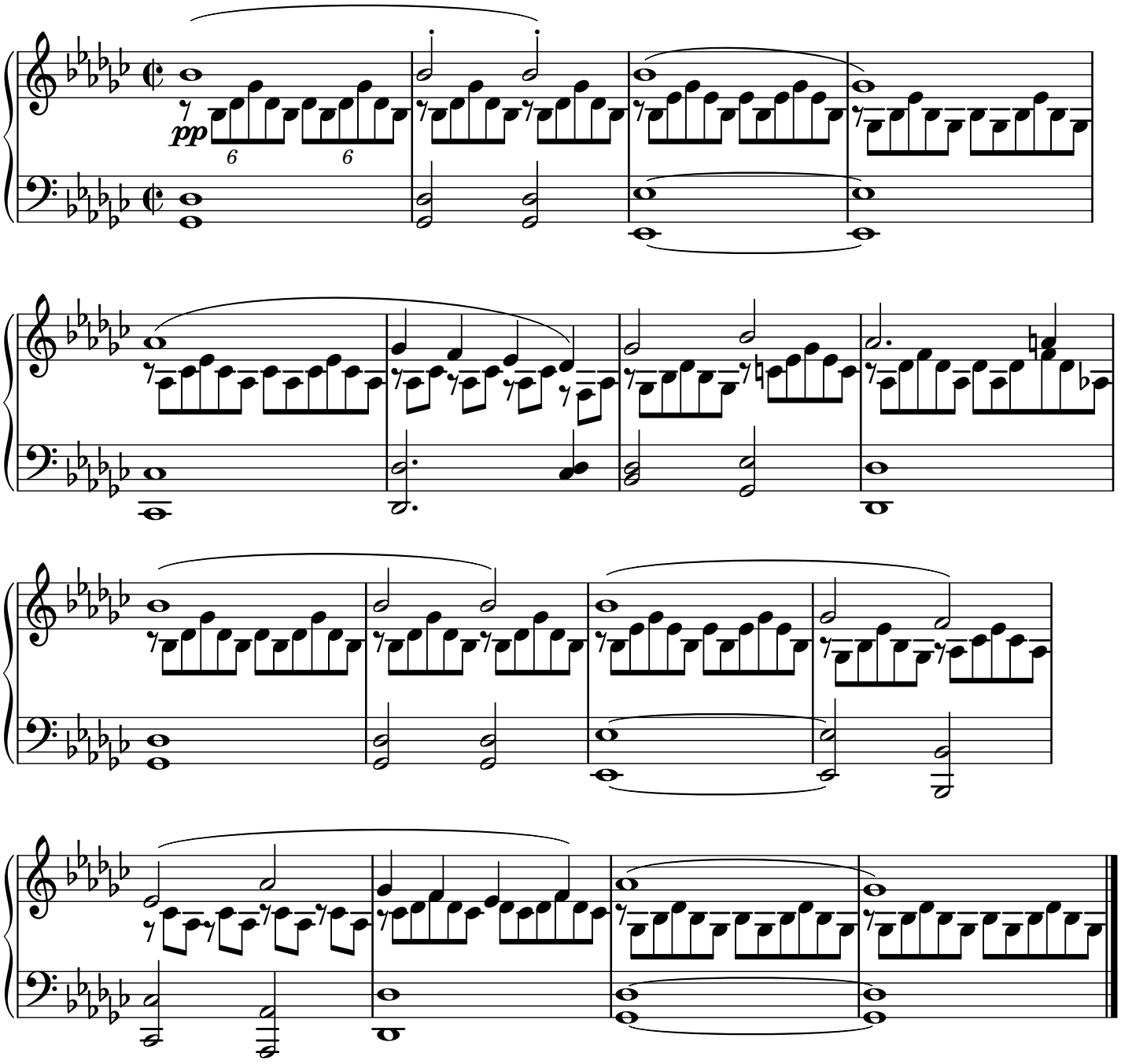
Five flats. The left hand's A-flats fall like raindrops all through the piece. Chopin's left hand has an inner voice and some notes for the right hand; here it plays the A-flats with its chords, and the ornamental run in bar 4 is left out. Chopin asks for the pedal: leave it until Unit 7. Source: Mutopia Project no. 471 (public domain).



Impromptu in G-flat ♩ = 50

Franz Schubert (1827), Impromptu, D. 899 No. 3 - the first sixteen bars, simplified

Six flats. Schubert writes four half notes in a bar (4/2); here each of his bars is split into two bars of 2/2. The right hand plays the slow tune (stems up) and a flowing accompaniment of six notes to each half note (stems down): all its eighths are triplet eighths, three to a quarter beat, though the figures 6 and 3 are printed only at the start. Count two beats in a bar. In bar 15 the hand stretches a ninth, from G-flat to the tune's A-flat. The last bar's accompaniment is a G-flat chord, so that the excerpt ends at home. Source: Mutopia Project no. 1193 (public domain).



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 7?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if you can name all fifteen major keys from their key signatures, round the circle of fifths.
- Pass if you can play both Enharmonic Twins at sight and hear that they are the same music.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 7.

Unit 7

Pedal, Clefs and the Whole Keyboard

New: The sustain pedal; the left hand in the treble clef and the right hand in the bass clef

The right pedal (the sustain pedal) keeps every note sounding after the fingers let go. With it the left hand can play a low bass note and then leap to a chord far above, and the bass still rings. In this volume the pedal is shown with a bracket under the bass staff: the pedal goes down where the bracket starts, up where it ends, and a notch in the bracket means 'up and straight down again' at a change of harmony.
With the whole keyboard in use, the hands also borrow each other's clefs: the left hand reads in the treble clef when it plays above middle C, and the right hand in the bass clef when it goes low.

What is new

Pedal brackets

Down at the start of the bracket, up at its end. At a notch, lift and press again just after the new chord sounds, so that the old harmony is cleared without a gap.

Ped. and *

Older editions write 'Ped.' for down and an asterisk for up. They mean the same.

Clef changes

A small clef in the middle of a line changes the reading for that staff until the next clef. Check the clef at the start of every line, too.

Leaps

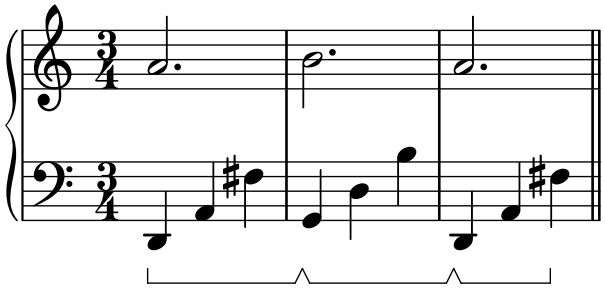
A low bass note followed by a chord in the middle of the keyboard is a leap of an octave or more. Look ahead, move the hand early, and let the pedal hold the bass.

Rolled chords

A wavy line before a chord means: spread it from the bottom up, quickly, like a harp.

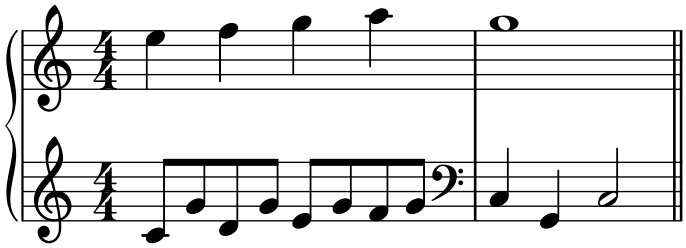
Pedal changes with the harmony

Down on beat 1; at each new bar the bracket has a notch: up and down again.



The left hand in the treble clef

Both hands read the treble clef while the left hand plays above middle C; the clef sign changes it back.



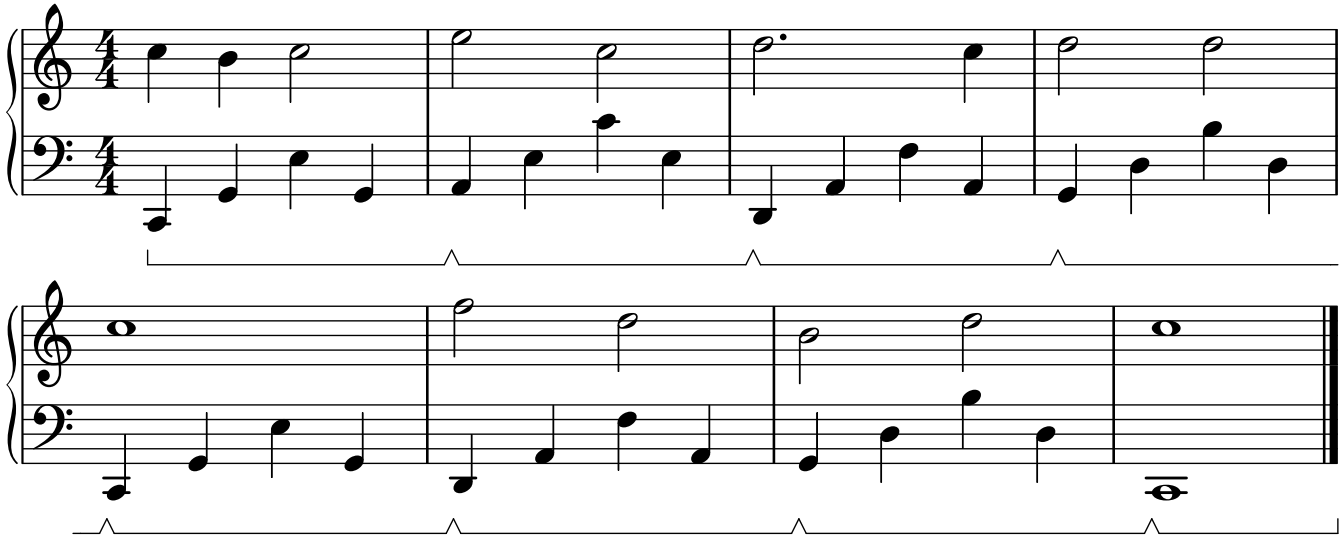
Reading tips

1. Before you play, find every clef sign in the music, not only at the start of the lines.
2. Pedal with the harmony: change it when the bass note changes, just after the new note sounds.
3. For a leap, look at the landing chord before you leave the bass note.
4. Keep the pedal foot's heel on the floor and use the ball of the foot.

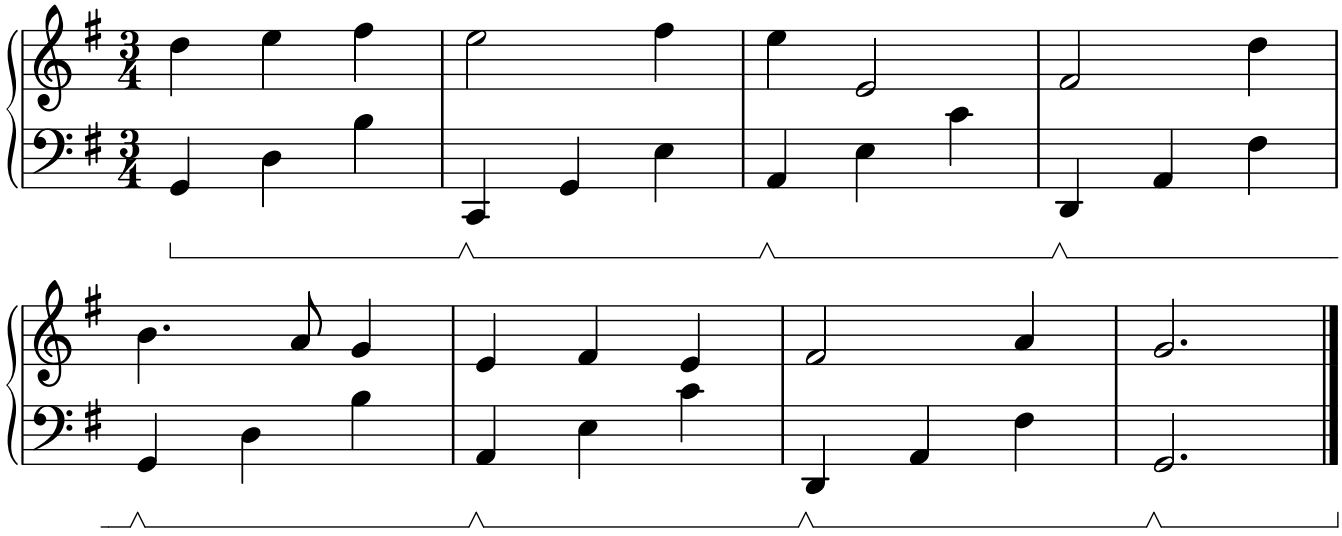
Part A: Wide broken chords with pedal ♩ = 66

Wide broken chords in the left hand (root, fifth, tenth): the pedal holds them. Change the pedal with each new chord.
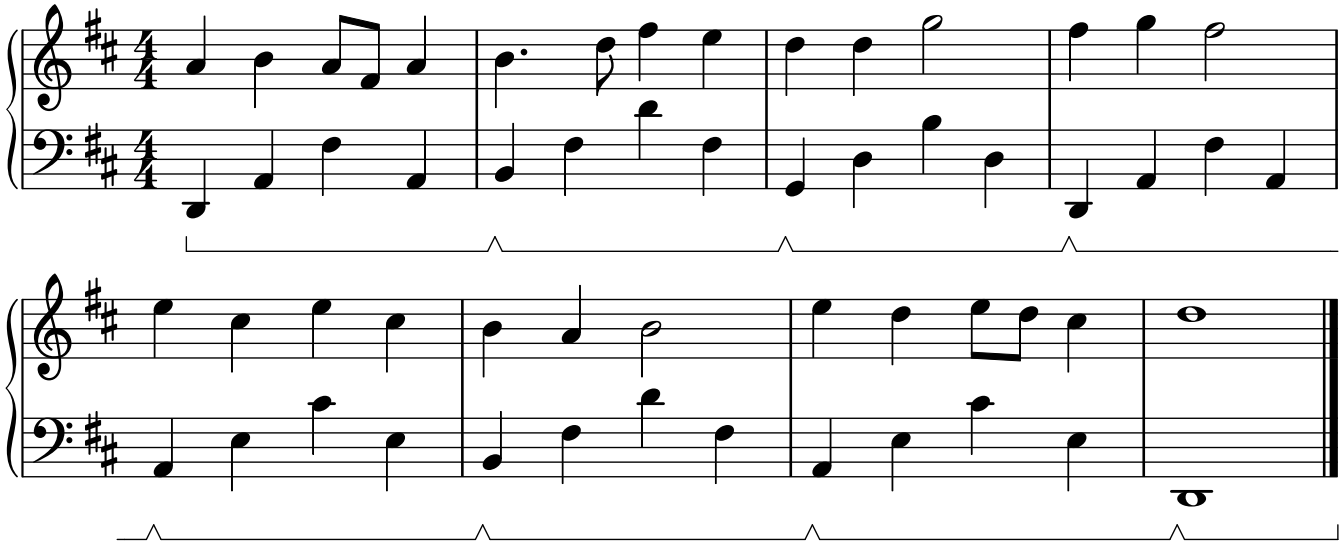
☐ **7.1**



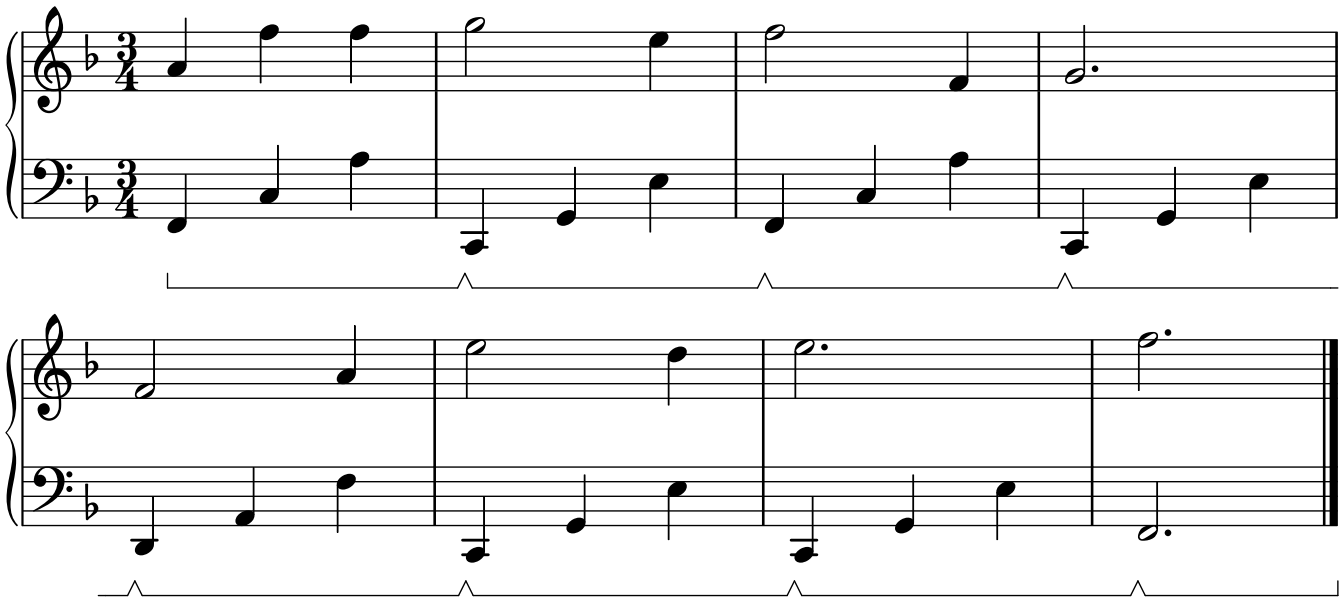
☐ **7.2**
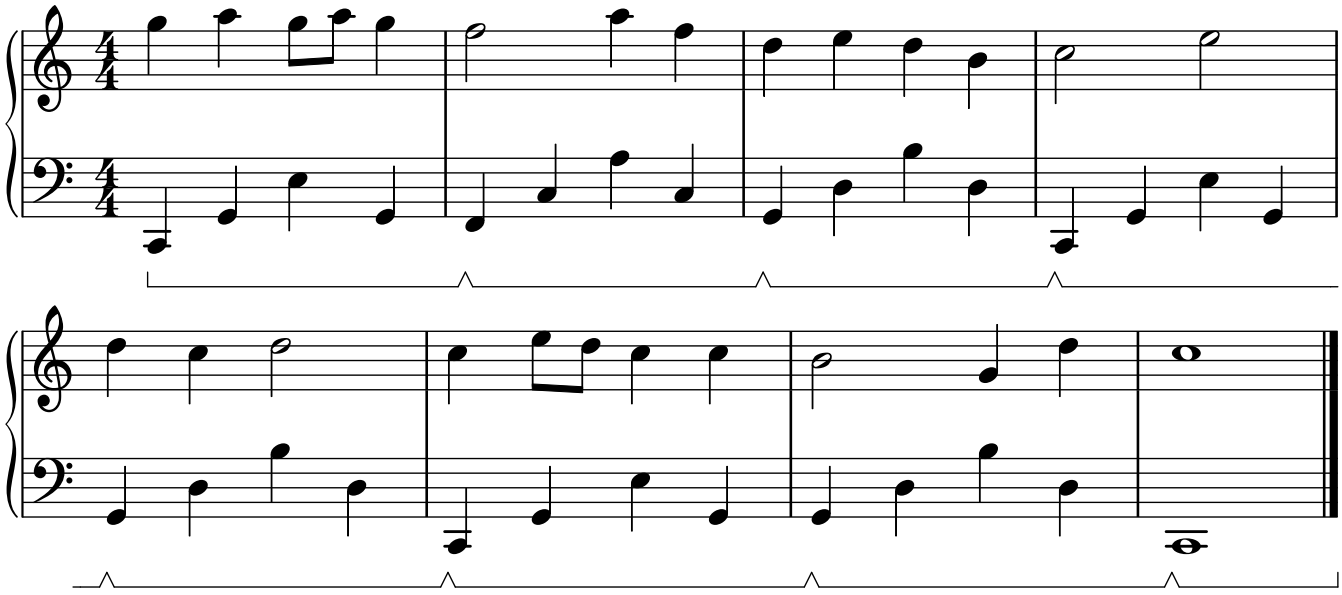


☐ **7.3**



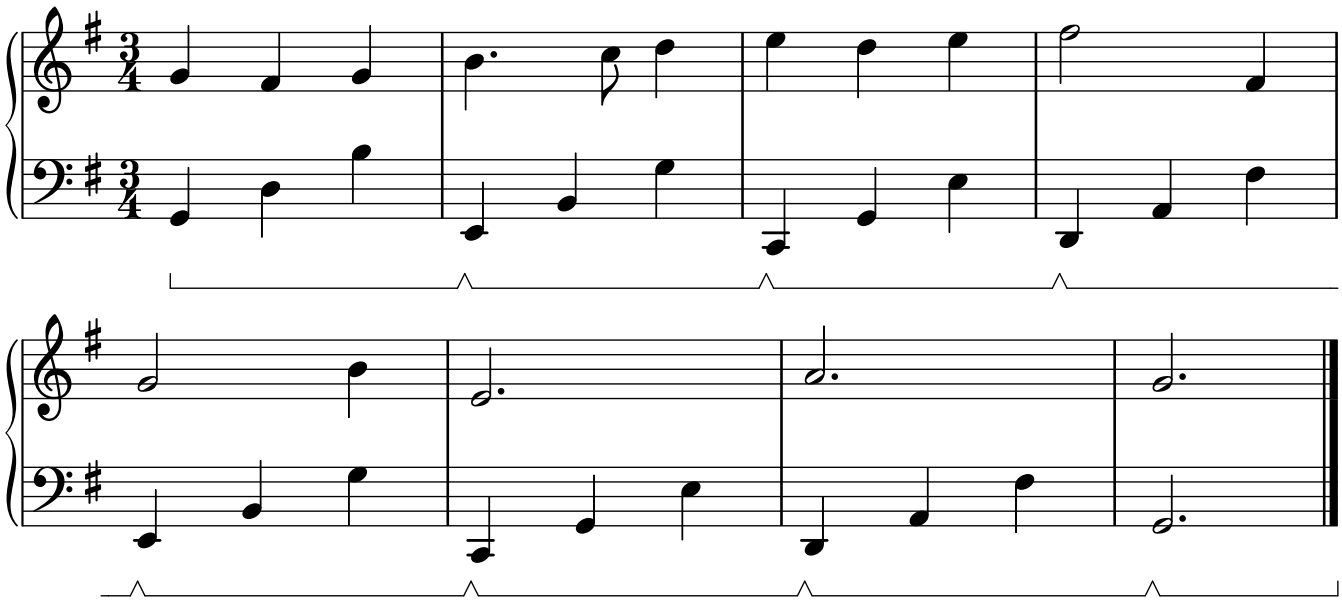
7.4



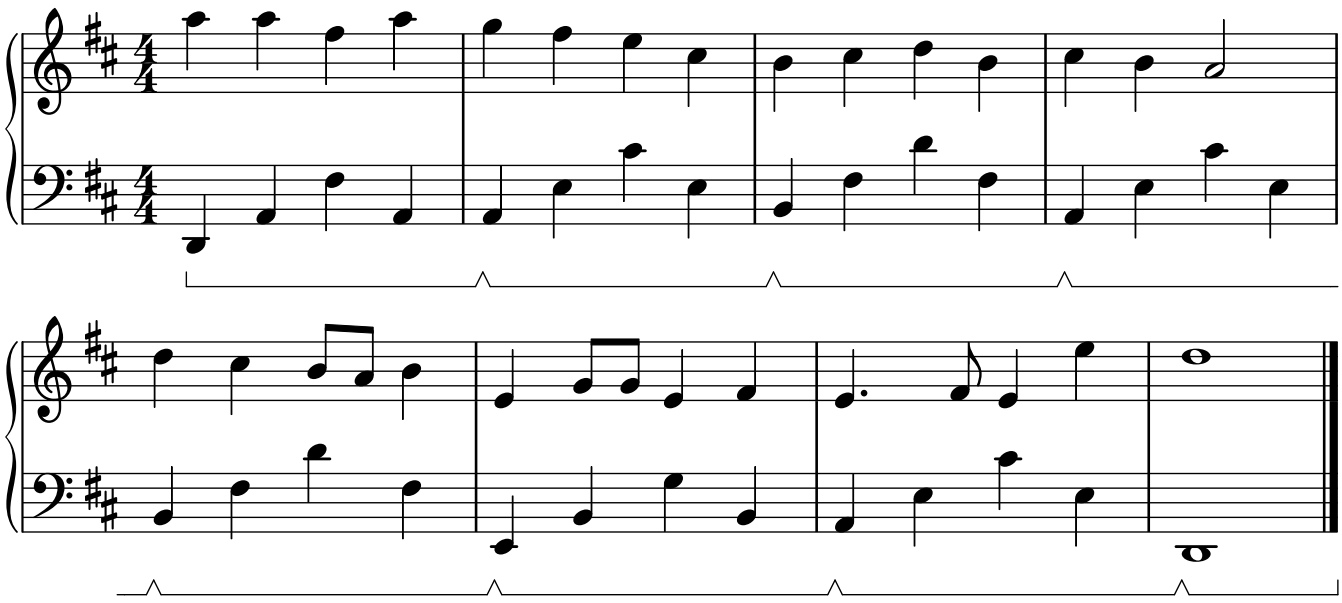
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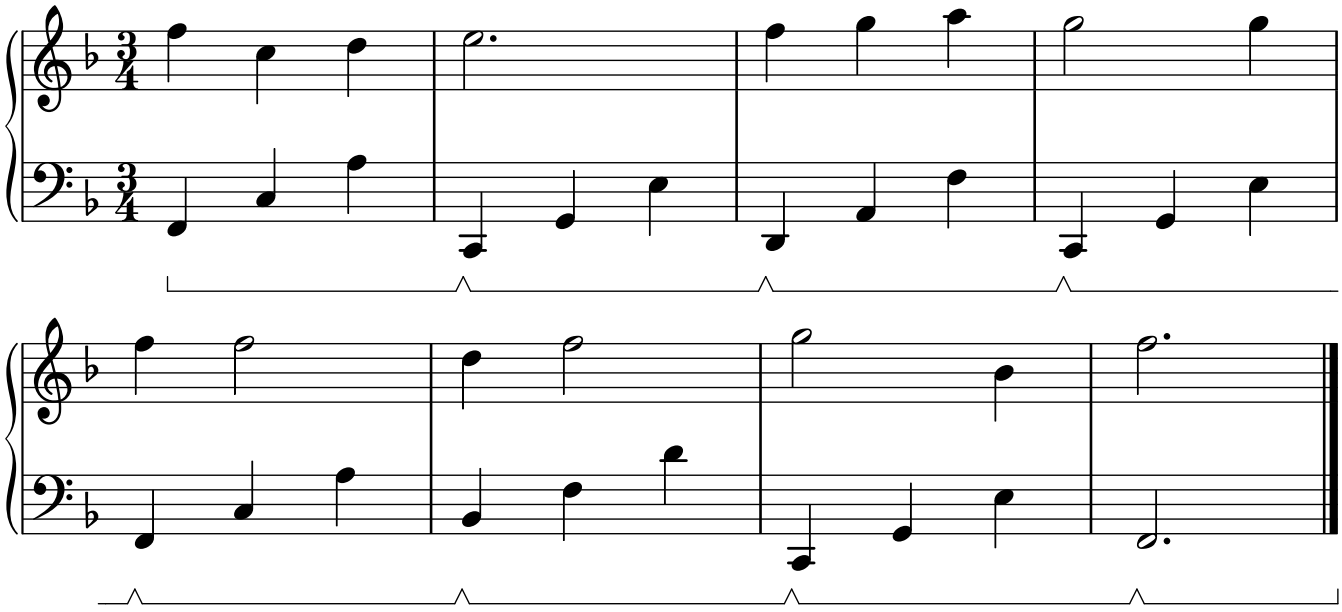
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7.7



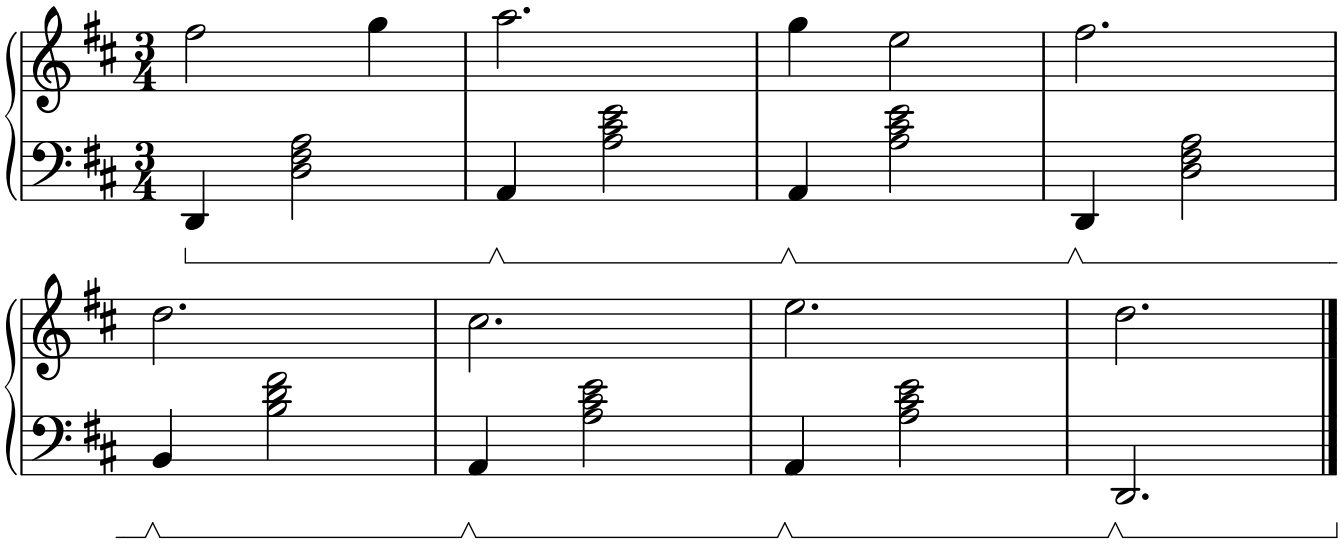
7.8



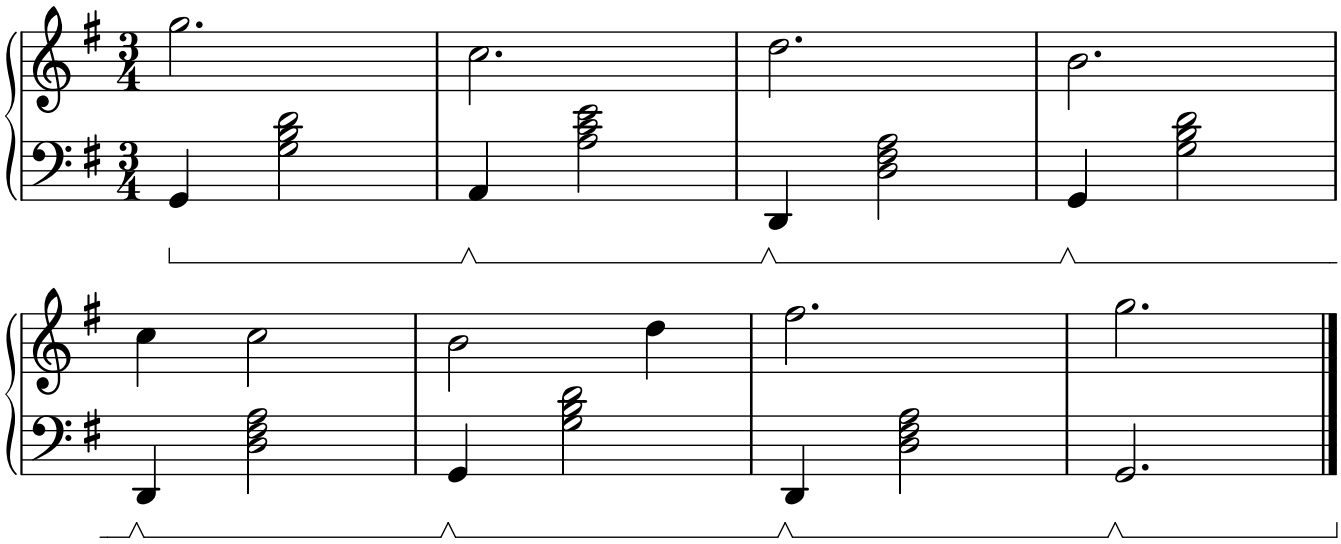
Part B: Low bass, chord in the middle ♩ = 72

Low bass note, then a chord in the middle of the keyboard (the Gymnopedie pattern), with the pedal.

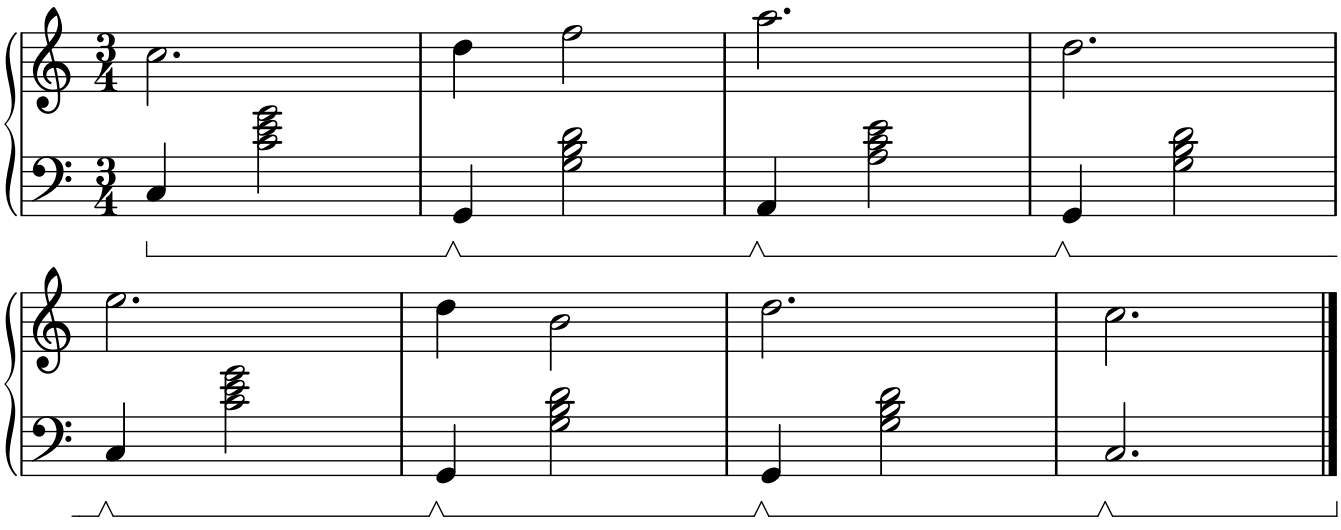
☐ **7.9**



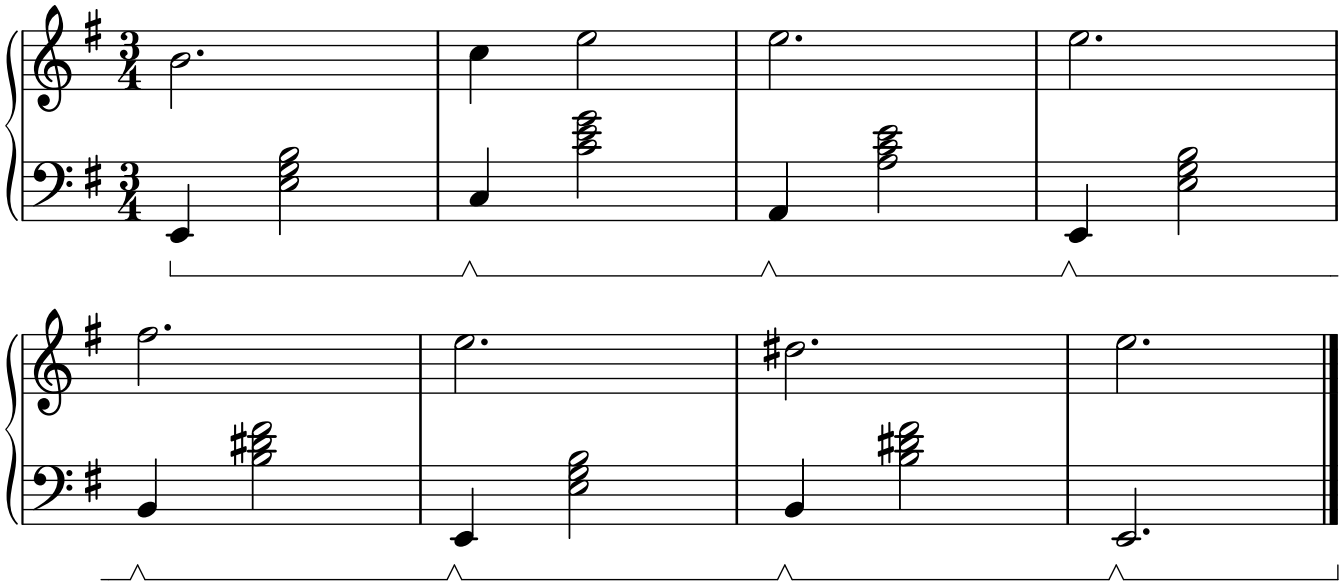
☐ **7.10**



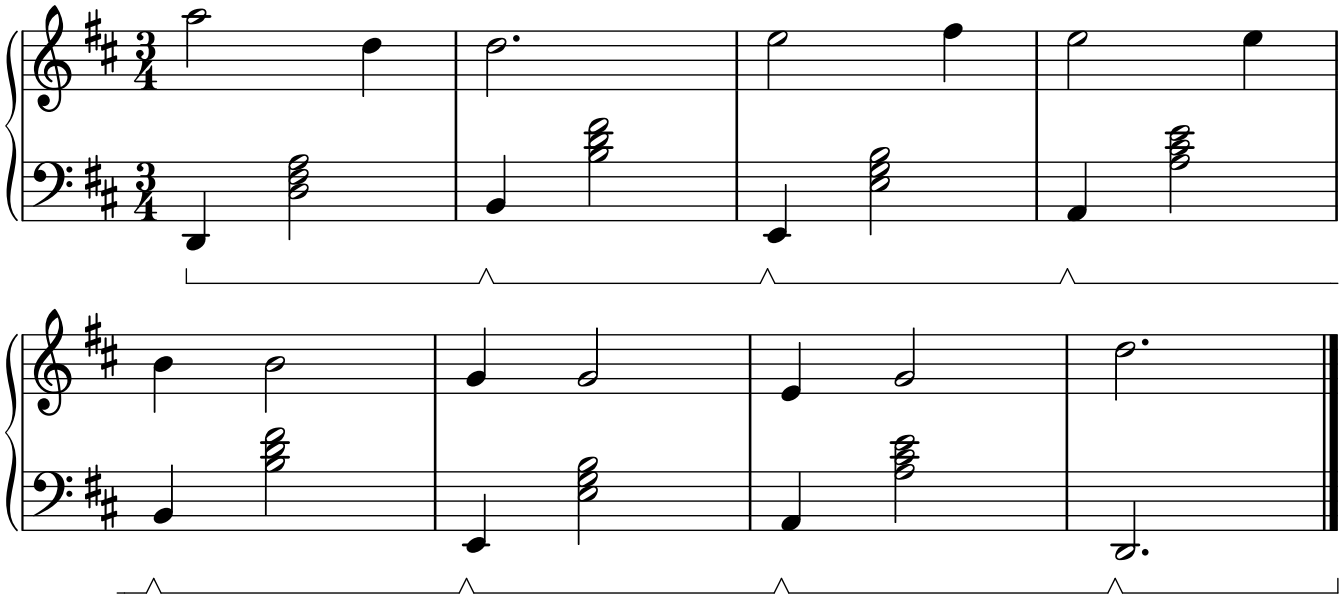
☐ **7.11**



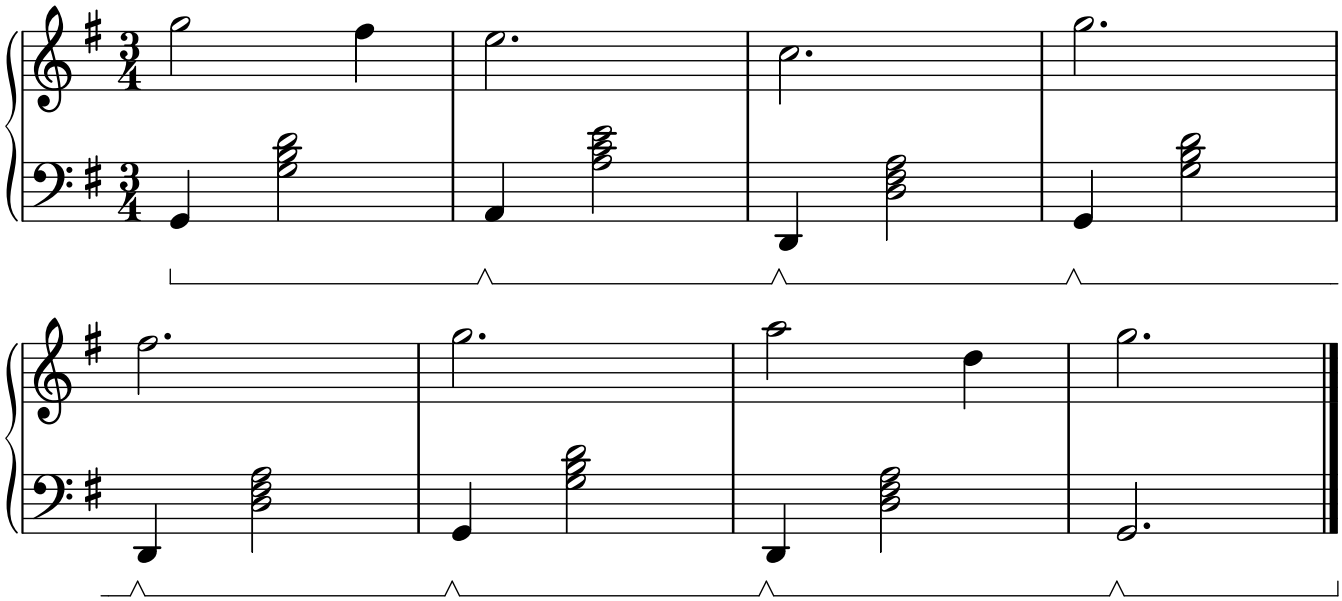
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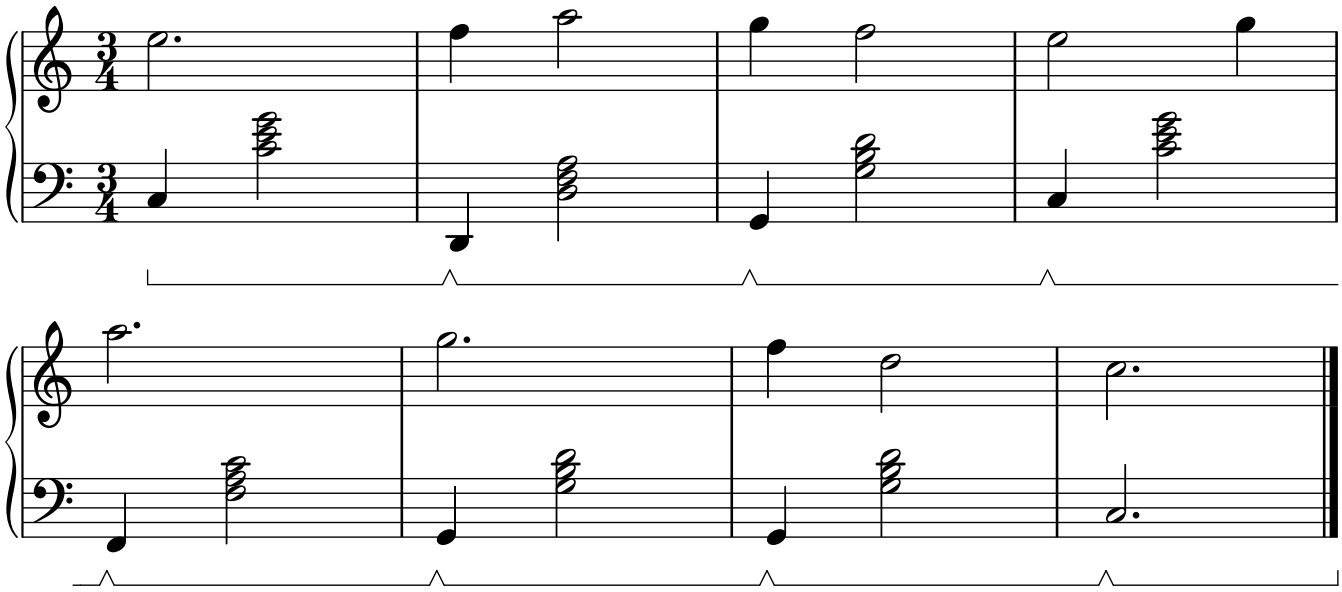
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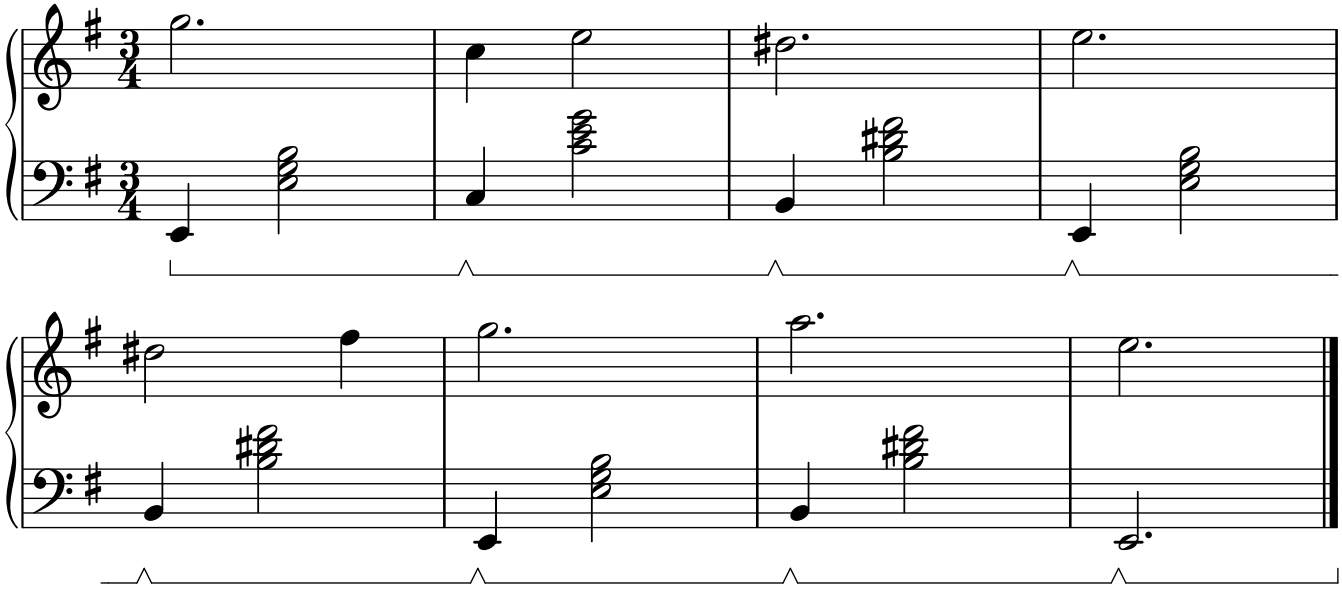
7.14



7.15
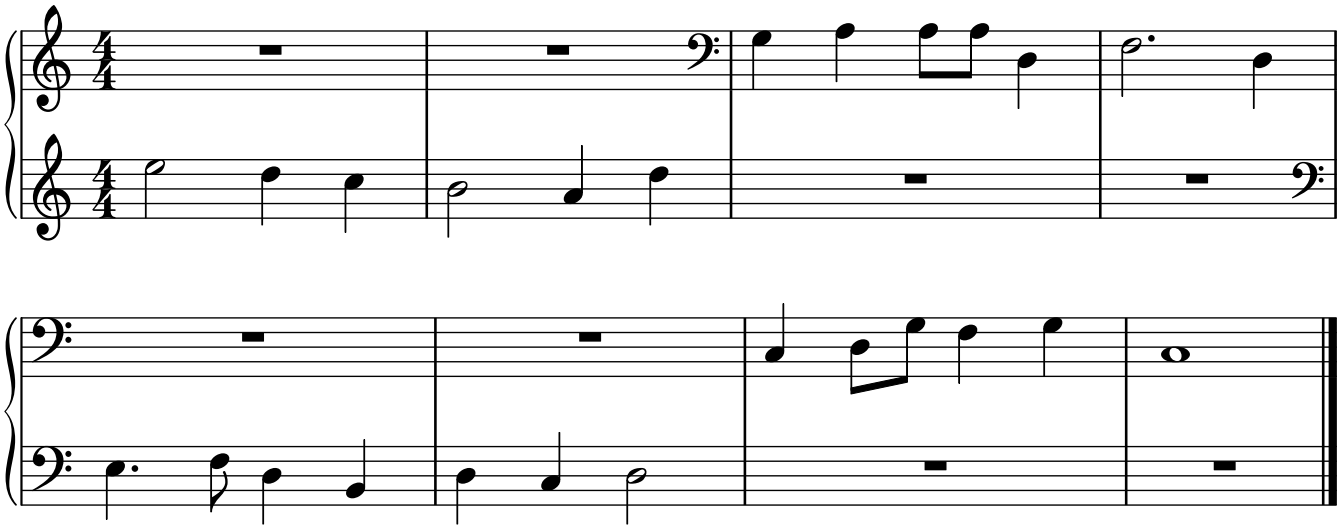


7.16
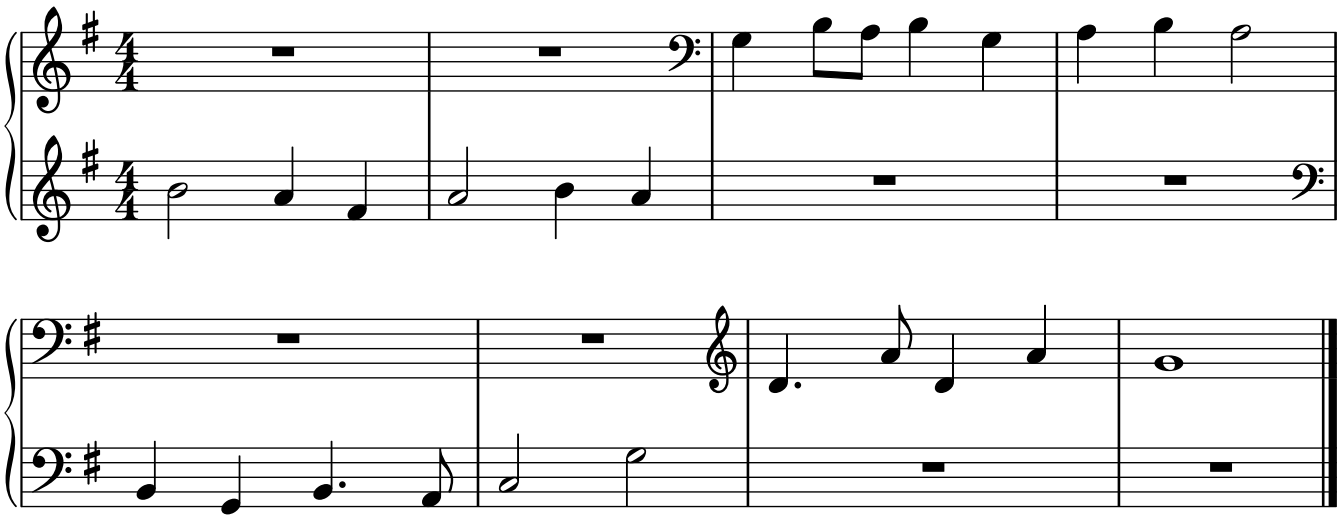


Part C: Clef changes ♩= 66

The hands take turns; the left hand sometimes reads the treble clef and the right hand the bass clef. Watch the clef signs.
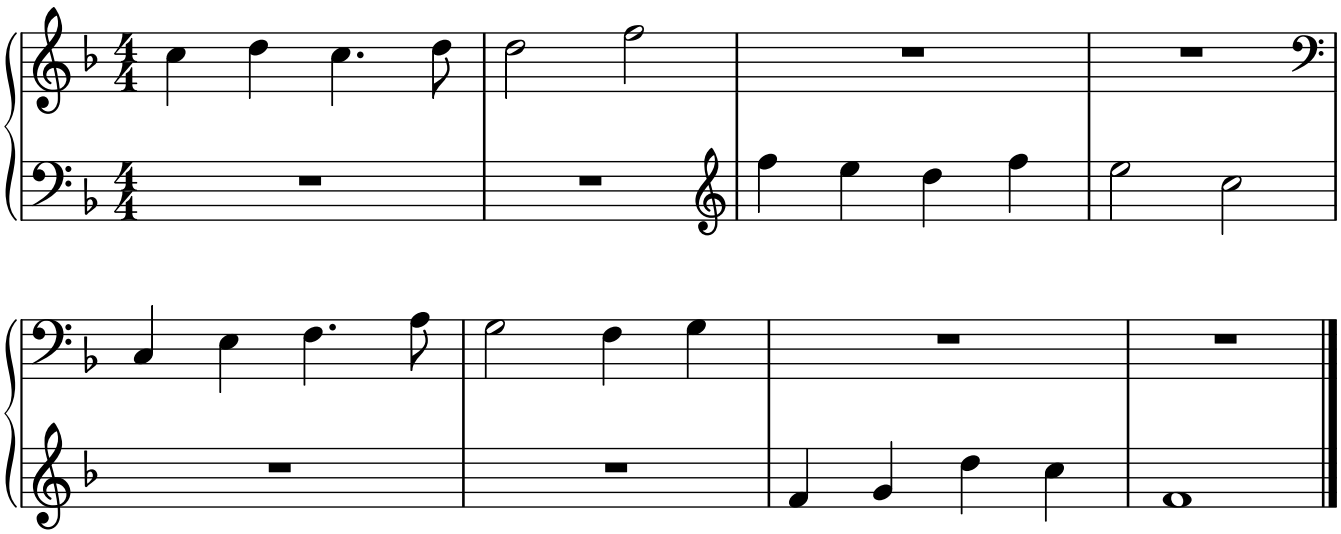
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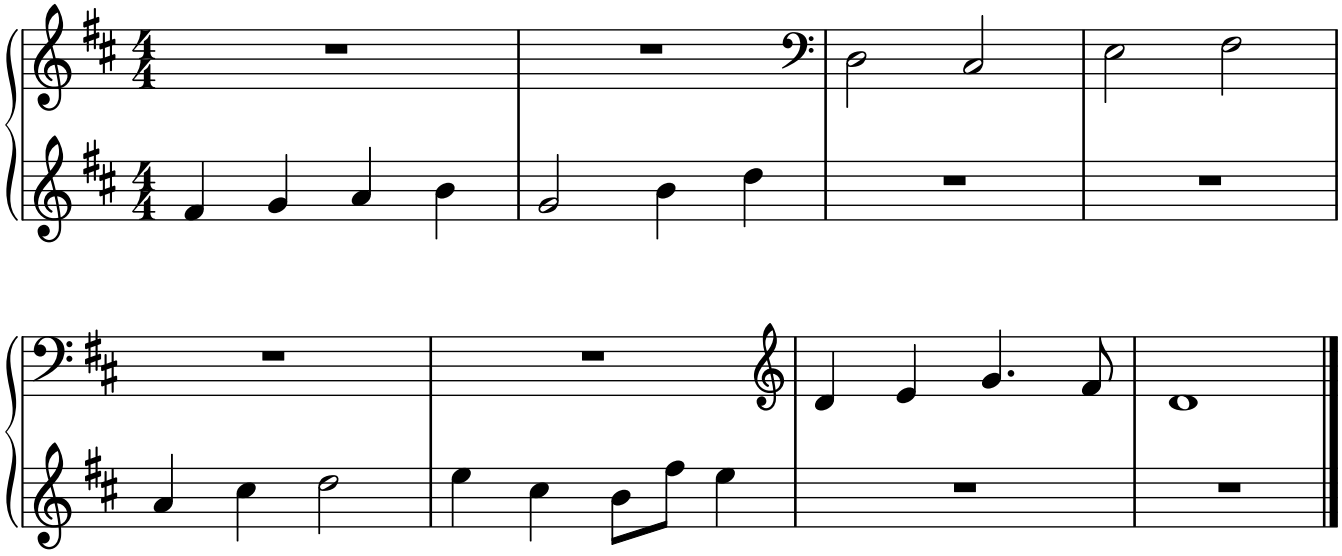


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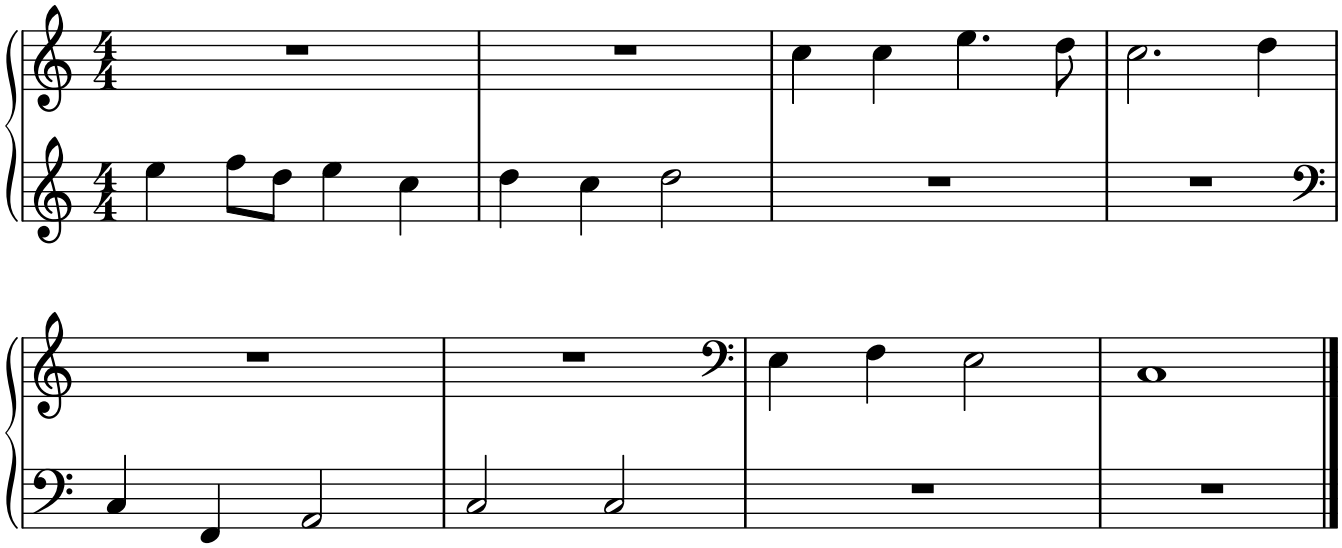


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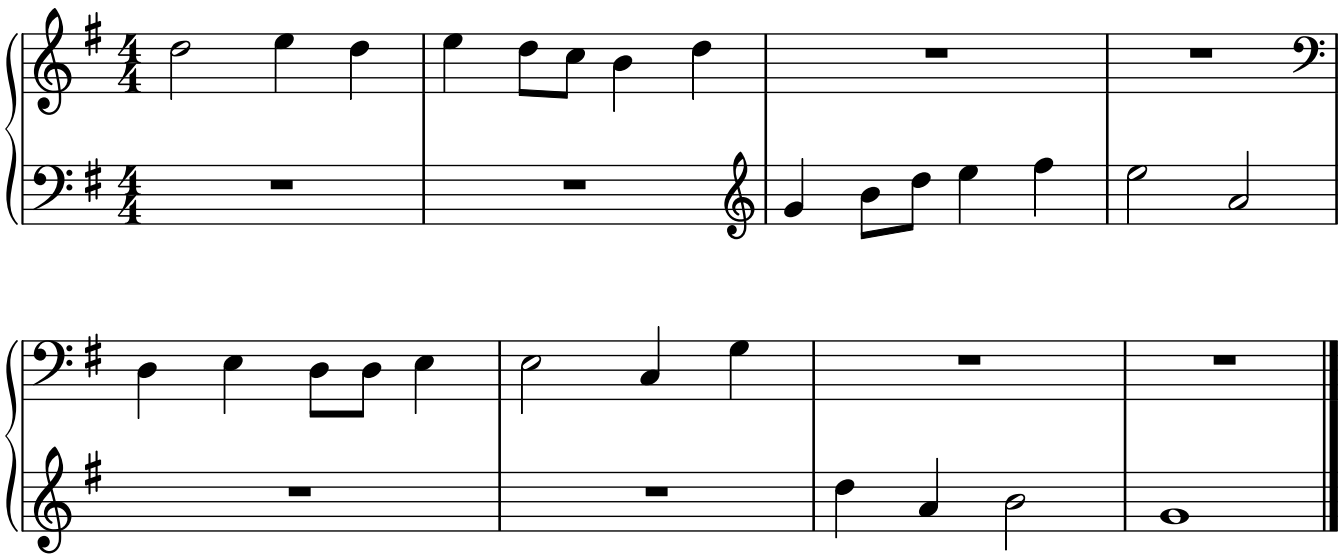


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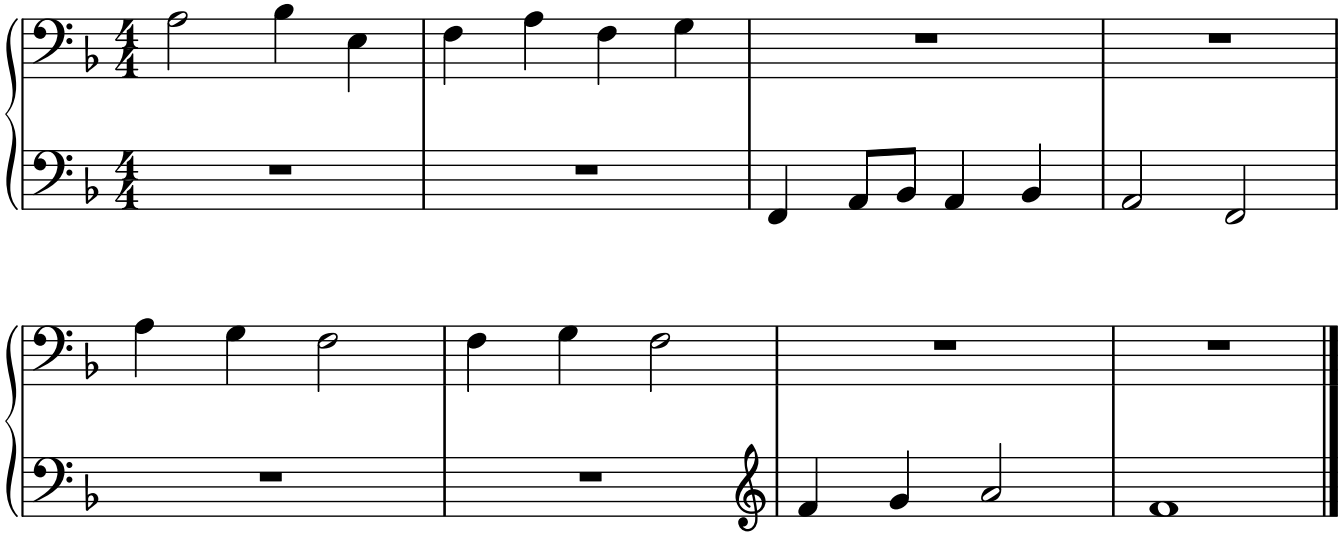


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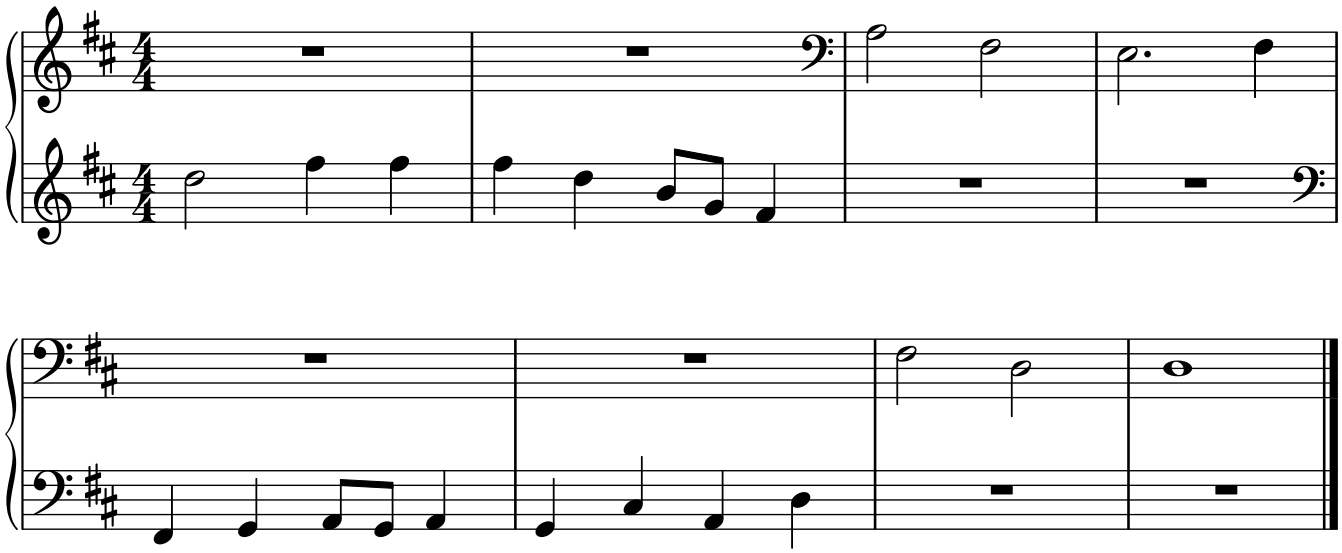


☐ **7.22**



7.23



7.24



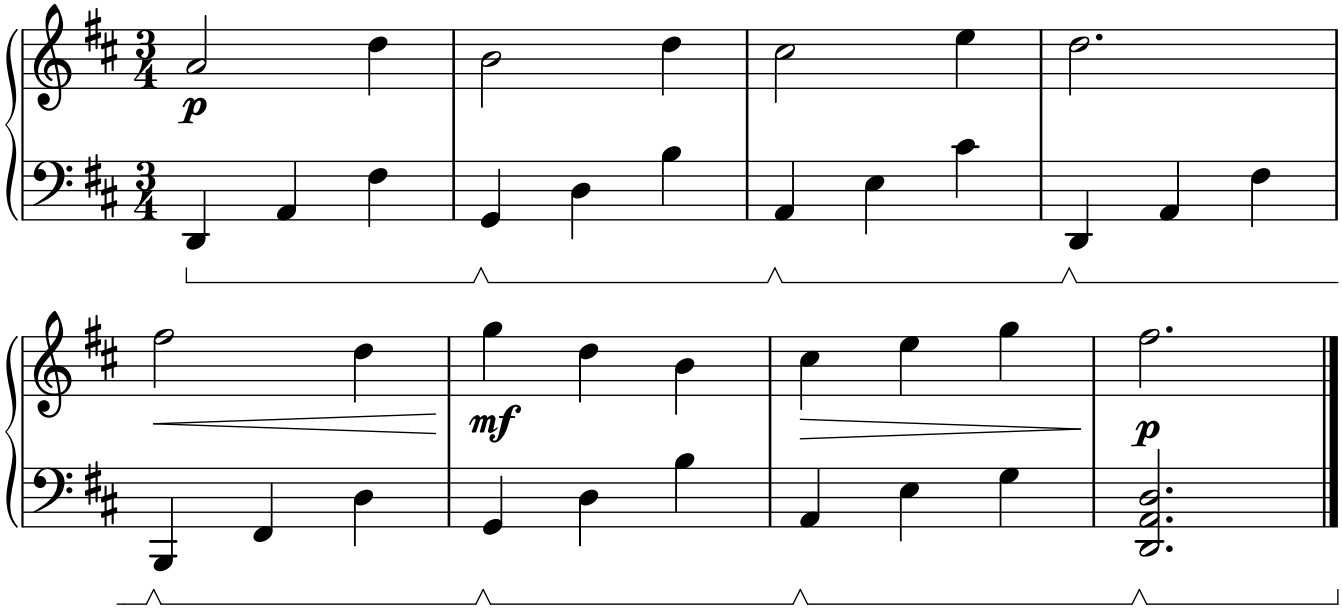
Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Pedal Song ♩ = 66

Original
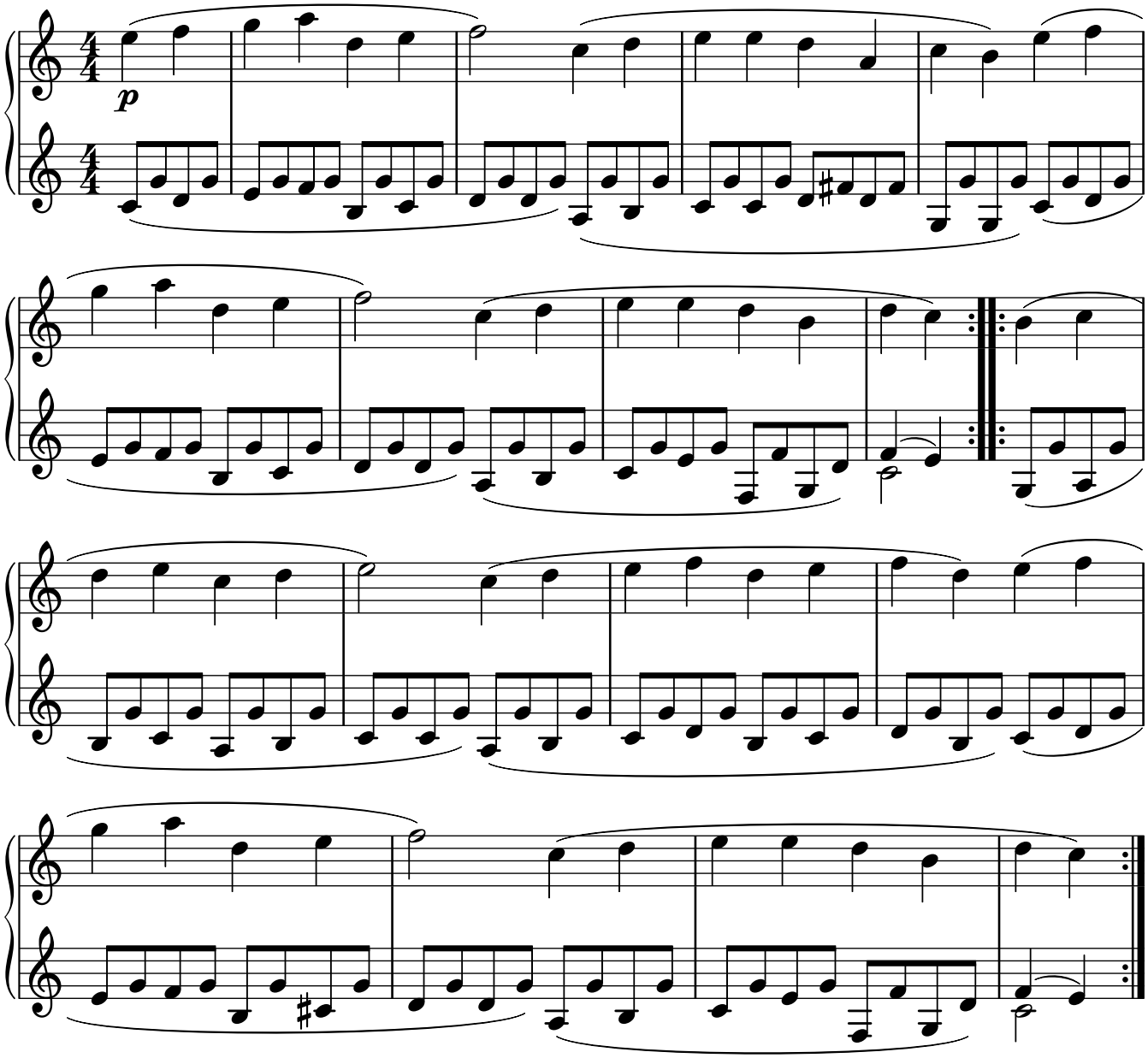
The left hand spreads each chord over a tenth (bass, fifth, third an octave higher); the pedal holds it. Change the pedal at the start of every bar.



Little Piece ♩= 80

Robert Schumann (1848), Album for the Young, Op. 68 No. 5 - complete
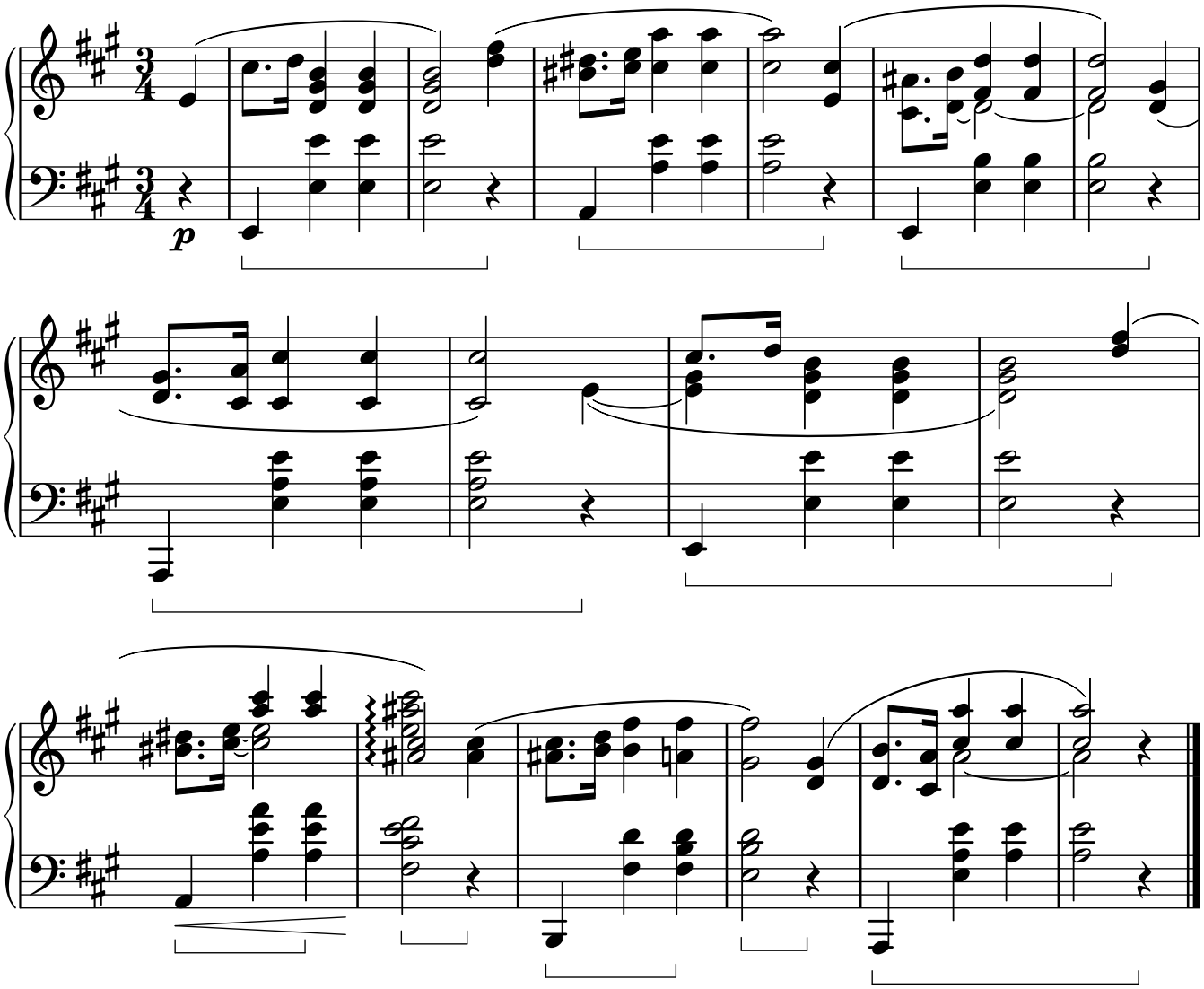
The left hand plays above middle C all through, so it is written in the treble clef. Its eighths are two voices: a moving line and a repeated G. Both halves are repeated; each starts with a half-bar upbeat. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 653 by Philippe Hezaine (CC BY-SA 2.5).



Prelude in A ♩= 60

Frederic Chopin (1839), Prelude, Op. 28 No. 7 - complete, one grace note left out
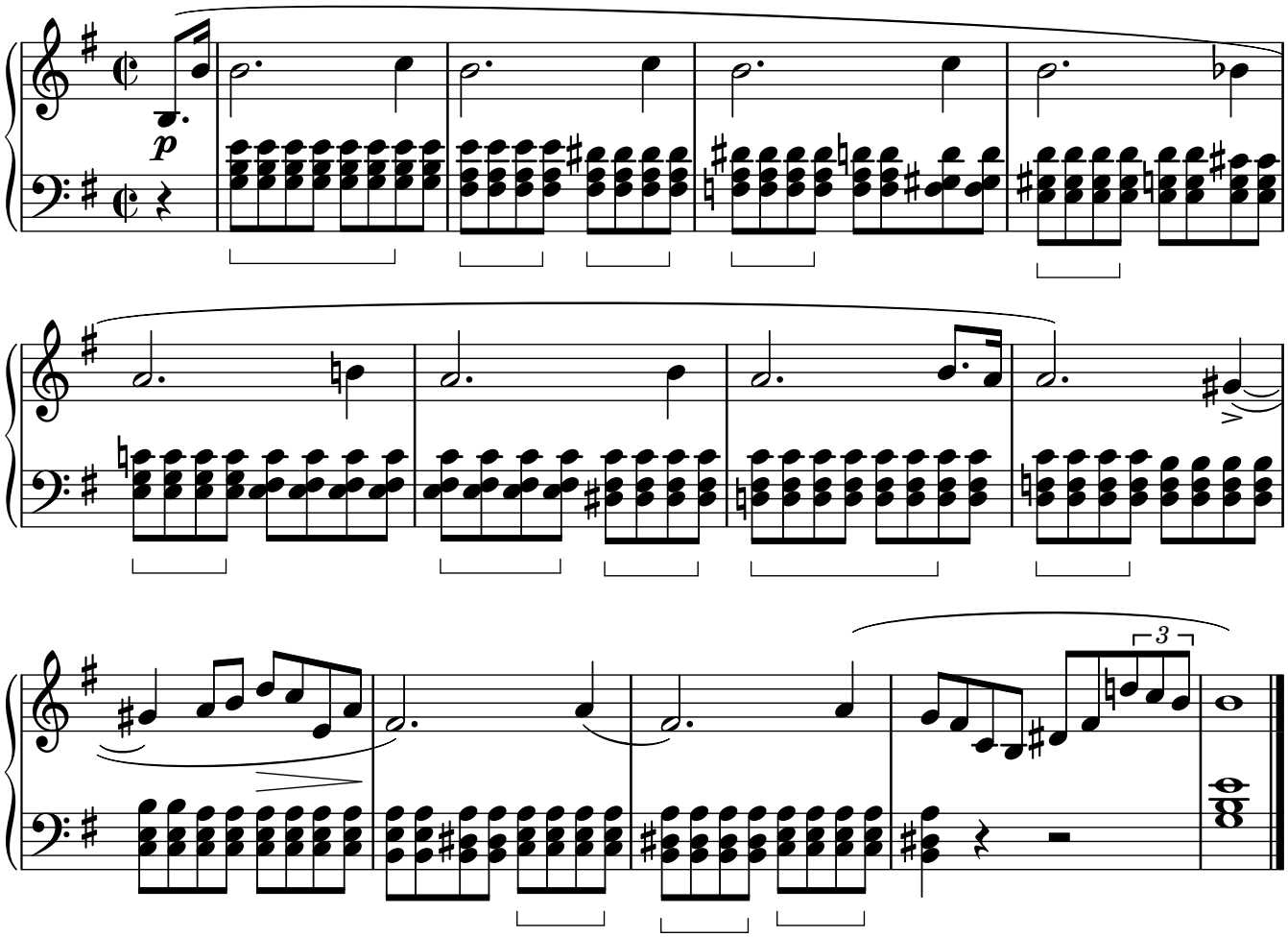
Chopin's own pedal marks: the pedal holds each two-bar phrase. The left hand leaps from a low bass note to chords in the middle; the right hand plays two-note and three-note chords, and in bar 12 a wide rolled chord (the wavy line). B-sharp is chromatic. Source: Mutopia Project no. 470 (public domain).



Prelude in E minor ♩ = 60

Frederic Chopin (1839), Prelude, Op. 28 No. 4 - first half, with a closing chord added

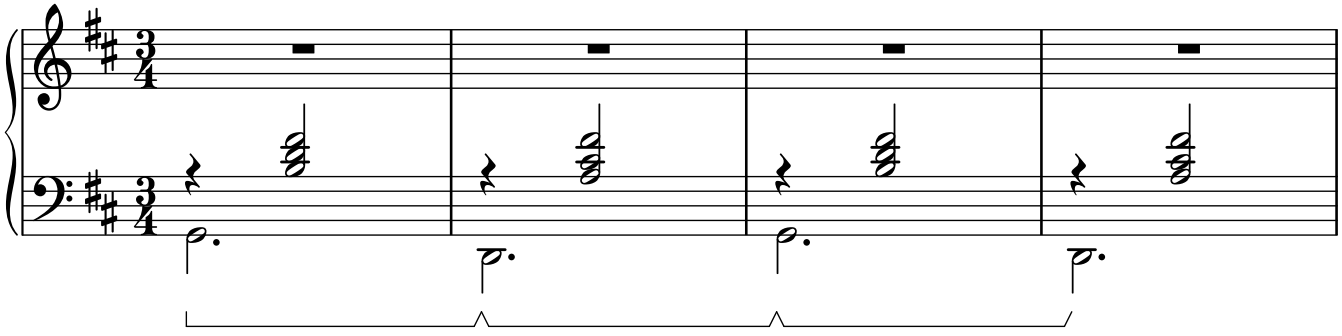
The right hand sings a long, slow tune; the left hand repeats soft chords whose notes slide down one half step at a time. Chopin's pedal marks show where to hold and change. Alla breve, but at this slow speed count four quarter beats. The grace note in bar 11 is left out, and a final E minor chord is added. Source: Mutopia Project no. 468 (public domain).
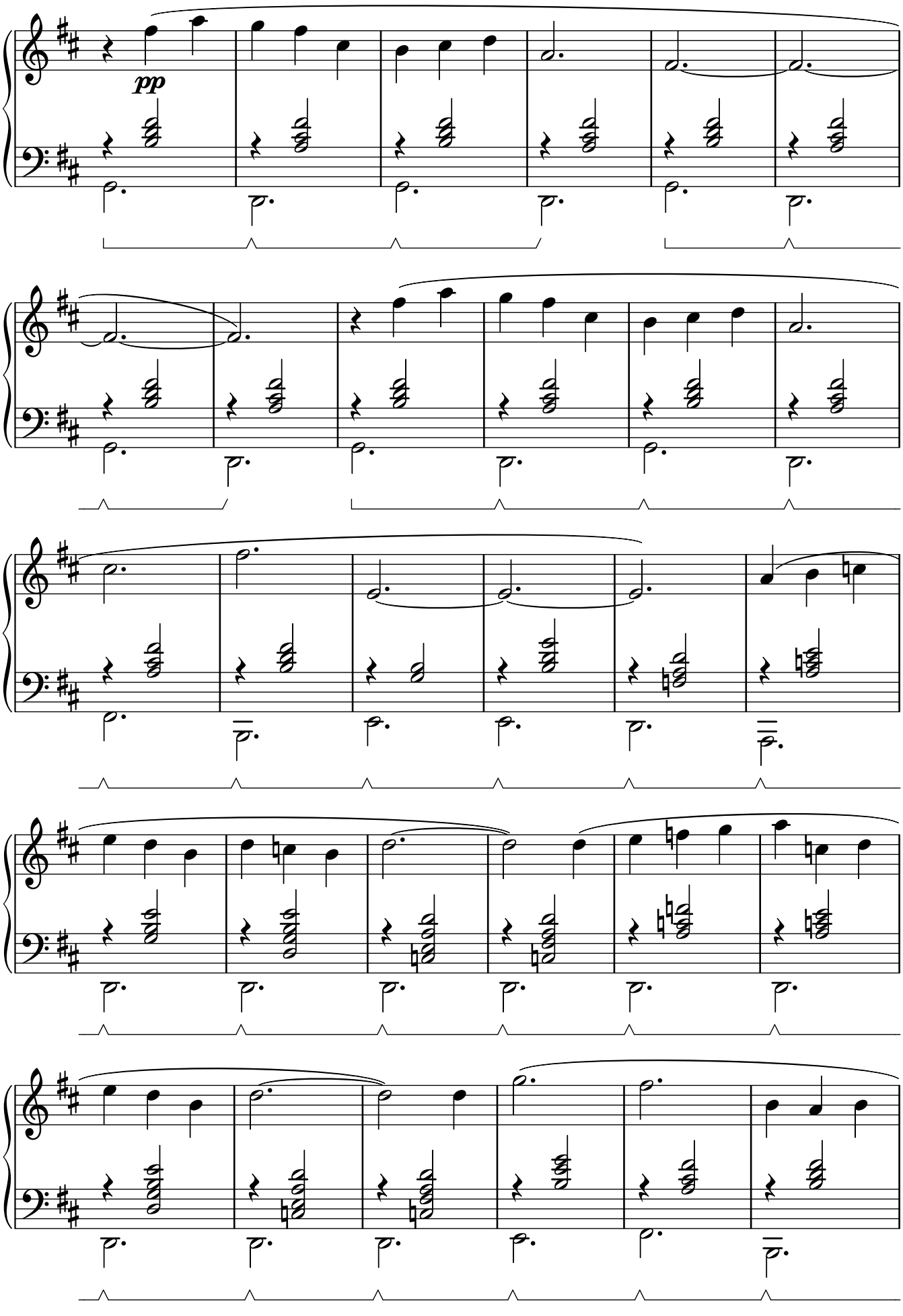


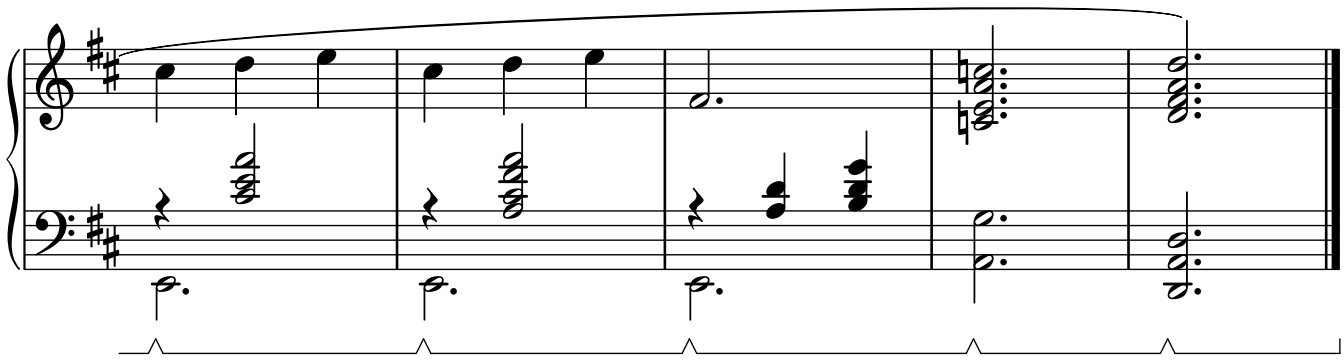
Gymnopedie No. 1 ♩ = 66

Erik Satie (1888), Trois Gymnopedies No. 1 - first half

Slow and sad. In every bar the left hand plays a low bass note on beat 1 and leaps to a chord in the middle of the keyboard on beat 2; the pedal (changed every bar; Satie left this to the player) holds the bass. A few four-note chords stretch a ninth: roll them quickly if your hand is small. The key signature has two sharps, but the music hovers between G major, D major and B minor, with C-natural and F-natural in the second half. Source: Mutopia Project no. 37 (public domain).




pp



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 8?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if the pedal changes cleanly with the harmony (no blur, no gap) and every clef change is read in time.
- Pass if you can play Pedal Song at sight and the first page of the Gymnopedie after a few days.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 8, the last unit.

Unit 8

Counterpoint, Ornaments and Review

New: Sequences and imitation; trills, mordents, turns and grace notes; review

The last unit brings together the oldest and the newest skills. Baroque music is built from lines that imitate each other and from short patterns repeated a step higher or lower (sequences); it is decorated with ornaments: small signs that tell you to add quick notes around a main note. And the review exercises are sixteen bars long, in any key, with everything from this volume.

What is new

Sequences

A short figure repeated a step lower (or higher) each time. Once you have read it once, read only the first note of each repetition and let the pattern do the rest.

Imitation
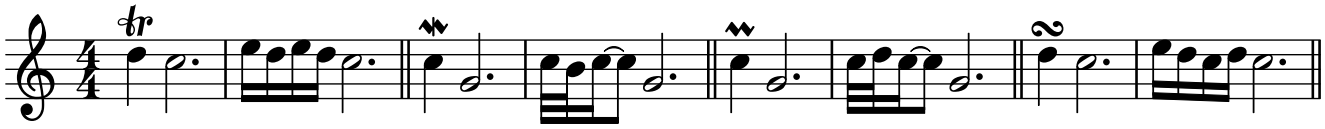
One hand plays a tune; then the other hand plays the same tune, often an octave lower, while the first hand goes on with a new line. Look for the tune you have just played.

Ornaments

Trill, mordent, turn and grace notes: the box of examples shows how each is played. At sight, keep the beat first; an ornament can be left out the first time through.

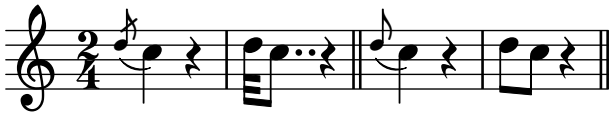
Ornaments: written, then played

Trill (tr): alternate quickly with the note above, starting on the upper note in Baroque music. Mordent (with a line): main note, the note below, main note. Short trill (no line): main note, the note above, main note. Turn: the note above, the main note, the note below, the main note.



Grace notes: written, then played

A small note with a slash (acciaccatura) is crushed in just before the beat. A small note without a slash (appoggiatura) leans on the beat and takes time from the main note: usually half of it.



Reading tips

1. In a sequence, check the first note of each repetition and the size of the step between them.

2. In imitation, the left hand often plays what the right hand played a bar earlier: look back as well as ahead.
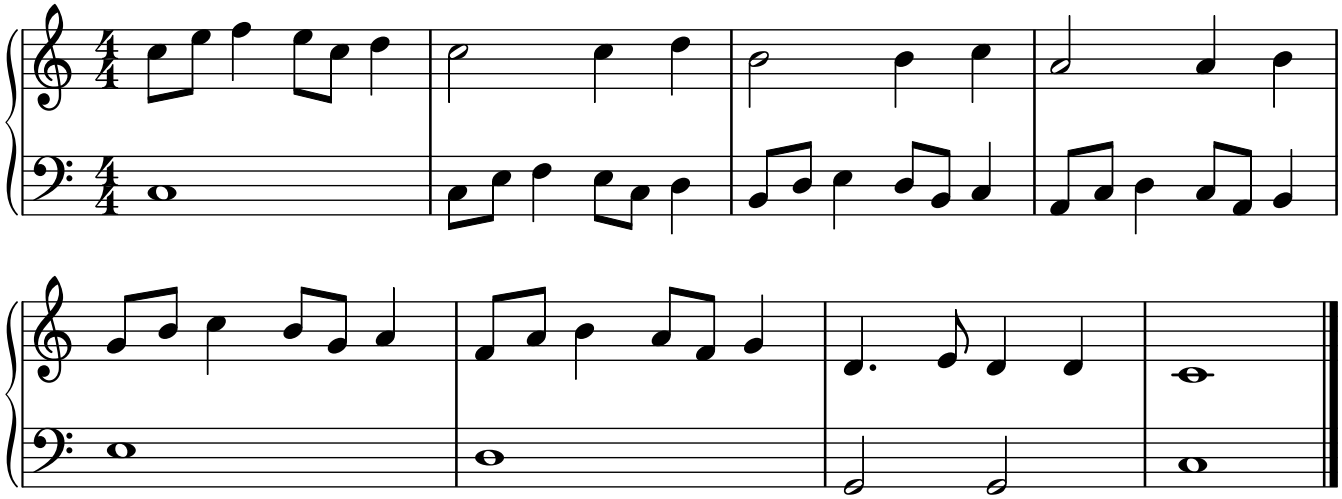
3. Ornaments are decoration. If one would break the beat, leave it out and add it when you practise.

4. For the review, use the full scan before each exercise: key, time, the left hand's pattern, accidentals, pedal, ornaments.
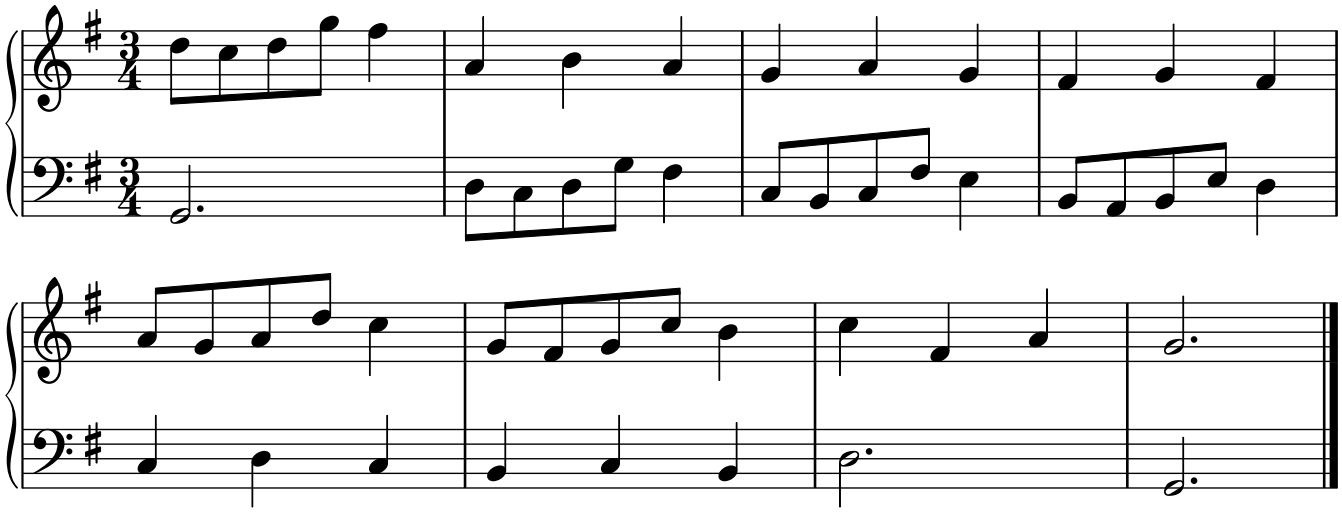
Part A: Sequences: the left hand imitates ♩ = 66

Two-part sequences: the right hand plays a one-bar motive; the left hand imitates it while the right hand plays a counter-line, and the pair moves down a step each bar. C, G, F major and A minor.
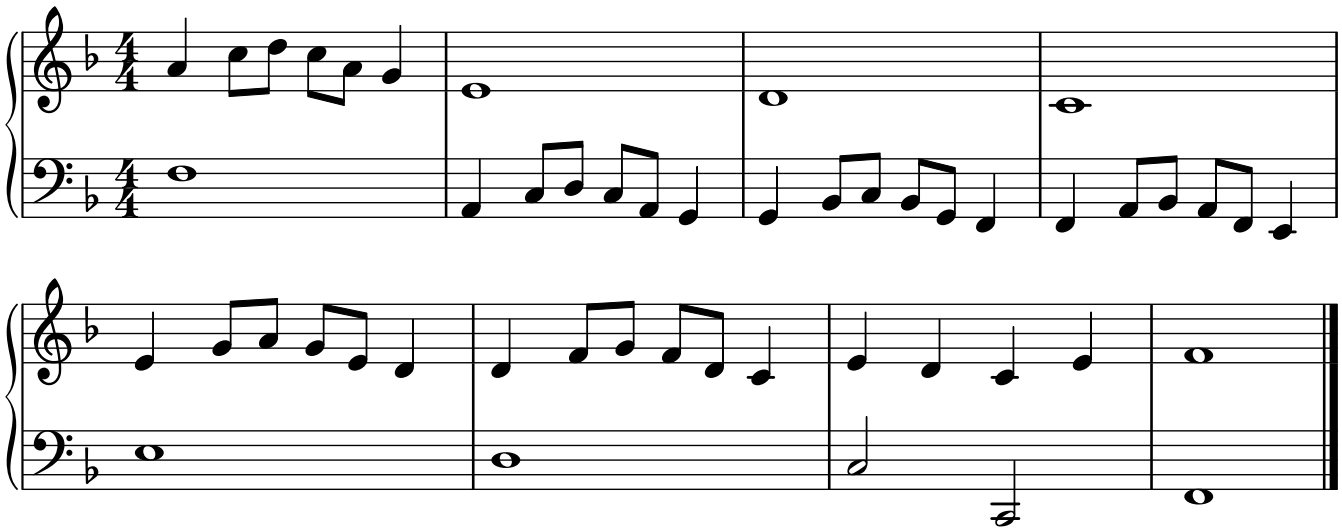
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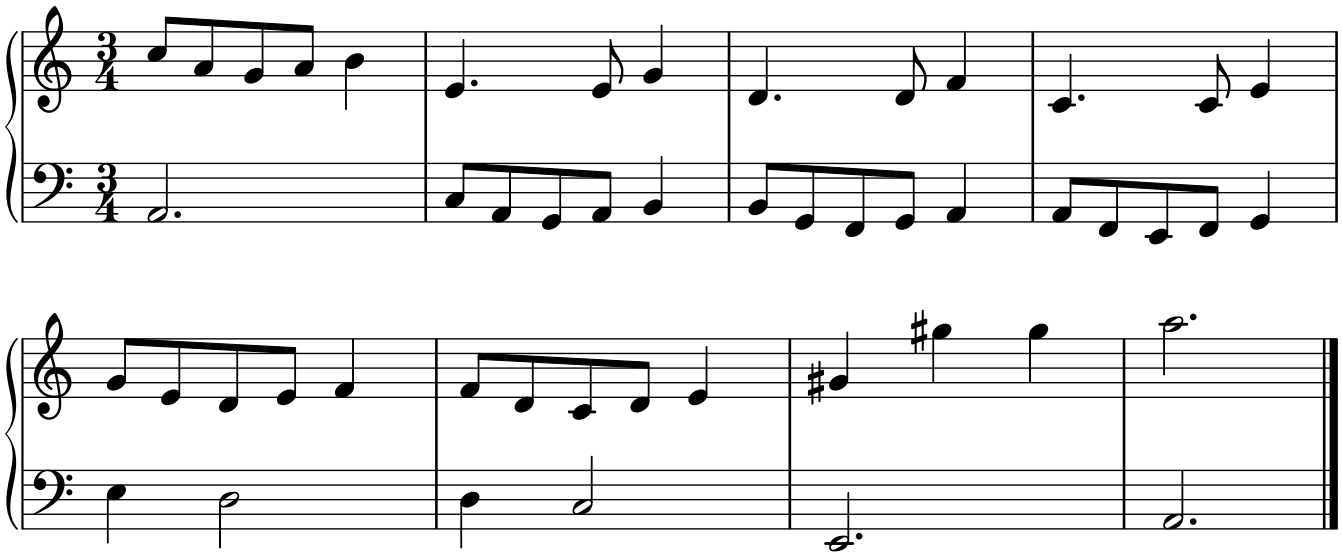


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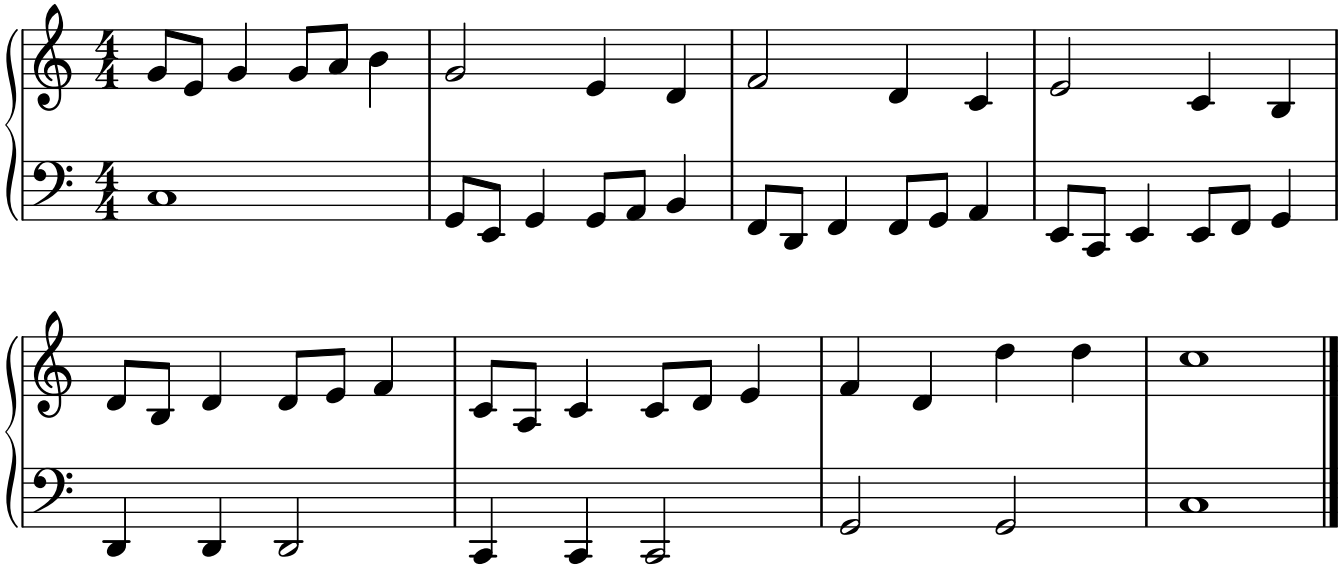


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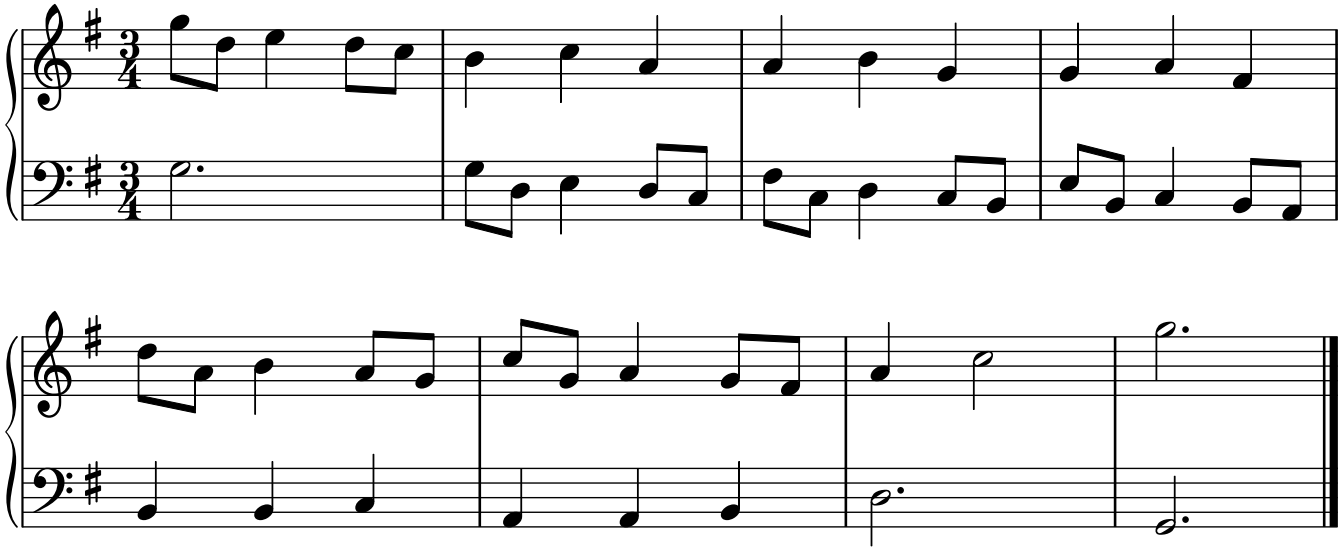


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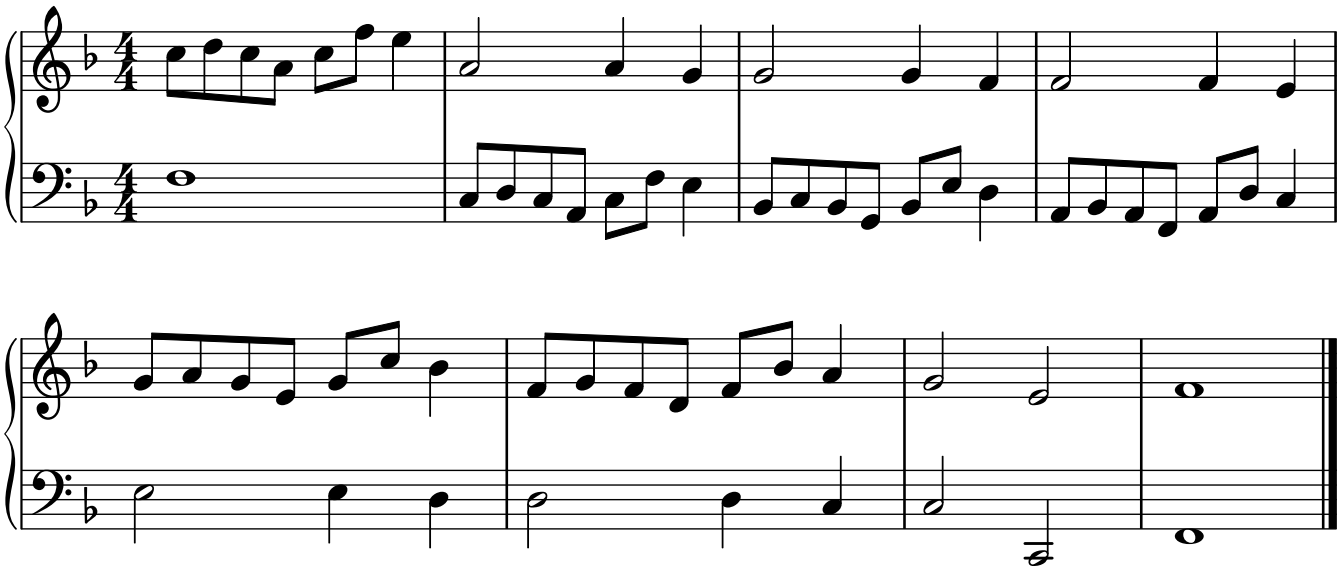


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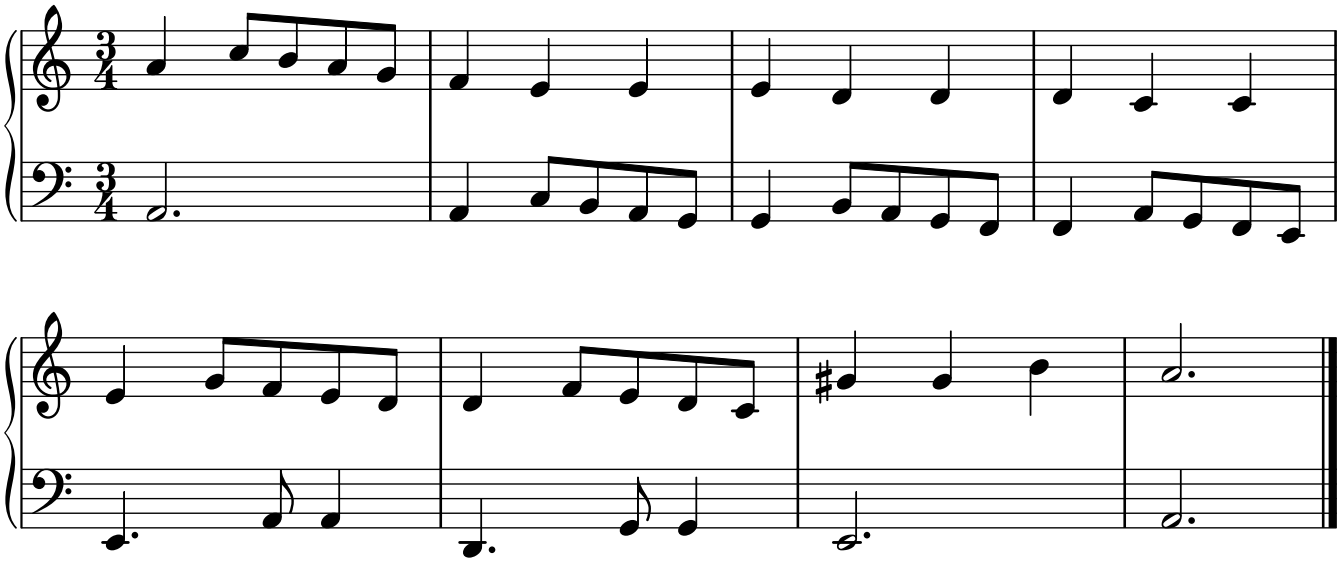


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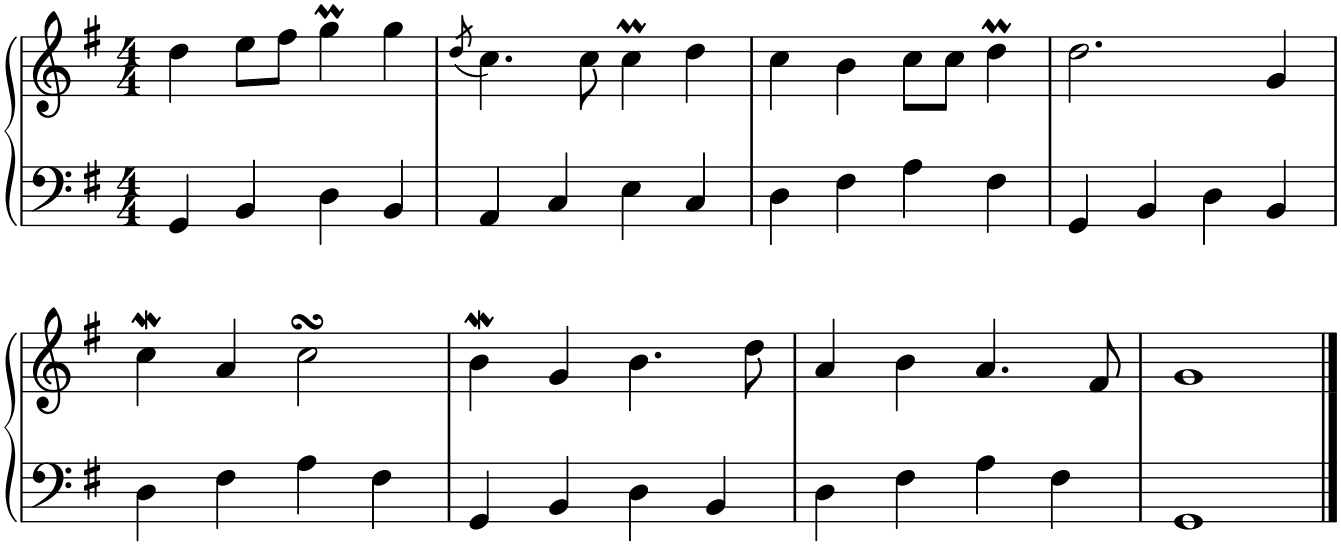


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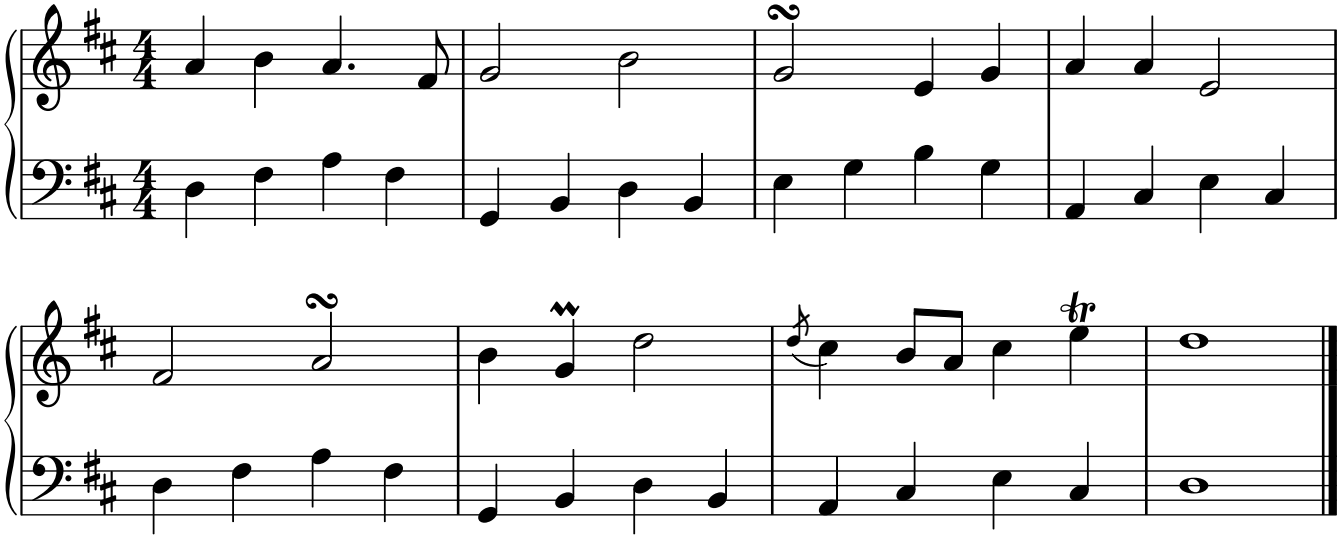


Part B: Ornaments ♩= 66

Ornaments: a trill on the note before the last, mordents, turns and grace notes.
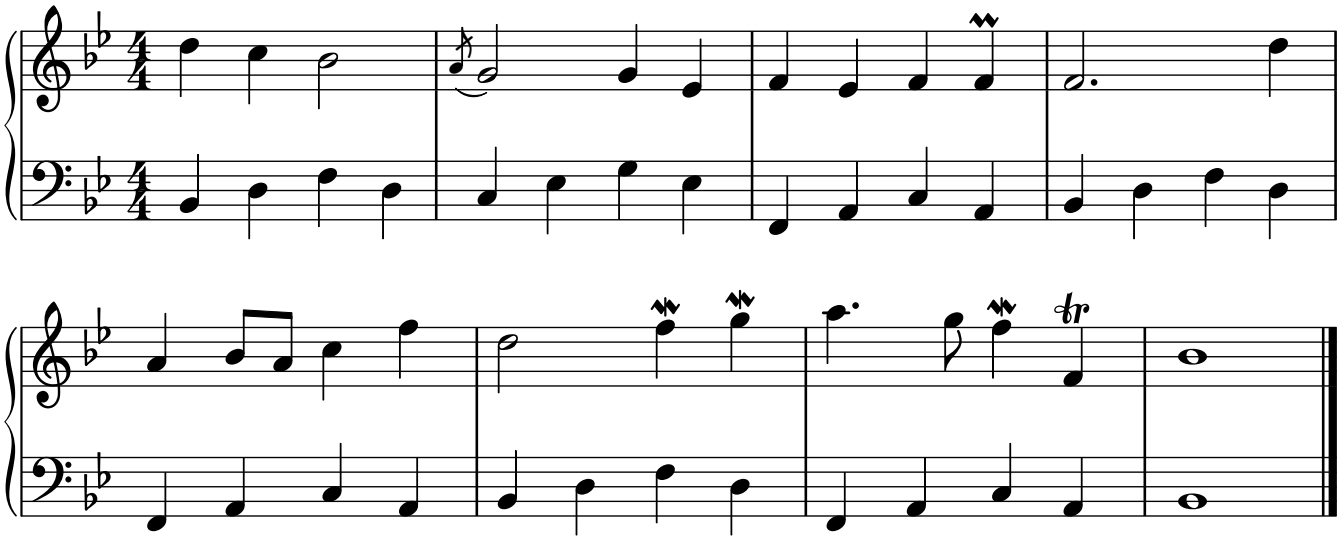
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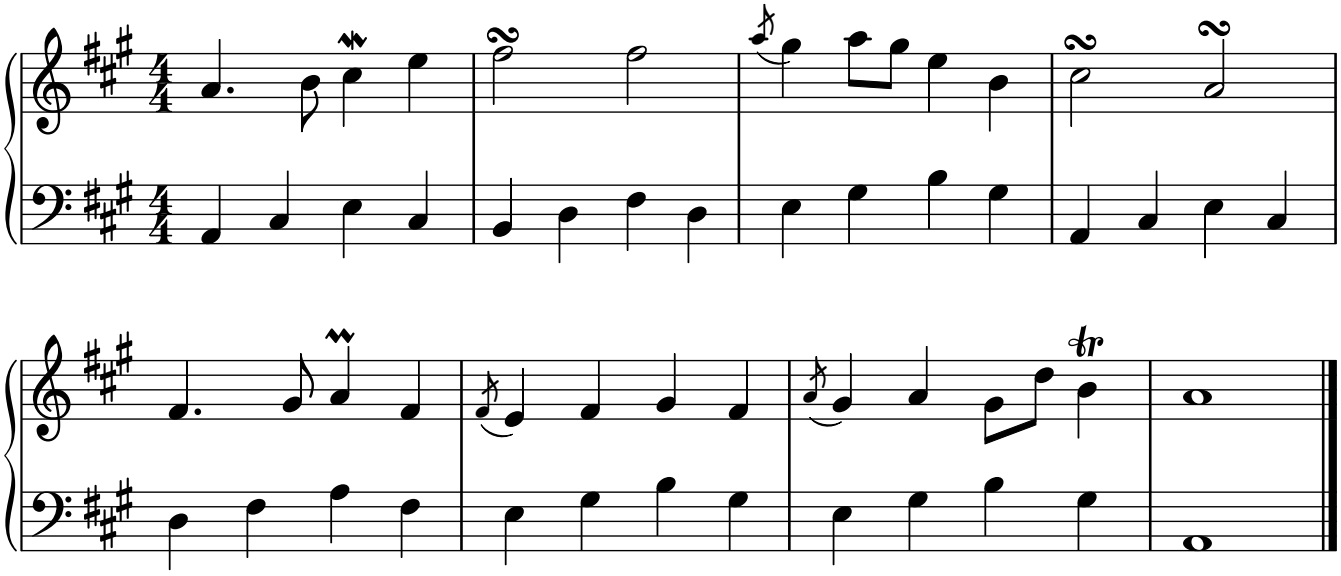


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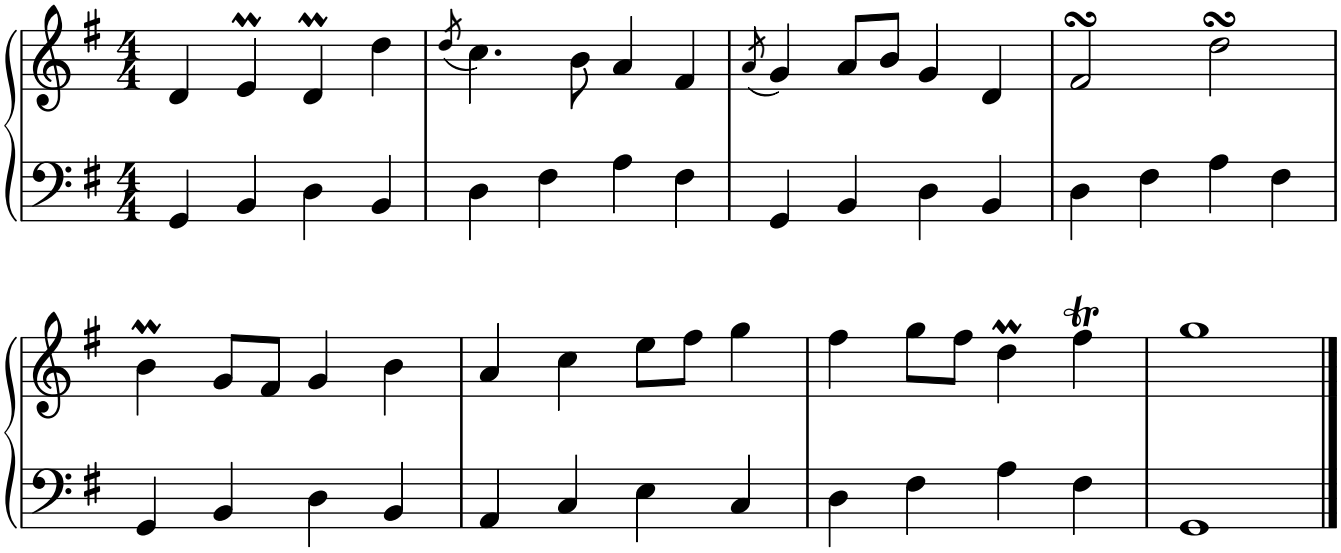


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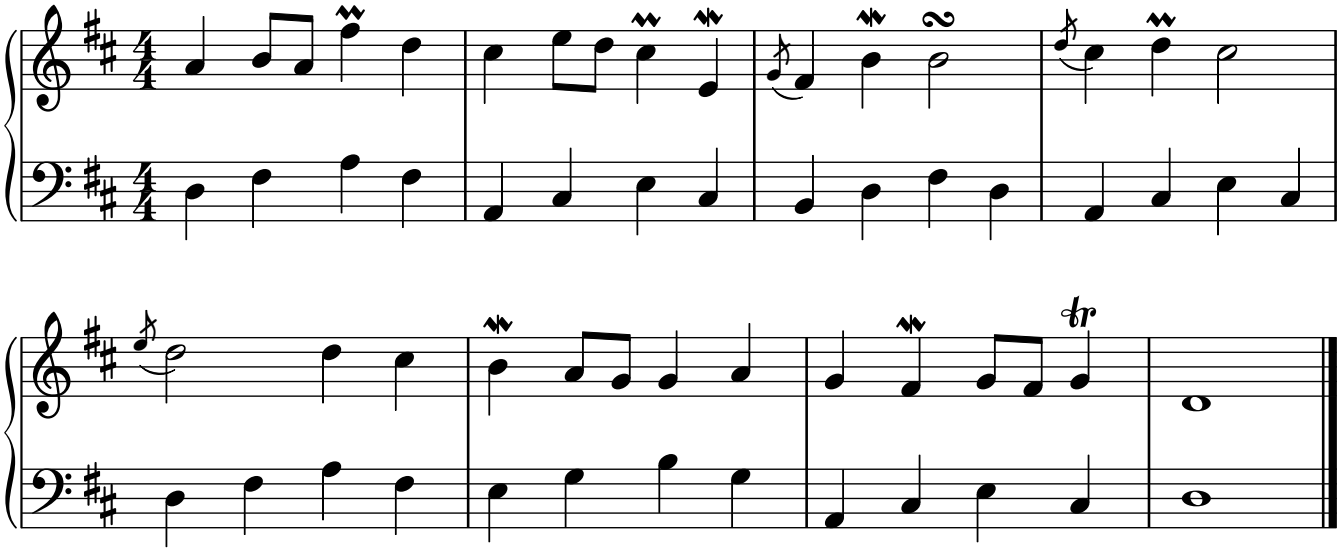


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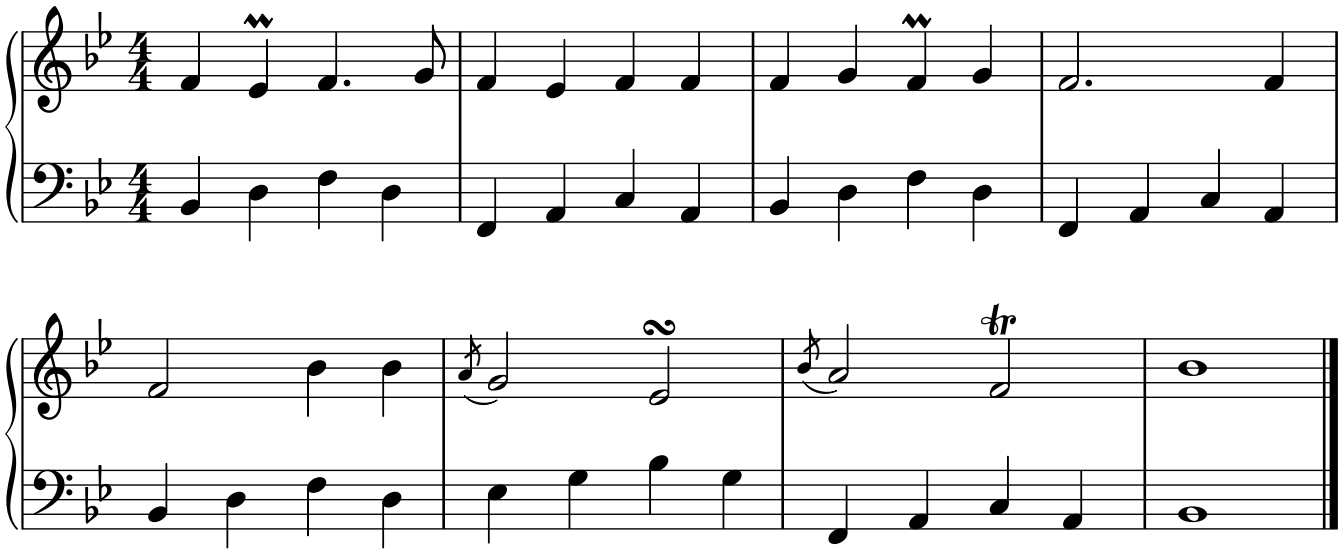


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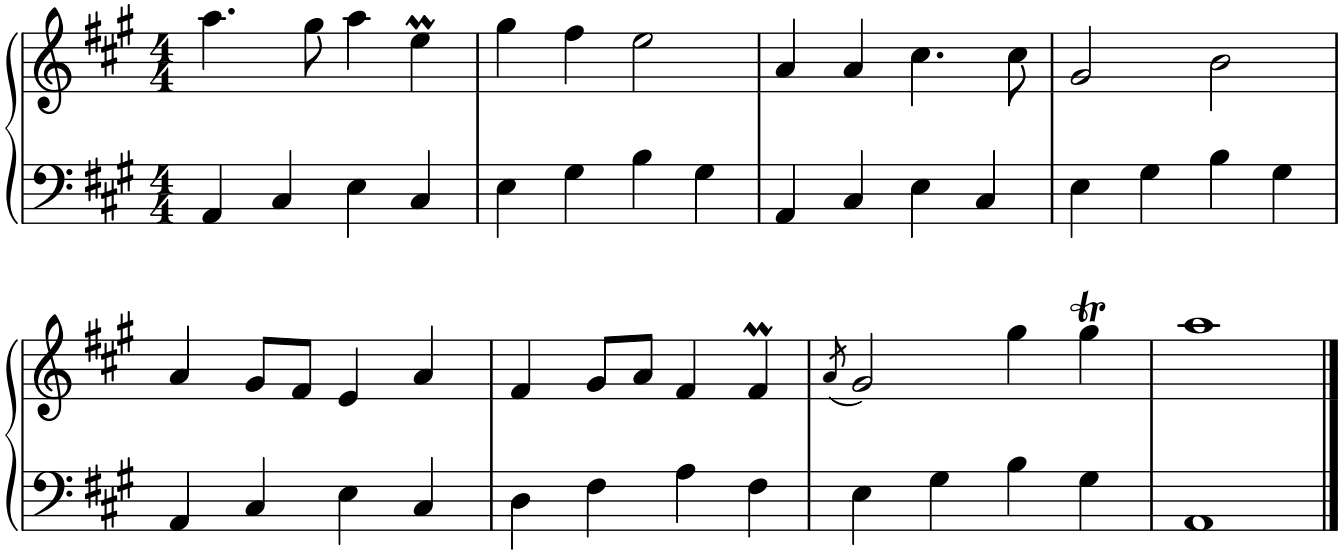


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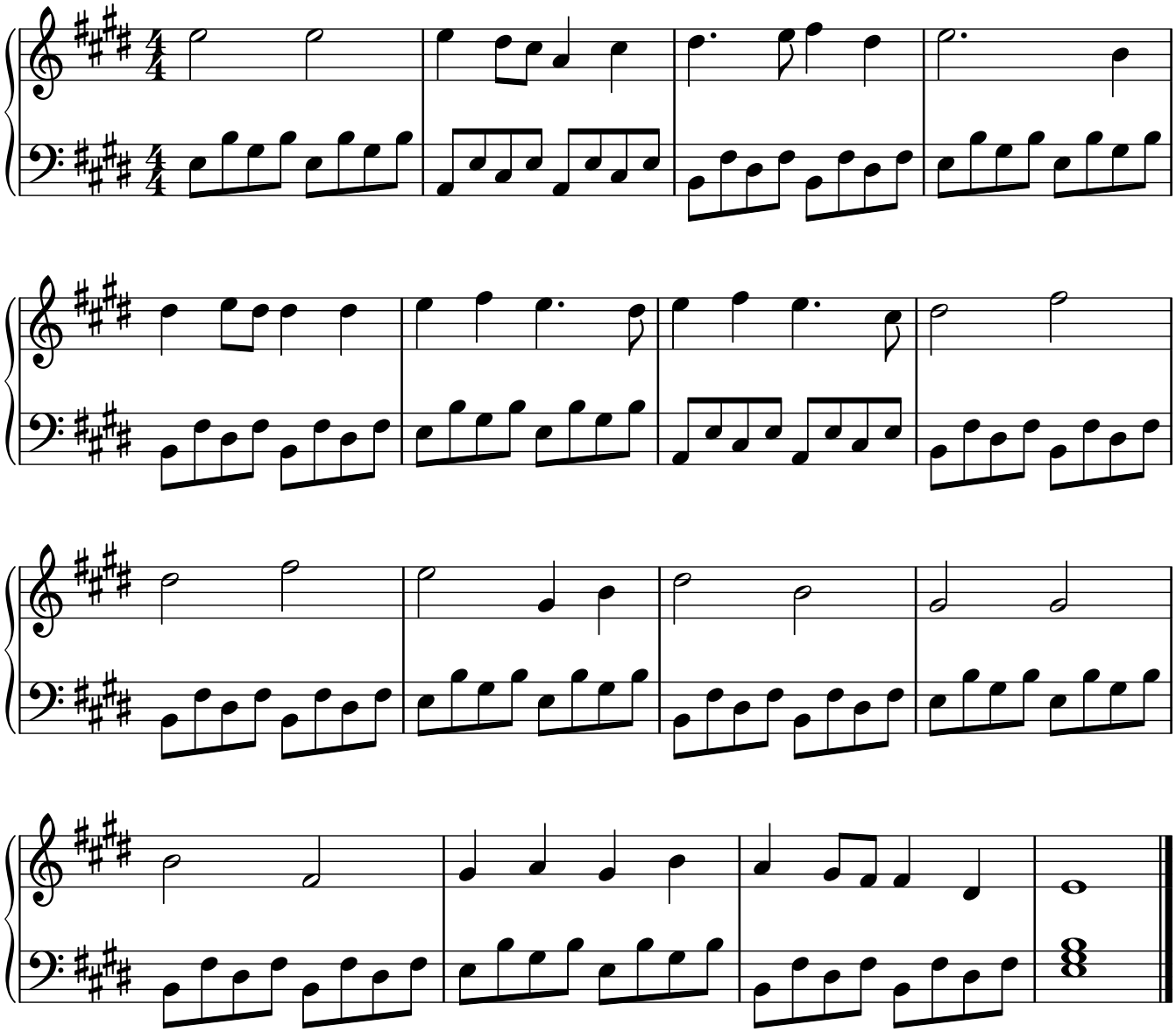


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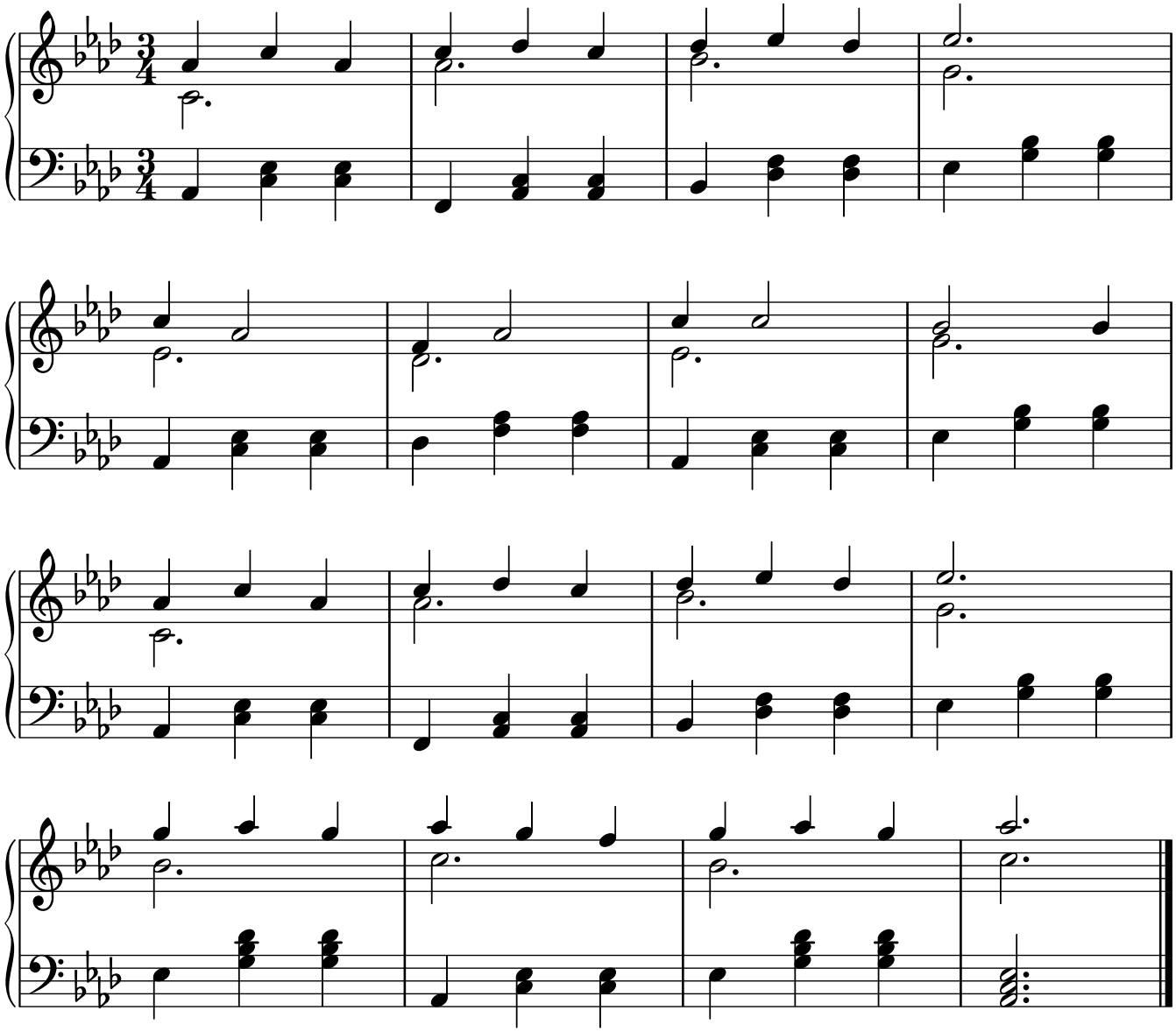


Part C: Review: sixteen bars ♩= 72

Review: sixteen bars in many keys and textures (held voices, chromatic notes, the pedal, 6/8, triplets, ornaments). The first eight bars end on V; bars 9-12 often repeat bars 1-4.
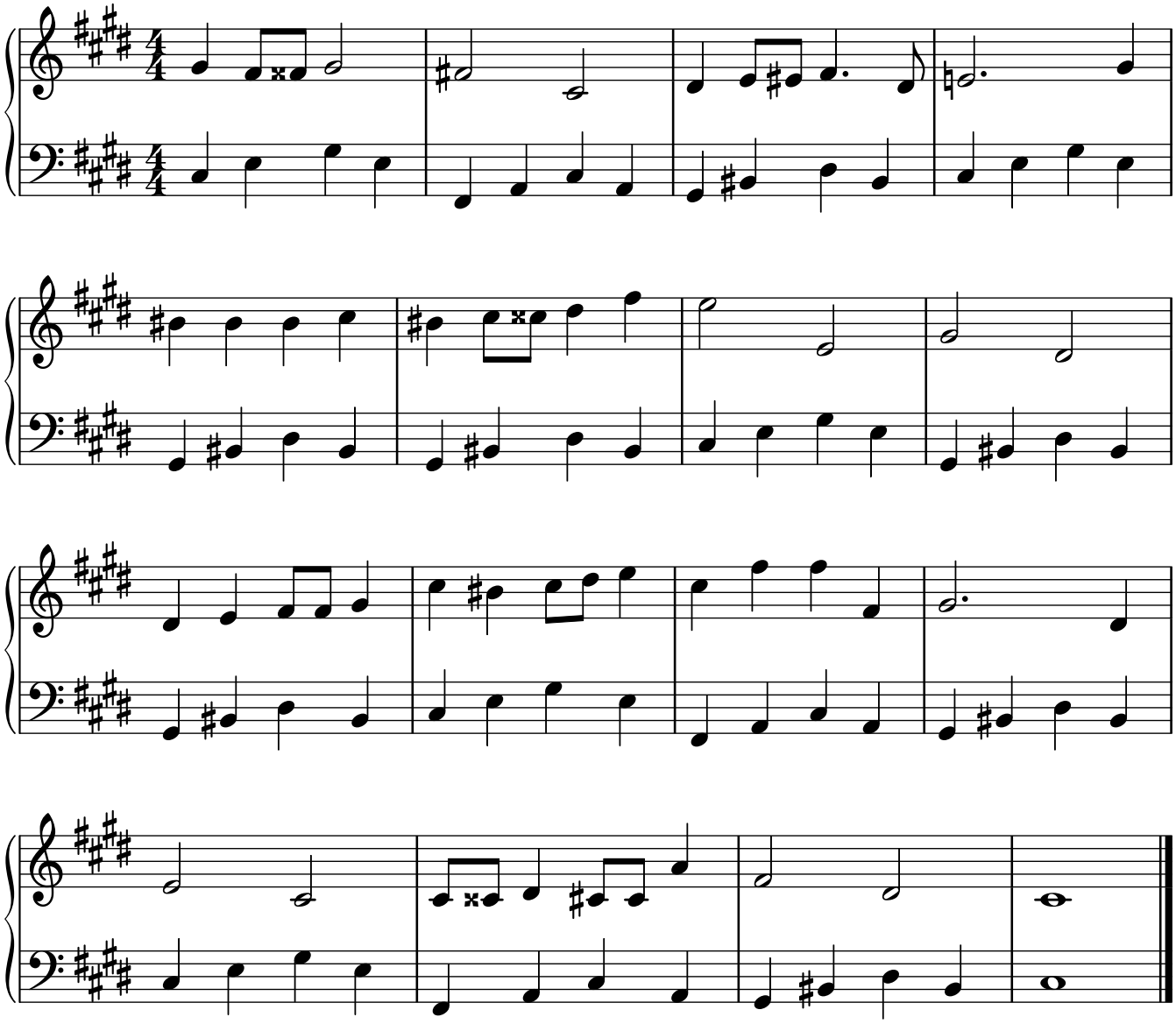
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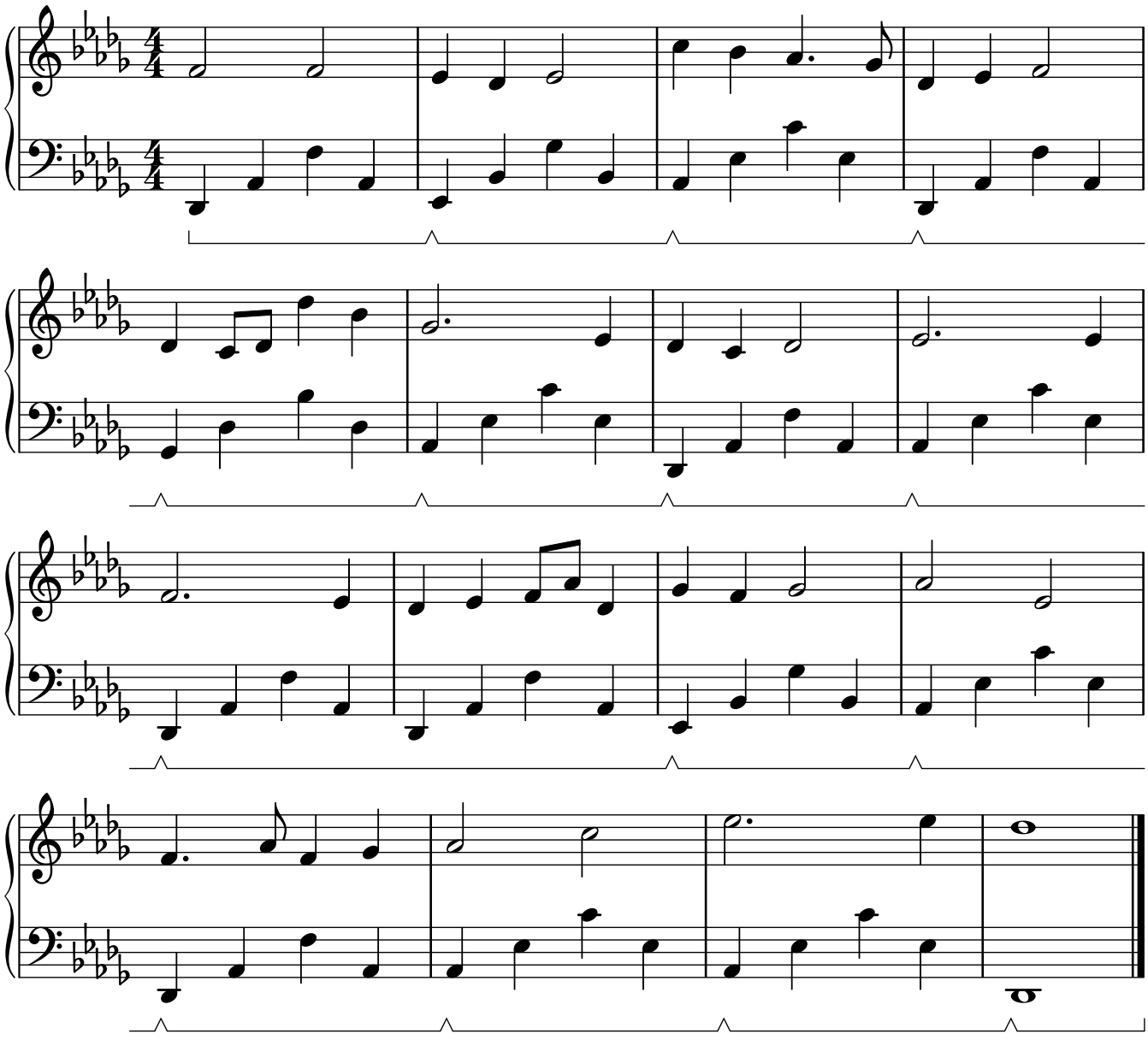


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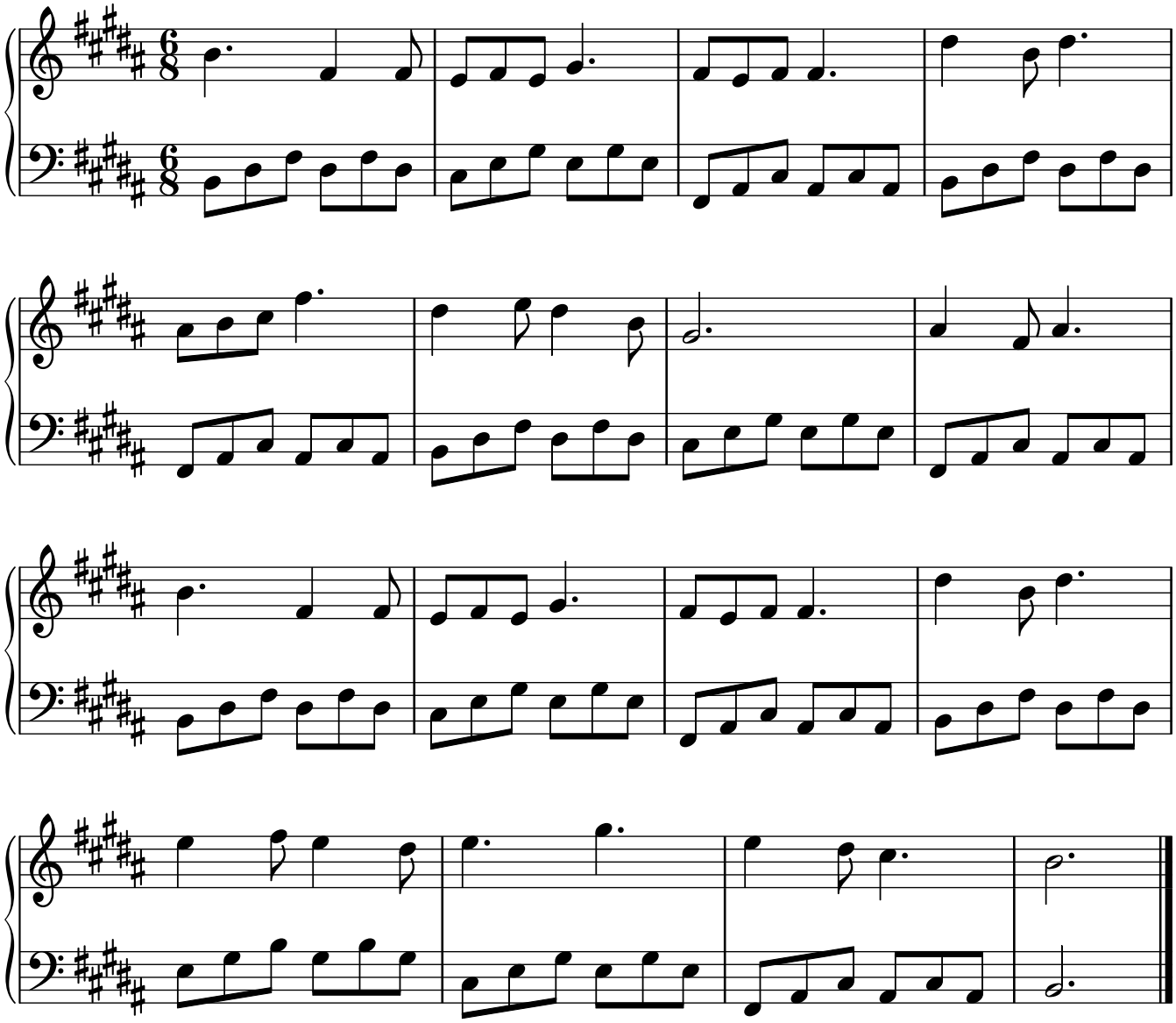


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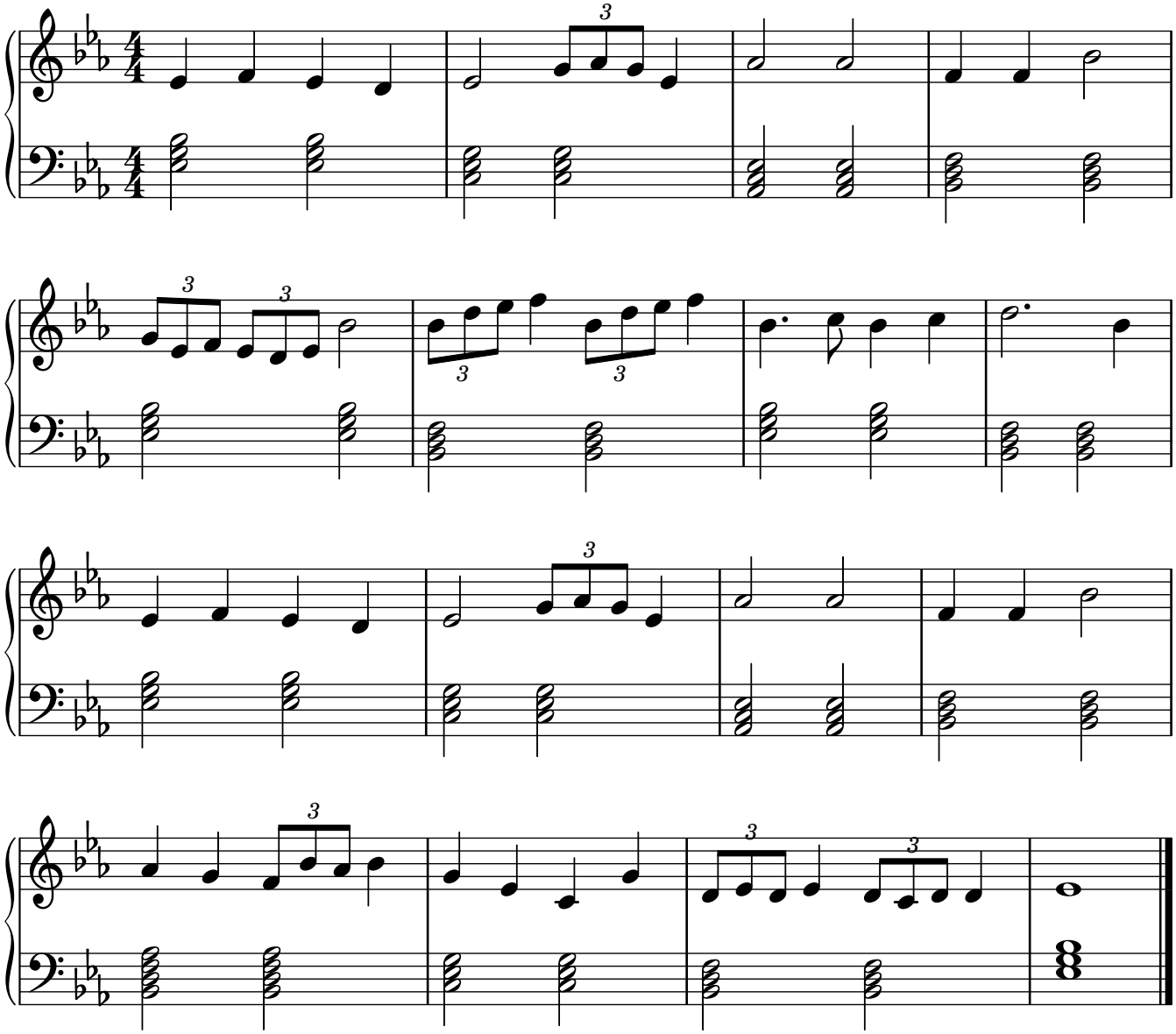


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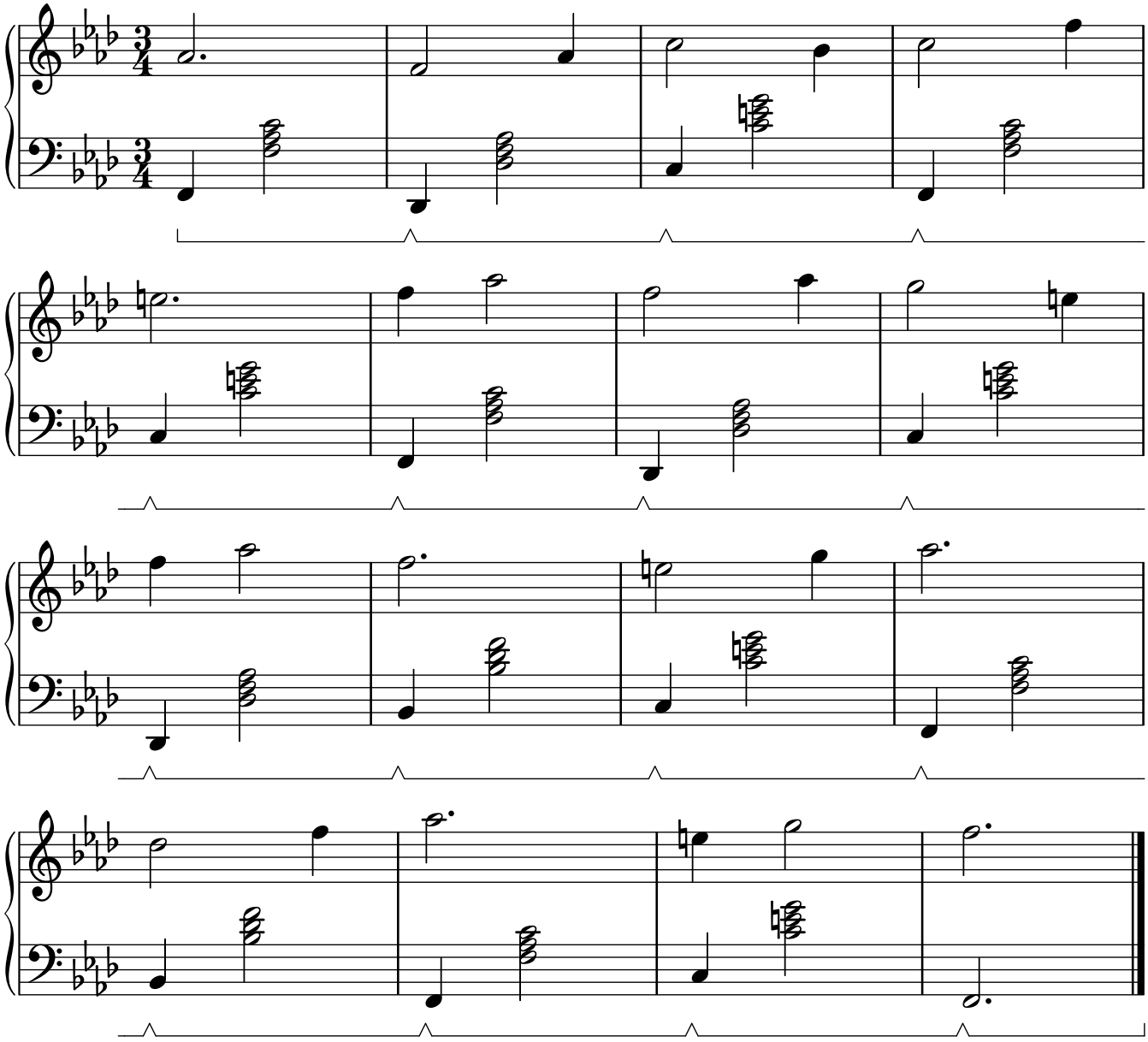
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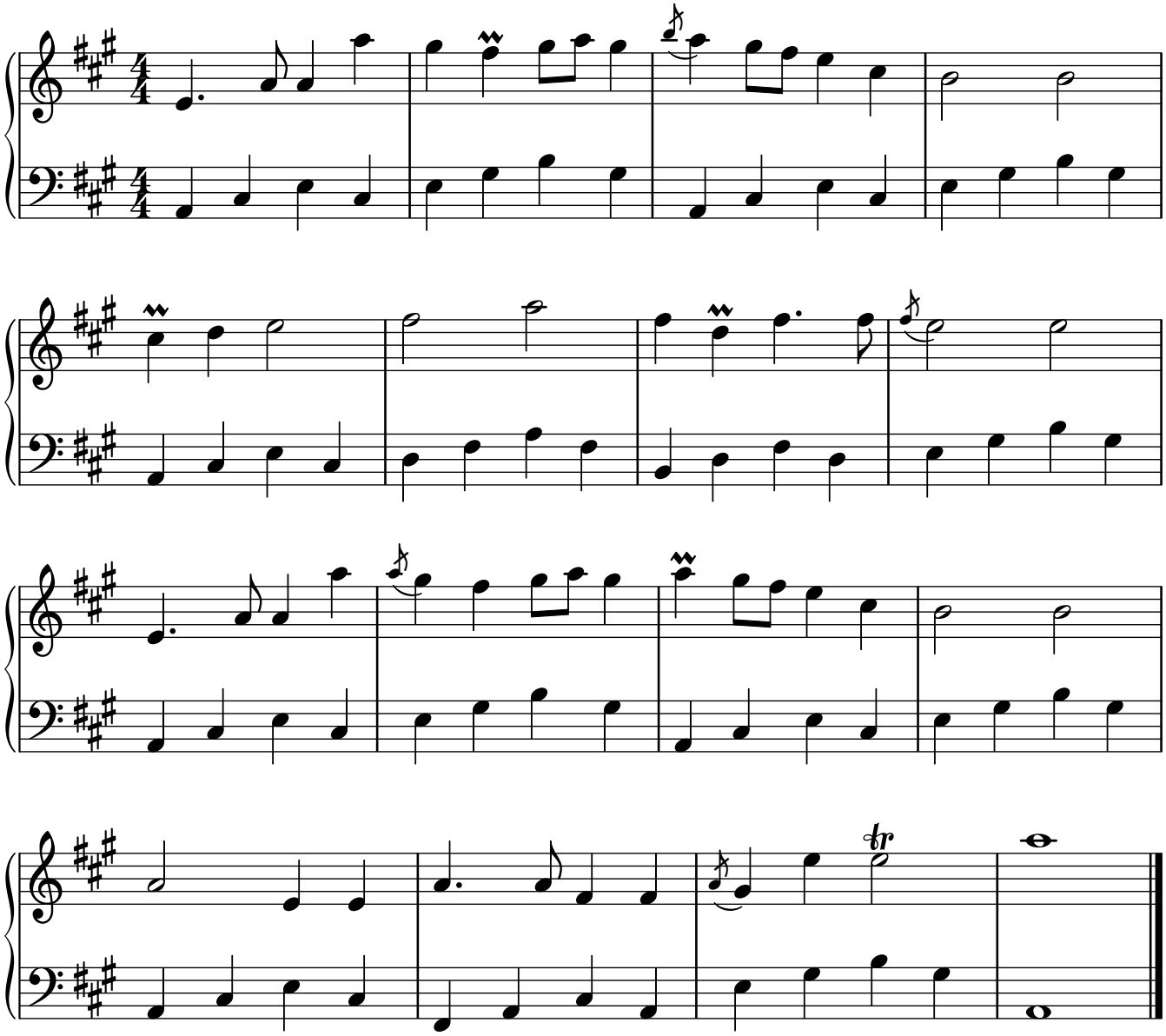


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8.24
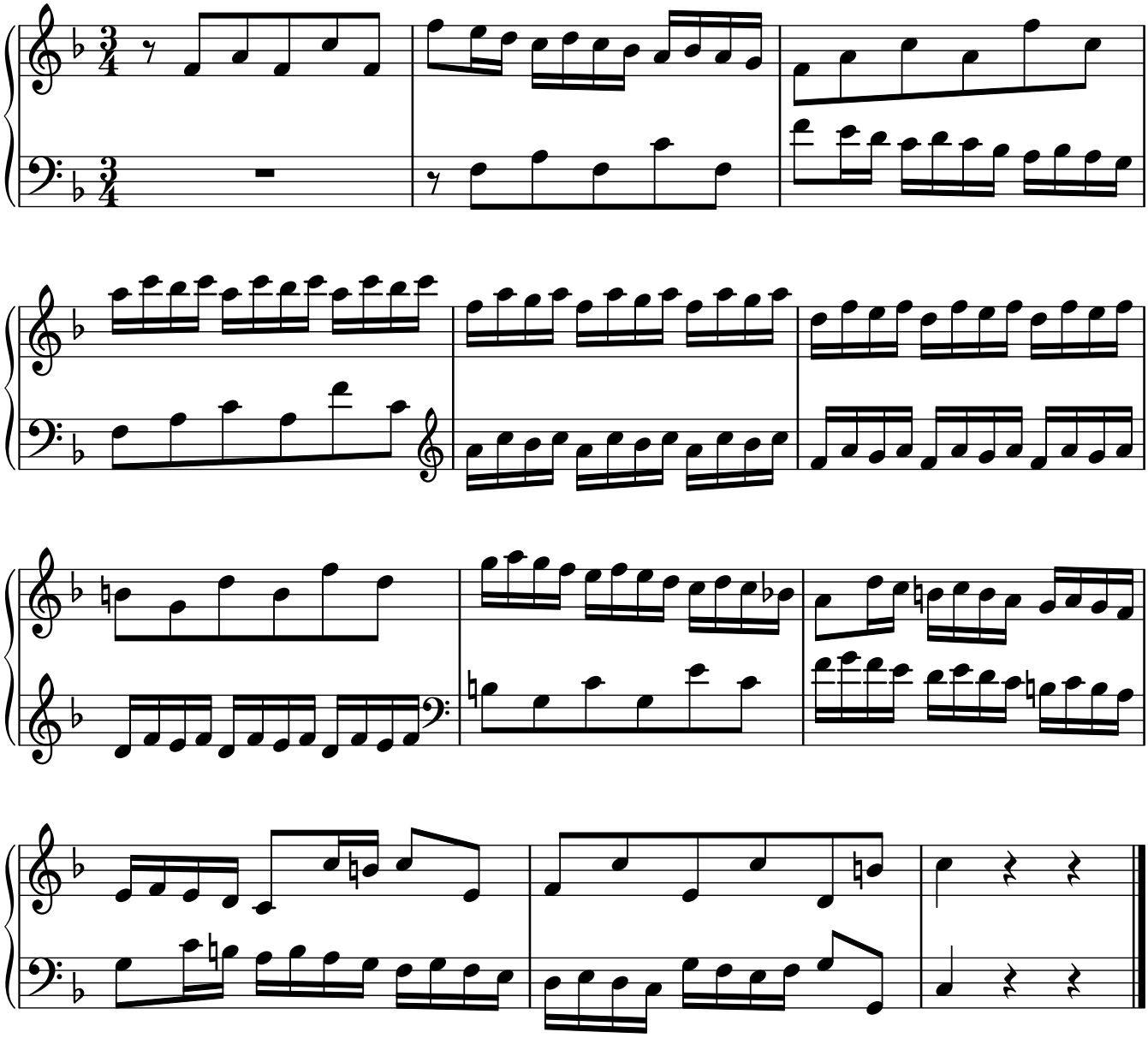


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Invention No. 8 ♩= 72

J. S. Bach, Two-Part Invention in F, BWV 779 - the first twelve bars, with the last bar shortened
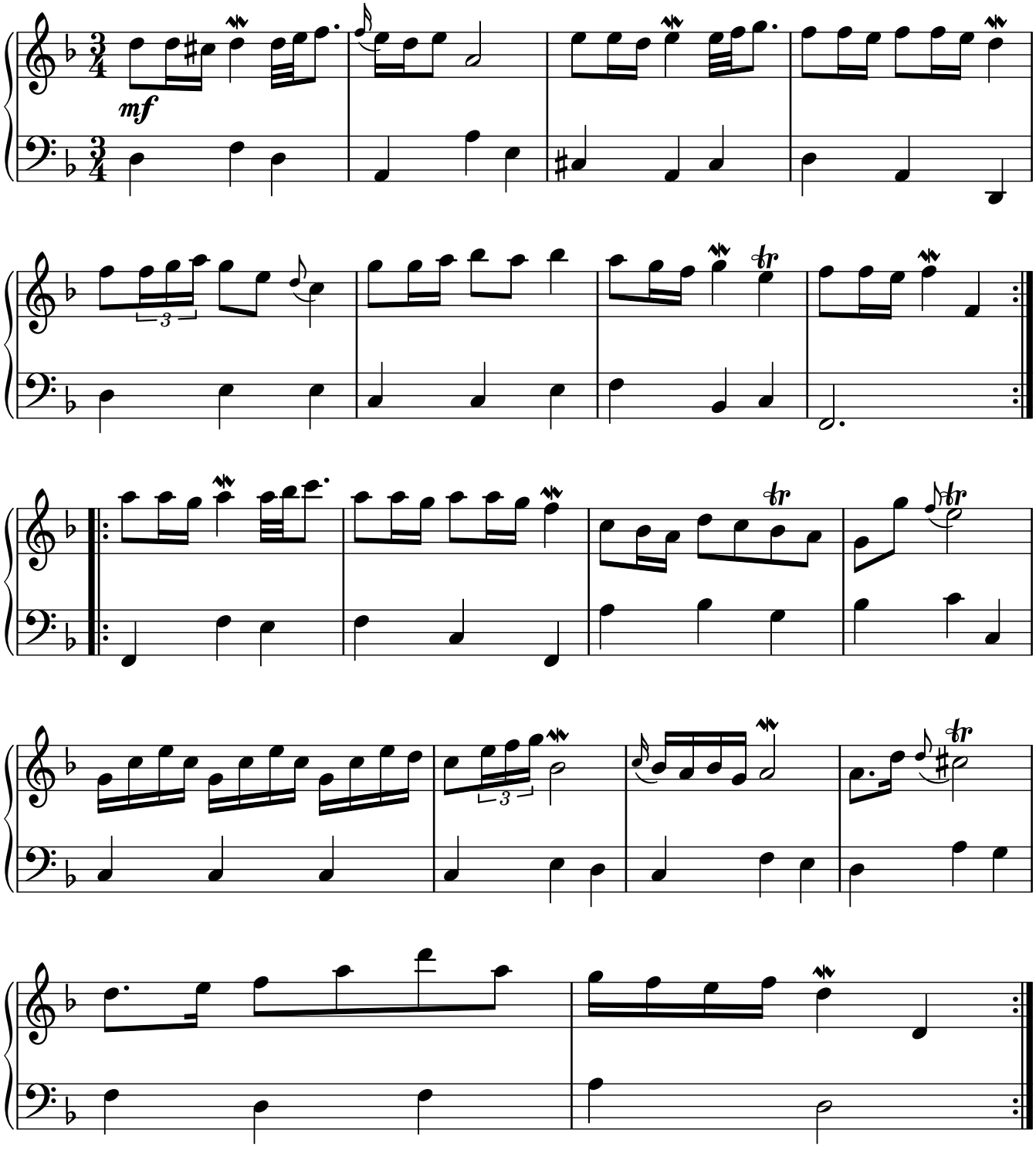
The right hand states the theme (a rising F major chord, then running sixteenths); one bar later the left hand imitates it an octave lower. From bar 4 the hands play sequences: one-bar patterns moved down a step each time. The left hand moves into the treble clef for three bars. The excerpt ends in C major, where Bach's first section closes. Source: Mutopia Project no. 61 (public domain).



Polonaise in D minor ♩= 72

From the Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach, BWV Anh. 128 - complete
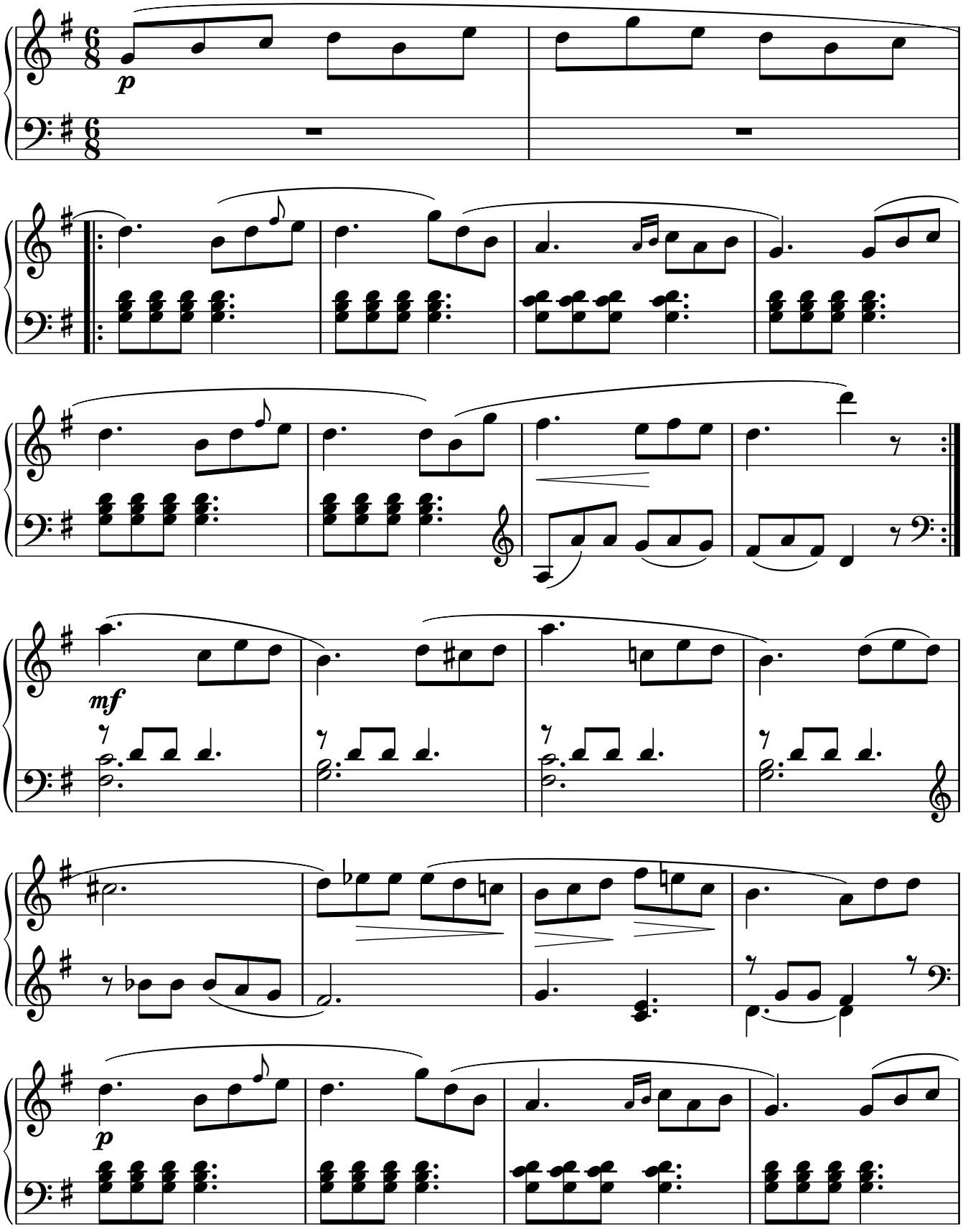
A polonaise full of ornaments: mordents (the zig-zag with a line: main note, the note below, main note), trills (tr) and appoggiaturas (small notes that lean on the beat). The two thirty-second notes in bars 1, 3 and 9 are a quick 'snap' up to the next note. Both halves are repeated. Source: Mutopia Project no. 1615 (public domain).
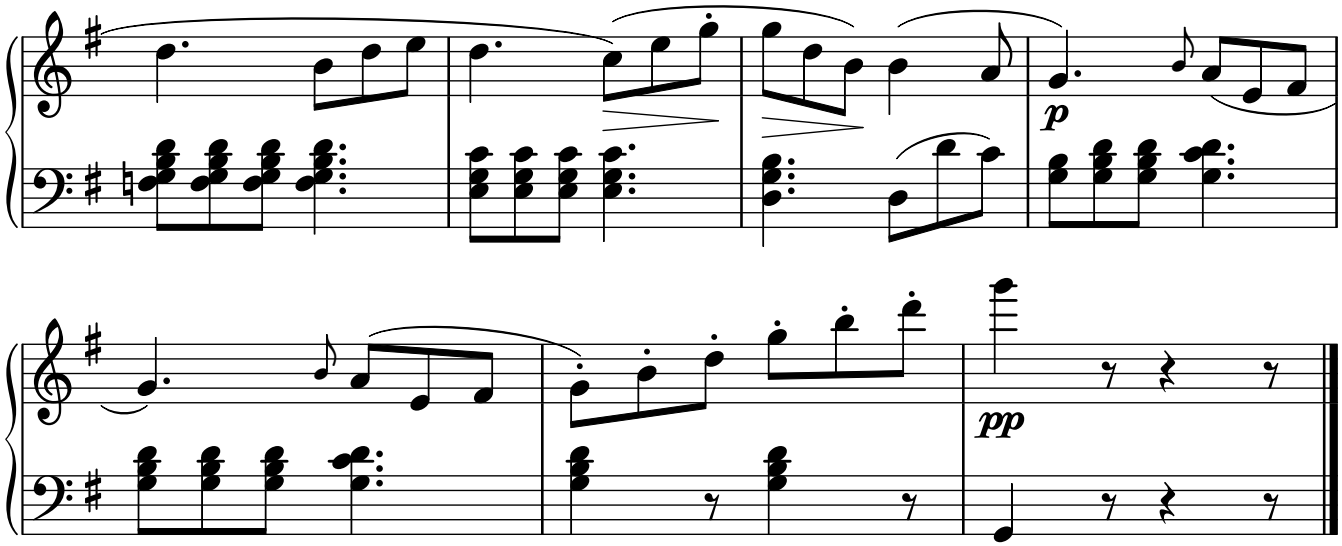


Pastorale ♩. = 50

Friedrich Burgmuller (1851), 25 Easy Studies, Op. 100 No. 3 - complete

A shepherd's tune in 6/8 with grace notes: crush each small note in just before the main note. The left hand rocks on G major chords; in the middle section it moves into the treble clef and holds low notes under its own moving line. The first section is repeated. Source: Mutopia Project no. 218 (public domain).
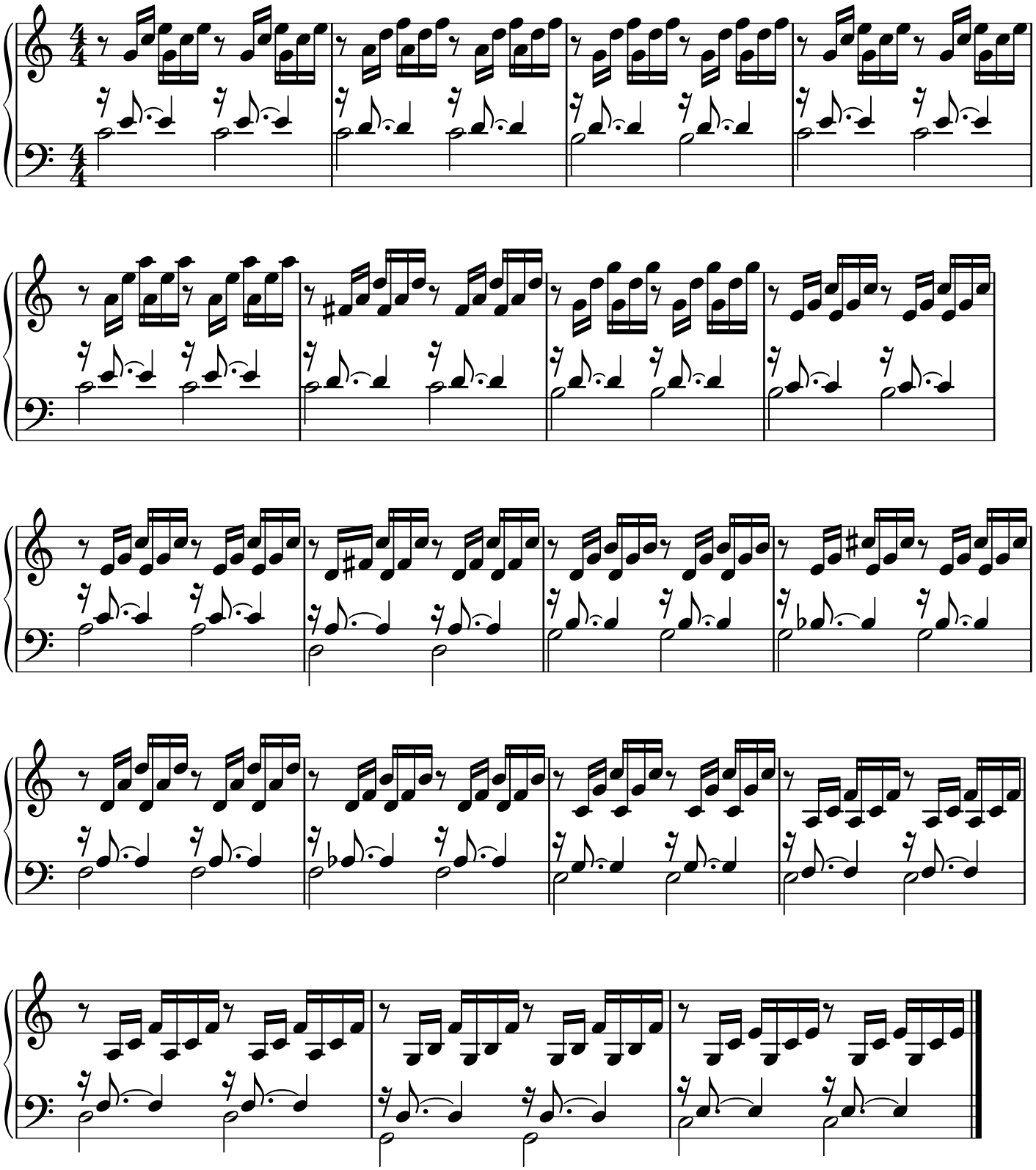



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Prelude in C ♩= 66

J. S. Bach, The Well-Tempered Clavier I, Prelude in C, BWV 846 - bars 1-19
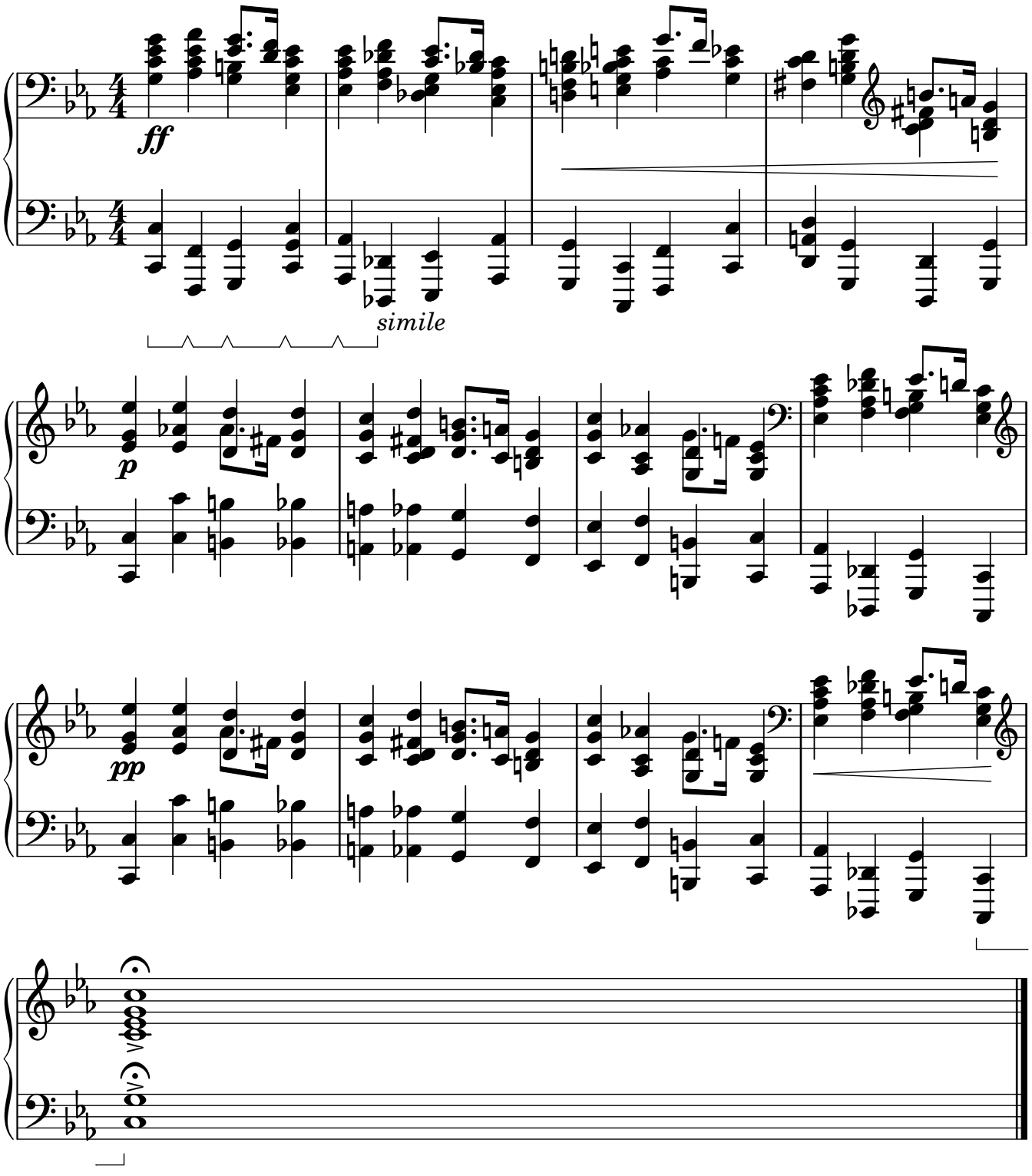
A whole piece made of one pattern: each bar is one chord, spread out in the same shape twice. Read it as a chord a bar: find the bass, the left hand's held note and the right hand's three notes, and let the pattern play itself. Bars 1-19 make a complete journey from C major and back. Source: Mutopia Project no. 5 (public domain).



Prelude in C minor ♩ = 42

Frederic Chopin (1839), Prelude, Op. 28 No. 20 - complete

The last piece of the course: thirteen bars of solemn four-part chords. Read each chord from the bass up, and keep the dotted rhythm on beat 3 exact. A few right-hand chords stretch a ninth; roll them quickly if you must. The right hand starts in the bass clef and moves up to the treble clef; both hands change clef again in bar 8. The pedal changes with every chord (Chopin writes it out in the first bars, then 'simile': go on in the same way). Source: Mutopia Project no. 472 (public domain).



Checkpoint: the end of the course

- Play two review exercises (Part C) a day for two weeks, in as many keys as you can: no more than one stop each, every accidental, pedal and ornament in place.
- Pass if you can read the Prelude in C and the Polonaise at sight, steadily, and the Prelude in C minor after a few days.
- You have finished Read at Sight. Keep reading new music every day: hymn books, Bach chorales, the easier pieces of Schumann, Chopin, Grieg and Bartok. The habit is the skill.